

APPLIED POSITIVE PSYCHOLOGY

THE PEOPLE'S
UNIVERSITY

School of Social Sciences
Indira Gandhi National Open University
New Delhi

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COURSE INTRODUCTION

MPCE 046: APPLIED POSITIVE PSYCHOLOGY Course is in the Second year of Master of Arts in Psychology (MAPC) programme. The course is an alternative course to Project course in the Second year. It is a Theory course of 6 credits. The course will provide you an understanding of the field of positive psychology where you will learn about various positive psychological constructs and how these can help us achieve good mental health and psychological well-being. It will provide a historical perspective on positive psychology and highlight its relation to Indian psychology. The course will also discuss the importance of character strengths, and the role of positive emotional and cognitive states and processes in helping individuals realize themselves and flourish. Finally, the course will highlight the applications of positive psychology in different arena of life.

The specific objectives of the course are as follows:

Objectives

1. To explain the nature of key concepts in positive psychology;
2. To know the Eastern and Western perspectives on positive psychology constructs with special reference to Indian Psychology;
3. To discuss positive emotional and cognitive states and processes ;
4. To describe various positive psychology interventions ; and
5. To explain the applications of positive psychology in everyday life.

Learning Outcome

At the end of this course, the learner will gain knowledge about the field of positive psychology. The learner will be able to explain the meaning, objectives, and the historical background of positive psychology, and indicate how it is related to Indian psychology. The learner will have knowledge regarding research methods and assessment procedure in positive psychology. The learner will be familiar with various Indian psychological constructs having implications for the aims of positive psychology. The learner will be able to describe various interpersonal and intrapersonal character strengths and their role in promoting our well-being and achieving flourishing state of mental health. The learner will also know the applications of various positive psychological constructs in different fields such as relationships, school, and workplace.

Introduction

MPCE 046 consists of five Blocks and a total of 17 Units which you need to study and complete during the second year of your MAPC programme. You will have continuous evaluation through assignment and a Term-End examination. Assignments are available on the IGNOU website. You can download the assignments on www.ignou.ac.in > student support > downloads > assignments. Refer to the instructional guidelines on the assignment for your assignment preparation and submission. You can also refer to the previous year question papers available under downloads to prepare for your term-end examination (TEE).

You will need to go through the course material in this book presented in different Blocks and Units to do your assignments and prepare successfully for the exam. Each

Unit is like a chapter written in a structured way. It contains Self Assessment questions (SAQs) in between the sections in the Unit so that you can check your progress and go back to the content for more clarification. This will help make your learning better. Further, there are Unit End questions also at the end of the Unit that facilitates your overall understanding of the Unit. Key Words section highlights the key words in the Unit that will help you recall the main terms and concepts learned in the Unit. References section will help you refer to specific studies and articles to gain more understanding of a particular point discussed in the Unit. At the end of each Unit, you are also provided with suggested readings for your further understanding of the Unit. Thus, the various aspects of this Self Learning Material (SLM) are designed to help you learn better. These features also ensure that the teacher is built into the course materials to help minimize the gap or distance between the learner and the teacher.

IGNOU follows a multi-pronged approach to teaching and learning. Thus there are printed course materials, audio and video materials. The soft copies of the course materials are also available on the IGNOU website through *egyankosh*. Interaction between the teacher and learner is also facilitated through *Gyanvani* (interactive radio counseling), *Gyandarshan* (tele conference) and web conference. Gyanvani is available on FM (105.6 channel). Gyandarshan is a television channel, a must carry channel for all the cable operators. Information about Gyanvani and Gyandarshan monthly schedule is available on the IGNOU website. Webconferences and online sessions are also held from time to time by the Faculty of Discipline of Psychology and you will get the information about the same from your Regional centre. You can make use of all these features of learning at IGNOU to take your learning to a new higher level and make it a truly enriching experience.

BLOCK I FOUNDATIONS OF POSITIVE PSYCHOLOGY

Block I – Foundations of Positive Psychology will introduce you to the field of positive psychology with a historical perspective on it. Research methods and assessment process in positive psychology will be described. Various key character strengths and virtues will be discussed with their implications on human well-being. It will also throw light on how positive psychology is related to Indian Psychology. *The Block consists of five Units.*

Unit 1 Introduction to Positive Psychology

It defines positive psychology and explains the meaning, nature, objectives and the historical perspective of it. Positive psychology perspectives by Seligman and Wong are highlighted. Relationship of positive psychology with other areas of psychology is also described.

Unit 2 Research Methods and Assessment in Positive Psychology

The Unit focuses on various research methods used to conduct research in the field of positive psychology. It also highlights assessment in positive psychology and explains the ethical considerations.

Unit 3 Eastern and Western Perspectives on Positive Psychology

This Unit distinguishes between the western and eastern, specifically Indian psychological perspective. It highlights the contributions of Indian psychological perspectives to positive psychology. Further, it describes various religious and spiritual practices for enhancing one's well-being.

Unit 4 Character Strengths and Virtues: Interpersonal Strengths and Well-being

The Unit explains the concept of character strengths and virtues. Interpersonal strengths such as forgiveness, gratitude, kindness, compassion, altruism, and empathy are described and their impact on well-being elaborated upon.

Unit 5 Character Strengths and Virtues: Intrapersonal Strengths and Well-being

The meaning of intrapersonal strengths is explained and their importance in good mental health is emphasized. Specific intrapersonal strengths of growth mindset, multicultural mindset, grit and determination, self-compassion, and self-forgiveness are explained.

BLOCK II POSITIVE EMOTIONAL STATES AND PROCESSES

BLOCK II – Positive Emotional States and Processes focuses on the positive affect and emotions in human beings. *The Block consists of two Units.*

Unit 6 Positive Affect and Positive Emotions

The Unit focuses on the role and importance of positive emotions in promoting human well-being. It discusses the concept of emotional intelligence and emotion regulation. Strategies to manage emotions effectively are described.

Unit 7 Happiness

It explains the meaning of happiness and factors affecting happiness. Models of happiness including the Indian perspective on happiness are elaborated. Finally, measures to enhance happiness and well-being are described.

BLOCK III POSITIVE COGNITIVE STATES AND PROCESSES

BLOCK III – Positive Cognitive States and Processes elaborates on five important categories of psychological disorders that can affect human functioning and personal-social interaction. They are discussed in detail with regard to their symptoms, causes and treatment. *The Block consists of five Units.*

Unit 8 Self and Related Concepts

In this Unit, you will learn about the concept of self and its different aspects, and their role in enhancing our well-being. Difference between real self and ideal self will be highlighted. You will learn about the importance of self-esteem, self-efficacy, and self-regulation of behavior in our effective adaptation and functioning in life.

Unit 9 Resilience

This Unit focuses on resilience, one of the key positive psychological constructs which helps one to adapt and thrive in challenging situations. Evolution of the concept of resilience is highlighted and the application of key concepts in resilience research in different aspects is described.

Unit 10 Optimism and Hope

The meaning of optimism and its different types are elaborated. Further the concept of hope is explained. Benefits of both optimism and hope related to different aspects of our life are described.

Unit 11 Flow and Mindfulness

This Unit focuses on flow and mindfulness which are important to function optimally in life. The concept of flow, its meaning, components, and benefits are described. Further,

mindfulness is explained, and various mindfulness-based interventions and their impact on well-being are discussed.

BLOCK IV APPLICATIONS OF POSITIVE PSYCHOLOGY

BLOCK IV – Applications of Positive Psychology explains the application of positive psychology constructs and principles in different aspects of our life. *The Block consists of three Units.*

Unit 12 Positive Schooling and Positive Parenting

The Unit describes the applications of positive psychology in the context of parenting and schools. Components of positive schooling are described and models regarding applying positive psychology principles to schools are explained. Further meaning of positive parenting is described and strategies and techniques to engage in positive parenting are highlighted.

Unit 13 Applying Positive Psychology in Relationship, Family and Aging

This Unit focuses on the applications of positive psychology in the context of close relationships, family, and friendship. Further, the concept of aging is explained and ways to apply principles of positive psychology in successful aging is delineated.

Unit 14 Positive Psychology in Workplace, Health and Well-being

The Unit explains the meaning and scope of positive psychology in workplace. It discusses various key concepts of positive psychology applied to work. Further, it describes positive psychology interventions at work to enhance employee well-being.

BLOCK V – Positive Psychology Interventions focuses on various interventions based on positive psychology constructs and principles that contribute to flourishing and well-being in individuals. *The Block consists of three Units.*

Unit 15 Stress Management and Post Traumatic Growth

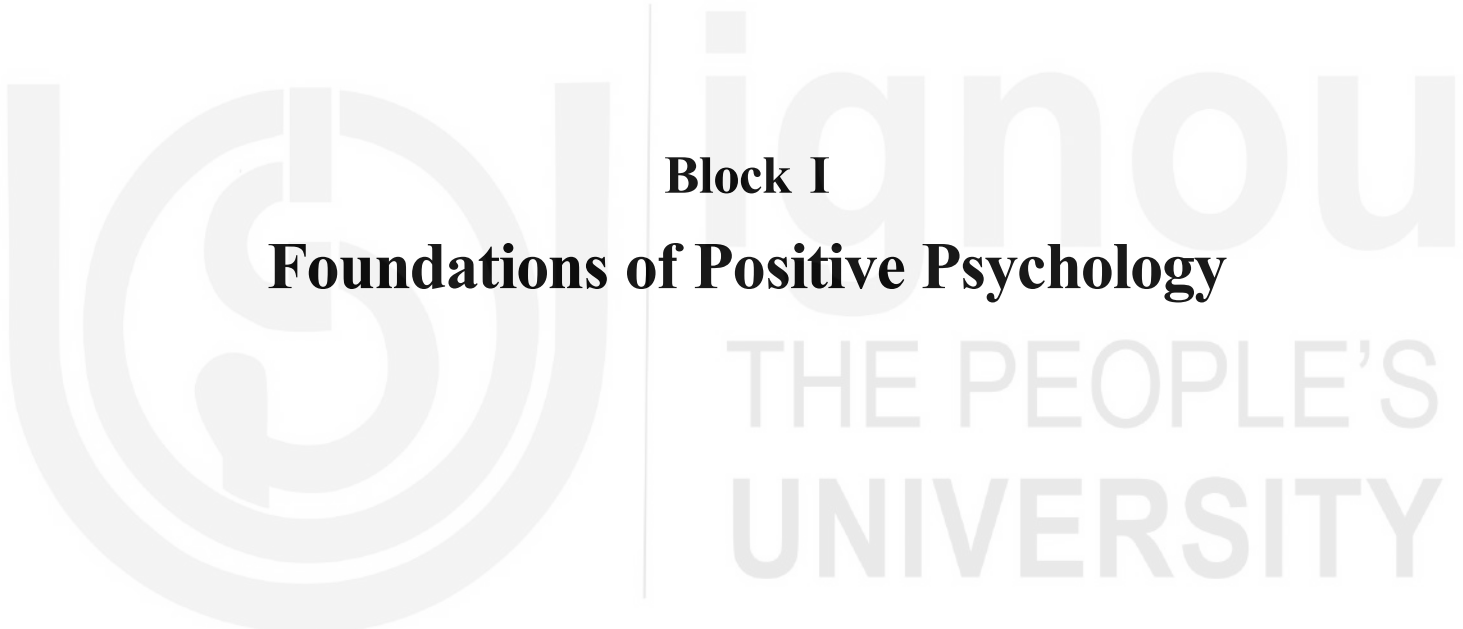
It discusses the concept of stress and elaborates on various strategies and techniques to manage stress. The meaning of post traumatic growth and its importance in contributing to mental health and well-being is also explained.

Unit 16 Yoga and Meditation

This Unit focuses on role of yoga and meditation in positive mental health. The meaning of yoga and meditation is explained. Ashtanga yoga of Patanjali is described in detail. Benefits of yoga and meditation are highlighted.

Unit 17 Current Trends and Future Directions in Positive Psychology

This Unit highlights the current trends in research in positive psychology. Further, it discusses the future directions in which the field of positive psychology needs to progress to develop as a robust and comprehensive field of study.

The background of the page features a large, light gray watermark of the Open University logo. The logo consists of a stylized 'U' and 'O' intertwined, with the text 'Open University' and 'THE PEOPLE'S UNIVERSITY' to its right.

Block I

Foundations of Positive Psychology

UNIT 1 INTRODUCTION TO POSITIVE PSYCHOLOGY*

Structure

- 1.1 Learning Objectives
- 1.2 Introduction
- 1.3 Positive Psychology 1 – Aims and Scope (Martin Seligman)
- 1.4 Positive Psychology 2 – Aims and Scope (Paul T. Wong)
- 1.5 The Concept of Well-being
 - 1.5.1 Descriptions of Well-being
 - 1.5.1 Definitions of Well-being
- 1.6 Historical Perspectives on Positive Psychology
 - 1.6.1 Positive Psychology and Other Social Sciences
 - 1.6.2 GDP to GNHI - Towards “Holistic Approach to Human Development”
 - 1.6.3 Value Crisis
- 1.7 Positive Psychology and Other Areas of Psychology
- 1.8 Applied Positive Psychology
- 1.9 Let Us Sum Up
- 1.10 Key Words
- 1.11 Answers to Self Assessment Questions
- 1.12 Unit End Questions
- 1.13 References and Suggested Readings

1.1 LEARNING OBJECTIVES

After studying this Unit, you would be able to:

- *Explain the meaning, and scope of positive psychology;*
- *Describe and define the concept of well-being;*
- *Differentiate positive psychology from other areas of psychology; and*
- *Explain how positive psychology can be useful to our lives.*

1.2 INTRODUCTION

Positive psychology is a **new field of inquiry** within modern psychology that emerged two decades ago, with an exclusive emphasis on understanding the nature of **happiness** and **well-being** and the conditions which promote them across cultures and societies. The aim was to help people to lead a **good life**. Hence, we can say that the field of positive psychology had an applied orientation from the very inception.

*Dr. Kiran Kumar Salagame, K., Former Professor of Psychology, Department of Studies in Psychology, University of Mysore, Mysuru

Martin E. P. Seligman, Professor of Psychology at the University of Pennsylvania and a Clinical Psychologist launched this new field of inquiry in the new millennium. He is well known for his postulation of “learned helplessness” as the explanation for the development of depression and later for his postulation of “learned optimism.” As President of the American Psychological Association in 1998, he chose Positive Psychology as the presidential theme for his tenure. He had a strong feeling that psychology has too long focused on studying negative emotions like anger, anxiety and depression and treated mental illness from a ‘disease model.’ He recognized that the discipline has not paid much attention to study what makes people to experience joy, satisfaction and contentment; to be healthy, resilient and grow; and to lead a meaningful, successful and worthy life. Therefore, he chose to usher in a new era of research in psychology discipline in the new Millennium.

Though Seligman presented his initial ideas on this new field in his presidential address at APA in 1998, they got crystalized in two meetings, one in January 1999 and another in January 2000 at Akumal, Mexico. The meetings were attended by a select group of psychologists who shared his vision. They drafted the first manifesto which has come to be known as “Akumal Manifesto”/“Positive Psychology Manifesto.” It was authored by Kenneth Sheldon, Barbara Fredrickson, Kevin Rathunde, Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi and Jonathan Haidt (<https://ppc.sas.upenn.edu/opportunities/conference-archives>). The vision and mission of this new field was formally made public to the academic community in the special issue of *American Psychologist* (January 2000) with the focal theme “Positive Psychology” (Seligman & Csikszentmihalyi, 2000). That issue included articles on pleasure and happiness, quality of life, subjective and psychological well-being, actualization of potentials and optimal functioning, creativity, optimism, hope, altruism, forgiveness, gratitude and spirituality. Another publication, with the title “On happiness and human potentials: a review of research on hedonic and eudaimonic well-being” (Ryan and Deci, 2001) in the *Annual Review of Psychology* catalyzed the interest among psychologists in this new field of inquiry. For the first time these two important publications brought together under one broad heading a wide range of previous researches that were conducted independently and separated in time and space by several investigators for many decades. Since then, ‘Positive Psychology’ has become a rallying point for many researchers already working on related themes.

Ed Diener’s previous work on “subjective well-being” (SWB) (Diener, 1984) and Carol Ryff’s publications on “psychological well-being” (PWB) (Ryff, 1989) became the primary or central foci of research, debate and discussion in the initial years because they had already worked for nearly two decades on them. They had also developed tools to measure those constructs (Diener, Emmons, Larsen & Griffin, 1985; Ryff & Keyes, 1995). In addition, Martin Seligman (optimism), Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi (flow), Charles Snyder and Shane Lopez (hope), Jeff Clifton (strengths), Christopher Peterson (character and virtue), Barbara Frederickson (positive emotions), Sonja Lyubomirsky (subjective happiness), Todd Kashdan (well-being) and Michael Steger (meaning and purpose) were some of the first few psychologists who published important books and research articles in quick succession in the initial year on their work and of others. All of them contributed for the development by providing the initial research inputs to define this new field. Their work served as the primary reference to outline its aims, objectives and scope. In addition, many products and practical techniques that are useful for practice have also been developed (see for example, (<https://positivepsychology.com/positive-psychology-interventions/>)).

As more researchers took interest in this field over the past two decades, the vision and scope of positive psychology has expanded further. Now positive psychology has passed its teenage age in its developmental phase, and has entered adulthood in 2021! In these two decades, the field has grown enormously with hundreds of books and thousands of articles published. They include both well researched scientific publications and also self-help books on how to be happy and achieve well-being. Thus, it has become hugely popular all over the globe, perhaps more than any other branch of modern psychology among researchers, mental health professionals, life coaches, educationists, management experts, and also among lay people because of its direct relevance to our day-to-day living.

Seligman and his associates in their initial thrust on positive aspects of human existence appear to have not paid much attention to the value of human adversities and suffering for human growth and defining well-being. This came under criticism from quite a few psychologists. Most vocal of them is Paul T Wong, a Canadian Professor of Psychology and also a Clinical Psychologist. He actively promoted his vision of positive psychology, known as *Existential Positive Psychology*. Wong emphasizes on the importance of pain, suffering and sorrow in human existence and their relevance in defining what is happiness, well-being and meaningful living (Wong, 2011). It cannot be said that Seligman neglected them totally. On the other hand, Seligman preferred to emphasize more on the positive side of human experiences. However, Wong, who is an Existential-humanistic psychologist, chose to highlight the relations between suffering and meaningfulness to well-being. Further researches resulted in new insights and shifts in the emphasis.

Thus, at present, there are two visions of positive psychology which are referred to as “**two waves**”- PP1 (Positive Psychology 1 - Seligman’s version) and PP2 (Positive Psychology 2 - Wong’s version). Hence, the definition, aim and scope of this field have to be understood in the context of these two major trends. It should be noted here that PP 2 is nearer to Indian perspectives on life and well-being. In this Unit you will be introduced to the meaning and scope of positive psychology; the context or background in which this new field emerged; its relation to other social sciences and to other branches of psychology; and its application in different domains.

Self Assessment Questions 1

1. _____ chose Positive Psychology as the presidential theme for his tenure as President in the American Psychological Association.
2. What is ‘Akumal Manifesto’?
3. The concept of Psychological well-being (PWB) was proposed by _____.
4. Wong’s vision of positive psychology is known as _____.

1.3 POSITIVE PSYCHOLOGY 1 – AIMS AND SCOPE (MARTIN SELIGMAN)

According to Seligman & Csikszentmihalyi (2000) the **agenda of Positive Psychology** are as below.

- To articulate a vision of good life that is empirically sound while being understandable and attractive.
- To show what actions can lead to well-being, to positive individuals, and to thriving communities.
- To help document - (i) what kinds of families result in children who flourish, (ii) what work settings support the greatest satisfaction among workers, (iii) what policies result in the strongest civic engagement, (iv) and how people's lives can be most worth living.

The PP manifesto says (Sheldon, et al., 2000) if one has to meet the objectives and achieve the aim of positive psychology “one must consider optimal functioning at multiple levels, including biological, experiential, personal, relational, institutional, cultural and global.” What does it mean? How can that be done? As per the manifesto we have to study:

- a) “The dynamic relations between processes at these levels.”
- b) “The human capacity to create order and meaning in response to inevitable adversity.”
- c) “The means by which ‘the good life,’ in its many manifestations, may emerge from these processes.”

As per the Positive Psychology Manifesto, “Positive Psychology is the scientific study of optimal human functioning.” It aims to “discover and promote the factors that allow individuals and communities to thrive.” The manifesto further states that positive psychology “represents a new commitment on the part of research psychologists to focus attention upon the sources of psychological health, thereby going beyond prior emphasis upon disease and disorder.” (Sheldon, et al., 2000, p.1). Another early pioneer of this field, late Christopher Peterson (1950-2012) says positive psychology is “the scientific study of what goes right in life” and what makes “life most worth living” (2006, p.4). To achieve these objectives, Seligman established a **Positive Psychology Center** in the University of Pennsylvania, in the United States. At present the vision and mission statements related to the definition, aims and scope of positive psychology are on the websites of the Department of Psychology and of the Positive Psychology Center (PPC). They are reproduced below because they provide a clear idea of this new field.

“**Positive Psychology** is the scientific study of the strengths that enable individuals and communities to thrive. The field is founded on the belief that people want to lead meaningful and fulfilling lives, to cultivate what is best within themselves, and to enhance their experiences of love, work, and play.” (<https://ppc.sas.upenn.edu/>).

“Positive Psychology aims to understand and build the emotions, and the strengths and virtues that enable individuals and communities to thrive. Positive Psychology has three central concerns: positive experiences, positive individual traits, and positive institutions.” - Angela Duckworth, Paul Rozin, and Martin Seligman. (<https://psychology.sas.upenn.edu/positive-psychology>).

According to Duckworth, Rozin, and Seligman, the three central concerns of positive psychology involve,

- “Understanding **positive experiences or positive emotions** consists in the

study of ‘contentment’ with the ‘past’; ‘pleasure’ in the ‘present’; and ‘hope’ for the ‘future’;”

- “Understanding **positive individual traits** means the study of strengths and virtues viz., the capacity to love, valour, altruism, grit, creativity, curiosity, integrity, moderation, self-control, spirituality and humor;” and
- “Understanding **positive institutions** involves the study of the strong families, communities, corporations and the virtues that nourish them such as justice, responsibility, civility, work ethic, leadership, teamwork, purpose and tolerance.” (<https://psychology.sas.upenn.edu/positive-psychology>).

1.4 POSITIVE PSYCHOLOGY 2 – AIMS AND SCOPE (PAUL T. WONG)

Dr. Wong is the Founding President of the Meaning-Centered Counselling Institute, Inc. (MCCI) and the originator of ‘meaning-centered counselling and therapy’ (MCCT), an ‘integrative existential positive psychotherapy.’ In Wong’s view, suffering is as much required for flourishing and growth as the experience of positive emotions. Therefore, he terms his vision as “Existential Positive Psychology (2.0) of Flourishing Through Suffering.” He also terms it as second wave of PP (see <http://www.drpaulwong.com/recommended-readings-for-the-existential-positive-psychology-2-0-of-flourishing-through-suffering/> - posted Nov 16, 2020). As he states:

“PP is intrinsically existential because it is concerned with such fundamental questions about human existence as: What is the good life? What makes life worth living? How can one find happiness? However, these existential questions cannot be fully addressed through PP research alone without recognizing people’s existential anxieties. A maturing PP needs to return to its existential-humanistic roots to rediscover the richness of the lived experience and the many pathways to meaning in life.” (Wong, 2016, p. 1).

Though Seligman’s vision and approach to PP has become very popular, it has been criticized for the overemphasis on positive emotions and undermining the significance of negative emotions experienced in our life. Existential-Humanistic psychologists are of the view that both pleasure and pain contribute to our well-being. Viktor Frankl, a German psychiatrist who survived the Holocaust during Hitler’s regime and later developed his therapeutic approach known as ‘Logotherapy’ argued that there is a strong relationship between depression, anxiety, and meaninglessness. Based on his personal experiences and of his fellow prisoners in the ‘concentration camp’ he realized that when a person loses all hope and a sense of purpose in life, he tends to become depressed and gives up. On the other hand, if he can take a perspective on his pain and suffering and searches for a meaning even in that negative circumstance, he can grow over that and feel a sense of well-being. Based on this he wrote the famous book *Man’s Search for Meaning*. In his view in the absence of meaning people try to fill the void in two ways: (i) by indulging in hedonistic pleasures and in the pursuit of power and materialism; (ii) and also by experiencing hatred, boredom, or neurotic obsessions and compulsions (Frankl, 1992, p. 143). Therefore, Paul Wong has focused on ‘suffering’ and

‘meaning’ as other important aspects in addition to the concepts discussed by Seligman as key themes of Positive Psychology.

Further, Wong notes that,

“Existential positive psychology (EPP) or positive existential psychology represents a natural amalgamation between PP and existential psychology. Basically, EPP addresses a few fundamental questions about self-identity and the human condition of striving for happiness within the constraints of reality.” (2016, p.1).

Some of the fundamental questions of the Existential PP include (1) “Who am I? What defines me?” (2) “How can I be happy? Why am I so dissatisfied with life?” (3) “What is the good life? Is this all there is to life?” (4) “What should I do with my life? What is my calling?” (5) “How do I make the right choices? How do I know that I am making the right decision regarding career and relationships?” (6) “Where do I belong? Why do I feel so alone in this world? How can I develop deep and meaningful relationships?” (7) “What is the point of striving when life is so short?” (Wong, 2016, p.1).

Thus, eight sources of a meaningful life have been repeatedly found through research: (1) Happiness and fulfilment, (2) Achieving something worthwhile, (3) Intimacy: marriage and family, (4) Good relationship with friends and people, (5) Self-acceptance, (6) Self-transcendence or altruism, (7) Religion and (8) Fairness or justice, (Wong 2011). Majority of human beings face such questions sometime or other irrespective of gender, race, color, socio-economic-status, caste, nationality, and others. Finding satisfactory answers to such questions give us a direction and meaning for our life and also satisfaction. On the other hand, failure to resolve such questions can cause anxiety and depression and may lead to suicide.

Self Assessment Questions 2

1. Positive Psychology is the scientific study of optimal human functioning.
True/False
2. Name the three central concerns of positive psychology.
3. Who has talked about ‘flourishing through suffering’?
4. Logotherapy has been proposed by whom?
5. What is the second wave of PP?

Comparison of the Two Visions/Waves of Positive Psychology

Both Seligman and Wong agree that the primary aim of positive psychology is to understand the nature of good life or worthy life and the conditions which facilitate such a living. Hence, there is no difference in their basic vision, i.e., **promoting good life and flourishing**. However, the differences lie in what they have focused upon, for what they give importance, from what philosophical and methodological framework they approach positive psychology. Paul Wong (2016) has provided us a comparative view of his vision of PP and of Seligman’s vision, which is presented below in Table 1.1.

Table 1.1: Comparative View of Seligman's and Wong's Visions of Positive Psychology

WAVE ONE (PP1) - MARTIN SELIGMAN	WAVE TWO (PP2) - PAUL WONG
1 Focuses on the positive only.	Focuses on both the positive and the negative.
2 Avoids the topics of suffering and death.	Embraces the topics of suffering and death as precondition for authentic happiness.
3 Emphasizes positive emotions.	Emphasizes responsible action.
4 Happiness oriented, self-fulfillment focused.	Meaning oriented, self-transcendence focused.
5 Direct pursuit of happiness may backfire.	Direct pursuit of meaning leads to authentic happiness.
6 Flourishing achieved through focusing on the positive and avoiding the negative.	Flourishing achieved only through confronting the dark side of human existence.
7 Truncated understanding of well-being.	Complete understanding of well-being in the midst of suffering.
8 Focuses on elements of well-being, such as behavior, cognition, affect, and so on.	Focuses on the whole person, taking a holistic and person-centered approach.
9 Distinct from humanistic-existential psychology.	Informed by humanistic-existential psychology.
10 Based on the positivist paradigm.	Based on the human science perspective.
11 Dichotomous and binary.	Dialectical and interactive.
12 Based on empirical findings from psychological laboratories.	Based on empirical findings from both psychological and real-life "laboratories."
13 Based on individualist culture.	Based on both individualist and collectivist cultures.

Thus, both quantitative and qualitative methodologies and mixed-method procedures need to be used to gain more insights about the basic issues of positive psychology than limiting ourselves to either of them.

Reflective Exercise 1

Now, before you proceed to read more, pause for a while...

Recollect, reflect and write your answers for the following questions.

- What are all the different sources from which you seek happiness?
- What are all the actions you undertake to get happiness?
- What makes you unhappy? What makes you dissatisfied?
- What makes you to have a sense of well-being?

1.5 THE CONCEPT OF WELL-BEING

Well-being is a central concept in positive psychology. Prior to Seligman, other researchers, mainly Bradburn, Ed Diener and Carol Ryff have already discussed about happiness and well-being and made significant contributions. Dodge, Daly, Huyton and Sanders (2012) have sought to distinguish between ‘description’ and ‘definition’ of well-being which is described below.

1.5.1 Descriptions of Well-being

Bradburn (1969) noted that high psychological well-being indicates more of positive affect than negative affect and low psychological well-being indicates the vice-versa. Ed Diener’s (1984) concept of Subjective Well-Being (SWB) is associated with two elements (1) positive and negative affect (2) and life satisfaction. The Satisfaction with Life Scale (SWLS) with five items only is developed by Diener (Diener, et al., 1985) and is the most widely used measure for research on well-being. The two kinds of affect are not opposite ends of a dimension, rather they are two distinct dimensions and each person can have both the affects. It is the predominance of one over the other that is indicative of high or low well-being. In positive psychology literature, SWB is associated with the ancient Greek notion of hedonia which implies seeking pleasure. Throughout his career Ed Diener worked on understanding and measuring SWB and published more than 200 articles and also a few books (Eid & Larsen, 2008).

Another important contribution came from Carol Ryff (1989) who questioned the idea of limiting the notion of well-being to pleasure seeking or happiness as is usually called. Ryff’s concept of Psychological Well-being (PWB) goes beyond one’s affective experiences. It focuses on knowing to what extent a person has been able to develop one’s self in terms of six different psychological dimensions viz., autonomy, environmental mastery, personal growth, positive relations with others, purpose in life, and self-acceptance. PWB is equated with the Greek notion of eudaimonia which means seeking meaning life. Ryff’s concept of PWB is informed by the Humanistic psychologists’ thrust on human potential and self-actualization. “Psychological Well-Being Scale” (Ryff & Keyes, 1995) is another most employed instrument in research on well-being next only to SWLS. It has many versions with differing number of items.

Seligman’s PERMA is the newer addition to this. Dodge, et al., (2012, p.226) note that Seligman’s “new theory of well-being concentrates...on elements of well-being,” which he believes are “a set of building blocks for a flourishing life” They are: *Positive Emotion, Engagement, Relationships, Meaning, and Accomplishment* (PERMA).” (Italic added for emphasis). Seligman himself seems to have changed the goal post of positive psychology from his first book (*Authentic Happiness* -Seligman, 2002) to his second book written after a decade (*Flourishing* – Seligman, 2011). He states,

“I used to think that the topic of positive psychology was happiness. I now think that the topic of positive psychology is well-being, that the gold standard for measuring well-being is flourishing, and that *the goal of positive psychology is to increase flourishing.*” (Italic added for emphasis. Not in the original). (Seligman, 2011, p. 13-15, cited in - Dodge, Daly, Huyton and Sanders, 2012).

Seligman asserts,

“Well-being theory denies that the topic of positive psychology is a real thing; rather the *topic is a construct* – well-being – which *in turn has several measurable elements, each a real thing, each contributing to well-being, but none defining well-being.*” (Seligman, 2011, p. 13-15, cited in - Dodge, Daly, Huyton and Sanders, 2012). (Italics added for emphasis).

The topics studied under positive psychology may be considered to represent facets/patterns/factors of well-being in a broad sense. As early as the year 2002, Marie Wissing, a South African researcher, had conducted factor analytical studies independently to arrive at a “*g*” *factor of psychological well-being* similar to the ‘*g*’ factor of intelligence found by Charles Spearman. She and her associates administered already available measures of affect, of SWB, of PWB, of social well-being and others in their studies. They found that the strong indicators of “*g*-factor” of psychological well-being are a *sense of coherence*, *satisfaction with life*, and *affect balance*. They also found that psychological well-being seems to be multidimensional with regard (a) to the facets of self that are involved (e.g., affect, cognition, behaviour); and (b) the domains of life in which these facets manifest themselves (e.g., intra- and interpersonal, social and contextual, in love and work) (Wissing & van Eden, 2002; Wissing et al 2002).

1.5.2 Definitions of Well-being

Just as there are descriptions there are definitions of well-being. A few examples cited by Dodge et al., (2012) are as follows.

Headey and Wearing (1992, p. 95) propose a definition of well-being in which well-being is shown, as depending on prior equilibrium levels of well-being and of life events, and also on recent events. (Dynamic equilibrium or set point theory).

Reber, (1995, p. 750) is of the view that well-being should be considered to be a state – a condition of a system in which the essential qualities are relatively stable.

Shah and Marks (2004, p. 2) state that “Well-being is more than just happiness. In addition to feeling satisfied and happy, well-being means developing as a person, being fulfilled, and making a contribution to the community.”

So, what is well-being? Is it a composite of many elements or is it a state of mind of a person? Dodge et al., conclude that Aristotle’s idea of eudaimonia is now more commonly translated as well-being and most researchers now believe that well-being is a multi-dimensional construct.

Self Assessment Questions 3

1. Name the two elements associated with the concept of Subjective Well-Being (SWB).
2. How many dimensions are there in Ryff’s concept of Psychological Well-being (PWB)?
3. What does PERMA consist of?
4. Well-being is more related to Aristotle’s idea of eudaimonia. **True/False**

1.6 HISTORICAL PERSPECTIVES ON POSITIVE PSYCHOLOGY

There are two ways of writing the history of a discipline viz., internal history and external history (Leahey, 2004). Internal history refers to the emergence of a field and the developments within it from its inception up to a particular period at which time the historian wishes to write. External history goes outside the disciplinary boundaries and looks at the social and cultural events and the context in which a particular discipline emerged and what are the influencing events. Here an external historical approach is followed in which not only you will learn how and when positive psychology emerged but you will also learn in what context it emerged and how it is relevant locally and globally.

Happiness, well-being, flourishing, good life, meaningful life and others are not new concepts and topics in themselves. Perhaps these topics have been the subject of human inquiry ever since man acquired the ability for self-reflexivity and began to contemplate on the meaning and purpose of one's existence. Globally humans have developed some notion of happiness over several millennia (Lomas, Case, Cratty and Vander Weele, 2021). Therefore, it is best to say positive psychology has a long past but a short history, as it is said about many other topics in our discipline. In psychology, Humanistic psychologists had already dwelt on the issues related to human potential and quality of human life in many ways and most importantly in terms of self-actualization and growth. Abraham Maslow (1954) had already used 'positive psychology' in his discussions on motivation and personality. Carl Rogers's concepts of acceptance, unconditional positive regard and genuineness; James Bugental's emphasis on authenticity, Sidney Jourard's research on self-disclosure and many others were discussed under the notion of "healthy personality" (Jourard & Landsman, 1980). In other words, there already existed a background to think about positive aspects of human existence. What differentiates Seligman's vision is his insistence on empirical and quantitative methodology that is characterized by "nomothetic approach", as against humanistic thinkers who laid stress on "idiographic approach" that emphasizes on uniqueness of individual persons. Humanistic thinkers' emphasis on phenomenological approach to study of subjective experiences in understanding an individual led to marginalization, because the quantitative and experimental approach of mainstream scientific psychology seem to be much easier to carry out.

The immediate antecedent factors that provoked Seligman to think about positive psychology is his interaction with his five year old daughter Nikki. The incident is as follows: One day he and his daughter were doing some garden work and he got irritated by her playful and jovial behavior in carrying out the task. That interaction is reproduced here as described by him.

"Daddy, I want to talk to you."

"Yes, Nikki?"

"Daddy, do you remember before my fifth birthday? From the time I was three to the time I was five, I was a whiner. I whined every day. When I turned five, I decided not to whine anymore. That was the hardest thing I've ever done. *And if I can stop whining, you can stop being such a grouch.*" (Seligman & Csikszentmihalyi, 2000, p. 6). (Italic added for emphasis).

He says, it led to a shift, in himself as well as in his thinking about the discipline, from negative emotions to positive emotions eventually to the emergence of positive psychology.

Another important incidence that led to the launch of a new field was Seligman's chance meeting with Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi in a beach resort. Csikszentmihalyi (1990) had been working on the concept of "flow" which is related to "optimal human experience" and functioning. Both of these persons had not met earlier though they knew about each other and their works. In this chance meeting they spent days together discussing about the status of psychology as a discipline, the direction it has taken and finally agreed that there is a need to focus on the positive aspects of human nature.

Seligman & Csikszentmihalyi (2000) note that psychology concentrated more on "repairing damage within a disease model of human functioning" and "neglects the fulfilled individual and the thriving community." Further, they observe that "Psychologists have scant knowledge of what makes life worth living" and they know "very little about how normal people flourish under more benign conditions". The focus of psychology, David Myers (2000) says, is "on illness more than health," "on aggression more than love;" and "on fear more than courage." Myers noted that from the year 1887 to 2000, *Psychological Abstracts* of APA published nearly 80,000 articles on depression, more than 50,000 articles on anxiety, about 10,000 articles on anger. On the other hand, articles on joy, happiness, and life satisfaction ranged between 800 to a few thousands. It was this anomaly, which made Seligman to say that we as specialists have focused too much on negativity. To set this right, to "begin to catalyze a change in the focus of psychology from preoccupation only with repairing the worst things in life to also building positive qualities", they launched this field.

1.6.1 Positive Psychology and Other Social Sciences

Since the main theme of positive psychology is happiness, well-being and flourishing, this field of inquiry is related to other disciplines in social sciences such as economics, political sciences, and sociology on the one hand, and to medicine, psychiatry and public health on the other. In general, we can say that positive psychology has relation to any discipline or a branch within it that has something to do with human welfare. Much of the earlier studies that were conducted by social scientists on 'quality of life' focused on certain 'social indicators' that ensures a better life. Such indicators include socio-economic conditions of a society such as GDP, infrastructure development, civic amenities, health and hygiene, crime rate, absence of religious conflicts, governance and others that distinguish developed nations from developing and underdeveloped nations. Those studies were conducted in the past and are still being conducted with primary focus on what are called 'objective factors.' However, in the past few decades, research on social indicators have shown that objective factors alone will not suffice to ensure happiness and well-being. When we examine the social climate as the context for the emergence of this new branch, it is obvious that many of the indicators of developed nations are not leading to the sense of satisfaction. The USA is one of the super-rich countries and also known as super power in the world. Yet, how is that Seligman and others felt the need to usher in this new field of inquiry?

Paul Wachtel (1989) also a Clinical Psychologist brought out this very well in his book titled *The Poverty of Affluence: A Psychological Portrait of the American Way of Life*. The author provides a diagnostic insight to the American situation and the quality of life

lived there. This work highlights the shadow side and the sad state of American life. Another piece of evidence is the many cross-national studies on the relationship between economy and the index of life satisfaction. It is found that many economically poor countries are at par with economically rich countries on the index of life satisfaction (Diener & Oishi, 2000). For example, one study (cited in Seligman, 2002) shows that USA with Purchasing Power Parity (PPP) of 100 on a scale of 1-100, has a life satisfaction score of 7.75 on a scale of 1-10. The same study shows that India has a life satisfaction score of 6.70 even though PPP of India is only 5. Just a difference of one point on life satisfaction index for a difference of 95 points on PPP! We are more satisfied than Americans though our country is considered as one of the poor and developing nations! More commonly economic wealth and political power are valued as important contributors for a better quality of life. GDP of a country is regarded as one of the important indicators of a nation's development. FORBES magazine keeps listing out the richest persons in the world and in a particular country periodically. Surprisingly, however, the clinical observations and empirical evidences show that this is not true. Money and power need not necessarily assure a better quality of living and well-being beyond a certain point. It follows the 'law of diminishing returns.' Therefore, now it is increasingly realized that happiness and well-being are not contingent upon the economic conditions and material affluence alone. Therefore, a geographically small neighbouring country like Bhutan, came up with the idea of GNHI (Gross National Happiness Index) as an alternative to GDP to understand the overall development of a nation and the extent of well-being experienced by its people.

1.6.2 GDP to GNHI - Towards “Holistic Approach to Human Development”

The term 'gross national happiness' was first coined by the 4th King of Bhutan, King Jigme Singye Wangchuk, in 1972 when he declared, “Gross National Happiness (GNH) is more important than Gross Domestic Product (GDP).” The concept implies that sustainable development should take a holistic approach towards notions of progress and give equal importance to non-economic aspects of well-being.” The GNH Index (GNHI) includes nine domains (1) Psychological well-being, (2) Health, (3) Education, (4) Time use, (5) Cultural diversity and resilience, (6) Good governance, (7) Community vitality, (8) Ecological diversity and resilience, and (9) Living standards. This idea was further developed by the Government of Bhutan in their Center for Bhutan Studies. A revised version of GNHI was released with 33 indicators in the 9 domains. These indicators and domains aim to emphasize different aspects of well-being, and different ways of meeting underlying human needs. GNHI was adopted through a resolution in the United Nations in the year 2011 by the support of 68 member states. The resolution calls for a “holistic approach to development” aimed at promoting **sustainable happiness and well-being**(<https://ophi.org.uk/policy/gross-national-happiness-index/>). Now Venezuela, UAE and India have established separate ministries/departments of happiness. Madhya Pradesh government first established such a department in India in 2017. Their motto is to enhance *ānanda*.

1.6.3 Value Crisis

Positive psychology also emerged in partial response to the value crisis experienced on the moral and ethical front in the American society and hence it is admittedly a cultural phenomenon (see Seligman and Csikszentmihalyi, 2000; Seligman, 2002). It has resulted in a renewed focus on the study of virtues and character strengths. *Values*

in Action Inventory of Strengths (VIA-IS) developed by Peterson and Seligman(2004) has become very popular among researchers. It is a systematic and comprehensive approach to the study of character strengths informed by all the major and lesser-known spiritual traditions of the world which include Buddhism, Christianity, Confucianism, Judaism, Islam, Sufism, Upanishads, Yoga, and many others. It is the best example of the response by psychologists for the value crisis experienced in American society. It has been translated in many languages and also cross-culturally validated in many countries (see <https://www.viacharacter.org/researchers/assessments/via-is>). A Hindi translated version of this inventory (Singh & Choubisia, 2009) is also available.

Thus, we have to understand the emergence and subsequent development of positive psychology in this background of American context. To certain extent the American context exemplifies the general Western situation where materialism has dominated the cultural ethos as compared to cultures in East and Asia. However, it has global implications because all over the world national governments are striving hard to better the quality of living and search for happiness in the material world.

Self Assessment Questions 4

1. What does the external history of a discipline refer to?
2. Phenomenological approach focuses on studying the subjective experiences in understanding an individual. **True/False**
3. The concept of 'Flow' is attributed to whom?
4. Which country has used the term Gross National Happiness (GNH) first?

1.7 POSITIVE PSYCHOLOGY AND OTHER AREAS OF PSYCHOLOGY

Within the discipline of psychology there are many branches which have contributed insights for the development of positive psychology. Baumgardner and Crothers (2014) identify the following as most important: health psychology, clinical psychology, developmental psychology, personality psychology, social psychology and the psychology of religion. Let us briefly review their significant influences.

• Health Psychology and Positive Psychology

Research findings from various studies affirm that stress, anger, resentment, anxiety and worry have the potential health threatening effects. A variety of related research show that those who undergo long periods of extreme stress are more vulnerable to illness. It is found that negative emotional states, the brain and rest of the nervous system, the endocrine system and the immune system interact in a complex way leading to negative impact on our health. "Psychoneuroimmunology", a new field of research came into existence in the 1980s to understand these complex pathways and mechanisms. Investigations in this new field have documented that the mind and attitude play a significant role in the functioning of the immune system, leading to illness.

In another direction Barbara Fredrickson investigated the relation between positive emotions and our sense of well-being. She proposed what she calls "broaden and build theory." According to her theory emotions like joy, contentment, interest, love,

and pride “all share the ability to broaden people’s thought-action repertoires and build their enduring personal resources, ranging from physical and intellectual resources to social and psychological resources” (2001, p. 219). It is also observed that expressions of positive emotions in early life have a significant relation to our longevity. Danner, Snowdon and Friesen, (2001) found from their longitudinal research on 180 nuns that the relation between probability of survival to an advanced age and the early-life expression of positive emotions appeared very strong. They found that the most cheerful of the nuns in the study live a full decade longer than the least cheerful. It is now known as “Nun Study.” In this background the role of positive emotions in maintaining and enhancing our health has gained significance. Baumgardner & Crothers (2014, p. 7) state as follows: “According to the results of the Nun Study, the phrase, “don’t worry, be happy” is excellent advice. You may live longer!”. Therefore, studying positive emotions is one of the three important foci of positive psychology.

• Clinical Psychology and Positive Psychology

The relation of clinical psychology to positive psychology can be traced back to how the concepts of mental health changed over the years from an exclusive focus on removal of symptoms of an illness to building positive health.

First, the clinical psychologists, followed the early ‘medical model.’ They were preoccupied in removing symptoms in treating a mental disorder to restore normalcy and health because the absence of illness was considered as the primary criterion of health. However, a famous psychiatrist, Thomas Szasz, vehemently opposed this idea. In his classic paper *Myth of Mental Illness*, Szasz argued that any disease, disorder and illness must have a definite location and relation with the pathology of our anatomy, physiology and biochemistry. It must be definitely related to any one of the organ systems in our body. That is, to consider something as an illness there must be an organic/physical basis. Since, in many so called mental disorders and illnesses one cannot demonstrate any such physical basis or relationship he argued that we cannot consider them as diseases. We have to treat them as “**problems of living**.” *Second*, with the emergence of Behavior Therapy and Behavior Modification many of the abnormal behavior considered as mental illness were viewed as either ‘**learning deficits**’ or ‘**excess**’ in learning due to faulty conditioning – classical and instrumental. *Third*, in Cognitive Therapy symptoms of many mental disorders are viewed as manifestation of ‘**irrational beliefs and thinking**’ leading to negative emotions. *Fourth*, Humanistic psychologists saw them as ‘**failure in a person’s growth**’ and ‘**inability to actualize one’s potentials**.’ *Fifth*, Systems therapists viewed many mental illnesses as manifestations of a ‘**dysfunctional family constellation**.’ Many such insights shifted the perspective from looking only at causal relation between symptoms and underlying pathology to what is healthy in a person. Thus, reduction of symptoms was not the only concern of a counsellor or therapist. Even helping the person to develop what is healthy and strength in a person was also considered important leading to the concept of ‘positive mental health.’

Marie Jahoda (1958) in her classic work *Current Concepts of Positive Mental Health*, identified the following six approaches to the definition of positive mental health: (1) attitude toward own self; (2) growth, development, and self-actualization; (3) integration; (4) autonomy; (5) perception of reality; and (6) environmental mastery. As we discussed already Carol Ryff incorporated some of the above into the construct of psychological well-being (PWB). But we do not have well developed models of positive health and what characterizes positive mental health, just as we have models of

psychopathology and diagnostic categories like DSM and ICD. In other words, “what personal characteristics and what type of life define the extreme opposite of mental illness— a state Keyes and Haidt (2003) call “flourishing?”. We have yet to find out what they are. Therefore, another goal of positive psychology is to establish criteria and a language defining the presence of positive mental health that parallels our current criteria and language for describing and diagnosing mental illness.” (Baumgardner & Crothers, 2014, p. 7).

• Developmental Psychology and Positive Psychology

What conditions in life facilitate healthy development is a long-standing issue in developmental psychology? The debate about ‘heredity vs. environment’ and ‘nature vs. nurture’ is well known. Developmental psychologists have studied for long the role of environments – physical, psychological and social, on the development of humans at various age period. The role of deprivation and disadvantage (cultural, social, economic and educational); of family environment (parental conflicts, abuse and alcoholism); and of the incidences of mental illness in the family with a genetic history have been studied in relation to the physical, emotional, cognitive, moral and ethical and social development. It is found that any kind of such adverse circumstances can affect one or more aspects mentioned leading to certain deficits. However, as Baumgardner & Crothers (2014, p.7) note all such studies were carried out from the assumption of a “deficit model” and these “assumptions began to change in the 1970s when many psychiatrists and psychologists drew attention to the amazing resilience of certain children and adults subjected to potentially debilitating life challenges (Masten, 2001).” It is now found that cases of resilience i.e., “good outcomes in spite of serious threats to adaptation or development (Masten, p. 228)” are more common than previously supposed.

Another concept which has demonstrated the relation of development psychology to positive psychology is “posttraumatic growth” (PTG). It is the opposite of “post-traumatic stress disorder” (PTSD). Earlier it was mentioned that all persons who face adversities in life and stressful situation will not react to them in the same way. While some who are vulnerable to stress may develop various kinds of illness, there are good number of people who come clean and stronger from such adversities. Research evidence is accumulating as the shift in focus from PTSD to PTG has occurred. It is found that “positive growth can occur as a result of traumatic experiences like serious illness, loss of a loved one, or a major accident or disability (Ryff & Singer, 2003a). In the aftermath of such events, many people report a greater appreciation for life and their loved ones, an increased sense of personal strength, and more clarity about what is most important in life.” (Baumgardner & Crothers, 2014, p.7). Research documenting the amazing resilience of ordinary people facing difficult life circumstances” and exhibit personal growth have increased and that highlights a major theme of positive psychology, viz., **studying human strengths**.

• Personality Psychology and Positive Psychology

The reading of the history of psychology of personality shows that several decades ago the terms ‘virtue’ and ‘character’ were considered as not scientific because they are value loaded terms. Hence, the term ‘personality’ was introduced by Gordon Allport as a neutral and scientific term in their place. Today we have come a full circle reclaiming those terms as valid concepts of scientific investigation! (See Section 1.7.3 on Value Crisis). Not only them, topics like altruism, forgiveness, gratitude, love, courage, creativity, meaning, wisdom, spirituality, transcendence and many others which

Humanistic Psychology associated with Self-Actualization have also been studied with a new vigor.

There are many critics of Positive Psychology who point out that this field of inquiry has its foundation in Humanistic Psychology but has not been acknowledged sufficiently (Froh, 2004). Ever since Humanistic psychologists like Kurt Goldstein, Carl Rogers, Abraham Maslow, Clark Moustakas, Sydney Jourard and many others emphasized on self-actualization and growth there has been a thrust on understanding what characterizes **healthy personality** (Coan, 1974; Jourard & Landsman, 1980). A healthy person is regarded as one who is free from neurotic conflicts and is able to function optimally actualizing his/her innate potentials. Maslow (1971) distinguished between 'Deficiency-needs' and 'Being-needs.' Unlike persons who are engaged only in fulfilling their deficiency needs to maintain some kind of homeostasis, those persons who function to fulfill their Being- needs manifest healthy personality characteristics. Many of those characteristics are now termed as **positive traits** and **positive strengths**, which is another important focus of positive psychology. They include both temperament and personality traits which are related to individual well-being. Important ones among them are hope and optimism, self-esteem, extraversion, a positive outlook on life, and pursuit of meaningful goals.

- **Social Psychology and Positive Psychology**

By now perhaps you have understood how our happiness and sense of well-being is dependent on many factors. We as humans do not live in isolation and we are always acting and interacting with others. Therefore, it is a matter of common sense that our health, happiness, and well-being depend as much on our relationships with others as on our own innate nature and material aspects of our life. Our interpersonal and social relations contribute quite a lot for our experience of well-being as we keep growing old.

Importance of satisfying interpersonal and social relationships and social support from significant others is amply demonstrated in many studies. Such satisfying relationships are found in happy marriage and having intimate friends. Corey M. Keyes (1998) postulated the concept of "**social well-being**" with five dimensions validated by empirical investigations. They are: *social integration, social contribution, social coherence, social actualization* and *social acceptance*.

Further, social psychologists have also sensitized to the fact that there are cultural differences in the understanding of what constitutes happiness and well-being. Concepts of happiness in America and Japan, for example, are quite different. In addition, social psychologists have also found that affluence and materialism among many so called developed societies with a consumer culture as in the United States, for example, has a dark side to it. It is also found that people who are after material wealth and fame only and sacrifice fulfillment of important psychological needs may also sacrifice their own happiness and life satisfaction. Studies show that increase in income like the sudden wealth of lottery winners, has only short term effects (Diener & Oishi, 2005b). In the Indian context our joint family system can provide satisfying relationship provided it does not become too restrictive of personal growth leading to a feeling of emotional suffocation.

- **The Psychology of Religion and Positive Psychology**

Religion, irrespective of which denomination it is, has two primary aspects (1) faith in a God or Divinity and associated beliefs and practices; and (2) moral and ethical code

of conduct prescribed to be adhered to. In recent years, a distinction is made between religion and spirituality as well. Religion is often employed when one refers to the following of organized and institutionalized faith system by practicing the customs and rituals prescribed. Spirituality is employed when one refers to an individual's desire and efforts to connect with a superior universal principle through expansion of one's awareness, which transcends the limited perspective of different religions. The role of religious practices such as prayer and worship are examined in researches on healing of various physical and mental disorders. On the other hand, **moral and ethical aspects have been studied as virtuous living**. The study of virtue has a prominent place because the meaning of a good life or life well lived is strongly connected to traits like honesty, forgiveness, compassion, gratitude and wisdom. It is found that expressing human virtues contributes to individual well-being and well-being of others. Peterson and Seligman's work on character strengths and virtues already discussed in an earlier section is relevant in this context as well. In this sense religion has become an important topic within positive psychology.

Self Assessment Questions 5

1. What is psychoneuroimmunology?
2. Define posttraumatic growth.
3. Which therapy views symptoms of many mental disorders as manifestation of irrational beliefs and thinking?
4. What are the five dimensions of social well-being?

1.8 APPLIED POSITIVE PSYCHOLOGY

Both Seligman and Wong are Clinical Psychologists and hence professionally they have an applied orientation. Therefore, both are concerned about betterment of human life. Seligman's background as a therapist made him to visualize positive psychology as an applied field, because he felt psychologists have spent their time and energies for too long in "repairing the damage" rather than "building strengths" and "improving the lives" of people. This is very much reflected in the "Positive Psychology Manifesto." The "potential application" of this new field as envisaged in the manifesto include:

- ❖ "Improving child education by making greater use of intrinsic motivation, positive affect, and creativity within schools"
- ❖ "Improving psychotherapy by developing approaches that emphasize hope, meaning, and self-healing"
- ❖ "Improving family life by better understanding the dynamics of love, generativity, and commitment"
- ❖ "Improving work satisfaction across the lifespan by helping people to find authentic involvement, experience states of flow, and make genuine contributions in their work"
- ❖ "Improving organizations and societies by discovering conditions that enhance trust, communication, and altruism between persons"

- ❖ “Improving the moral character of society by better understanding and promoting the spiritual impulse within humans.”(Sheldon, et al., 2000, p.3).

There is a popular saying “proof of pudding is in eating.” That is, the quality of food cooked is indicated in eating. In the same way, in just a span of two decades the insights gained from this new field of inquiry has found application in different domains of life. Most of its central issues, such as well-being and happiness, character strengths and virtues, optimism, resilience, flow, positive education, positive therapies/ interventions, and positive organizations and communities are interdisciplinary in nature and they are not issues specific to a single area of psychology or to our discipline only. Currently positive psychology perspectives are evident in research and scholarship in many areas of human endeavor such as education, public health, health care, social and human services, economics, political science, neuroscience, leadership, management, organizational sciences and others. Currently principles of positive psychology have been applied more in the area of education, healthcare, organizational effectiveness and work life (Linley & Alex, Souders, 2021; www.positivepsychology.com). The scope and application of positive psychology is both interdisciplinary and multidisciplinary and spans across many domains of life. Thus, positive psychology has an applied orientation from its very inception. The ultimate aim of this new field of inquiry is to help people to get maximum out of their lives and feel they have lived a worthy life.

Reflective Exercise 2

- Think and reflect on the implications and applications of positive psychology in the field of school education.
- Human relationship is characterized by much more complexity in the present times than earlier. How positive psychology can be applied in the area of family relationships for creating peace and harmony?

1.9 LET US SUM UP

Positive psychology emerged within our discipline in the New Millennium to study scientifically the nature of happiness, well-being and flourishing and what conditions facilitate and ensure them. Martin Seligman ushered in this new field inquiry along with like-minded psychologists. The aim is to help people improve the quality of their life by providing scientifically valid information regarding what constitutes well-being and how to achieve that. In the past two decades (year 2000 to 2021) as the field has developed and matured into its adulthood, more researches have been undertaken on its three main focus viz., understanding of positive emotions, positive traits and positive institutions. Several books have hit the stands in book stores and hundreds of research articles in academic journals and popular articles also in print, electronic and social media have been published.

In addition, the very understanding of what should define the field has also changed. Seligman gave importance to certain elements which he termed as PERMA (positive emotions, engagement, relationship, meaning and achievement) as the building blocks of flourishing. Paul Wong, another psychologist with humanistic-existential orientation, emphasized on the importance of including struggles of human existence and consequent pain and suffering in deriving meaning for life and defining well-being and flourishing.

This extended the scope of positive psychology. He also termed his vision as the ‘second wave’ or PP 2 and Seligman’s vision as PP 1.

Positive psychology is related to other disciplines of social sciences and also with different branches within psychology itself. The research outcomes of the last two decades demonstrate that human beings within and across societies and cultures have different notions of what happiness and well-being mean. It is also found that pursuit of money and acquisition of wealth affect our happiness and sense of well-being only up to a point. In other words, the external and objective sources do not play a greater role in our feeling of happiness and well-being. Inputs from other branches of psychology support this view. In brief, it is now realized by many that sustainable happiness and well-being is intrinsic rather than dependent on extrinsic factors.

1.10 KEY WORDS

Positive Psychology	: is the scientific study of the strengths that enable individuals and communities to thrive, and results in optimal functioning.
Existential Positive Psychology	: emphasizes on the importance of pain, suffering and sorrow in human existence and their relevance in defining what is happiness, well-being and meaningful living
Second Wave of PP	: views that suffering is as much required for flourishing and growth as the experience of positive emotions.
Well-being	: is more than just happiness. In addition to feeling satisfied and happy, well-being means developing as a person, being fulfilled, and making a contribution to the community.
Broaden and build theory	: postulates that positive emotions like joy, contentment, interest, love, and pride broaden people’s thought-action repertoires and build their enduring personal resources, ranging from physical and intellectual resources to social and psychological resources.
Posttraumatic growth	: refers to positive growth that can occur as a result of traumatic experiences like serious illness, loss of a loved one, or a major accident or disability.

1.11 ANSWERS TO SELF ASSESSMENT QUESTIONS

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 1

1. Martin Seligman
2. ‘Akumal Manifesto’ is also known as the ‘Positive Psychology Manifesto’ which was drafted at Akumal, Mexico in two meetings held in January 1999 and in January 2000. Authored by Kenneth Sheldon, Barbara Fredrickson, Kevin Rathunde, Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi and Jonathan Haidt, it highlighted the focus on positive psychology.
3. Carol Ryff
4. Existential Positive Psychology

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 2

1. True
2. positive experiences, positive individual traits, and positive institutions.
3. Paul T. Wong
4. Viktor Frankl
5. The second wave of PP emphasizes that suffering is as much required for flourishing and growth as the experience of positive emotions.

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 3

1. positive and negative affect; and life satisfaction
2. six
3. Positive Emotion, Engagement, Relationships, Meaning, and Accomplishment
4. True

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 4

1. External history of a discipline refers to the social and cultural events and the context in which a particular discipline emerged.
2. True
3. Csikszentmihalyi
4. Bhutan

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 5

1. Psychoneuroimmunology refers to the study of complex interaction between our negative emotional states, and our brain, nervous system, endocrine system and the immune system, leading to negative impact on our health.
2. Posttraumatic growth refers to positive growth that can occur as a result of traumatic experiences like serious illness, loss of a loved one, or a major accident or disability.
3. Cognitive therapy
4. social integration, social contribution, social coherence, social actualization and social acceptance.

1.12 UNIT END QUESTIONS

1. Compare and contrast the aims, objectives and scope of PP 1 and PP 2.
2. Define the concept of well-being. Delineate the goals of applied positive psychology.
3. Throw light on the historical context of the development of the field of positive psychology.
4. Explain the interrelation between clinical psychology and positive psychology.
5. How positive psychology is related to the field of developmental psychology?

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UNIT 2 RESEARCH METHODS AND ASSESSMENT IN POSITIVE PSYCHOLOGY*

Structure

- 2.1 Learning Objectives
- 2.2 Introduction
- 2.3 Research in Psychology: Meaning and Goals
- 2.4 Types of Research
- 2.5 Process of Research
- 2.6 Research Methods in Positive Psychology
- 2.7 Assessment in Positive Psychology
- 2.8 Ethical Guidelines in Research
- 2.9 Let Us Sum Up
- 2.10 Key Words
- 2.11 Answers to Self Assessment Questions
- 2.12 Unit End Questions
- 2.13 References and Suggested Readings

2.1 LEARNING OBJECTIVES

After studying this Unit, you would be able to:

- *Gain an understanding of the meaning and goals of research in psychology;*
- *Describe the types of research conducted in psychology;*
- *Explain the research methods used in positive psychology;*
- *Elucidate the process of psychological testing and assessment in positive psychology; and*
- *Describe ethical issues in research in psychology.*

2.2 INTRODUCTION

In Unit 1, you learned about the origin of positive psychology and its scope. Well-being is the main focus of positive psychology. It talks about various character strengths that can help promote our well-being. As you know, research occupies a central place in the advancement of any field of knowledge. It provides evidence-based practices to apply the theoretical knowledge to practical applications so that it contributes to the betterment of human beings. Research in positive psychology focuses on studying

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positive psychology constructs, assessing these and designing interventions to enhance these strengths so that human beings can flourish. Further, given the widening scope of positive psychology affecting practically all the branches of psychology, research studies also focus on the application of positive psychology to these areas. Hence it is important to know about how research is conducted in the field of positive psychology, the traditional research methods as well as the modern developments in research methods, and the challenges of doing research in positive psychology.

In this Unit, you will learn about research in general in psychology and also in the context of positive psychology.

2.3 RESEARCH IN PSYCHOLOGY: MEANING AND GOALS

You have already studied about research in your MAPC First year. So you must be knowing that research is a systematic and objective process which follows various steps to arrive at a conclusion. Research is based on data inputs that provide us information about aspects of behavior and mental processes of human beings. For instance, we can study what personality traits are most significant in determining effective coping of cancer patients. We can find out how parental mental well-being can impact the child's development of positive personality traits. Or how our coping to a traumatic situation is influenced by our psychosocial and environmental factors. Thus research can be said to be ***a systematic study of some concept, phenomenon, or an issue***. It not only studies the particular concept to know in detail about the nature, characteristics, and components of the concept, but also studies the dynamic interaction of the concept with other relevant concepts or phenomenon. In the process, ***research aims at filling the gaps*** in our existing knowledge of the phenomenon. This adds to the body of knowledge in any area of research and leads to the development of theories and principles. The objective and systematic approach of conducting a research study ensures the reliability and validity of the data and findings based on this data. Research is required to develop the subject field knowledge and also to apply this theoretical knowledge to the practical field and in policy formulation.

The main goals of any research can be described as follows:

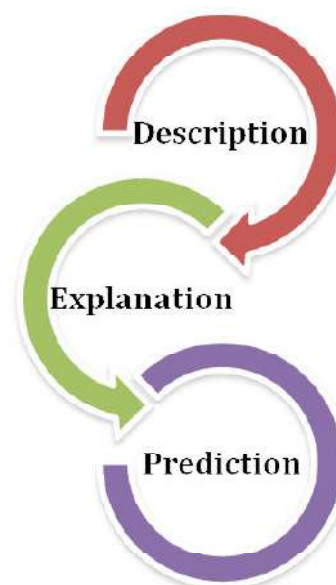


Fig. 2.1: Three Main Goals of Research

As you can see in Fig. 2.1 above, research helps us in **Description** of things, or phenomena. It provides a picture of the features of the constructs studied in a particular field, for instance, when we talk about ‘forgiveness’ as an important construct in the field of positive psychology, we need to know what exactly does it mean, what are its components, how does it happen, the process, and how does it relate to other concepts such as gratitude or differ from self-forgiveness. Thus research is important in understanding things, phenomena, and issues – their nature, relationship, and differences with other variables. This will help us to understand and explain their dynamic interaction with other related variables. Hence, the first important step in this direction is to describe the variables in scientific terms.

The next important goal of research is **Explanation**, that is, to explain the relationship between things or variables. This answers the “Why” of events and phenomena, e.g., why forgiveness can lead to reduction in stress level, or why cultivating a sense of gratitude can make it easier for us to forgive.

The third main goal of research is **Prediction**. When we know how things or variables are related to each other, and why a particular phenomenon has happened, it helps us in predicting things. For instance, feeling blessed or being thankful for good things that have happened to us may predict to what extent people can develop the ability to accept others and letting go of things. Thus intervention measures focusing on forgiveness may include ways to promote gratitude in the individual.

In short, we can say that research aims at,

- ***finding out relationship*** between different things, e.g., relationship between emotion regulation and mental health.
- ***studying the differences***, e.g., how do children differ in their emotion regulation from adolescents, or studying gender difference with regard to resilience or forgiveness.
- ***analyzing the influence or impact*** of one thing on another, e.g., how parenting style affects emotion regulation of children.
- ***predicting*** things, e.g., if a child will have higher emotion regulation, it will predict better mental health in the child and also at later stages of life.

From the above we find that research is carried out to fulfill different objectives. It gathers/collects evidence to answer proposed research questions. In addition to this, research can also be carried out to formulate theories, develop measures to assess psychological constructs, and develop evidence-based intervention strategies.

Thus research consists of observing the phenomena, recording them, analyzing them, and then interpreting the findings, making conclusions. In this process it follows a scientific approach marked by objectivity, reliability, validity and also ethical guidelines. Thus research can be said to be a **way of thinking** and it also consists of **certain skills**.

2.4 TYPES OF RESEARCH

In this section, let us see the various types of research which can be grouped under three broad headings as given in the Fig. 2.2 below.

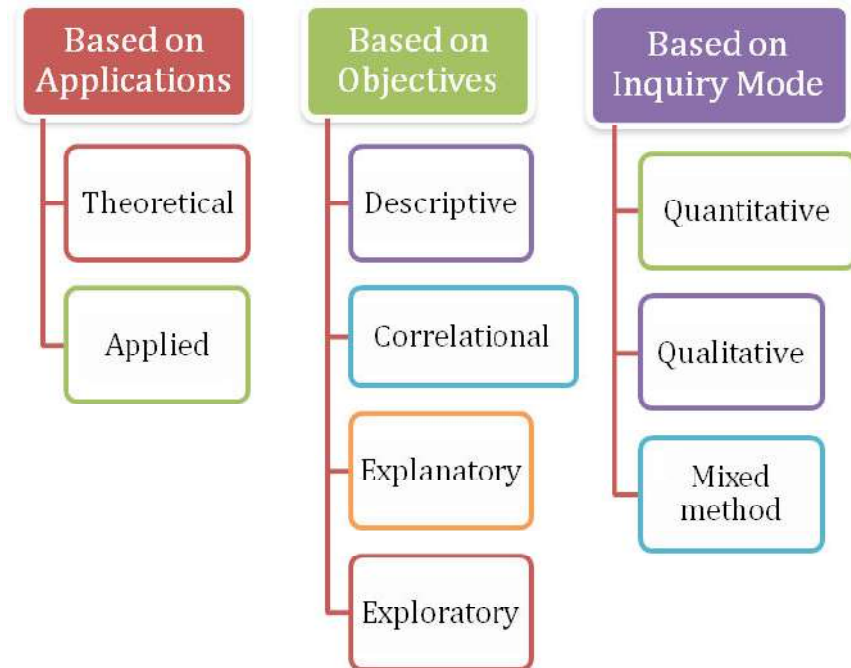


Fig. 2.2: Types of Research

(1) Based on Applications

- **Pure research/ theoretical research:** This kind of research investigates the basic concepts or phenomenon, e.g., memory, motivation, intelligence or personality etc. Theoretical research as the name suggests indicates assumptions or views based on which concepts and relation to their surrounding environment are explored. It helps in the advancement or knowledge build up in the particular discipline. The focus is development of knowledge for the sake of knowledge. However, it is not just describing and combining various sets of observations and proposing a theory. Rather, it includes logical analysis of assumptions and beliefs, developing theories and then testing these theories. It may also include reexamining the existing theories in the light of new developments in the field.
- **Applied research:** It focuses on the application of the theoretical knowledge to the actual field, e.g., how the body of knowledge related to memory can be applied in case of older people to help them in remembering important aspects in their daily life, or how it can be used to enhance student's academic performance. Thus theoretical knowledge is applied to practical situation, and knowledge is created from real experience rather than theoretical or logical assumptions. This again feeds into the theoretical assumptions and enhances and refines the theoretical knowledge. Thus theoretical and applied or empirical research complement each other and together contribute to the advancement of any field of knowledge.

(2) Based on Objectives

- **Descriptive research**

Meaning: This type of research aims at describing things, describes the nature and the characteristics of a situation, thing or phenomenon. This can also be called as prevalence studies, e.g., mental health status of orphan children or the prevalence of depression among adolescents. It describes the things

systematically – it may be a phenomenon or program or service. For instance, the happiness curriculum programme implemented by the Government of Delhi in its schools can be studied as to how the program is being perceived by the students.

Thus it addresses the ‘what’ of the phenomenon, not the cause or the ‘why’ the things are as they are.

Methods: Descriptive research uses the methods of observation, survey, case study.

Advantages: It includes large data collection, cost effective, less time consuming, informs further research, and data collected in natural environment.

Limitations: It does not answer the ‘why’ of the thing studied, sample may not be representative, there may be biases of observation.

- **Correlational research**

Meaning: It studies the correlation or relationship between aspects of a phenomenon or an issue or thing. It finds out how the aspects are associated or related. Thus it studies two variables and finds out how change in one affects change in the other, e.g., how parenting style is related to the development of self confidence in children; or peer pressure impacting the mental health of students.

Methods: Correlational research uses observation method, survey questionnaire, interview.

Advantages: It establishes the association between variables.

Limitations: Correlation does not establish the causality or the cause and effect between two variables, i.e., what causes what. For example, there may be a correlation between self esteem and mental health of adolescents, but we cannot say whether poor self esteem in adolescents causes their poor mental health or it is the poor adolescent mental health that causes poor self esteem in them.

- **Explanatory research**

Meaning: As the term indicates, explanatory research aims at explaining things rather than just finding out if there is a relationship or not. It answers the ‘why’ of the research being done, e.g., why poor academic achievement leads to internet addiction? Or why a particular parenting style causes reduced self-esteem.

Method: It uses systematic design experimental method where there is more control exercised, the main variables can be manipulated and the external variables are controlled so that we know what impacts what.

Advantages: There is internal validity, the results are more conclusive. It explains the why of human behavior.

Limitations: The degree of control exercised may affect the result. Manipulation of the variable and controlling the extraneous variables is not possible in all situations. Further, human beings may behave differently in a controlled laboratory setting than in the natural environment/real setting.

- **Exploratory research**

Meaning: It explores the area of study to determine the feasibility of conducting a full proper research study. Hence it can be called a feasibility study or pilot study. It is an initial study which serves as a groundwork for a future study.

It is done when we have very less knowledge of a particular area or to find out if a study can be done on certain aspects, e.g., doing a study on the customs of a particular tribe or when we view an existing research topic from a new angle.

(3) Based on the Enquiry Mode

- **Quantitative**

Following a philosophy of rationalism, it refers to a structured approach of doing research. All the aspects of research are pre-determined. It emphasizes the quantity – the data is quantitative in nature. Result is quantified, analyzed by statistics, and then interpreted.

Thus replication of the study is possible and findings can be generalized.

- **Qualitative**

Qualitative research is more flexible in nature, no pre-determined set of steps, follows an unstructured approach. It follows a philosophy of empiricism, that is, 'knowledge acquired through sensory experiences', unlike the emphasis on 'reasoning' in rationalism approach. Data collection in qualitative research is an ongoing process. Inputs from the data influence the progress, path and direction of the research. Thus the process is dynamic and evolves.

Emphasis in qualitative research is on description and narration of the data rather than on analysis and measurement. It focuses on the experience of the participant. Hence it can provide rich and complex data sources. However, it may not be generalized.

- **Mixed method research**

It follows both quantitative and qualitative aspects, flexibility in some parts and structured in some other aspects of research design. Mixed method research can also involve data collection using both quantitative and qualitative ways. One's research objectives will determine whether one would go with quantitative, qualitative, or mixed method research.

Self Assessment Questions 1

1. Research aims at filling the _____ in our existing knowledge of the phenomenon.
2. The three main goals of research are _____, _____, and _____.
3. What are the types of research based on inquiry mode?
4. The 'why' of research is addressed by which type of research?
5. Quantitative research involves a philosophy of _____.

2.5 PROCESS OF RESEARCH

The process of research answers the “How” of research, that is, how a research is conducted. You must have studied about the process of carrying out a research study in your First year. Here the steps in doing a research study are provided for your recapitulation and clarification. We can divide the entire research process into six steps:

Step 1: Topic selection and Review of Literature

Step 2: Methodology

Step 3: Data collection, coding and analyses

Step 4: Findings, discussion and conclusion

Step 5: References

Step 6: Putting the research as a paper/ preparing a research paper

Let us discuss each of these steps in detail below.

Step 1: Topic Selection and Review of Literature

(1) Topic Selection Process

(a) Generation and development of research ideas

Research always starts from an idea. How does that idea come? And when you have an idea, how do you develop it?

- Discuss with your teachers and seniors like research scholars, consult the experts in the field
- Read the literature – read in a focused manner and go in depth on a specific area
- Ensure that the specific area you are exploring are addressing/concerned with contemporary/recent issues, not old issues on which already lots of research have been conducted.

How will you come to know about the current issues/concerns in the field? Read recent journal articles.

- Once you are interested in one particular area, then have a general reading of the theories etc. of the area and then move to the specific reading related to your topic.
- Ideas can also be generated through observation of oneself as well as other people around us in different situations and contexts.

A sense of curiosity, questioning the things, analyzing, synthesizing different aspects, keenness, creativity, thinking in new ways – all will help us to come up with ideas which then can be discussed or read through the literature.

(b) Evaluation of ideas as research-worthy

Not all ideas can be pursued as research. One needs to know whether it can be studied through research. A few things that we need to keep in mind here are,

- Going beyond the known. Ensure that we are not reinventing the wheel, i.e., it is already there studied widely in the field. Hence your idea need to go beyond what is known. So do a thorough literature survey of the particular area.
- Feasibility. Idea should be testable. One should be able to conduct a study on it. It should be feasible.
- Resources availability. One should also assess one's resources. Availability of resources plays an important role - human, material and financial resources to conduct the research
- Interest. You should be really interested in the topic. It should excite you to study the topic. Research is a long process requiring money, energy, time and hard work. So the topic should be such that it will sustain your motivation through the research journey.

(2) Review of Literature

It refers to finding out the related studies in the area of research you are interested in. Refer to journals, books, electronic search, encyclopedias, handbooks, and databases such as ERIC, JSTOR, PsychInfo, PubMed for doing the review of studies. Review of literature helps you to know the theoretical background concerning your topic, find out the studies related to the topic, and point out the research gaps. It helps in refining your topic and brings more clarity about the research methodology.

Difference between literature summary and literature review:

Literature summary simply summarizes whatever research has been conducted in a particular area. It presents the main findings of each study in the area. Whereas literature review is analyzing the studies in an area and finding out the research gaps, directions, limitations, scope etc. Thus in summary, it is presented study wise, whereas in review, it is presented theme-wise. Discussion and presentation centres around main themes that emerged from literature search.

Thus Review not only summarizes but also evaluates the studies in an area and highlights the relationships, main points, contradictions, gaps, unanswered questions. It also points out future research direction. It tries to take a comprehensive look at the existing knowledge and integrates it, and in the process, points out/indicates the key concern areas and issues.

Research Problem/ Research Questions

You need to be clear about what you are going to study. It determines or affects the subsequent steps in the research. This aspect is very important as it puts you on a solid ground. Because when you know clearly where you want to go, you can take concrete and appropriate steps accordingly. It will help you formulate your research design, sample, variables, analysis etc. properly, e.g., to measure the effectiveness of a well-being program on the health of the older population or effectiveness of a motivational program on the motivation of the sportspersons or study how resilience affects the coping and well-being of the flood victims etc.

There are two aspects to a research problem: (a) People - your study population; and (b) problems, programmes and phenomena - the subject area.

Variables

You need to identify variables in your research study, and provide operational definitions. Mainly you have (a) Independent variable (IV), which we can manipulate and which causes the dependent variable; (b) Dependent variable (DV), which is the result and it depends on the IV; and (c) Extraneous variables, the external variables which we need to control as they can influence the dependent variable, and thus findings may not be valid.

Step 2: Methodology

(1) Objectives: It states in specific terms what you want to study.

(2) Hypotheses: These are tentative proposition/statement or assumption based on the existing studies. We can propose either null hypothesis or alternate hypothesis depending on the existing studies. The data collected is analyzed to see if it supports or rejects the proposed hypotheses.

There are possibilities that a hypothesis is wrongly accepted or rejected because of many factors such as a faulty design, or faulty sampling technique or improper data collection techniques etc. This leads to errors in hypothesis. Thus, when our null hypothesis is true, but we reject it, it results in *Type I error*. And when the null hypothesis is false but we accept it, it is *Type II error*.

In qualitative research, hypothesis is not required and also cannot be formulated as hypothesis needs to be specific in nature and qualitative research involves non-specificity in problem formulation. It aims at describing and exploring and subjective measurement of the variables.

(3) Research Design

It is a plan, strategy or blueprint of how you will go about conducting the research including the analyses of the data. It addresses how will you find answers to your research problems. It ensures that the study is conducted with a proper plan/design to achieve the objectives. It is not a faulty design or strategy. Thus it ensures or aims at getting accurate, objective, un-biased, and valid results – objectivity, validity and accuracy of the study procedures.

Research design clearly mentions how to go about the study – what design is to be followed, how the sample will be selected, how the data will be collected, what analysis will be used, how findings will be communicated. All this makes possible the replication of the study by other researchers.

Types of Research Design

(a) Research Designs based on the nature of investigation

Experimental: It studies the phenomenon under a controlled condition involving manipulation of the variable and randomization of the sample and/or treatment. Internal validity is usually high in a properly designed experimental research which indicates that the changes in the dependent variable have really resulted from the manipulation of the independent variable. However, this design is not suitable in many cases as it is not possible to manipulate all variables.

Non-experimental: The three main features of experimental design, that is, controlled condition, manipulation of variables and randomization are absent in non-experimental

design. It simply describes the variable, observes, finds out the difference or studies the relationship between variables in real life setting. Thus it includes descriptive research and correlational research design. Non-experimental research has the advantage of studying variables in their natural environment which also enables the researcher to study many variety of variables which is not possible in experimental design.

Quasi-experimental: This design studies cause and effect relationship like an experimental design. It also involves manipulation of the independent variable, but it does not involve random assignment of participants to the experimental and control group.

(b) Research Designs in Qualitative research

Qualitative research deals with data that is not focused on numbers as in the quantitative studies described in above research designs. It also does not rely on statistical techniques to analyze the data. Since the nature of data is different in qualitative design, the data is analyzed in different ways such as content analysis, conversation analysis etc. depending on the data unit.

Case study: It is both qualitative and quantitative study design. It is a detailed, in-depth study.

Focus Group/ Interviews: It involves collective interviewing of a small group of participants on a common issue. There is interactive discussion and the researcher as the moderator attempts to elicit the attitudes, beliefs, and emotions of the participants related to the topic of discussion.

Participant Observation: It involves participating in the particular group or community, and then observing the behavior of people in the group. Thus it provides an insider's perspective to the researcher on the study topic.

(c) Research Designs based on the number of contacts

- *Cross-sectional:* It studies the issue or phenomenon by taking a cross section of the population at the same time. Thus, both the study population and the time of study represent the same time point.
- *Before and after* (pre and post test): It is with reference to any intervention or program to see the effectiveness. It involves two cross-sectional data sets.
- *Longitudinal:* Pre and post design tells us the extent of change at two points of time. But it does not tell us about the pattern of change or how change has progressed/occurred. For this, we need to study the same set of population over a long period of time, collecting data from them at regular intervals. It is the same population, but it may not be the same respondents. Thus, a longitudinal design involves a series of repeated cross-sectional studies.

(4) Sample

Sample helps us to draw inferences regarding the study objectives from it to the population. Hence proper sampling technique needs to be used and due attention needs to be given to sample size, representativeness, and randomization. In Quantitative research there is pre-determined sample size, sample randomization, and probability and non-probability sampling. However, in Qualitative research, the focus is on non-probability sampling, ensuring an information rich sample, and ongoing data collection till a data saturation point.

(5) Tools

Quantitative research design uses standardized tools, or self developed questionnaire having reliability, validity, and norms. Whereas qualitative research makes use of interviews, observation, and focus group discussions. Primary sources and Secondary sources both are used for data collection.

Ethical issues: It is very important for the researcher to take care of any ethical issues that may come up in the research study, and follow all ethical guidelines such as taking the informed consent of the research participants, ensuring confidentiality, benevolence, avoiding bias by the researcher, following an appropriate research design, and accurately reporting data.

Research proposal: Sometimes the researcher needs to prepare a research proposal for the research study. Once the methodology step is clear, one can easily prepare the research proposal. The researcher can prepare it in the following format to ensure providing complete information about the research in the proposal. It needs to contain the following sections such as – Introduction, Review of literature, Theoretical framework for the study, Rationale of the study, Research questions, Objectives, Hypotheses, Research design, Sample, Tools, Ethical issues, Data analyses techniques, References and Appendix.

Step 3: Data collection, Coding and Analyses

Methodology is the main pillar of any research. It is like the blue print of any building. Once it is finalized, one can further proceed with collecting data and analyzing it.

Step 4: Results, Discussion and Conclusion

Findings of the study need to be reported in terms of the proposed hypotheses. Next, one needs to discuss these findings according to the earlier studies and theories. The researcher highlights the key findings of the study and points out the implications of the research study.

Step 5: References

References need to be written in the latest APA format (refer to www.apa.org).

Step 6: Preparing a research paper

The aim of any research ultimately is to disseminate the findings in the wider research circle and academia so that it adds to the general pool of knowledge in the field. Further, it will encourage discussion and interaction related to the research. Hence it is important to conduct a proper research following all the guidelines of doing a research.

Thus the entire research process can be divided into three main phases such as **deciding** the research topic (answers the ‘what’ of research), **planning** the research process (focuses on the ‘how’ of research), and finally **conducting** (collecting the required data) the research (Kumar, 2014, p. 35).

Self Assessment Questions 2

1. The “How” of research is indicated by the _____ of research.
2. When our null hypothesis is true, but we reject it, it results in _____ error.
And when the null hypothesis is false but we accept it, it is _____ error.

3. _____ is called as the blueprint of a research study.
4. Experimental design studies the phenomenon under a _____ condition involving _____ of the variable and _____ of the sample and/or treatment.
5. _____ is a detailed, in-depth study.
6. Longitudinal design does not tell us about the pattern of change or how change has progressed/occurred. True/ False
7. References in psychology are written in which format?

2.6 RESEARCH METHODS IN POSITIVE PSYCHOLOGY

Positive psychology mainly focuses on three broad areas of research: (i) positive experiences of the individual (it studies the subjective experiences, affective and cognitive states of the individual, contentment with the past, happiness at present, and hopefulness for the future, thus contributing to flourishing of the individual); (ii) positive individual personality traits (it studies the character strengths and virtues in the individual that will help the person to thrive); and (iii) positive institutions (it studies the factors and interpersonal dynamics that contribute to the well-being of the institution/organization as a whole (in addition to a focus on the individual well-being, it also studies organizational well-being, how an organization can grow and prosper along with its employees). Thus it aims at contributing to the well-being of individual as well as society and nation.

Various research methods are employed to achieve these objectives of the field of positive psychology. Quantitative as well as qualitative research methods such as observation, focus group, interview and case study are also used to collect data related to positive psychology constructs. Further, the applied nature of the field of positive psychology makes use of various positive psychology interventions to enhance mental health and well-being. Research in positive psychology also focuses on studying the effectiveness of these intervention programmes and thus contributes towards creating a pool of evidence based measures.

Pause for a moment and think what kind of research methods are likely to be used by researchers in the field of positive psychology? Given the objectives and agenda of positive psychology as described above, which research methods would be more suitable? Which methods will provide rich in-depth information/data to explore the positive psychology agenda of what makes life better, worthwhile, and how to move towards the transcendental stage to attain pure bliss or 'ananda'? What kind of research design can provide robust scientific way to do studies in positive psychology?

Since the inception of the field of positive psychology in 1998 with the declaration of Martin Seligman, lots of research studies have been done in these a little over two decades of time. However, research needs to be of good standard and follow a sound methodology. In any research, methodology occupies a central place and determines the quality of the research. Despite the field of positive psychology flooded with research

on various aspects of it, research in positive psychology has been criticized on methodological and other grounds as below (Wong, 2017; Cromby, 2011; McNulty & Fincham, 2011):

- Lack of methodological rigour
- Not many longitudinal studies
- Use of mainly self-assessment measures
- Studying the positive aspects only neglecting the negative aspects of human functioning
- Neglecting the cultural context in studying positive psychology constructs, their assessment and positive interventions
- Generalizability of research findings are questioned

A recent comparative review of current research methods in positive psychology has evaluated the methodological quality of research methods used in the field of positive psychology (Helwig et. al., 2020). On the basis of reviewing 250 studies in positive psychology and 187 studies in educational psychology published from 2015-2016, they reported less use of experimental methods in positive psychology research and more use of self-assessment or self-report measures. The overall quality of research methods used in positive psychology though was found to be good.

Based on their review study, Helwig et. al. (2020) have advocated the following for expanding research methods and enhancing research quality and effectiveness.

- use of other research methods instead of simple descriptive and correlational designs
- more longitudinal studies to focus on the development of positive psychology constructs
- large representative samples and diverse samples from varied sociocultural contexts and economic backgrounds
- employing more complex data analyses techniques

With the proliferation of research studies in the short span of two decades of positive psychology, it is important that it establishes its credibility through good research. As Snyder and Lopez has pointed out in the Oxford Handbook of Methods in Positive Psychology by Ong and Dulmen (2007, p. vi), the 21st-century positive psychology research needs to use the state-of-the-art techniques of science such as fMRI scans, and a variety of other techniques usually considered to be part of the 'hard' sciences. We need to move beyond the conventional way of conducting research and integrate neuroscience and artificial intelligence technologies into our research to facilitate a comprehensive perspective on the aspects of well-being and flourishing. Snyder and Lopez (in Ong & Dulmen, 2007, p. vi) also indicate at the use of multiple methodological techniques and triangulation of findings to strengthen and advance the research base of positive psychology. As noted by Rich (2017), use of more qualitative research methods will reduce the gap between the academia and the society and bring them closer.

Activity 1

Given below are some research papers on positive psychology. These depict how research is carried out in different aspects of positive psychology. Go through each of these journal articles and then write down: the main focus of the article, details of the sample (sample size, sample selection procedure, sample characteristics), tools used (psychometric properties), methods of data collection, data analysis techniques, contribution of the study to the field of positive psychology.

1. Rashid, T. (2015). Positive psychotherapy: A strength-based approach. *The Journal of Positive Psychology*, 10(1): 25-40
2. McGrath, R. E. (2015). Character strengths in 75 nations: An update. *The Journal of Positive Psychology*, 10(1): 41-52
<https://www.viacharacter.org/pdf/CHARACTER%20STRENGTHS%20IN%2075%20NATIONS-%20AN%20UPDATE.PDF>
3. Niemiec, R.M., & Pearce, R. (2021). The practice of character strengths: Unifying definitions, principles, and exploration of what's soaring, emerging, and ripe with potential in science and in practice. *Frontiers in Psychology*, 11, 27 January 2021. <https://doi.org/10.3389/fpsyg.2020.590220>
4. White, M. A., & Waters, L. E. (2015). A case study of 'The Good School:' Examples of the use of Peterson's strengths-based approach with students. *The Journal of Positive Psychology*, 10(1): 69-76
<https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC4241650/>
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<https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC4779362/>
7. Tomlinson, J. M., Feeney, B. C., & Van Vleet, M. (2016). A longitudinal investigation of relational catalyst support of goal strivings. *The Journal of Positive Psychology*, 11(3): 246-257. <https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC4795838/>
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<http://hiramweb.org/h/images/pdfs/psychology/SchuellerParks2012.pdf>
10. Wellenzohn, S., Proyer, R. T., & Ruch, W. (2018). Who benefits from humor-based positive psychology interventions? The moderating effects of personality traits and sense of humor. *Frontiers in Psychology*, 9, p. 821. doi: [10.3389/fpsyg.2018.00821](https://doi.org/10.3389/fpsyg.2018.00821)

11. Thin, N. (2018). Qualitative approaches to culture and well-being. In E. Diener, S. Oishi, & L. Tay (Eds.), *Handbook of well-being*. DEF Publishers: Salt lake City, UT. <https://www.nobascholar.com/chapters/9/download.pdf>
12. Halonen, S.M., & Lomas, Tim. (2014). A passionate way of being: A qualitative study revealing the passion spiral. *International Journal of Psychological Research*, 7 (2), 17-28. <http://www.scielo.org.co/pdf/ijpr/v7n2/v7n2a03.pdf>

Note: *If you want to first get familiar and know the positive psychology constructs to enable you to understand the above research studies better, you can read the other Units in this course, and then come back to do this activity later.*

2.7 ASSESSMENT IN POSITIVE PSYCHOLOGY

One important goal of assessment in positive psychology is to measure various positive psychology constructs. A central question in positive psychology is ‘What is a good life?’, ‘How can we all thrive in our life?’ ‘What makes life worth living?’ Answers to these indicate at various internal and external factors in one’s life. Internal factors include the character strengths in the individual. We need to know and measure these strengths so that they can be developed further leading to thriving and well-being. Hence assessment of constructs related to well-being is a crucial aspect of research studies in positive psychology.

Since positive psychology as a scientific field, has a western origin and the current field of PP is dominated by a western perspective, the measures to assess the variables may not be suitable for other sociocultural contexts. Hence there is a need to either adapt or develop indigenous measures of well-being constructs.

As researchers in the field of positive psychology, one needs to be familiar with psychological testing and assessment procedures. This will help to be aware of the various quantitative and qualitative methods of data collection, to know the characteristics of a good test, and understand the development process of a research instrument including psychological tests.

Quantitative research uses methods of data collection involving pre-determined questions and the data are expressed in numerical or category forms. Thus it mainly uses questionnaires, structured interviews and observation. Questionnaires need to be standardized which are called the psychological tests. Structured interviews include fixed set of questions. Observation can be in natural setting or controlled setting, and includes pre-decided points of observation.

Qualitative research uses assessment methods that are unstructured and flexible. Methods of data collection include unstructured interview where the researcher does not have any fixed set of questions. Rather it evolves as the interview progresses, though the researcher can have a broad framework of themes and issues related to the topic as an ‘interview guide’. Narratives, Focus group discussions, case study etc. can come under unstructured interviews. Observation is also used as a method of data collection which can be participant or non-participant observation. Although observation as an assessment method is used both in quantitative and qualitative research, the difference lies in the way in which data is expressed. Quantitative approach puts the data in category or scale form, whereas qualitative approach puts the data in narrative or description form. Secondary sources are also used as assessment methods in positive

psychology. It refers to various documents obtained from different sources that already contain the required information.

Technology and social media tools

In the current digitalized world, use of various technology and social media tools facilitate accessibility to the research participants, removes the constraints of time, distance and energy, and makes the data collection and intervention more convenient. However, such research needs to be robust with proper research design and taking care of ethical issues.

Psychological Testing :

The most widely used method to collect data is psychological tests/questionnaires which consist of various items/statements measuring the concept/aspect of study. These items are finalized and the test developed following the standardization procedure. As Anastasi had said, a psychological test is a standardized measure of a sample of behaviour. Thus the key aspect of a psychological test is standardization which ensures accurate results. Standardization involves (a) uniformity in test administration, instruction and scoring, (b) reliability of the test, (c) validity of the test, and (d) test norms. It helps not only in ensuring accurate results but also in replication of the study without any bias affecting it. Psychological assessment is a broader term than testing. Assessment involves collection of information from tests as well as other sources. It provides an overall picture of the individual.

Construction of a psychological test involves a detailed systematic process. You can find out the various tests available that assesses hope, optimism, well-being, mindfulness, gratitude, forgiveness and other constructs of positive psychology. One needs to check the social-cultural suitability of these tests in Indian context. Further, as the scope of positive psychology is widening and Indian psychological thoughts are being increasingly emphasized in the field of positive psychology, there is a need to develop measures for assessing these indigenous concepts important for well-being such as 'ahamkara', 'triguna' etc.

Various steps are involved in test construction as mentioned below.

- **Planning:** It involves first of all deciding on the variable for which a test needs to be developed. The target population, age group etc. need to be finalized.
- **Writing the test items:** the researcher needs to define the variable, find out the components of it, and then write items related to these.
- **Finalizing the test items:** It involves reviewing the items and getting expert feedback on the items.
- **Preliminary administration:** After expert review, the test is administered on a pilot sample. The objective of this first try-out is to check if the participants are facing any difficulty in understanding the language, if it is too easy for them, how much time they are taking to complete the test, clarity of instructions given, and any ambiguity in the test. Based on these, the test is revised, and items are deleted or modified suitably.
- **Final administration:** The test is now administered on a final sample that needs to be large and representative of the population for which the test is being

developed. The objective here is to carry out the item analysis, and then find out the reliability, validity and norms for the test.

- Test manual preparation: The manual for the test is prepared and the test can be published now.

2.8 ETHICAL GUIDELINES IN RESEARCH

The first professional code of ethics is the Hippocratic oath written around 400 BC. Ethics are important to guide our conduct in any field to ensure fairness and justice. Ethics refer to standards of conduct. It includes normative guidelines regulating the behavior of the researcher/professional and the relationship between the researcher/professional and the participant/client.

As a positive psychology researcher, it is important that one knows and follows ethical guidelines so that one can contribute effectively to the growth of knowledge in the field. The research participants collaborate with the researcher and help advancing the knowledge; hence their welfare needs to be ensured. Further, researcher needs to follow ethical guidelines in data collection and reporting the findings. Thus ethical guidelines apply at various stages of conducting a research as given below.

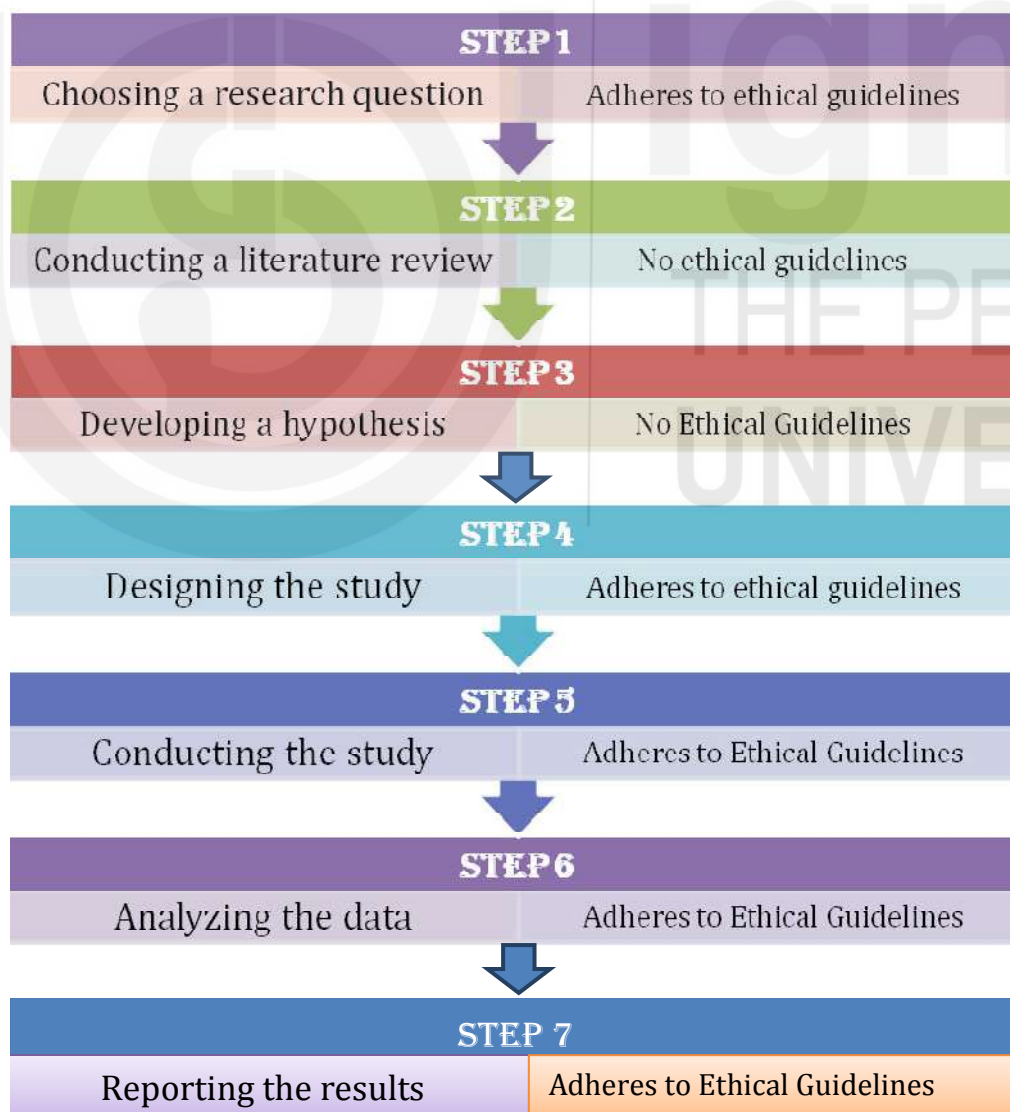


Fig. 2.3: Ethical Guidelines at Various Steps in Research

Source: McBride, D.M. (2016, p. 91). The Process of Research in Psychology. 3rd ed. Sage Publication, USA.

The Institutional Ethics Review Board of the Institution/University examines the research proposals for adherence to ethical guidelines at each step in the conduction of research. Standard reputed journals also require submission of ethical clearance for publishing your research.

Purpose of ethical guidelines can be described as follows:

- a) Ensuring the rights of each participant
- b) Focus on the welfare of the participant
- c) Causing no harm to the participant
- d) Maintaining confidentiality of information and data related to the participant
- e) Emphasizes adherence to professionalism by the researcher
- f) Focuses on the responsibilities of the researcher
- g) Promotes fairness and credibility of the research studies in the field
- h) Contributes to the growth of the discipline as a scientific field

The researcher needs to take care of the following *ethical aspects* while carrying out research. These are given below.

Informed Consent: The researcher needs to provide all information related to the participant and take the written consent of the participant to take part in the research process. The participant is free to withdraw from the research at any point of time.

Confidentiality: All the data related to the participant are kept confidential. However, there are exceptions to confidentiality especially when there is threat to the life of the participant or to any other's life, and also when it is required by the law.

Deception and Debriefing: Sometimes the researcher needs to hide the real objective of the study from the participant in order to avoid bias or desirability effect, e.g., In this case, the researcher needs to debrief the participant, that is, tell the real objective of the research to the participant after the data collection from the participant is completed.

Beneficence: The researcher needs to ensure the welfare of the participant.

Non-maleficence: Further, there should be no harm and maltreatment to the participant during the conduction of research.

Risk-Benefit Ratio: The researcher needs to see that the benefits of the research study outweighs the risk, if any, to the participants. Further, the risks should not be affecting the participants in any significant way.

The code of ethics given by the American Psychological Association (APA Code of Ethics, 2010, 2017) provides the guidelines that are followed by researchers in Psychology. It talks about general principles of ethics under five broad headings such as

Principle A: Beneficence and Non-maleficence

Principle B: Fidelity and Responsibility

Principle C: Integrity

(Refer to www.apa.org/ethics/code for APA ethical principles of psychologists and code of conduct)

APA code of ethics describes various ethical standards in detail under ten categories ranging from competence of professionals, education and training to research and publication, and assessment, and therapy. In India, the National Association of Psychologists (NAOP), a premier national body in the field of psychology, has also advocated for adhering to ethical guidelines in respect of dignity and well-being of participants, and integrity and professional responsibilities of the researchers/professionals in psychology.

Self Assessment Questions 3

1. Mention some of the qualitative research methods.
2. _____ research uses methods of data collection involving pre-determined questions.
3. Observation can be used as an assessment method in both quantitative and qualitative research. True/ False
4. Psychological assessment is different from psychological testing. True/ False.
5. Confidentiality in research needs to be maintained at all costs and there cannot be any exceptions to it. True/ false.
6. Debriefing happens before the data collection process begins in a research study. True/ false.

2.9 LET US SUM UP

Research and assessment are important aspects of any scientific field of study. They contribute to the advancement of the concerned discipline by expanding the scope, building up the credibility, and developing evidence-based practices. Hence it is important to know about research methods and research process related to the subject field. In the present Unit, you learned about research methods and assessment in positive psychology. The types of research methods and the process of research were described. Assessment procedure and procedure for test construction to assess various positive psychology constructs were explained. Finally, ethical guidelines to be followed during the research process were delineated.

2.10 KEY WORDS

- Research** : is a systematic study of some concept, phenomenon, or an issue.
- Descriptive research** : aims at describing things, describes the nature and the characteristics of a situation, thing or phenomenon.
- Empiricism** : includes acquisition of knowledge through sensory experiences.

Independent variable	: refers to that which we can manipulate and which causes the dependent variable.
Research design	: is a plan, strategy or blueprint of how you will go about conducting the research including the analyses of the data.
Quasi-experimental design	: involves manipulation of the independent variable, but it does not involve random assignment of participants to the experimental and control group.
Focus group interview	: involves collective interviewing of a small group of participants on a common issue.
Cross-sectional research design	: studies the issue or phenomenon by taking a cross section of the population at the same time.
Qualitative research	: uses unstructured and flexible assessment methods and involves in-depth analysis.
Psychological test	: is a standardized measure of a sample of behaviour.
Informed consent	: refers to consent given by the client/participant to participate in the research after being informed about the details of research.
Non-maleficence	: refers to that there should be no harm and maltreatment to the participant during the conduction of research.

2.11 ANSWERS TO SELF ASSESSMENT QUESTIONS

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 1

1. gaps
2. description, explanation, and prediction
3. quantitative, qualitative, and mixed methods
4. explanatory research
5. rationalism

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 2

1. process
2. Type I, Type II
3. research design
4. controlled, manipulation, randomization
5. case study
6. True
7. APA format

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 3

1. observation, focus group, interview and case study
2. quantitative

3. True
4. True
5. False
6. False

2.12 UNIT END QUESTIONS

1. Describe the meaning and goals of research.
2. Justify the statement ‘research is a way of thinking’.
3. Explain the types of research based on objectives.
4. Explain the process of topic selection in research, and differentiate between literature review and literature summary.
5. Explain the steps involved in psychological test construction.
6. Describe the research designs used in qualitative research.
7. Critically discuss the research methods used in positive psychology and suggest improvements.
8. Discuss the ethical guidelines in the conduction of a research study.

2.13 REFERENCES AND SUGGESTED READINGS

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UNIT 3 EASTERN AND WESTERN PERSPECTIVES ON POSITIVE PSYCHOLOGY*

Structure

- 3.1 Learning Objectives
- 3.2 Introduction
- 3.3 Distinction between Western and Indian Psychological Perspectives
- 3.4 Implications of Culture for Positive Psychology
- 3.5 Positive Psychology and Indian Psychological Perspectives
- 3.6 Religious and Spiritual Practices for Enhancing Well-Being
 - 3.6.1 The Challenge of Sustainable Happiness
- 3.7 Let Us Sum Up
- 3.8 Key Words
- 3.9 Answers to Self Assessment Questions
- 3.10 Unit End Questions
- 3.11 References
- 3.12 Suggested Readings

3.1 LEARNING OBJECTIVES

After studying this Unit you will be able to,

- *distinguish between Western and Indian psychological perspectives;*
- *explain the role of culture (i.e. Eastern and Western) in conceptualizing positive psychology;*
- *identify major contributions of Indian psychological perspectives to positive psychology;*
- *appreciate the religious and spiritual practices for enhancing well-being, and*
- *discuss the challenges involved in attaining sustainable happiness.*

3.2 INTRODUCTION

When you read a newspaper, watch news on the television or read popular magazines, one common thing that you may notice is that there are increasing incidents in which people are indulging in conflict, violence, corruption, crime, and other kinds of deviations from moral and ethical norms. In contrast, there are very few reports of cooperation, altruistic behavior, charity, and compassion. Either this may indicate that people are not happy and suffer from various kinds of problems; or stories of hope, values, strengths,

and resilience do not excite people as much as stories of conflicts, violence, and negativity. In other words, stories and news of what's wrong in people generate more attention and excitement than stories of positivity. Further, we also find that people in general want to attain peace of mind, happiness, and well-being.

Indeed, attaining an enduring state of happiness has been chosen as a goal worth pursuing by individuals and societies across the globe and this has been there since antiquity. It has become more prominent in the modern era with the dominance of market forces and the ideology of materialism. Coupled with a strong belief in individualism, the modernist ideology has created a state of cut-throat competition and fuelled desire to pursue incessant needs and accumulating more and more resources. The outward gaze has made happiness contingent upon the attainments in the outer world, which are subject to the availability of and access to material resources. As earth's carrying capacity is limited these resources are not in sufficient supply. Such a situation frequently causes frustration, conflict, and aggression. The net outcome is that well-being is frequently compromised. People often complain that their experiences of leisure, exercise, rest, health, and pursuit of excellence in professional engagements are being adversely influenced. We note that the experiences of stress, worry, anxiety, depression, and other negative emotions are showing a steep rise, and peace of mind and happiness are becoming increasingly elusive. Mental health is at stake and expenditure on medicines to ensure mental health is becoming disproportionately high in the rich countries from developed part of the world.

It may also be noted that the idea of happiness has been changing in different historical periods. Such differences are attributable to the changing life circumstances and perspectives on life. Indeed they are dynamically related to the modes of human interaction with the circumstances in the external world and the state of inner world. The biological structure of human beings has remained remarkably stable over time but the habitat has been changing on account of human intervention. In particular, technology has been playing a major role in determining the style of life. You may notice that the speed of social change has gone up owing to the introduction of increasingly advanced and sophisticated technologies in the areas of transportation, communication, and entertainment.

The response of psychology to the challenges in organizing human lives to pursue the goals of well-being, productivity, and mental health has traditionally been rooted in a deficit model and attempts were made to compensate for the problems and reduce the difficulties. Barring the work of Maslow (1971) and some other humanistic psychologists, the discipline of psychology remained preoccupied with mental illness and the dark side of human nature. Towards the end of the twentieth century, however, a strong academic movement started with a focus on building human strengths. As you have studied in Unit 1, Martin E.P. Seligman in his presidential address to the American Psychological Association (APA) in 1998, reminded that psychology is not just the study of weakness and damage, it is also the study of strength and virtue. Treatment is not fixing what is broken; it is nurturing what is best within ourselves (see Seligman, & Csikszentmihályi, 2000).), his efforts led to the articulation of the field of positive psychology (PP). As a subfield of the discipline of psychology, PP tries to address the challenges involved in conceptualizing, assessing, and nurturing human strengths at individual and organizational levels. It emerged as a protest against the deficit model prevalent in the practice of psychology and committed itself to bring in positive changes in individual and organizational lives of the people.

This tradition has been extended to India too and a large number of studies have been undertaken (see Mehrotra & Tripathi, 2019 for a review of Indian studies). Positive Psychology, however, shared the assumptions about social and psychological reality, attributes of human nature, and methods of investigation with mainstream psychology which is predominantly objective, quantitative and materialistic in its basic orientation (Baumgardner & Crothers, 2006; Snyder, & Lopez, 2002). It retains the perspective of mainstream psychological science and expands its agenda by incorporating the theme of human strengths and positivity. The pursuit of individual's self interest continues as a prime concern. However, the developments in cross-cultural psychology, cultural psychology, and indigenous psychology have increasingly drawn attention to the limitations of mainstream approach and advocated for alternative approaches to the study of psychological phenomena which emphasize on the key role of culture (Misra, 2003; Misra & Gergen, 1993; Gergen, et.al. 1996; D.Sinha, 1997).

The stream of Indian Psychology (IP) rooted in the vast intellectual resources available in the indigenous thought systems offers comprehensive and integral approaches to reality encompassing physical, social, psychological, and spiritual layers of existence. Its strategy is to maintain harmony with nature from a symbiotic perspective. Thus it goes beyond the pursuit of self interest and offers maintaining balance (*Samya*) as a central concern.

Similarly the ideas from other Eastern perspectives such as Confucianism, Taoism, Buddhism, and Islam also contribute to the understanding of the issues of well-being, good life and virtues. However, the Western and Eastern perspectives including Indian perspectives do share the need to develop certain human strengths and advance strategies for the same. This unit will help you familiarize and understand some of the main themes, concepts, and practices of Positive Psychology from Western and Eastern perspectives. In view of the relevance to your socio-cultural context, the key ideas from Indian perspectives to pursue health, happiness, and well-being have been presented in greater detail. The unit will help to appreciate the similarities and differences between the Western and Indian perspectives on positive psychology and give opportunity to understand your life style and bring changes to gain peace and well-being.

3.3 DISTINCTION BETWEEN WESTERN AND INDIAN PSYCHOLOGICAL PERSPECTIVES

Mainstream psychology as it exists today is primarily a product of the Euro-American cultural milieu. As such it has a short history but ideas about mental processes do have a long past beginning with Greek philosophical discourses. Modern psychology grew in the context of the ideology of modernity, industrialization, and development. It tried to emulate and adopt the model of natural sciences in order to gain an understanding of mental processes. In this exercise, use of scientific method emphasizing an outward gaze with a focus on observing external reality by a neutral observer became the chief methodological strategy. Also, quantification assumed a significant place in gaining the status of science. Today psychology is considered as a science focusing on mental processes and behaviors with the help of empirical methods. It has grown in many directions to serve the human needs in almost all areas of life. While its repertoire of methods and concepts has grown in many contexts, its prototypical form maintains the position of a positivist scientist and favors an objective stance toward reality. Of course,

there are many new developments that are constructionist in approach and opening up to respect, culture, subjectivity, and use of qualitative methods.

The modern discipline was transported from European countries and subsequently from North America to other parts of the world in the last one and a half-century. Many of these countries were colonies of the erstwhile European empires. As a result, the alien knowledge systems were imposed and indigenous psychological concepts and theories were ignored and marginalized. In India, the discipline formally started at Calcutta University in the year 1915-16 when Dr. N.N. Sengupta, a Harvard-trained psychologist, joined as a faculty. He was a student of Muenzinger who had his studies with Wilhelm Wundt, who is considered by many as the father of experimental psychology. Another pioneer was Dr. Girindrasekhar Bose who was interested in psychoanalysis and completed the first doctoral research in psychology in India on the concept of repression. Both these scholars did have interest in the Indian thought systems but the formal teaching and research in psychology remained confined largely to the Euro-American tradition of mainstream psychology (see for historical perspectives Sinha, 1986; Dalal, 2014; Misra et.al. 2021). This tradition has formed the formal or official perspective adopted in teaching and research in the Indian academia. Modern psychology in India has shown remarkable growth in terms of establishment of institutions and publications.

In general, the teaching-learning practices have been preoccupied with the concepts, theories, and methods developed in the Euro-American centers of learning. They were adopted and to some extent indigenized to study various issues in the Indian context (D.Sinha, 1997). The empirical researches thus used Indian samples and provided patterns of data reflecting variations in Western theoretical concepts. The use of concepts and theories of Indian origin was rare. The awareness of limitations of this approach led to various efforts towards indigenization of Western concepts and theories and incorporating concepts of Indian origin (see Bhawuk, 2011; Dalal & Misra, 2010; Misra & Mohanty, 2002; Salgame, 2011; D. Sinha, 1997). The term 'Indian Psychology' has been used for both the knowledge based on Indian data as well as the psychology rooted in the indigenous Indian intellectual tradition. However, the latter usage seems more appropriate.

In the modern period, the phrase Indian Psychology (IP) was first used by Jadunath Sinha (1931) to present a review and reconstruction of the repertoire of rich Indian knowledge systems related to mental functions and consciousness. Subsequently, he published two more volumes (J.N. Sinha, 1958, 1961) in this series. While there were many sporadic writings, it is only recently that IP has revived and gained some momentum and several volumes and contributions have been published (Akhilanand, 1948; Cornelissen, Misra, & Varma, 2014; Misra & Paranjpe, 2012; Misra, 2013; Paranjpe, 1984, 1998; Paranjpe & Misra, 2012; Rao & Paranjpe, 2016; Rao, Paranjpe & Dalal, 2008; Safaya, 1976).

As we know, the concepts, theories, and methods of IP have developed through centuries of testing and practice and are quite diverse as reflected in the Vedic literature (Vedas, Āraṇyaka, Brāhmaṇa, Upanishads), Vedāṅga, and schools of thought such as Vedānta, Sāṅkhya, Yoga, Vaiśeṣika, Mīmāṃsā, Cārvāka, Āyurveda, Buddhism, Jainism, and Taṇtra, to name a few. Out of these, the position of Cārvāka comes closest to the materialist view held in modern psychology. It did not consider any reality beyond what is perceivable through sensory modality. It advocated that one should enjoy life

thoroughly maximizing pleasure and minimizing pain. But this view could not receive prominence. Most of the other approaches are characterized by deep but diverse kinds of engagement with transcendental reality and are characterized by moral-ethical concerns. Also, there exist psychological concepts and insights in the huge corpus of literature of various Indian disciplines (Śāstra), epics (Mahābhārata and Rāmāyaṇa), Smṛiti texts, Purāṇa, Dharmaśāstra, Arthaśāstra, Kāmaśāstra, etc. Owing to deeply entrenched colonial mindset and institutionalization of Western-centric academic practices, most of these resources are still untapped.

Keeping the present context in view there is a need to familiarize ourselves with the classical Indian psychological perspective. Rao (2011), a prominent figure in the study of Indian Psychology, has noted that IP is the study of the person (Jiva). This person is not an isolated and disconnected entity as Jiva is transpersonal, bound by transcognitive states. The person is consciousness embodied. *Consciousness-as-such* is irreducibly distinct from the material objects, including the brain and the mind. Mind is different from consciousness as well as the body/brain-machine. Unlike consciousness, the mind is material, albeit subtle. Unlike the brain, the mind has non-local characteristics, that is, it is not constrained by time and space variables, as gross material objects are. Time and space are superimposed by the mind; they are thus the creations of the mind.

Explaining the problem of suffering, Rao (2011) argues that consciousness in the human context is conditioned by a vortex of forces generated by the mind-body connection. Consequently, the conditioned person becomes an instrument of individualized thought, passion, and action. From individuation arises subjectivity and ego. With the ego, come attachment, anxiety, distress, and suffering. In such situations, humankind seeks liberation (*Moksha*) by a process of deconditioning training and transformation so that access may be made to consciousness-as-such. To this end, brain-processed learning (*Sravaṇa*), mind generated understanding (*Manana*), and consciousness-accessed realization (*Nididhyāsana*) are required. Yoga is a method of liberation via the realization of transcognitive states. Depending upon one's disposition one may go for knowledge-focused *Gyāna yoga* or devotion-focused *Bhakti yoga* or action-oriented *Karma yoga*.

Thus we find that IP is broad-based in its assumptions about reality and encompasses physical, social, moral, and spiritual aspects of functioning in an integrated manner. It aspires to program and live life free from afflictions (*Jīvanmukta*). Also, the Indian approach does not view reality from the position of an individual. It is cosmocentric and views things in a complementary fashion. The microcosm and macrocosm do share similarity (*“Yatpiṇde, tat brahmānde”*, i.e., *whatever is inside you, the microcosm, it is also there outside you in the universe, the macrocosm*). Keeping various perspectives in view, Misra and Gergen (1993) have presented a comparison of the key features of the Indian and western perspectives as given below (Table 1).

Table 3.1: Key Features of the Indian and Western Perspectives

Indian View	Western View
Holistic-organic world view	Anthropocentric and individual centered world view
Coherence and natural order across all life forms	Belief in control over nature and humanly created order

A socially constituted/embedded and relational concept of person	Autonomous and bounded self with fixed and strong boundaries
Non linear growth in life	Belief in progress and growth
Continuity across various life forms	Belief in dualism and acceptance of a dichotomy between subject and object
Social individualism	Liberal ontological individualism and belief in freedom
The temporal and atemporal existence of human being	Linear perspective on time
Contextualized relationships depending upon time, place and person	Decontextualized, contractual and open ended nature of relationships
Emphasis on self discipline	Self-interest, pursuit of wants and preferences, and consumerism as important values
Shared and relational notion of control	Personalized nature of control
Knowledge as moral and sacred	Knowledge (science) as amoral (value free) and secular
Functional belief in multiple worlds (material-transitory and spiritual-eternal)	Functional belief in materialism and a utilitarian view in the service of possessive and self contained individualism
Dharma (duty) centered moral code	A moral code organized around the idea of right to self fulfillment and social contract

Source: Misra and Gergen (1993)

The above comparison shows that the Indian view differs from the widely held assumptions of Western psychology. More than materialistic-deterministic aspects of human existence, it assumes a more inclusive spiritual-growth perspective on human existence. This position has nurtured a worldview informed by continuity, interdependence, and connectivity across all life forms. It maintains an inclusive notion of the field rather than the individual as the center of reality. The field (*Kshetra*) and knower of the field (*Kshetrajya*) are not mutually exclusive. It focuses on finding out one's own *Svadharmā* (duty) according to *Svabhāva* (personal attributes) and pursuing one's own path of evolution in a wider time-space frame. The veridical methods of direct observation (e.g. intuition) are prescribed in contrast to empirical methods that rely on sensory data.

A fine blending of the first person and the second person perspectives is proposed. They work well within Guru/Preceptor (second) – Śiṣya/Disciple (first) person pedagogical approaches. It is reflected in the Upanishad tradition. Finally, it may be mentioned that knowledge in the Indian tradition was for liberation (*Sāvidyāvimuktaye*), which clearly goes against the desire to control over others reflected in the western ideal of 'knowledge is power'. The consciousness-based IP offers a more coherent framework for psychology than psychology with a material base as noted in mainstream psychology. Self as a subject is the focus in IP, but in

West, it is the object. Experience is at the center of awareness and knowing becomes being. There is direct personal involvement and Hindu, Buddhist, Jain, and Tantric traditions clearly focus on spiritual development. It must be understood that the Indian perspective is not merely inner-directed, spiritual, and otherworldly as characterized and projected in western writings and media. It is certainly not armchair speculation. It utilizes a comprehensive framework which attends the existential conditions ranging from physical to spiritual. In this way it becomes more inclusive than the materialistically oriented western psychology.

It needs to be noted that the physicalistic view of reality ignores subjective experience, and values as it is rooted in a kind of materialist reductionism. As Cornelissen (2003) has noted *‘we need, not only a comprehensive ontology, which does full justice to every aspect of our phenomenological existence, but also a coherent epistemology that does not cut off the branch on which it has perched itself. We need, in other words, an ontology and epistemology that cover all aspects of reality and that can support and refine all the different types of knowledge we as human beings can and need to develop’* (p. 41). He further notes that the Indian tradition bases itself on the experience that with training we can change our level of consciousness at will and rise up into levels of consciousness far beyond our ordinary human state. One such possibility is in Sri Aurobindo’s synthesis of Eastern and Western ideas. The resulting vision of an ongoing evolution of consciousness not only offers a perspective that restores meaning and hope to the human enterprise but also clearly indicates the direction in which psychology has to move if it wants to contribute something substantial to our individual and collective development. To learn more about the ideas of Sri Aurobindo, you can read *A Greater Psychology* (A.S.Dalal, 2001; also refer Sen, 1986). The Indian perspectives widen the scope of inquiry by complementing as well as suggesting new ways.

The Indian approach considers the pursuit of knowledge as a value-driven process. Knowledge is considered to be a purifier and pious (Bhagavadgītā says that there is nothing as pious as knowledge, *Na hi gyānena sadriśam pavitram iha vidyate*). Here it may be worthwhile to note that in the Western tradition, consciousness is held as a state of mind. It is a quality of experience accessible to introspection. In addition to waking consciousness, there are other pre /sub-conscious states and unconscious. The waking consciousness or ego receives input through sense organs from the external world, which is analyzed and interpreted. The Indian perspective endorsing ‘consciousness as such’ is held independent of these functions. Here we may note that a central concern of Indian psychological thought is transcendence in which focus is on the mind in relation to pure consciousness. The addition of the spiritual dimension to human functioning opens up new modalities of self-transformation and attaining the state of well-being. The Indian view holds that there are two kinds of knowledge empirical or worldly (*Aparāvidyā*) and higher spiritual (*Parāvidyā*). The knowledge obtained by consciousness is authentic. The sensory distortions and conditioning of the mind make it susceptible to errors.

Self Assessment Questions 1

1. The traditional approach in psychology was based on _____ model.
2. According to Seligman, psychology is not just the study of weakness and damage, it is also the study of _____ and _____.

3. Confucianism and Taoism are examples of Eastern perspective. True/ False
4. The phrase Indian Psychology (IP) was first used by whom?
5. Cārvāka philosophy referred to the materialist view. True/ False
6. Indian Psychology is the study of the person called _____.
7. Human beings can access the consciousness-as-such state of being through which processes?
8. Indian Psychology views reality only from macrocosm perspective. True/ False
9. Differentiate between western and Indian perspective on human existence.
10. What are the two kinds of knowledge according to the Indian view?

3.4 IMPLICATIONS OF CULTURE FOR POSITIVE PSYCHOLOGY

The idea of good life, well-being and flourishing are significantly shaped by the culture to which people belong. Understandings of such concerns are situated in the ideals and world views maintained in a given culture. They are often manifested in the religious practices, social institutions, value priorities, and parenting etc. As mentioned earlier positive psychology has evolved in North American cultural context; it essentially reflects the ideas of self, values and world view commonly accepted as Western which differs from their non-Western counterparts. The meaning, goals and practices for thriving and flourishing may not be similar across different cultures. As Christopher and Hickinbottom (2008) noted the field of PP seems to be narrow and ethnocentric by exclusive emphasis on Western individualism. Here it may be worthwhile to note that in reality the socio-anthropological meaning of 'culture' in terms of values, belief systems, and transmitted habits also relates to purposeful attempt at creating meanings and aesthetic values too. It involves purposeful engagement in expressive and creative activities which may rely upon the received traditions but also engages with conscious involvement of people. This kind of participation makes cultures dynamic. All this happens in specific ecological conditions. Therefore we need to understand culture in a pluralistic context and refrain from imposing an alien one and avoid distortions. In terms of coverage of humanity, western psychology as Henrich et al. (2010) consider is psychology pertaining to the world of WEIRD people from (Western, Educated, Industrialized, Rich, and Democratic) societies. It leaves the majority world unattended.

More recently Marecek and Christopher (2018) have questioned the premise that 'there is one set of practices applicable to all the groups worldwide'. It cannot be considered universal and transhistorical. Indeed, what is universal to the human species and what is unique to particular groups and communities need to be figured out. There is growing evidence that the individualistic models of self do not reflect selfhood in non-western collectivist cultural settings (Kitayama & Markus, 2000; Kagitcibasi, 1997; Mascolo, Misra & Rapisardi, 2004; Mishra, Akoijam & Misra, 2009). The ideas of individualistic and collectivistic (or independent and interdependent) modes of self construal seem to involve different meanings of good life. A fixed, essentialist, interiorized and atomistic self as separate from others is not tenable in non-western settings. Self

notions are interpretive in nature and depend upon the traditions in which they are embedded. Many non-western societies subscribe to two planes of reality consisting of a cosmological and an ordinary. The modern, secular and western view dismantled the two and went for a one tier system. The connect with social and natural order and God lost its meaning. The individual alone is responsible for deciding about good life. Individual is no more an element in a larger order. Freedom, autonomy and self expression became important.

However, the non-western perspectives like Buddhism, Taoism, Yoga, and Vedanta often emphasize that identification with ego results in attachment, sin, and negative emotions, leading to suffering and works as an impediment in spiritual growth. Instead, identification with greater entities like Atman, Brahman or infinite leads to mental peace and wellbeing.

The conception of happy and good life is not only a matter of emotional satisfaction and authentic happiness for the individual as proposed in the discourse of positive psychology. Happiness is part of a moral vision. The non-western cultures, for instance assign value to “giving” as a source of satisfaction. Thus charity (*Dāna*), helping others (*paropakāra*) and renunciation (*tyāga*) are seen as satisfying experiences. ‘Amae’ is a Japanese emotion which indicates a sense of hope for being lovingly cared for and dependence on another’s indulgence. The ‘Ifaluk’ ethnic people experience ‘fago’ which comprises of a combination of love, sadness and compassion for others (See Lutz, 1988). The Chinese are found to show dialectical reasoning which makes negative emotions more tolerable and less need to resolve ambiguity (Nisbett, 2003). Other-centered emotions occupy important place in non-western analyses of emotion states and well-being. Thus the sense of satisfaction is derived from different kinds of experiences and engagements. The idea of subjective well-being as considered in PPSy has been advanced as some kind of universal goal and suggestion has been made that nations must have provisions for accounting of subjective well being, happiness and life satisfaction of the people. For instance the monistic Vedānta maintains that one’s self is inseparable from rest of the world (non dual *Advaita*!). This kind of identity expands the scope of thinking about life satisfaction and approaches seeking well being of every one (*Sarve bhavantu sukhinah*).

Indeed the cultural variety in ideology and world view is very wide and beyond the scope of this Unit. Some of the relevant Eastern ideas, however, are mentioned here. The Chinese view as reflected in the philosophy of Confucius emphasizes morality. Empathy and taking care of others are given considerable importance. The emphasis is on attaining virtue. There are five key virtues include *jen* (humanity), *yi* (duty to respect others), *li* (etiquette), *zhi* (wisdom), and *xin* (truth). This view emphasizes on harmony. Taoism was practiced by Lao-Tzu, the ancient Chinese philosopher. His key term is ‘*Tao*’ which is complex concept meaning direction, thought, method, and movement. It is the energy that surrounds everybody. The Taoist understanding is experience based and participatory. The positive and negative experiences shape the understanding of Tao. The key to emerging development is a state of spontaneity or naturalness. It is expected that pursuing Tao would involve serious engagement and inculcation of virtues such as humanity, justice, temperance, and propriety. Taoism is best summarized by the *yin* (masculine and active) and *yang* (feminine and passive) principles. This implies that the world is dynamic and changing in such a way that one part depends on the

other part. So the experience of good and bad continue to follow one after the other. The best strategy to practice, therefore, is balancing.

Srivastava and Misra (2003) argue that Hindu Indians view happiness and sorrow as the results of past lives and not just the present ones. To the extent that one has no control over past lives, Hindu concepts of happiness appear to be consistent with the ancient Greek view. The Hindu Indians tend to feel happiness when they sacrifice their material possessions and/or respond to others' needs. Like Buddhist traditions, they see attachment to objects as a cause of suffering. Thus, Hindu happiness is concerned with the attainment of 'Ānaṇḍa' or a transcendental journey involving realization of connectedness or oneness. Buddhism holds that suffering is part of life and caused by desire. It recommends practicing non-violence and compassion for everyone. Freedom from desire is the key to happy life, allows to reach the state of Nirvana which is considered as free from bondage. It is a state which is characterized by complete harmony, balance and equilibrium. The core qualities or virtues include love, compassion, joy, and equanimity which are pursued by overcoming desire. The Buddhist followers of Anatta (not Self) view, propose and practice identification with nothing (Śunya) (see Levine, 2009). The Judeo-Christian-Muslim thought consider identification with the will of God and practice of spiritual surrender as the method to live happily and pursuing well-being. Islamic conceptions of happiness are also quite different from the American notion of happiness. The Islamic conceptions of happiness are anti-hedonic. In addition to stoicism, the Islamic view of happiness is centered on the fear of, total submission to, and worship of God.

There are empirical studies and literary analyses which tend to suggest that the Eastern cultures emphasize on relationships, have cyclical time orientation, emphasize on the context in which people and objects are situated. In contrast, the Westerners emphasize on the attributes, have linear time perspective and think in terms of internal control (See the interesting book *The Geography of Thought* by Nisbett, 2003) The implication of cultural differences (and similarities) is that any attribute or behavior has to be judged from the perspective of culture and interventions to improve well-being should also be undertaken accordingly.

A recent review of studies on happiness across cultures by Oishi (2018) has reported that Americans tend to associate excitement and success with happiness, whereas the Chinese tend to associate peace and calm with happiness. Similarly, Taiwanese and Hong Kong Chinese value low-arousal positive affect such as calmness, whereas Americans typically value high-arousal positive affect such as excitement. Christian texts often use high arousal positive emotions, whereas Buddhist texts often use low arousal positive emotions. The Japanese mentioned that happiness could disrupt interpersonal relationships via evoking envy and jealousy in others. In contrast, Americans' descriptions were concerned mostly with personal achievement and positive hedonic experiences (e.g., joy, smiling). Thus happiness is construed among Americans as a bond between people but in Japan it is considered as a high arousal an emotion that could disrupt important social relationships. They aim more towards achieving balance and harmony with others.

The meaning of happiness has expanded and changed over time in different parts of the world owing to different religious beliefs and economic, social, political, and physical conditions. The diversity found in the concepts of happiness across cultures and time poses a major challenge to empirical research on happiness.

Self Assessment Questions 2

1. What does WEIRD refer to ?
2. What are the two planes of reality propounded by eastern thinkers ?
3. How is subjective well-being considered in the non-western cultures ?
4. Taoism was propounded by whom ?
5. _____ view, propose and practice identification with nothing (Śūnya).

3.5 POSITIVE PSYCHOLOGY AND INDIAN PSYCHOLOGICAL PERSPECTIVES

Concerns and Approaches: Shared and Different

It is interesting to note that attention to PP and IP in the contemporary period is an outcome of dissatisfaction with the current state of affairs in the discipline of psychology. While positive psychology emerged as a protest against the deficit model and emphasis on pathology, Indian psychology has its roots in the realization of the hegemony of Euro-American psychology in India. Also, both of them emerged in the twenty-first century though both have a very long past. In the Indian scholarly works as well as folk traditions concerns for health and well-being have been prominent. Profound discussions on the concepts like *svāsthya*, *sukha*, *dukha*, *ānaṇḍa*, *ārogya*, and *prasannatā* etc. are available at many places. Similarly, we find elaborate discussions about human strengths like *paropakāra*, *sāhasa*, *dhairya*, *kṣamā*, *śānti*, *ādhyātma*, *pragyā* and *śīla* etc. However, the framework of the Indian psychological perspectives is different from positive psychology. The Indian perspectives on human nature have been articulated in an integrated way from the position of a higher state of consciousness that transcends the limits of ordinary awareness and space-time constraints. It may be recalled that the Upanishads considered happiness as a state that is intrinsic to human nature itself and reflected in a profound conceptualization of transcendental divine as existence-consciousness-bliss (*Sat-Chit-Ānanda*). In contrast, the Buddhist tradition dealt with suffering. The higher states of consciousness lead to a state of joyful equanimity.

Positive psychology has its roots in the works of Maslow on growth and self-actualization and peak experience. As noted earlier the current upsurge of PP is often attributed to the efforts of Martin Seligman and his presidency of the American Psychological Association. In broad terms PP draws attention to the exploration of optimal psychological functioning, investigating the nature and correlates of happiness and wellbeing, and conceptualizing and assessing virtues and character strengths (Peterson & Seligman, 2004) which are quite close to the Greek concept of eudaemonia. However, the question of whether hedonic and eudaemonia represent two different kinds of happiness is debatable (Kristjansson, 2010). In the Indian context happiness has a relational core (see Misra & Sharad, 2011).

We also find that IP and PP both the traditions of psychology emphasize potentials, strengths, and pursuit of well-being. The two streams of knowledge, however, differ in

several ways. The way of defining human existence, the basis of awareness, thinking, and action is conceptualized differently. It may be noted that the discipline of modern psychology as developed in the Euro-American settings is rooted in an evolutionary view in which humans are evolved form of animals. In contrast, the Indian view considers human beings as part of the divine. These two divergent standpoints on human nature implicate diverse agendas in regard to the definition of self, life goals, conceptualizing well-being and happiness, and approach to our habitat.

It may be noted that the satisfaction of biological needs and diverse cultural engagements are significantly conditioned by the ecological conditions and life circumstances. While pursuing various activities in diverse life-contexts, people in different cultures create diverse criteria for articulating, judging, and experiencing happiness. However one cannot miss the point that life is inconceivable without co-travelers and other fellow beings. Also, habituation and adaptation to living conditions make the life experiences less or more attractive and pleasant. The mainstream views primarily endorse a materialistic world view which tends to focus on an extremely individualized notion of being or selfhood. The overly individualistic outlook leads to a lopsided and misleading construal of selfhood in which consumption and exploitation of others including natural resources become prominent. Being anthropocentric ignores the presence of others. The reality is that our lifeworld is a connected world and we are interdependent beings.

The intense attachment engrained in the materialistic outlook often tends to induce conflicts, anxiety, violence, alienation, and various negative emotions. The scheme for formulating an externally oriented object-based perspective on happiness is bound to put people in a state of perpetual stress and tension. The contemporary world is already experiencing troubles on several fronts and mental health and well-being are threatened. Some of the key issues are as follows:

- *The growth of market-centric consumerist ideology and concomitant focus on economic development has been adversely impacting human lives.*
- *Economic growth after a point does not contribute to life satisfaction. It also tends to diminish resilience and reduce the sense of personal well-being.*
- *The media-generated artificial needs are constantly keeping people in a state of unending deprivation.*
- *The outward gaze is disturbing and disrupting the flow of life by arresting the reflective capacity and decreasing the potential for self-awareness.*
- *The mindset installed in the emerging competitive contexts is unbalanced and a variety of disadvantages and discriminations related to salient social categories (e.g. gender, caste, religion, region, language) are being maintained.*
- *Equity, equality, and justice in the social world are being curtailed due to the dominance of the few rich and resourceful people. This situation is leading to conflict and violence in different parts of the globe.*

A close perusal of the constructs and findings in the field of PP in the West shows that it neglects the totality of human experience that includes positive as well as negative states. It marginalizes the social, moral, spiritual, and even physical aspects of reality, particularly in countries that are not resource-rich. Thus only a limited facet of human experience is attended to. It may also be noted that PP is intensely ego-centric (Misra & Sharad, 2011). The strength-based approach celebrates the self and locates positivity in the individual. It ignores the relational and contextualized self.

The Ideas of Pleasure and Pain

While discussing the Indian notion of happiness, Srivastava and Misra (2011) have drawn attention to the emphasis on the qualities of contentment, control over desires, surrender, non-attachment, equanimity in opposites, perseverance, and hard work, relating to others and search for inner peace. It considers that positivity is not a quality vested in the individual, rather, it is a quality found in relational spaces (see also Misra & Srivastava, 2003; Salagame, 2006). Kanada (300 BCE), the founder of the Vaisheshik philosophy held that pleasure and pain are two irreducible feelings and are different from each other. They arise from cognitions of either a desirable or undesirable object and are hostile to each other. Thus pleasure is an agreeable feeling. Its nature is one of gratification or satisfaction. It arises under the following conditions: (i) proximity of desirable objects; (ii) interaction of the objects with the appropriate sense organs; (iii) conjunction of the self with the mind; (iv) perception of the desirable object; (v) merit; (vi) and health of the organism. It should be noted that two conditions i.e. merit (Dharma) and health (Svāsthya) are included as additional factors in the experience of pleasure (J.N.Sinha, 1985).

Whether one subscribes to the notion of past moral deeds or not, it is clear that we cannot enjoy or derive pleasure purely because external conditions are present unless we also have the necessary mental set. This is why many of us are unhappy despite all the resources that we have. It may also be noted that pleasure or pain is independent of the object because the same object produces pleasure in one person and pain in another or in the same person at different times (J.N.Sinha, 1985).

The pleasures may be of several types. According to one popular view they are sensuous, retrospective, and prospective happiness. Sensuous pleasure arises from the perception of desirable objects in interaction with the sensory organs. Retrospective pleasure stems from a recollection of previous enjoyment and prospective pleasure comes from the anticipation of occurrence in the future. While these three kinds spring from the gratification of desires, happiness arises from the conquest of desires (J.N.Sinha, 1985).

Pain is regarded as a disagreeable feeling produced by an undesired object and involves a feeling of being thwarted. It occurs due to the proximity of undesirable objects interacting with the sensory organs in conjunction of the self with manas associated with demerit (J.N.Sinha, 1985). Pain is categorized as *ādhyātmika*, *ādhibhoutika*, and *ādhidaivika*. *Ādhyātmika* refers to self and it is divided into two categories viz., physical and mental. Physical refers to the bodily disturbances causing discomfort and pain. Mental pain is associated with desires, anger, greed, fear, delusion, dejection, envy, etc. *Ādhibhoutika* refers to pain and suffering caused by external circumstances of physical nature that include natural calamities, as well as suffering caused by animals

and other human beings. *Ādhidaivika* refers to pain and suffering caused by imperceptible agents, ghosts, demons, and other supernatural entities (J.N.Sinha, 1985). There is also a description of neutral feeling or feeling of indifference (Upeksha), and transcendence of pleasure and pain.

Sakshi Bhava (Stance of a Witness)

The idea of a knower or observer within us is central to the Indian perspective. As a result, the methods used in systems like Yoga are first-person methods. It is held that by following specified procedures and cultivating certain habits of mind, it is possible to attain a state of awareness in which one is witnessing the changes (*Sākshībhāva*). Thus subjective experience is of great value. Western psychological studies still favor third and second-person approaches as their focus is on the environment and objective observation (Paranjpe, 1984, 1998).

As we have learned in Unit 1, positive psychology aims at building human strength, resilience, and health so that people may live a satisfying and flourishing life. It turns psychologists' gaze from pathology to hope and positivity in life. It changes the mindset towards paying greater attention to the positive attributes and processes like positive emotions, experiencing flow, developing hope and optimism, positive traits, and virtues. The early emphasis of PPsy was on increasing happiness and positive emotions. Only recently they have started recognizing the limitations of this view. They are now attending to the possibility of attaining a balance between positive and negative attributes. They consider negative emotions as pertinent to survival and positive emotions necessary for growth and well-being. The Indian view recognizes the functional value of positive and negative thoughts and emotions. In fact, the meaning of positive and negative attributes is significantly related to the socio-cultural context. An integrated view is absent in positive psychology. As stated by Rao (2014, p.6) 'the Indian psychology shares with positive psychology the goal of elevating human condition to the optimum levels of functioning, to overcome suffering and promote forms of happiness, bliss'.

Let us now discuss some of the **Key themes and ideas from the Indian perspective** on the concerns of PPsy. These, however, offer only a selective view and not an exhaustive one.

- **The Multilayered Structure of Human Existence**

From the Upanishadic period, one finds that human existence is conceived as a multilayered structure that is connected with human development and well-being. The Taittiriyaopaniṣad describes five Koshas or sheaths. The first level is *Annamaya Kośa* or bodily sheath, it is concerned with food, the physical body, and the material world. The second level is *Prāṇamaya Kośa* or the sheath related to vital biological functions such as life-breath, emotions, and bio-energy. The third level is the sheath of *Manomaya Kośa* which is made up of the mind. The next level is *Vigyānamaya Kośa* which relates to higher forms of the mind and the subtle realms like high order insights, intuition, and clarity of awareness. The final stage is the *Ānandamaya Kośa* or the realm of transcendence and blissful release into infinity and perfect awareness. The *Ānandamaya Kośa* is full of profound happiness and bliss beyond ordinary experience.

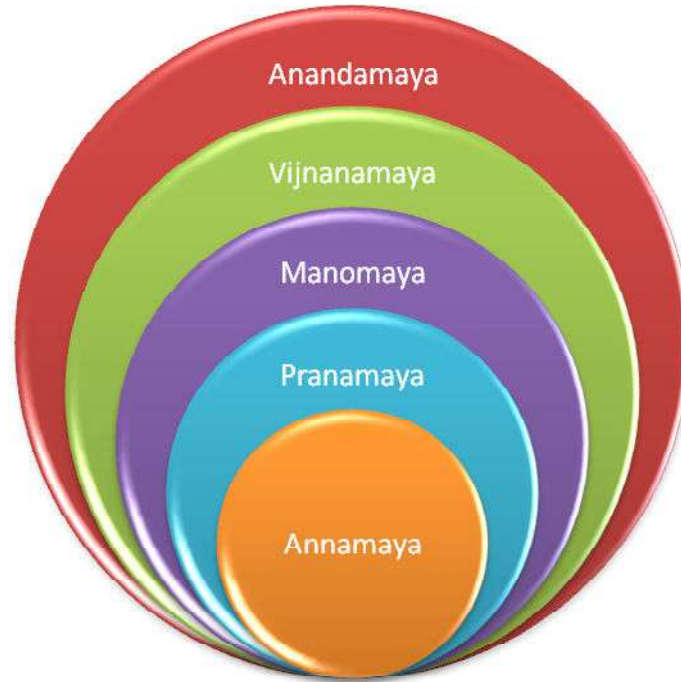


Fig. 3.1: PanchaKosha Model

- **Pursuing the Middle Path**

Āyurveda, the Indian system of medicine, as well as the Indian folk wisdom prominently emphasize that the extremes should be avoided (*Atisarvatraravajayeta*). The Buddhist doctrine of the middle path (*Majjhimaparipada*) also gives preference to observing the middle way. It may be recalled that Buddhism favors the position of *Anātma* and does not subscribe to the idea of Atman. It also says that everything is changing in this world and nothing is permanent. This may give freedom from everyday suffering. Impermanence, egolessness, and ‘Nirvana’ form the key teachings of Buddha.

A related theme is of pursuing equanimity (*Sāmya*). In fact, Āyurveda considers maintaining equanimity as key to health and well-being (see Svoboda, 2005). Bhagavad gītā also maintains that *samatva* is yoga (*Samatvam yoga uchyate*). It may be noted that the orientation of PP emphasizes positivity while the Indian psychological approach maintains that the balance (*Saṁtulan*) of positive and negative is important. Also, it proposes a model of human perfection in terms of *SthitaPragya*, or a person with steady wisdom who is free from the ups and downs in life and remains equidistant from negative and positive states. Thus he is neither elated after gaining the desired object nor pained by the failures in reaching the desired goals or getting the objects.

- **Pursuit of Sthita Pragya or Steady Wisdom as a Desirable State**

The text of *Srīmad Bhagavad gītā* proposes that the state of bliss is an attainable goal. To this end, it recommends that one should move on the path of seeking a state of steady wisdom (*Sthitapragya*). This state is achievable by training the mind to maintain a state of equanimity in happiness and misery, success and failure, fame and anonymity. It helps to transcend the illusory world full of suffering and attaining bliss. Indeed it’s a model of a perfect person. Chapter 2 of the Bhagavadgītā (verses 54-72) provides a roadmap for the journey towards the goal of experiencing steady wisdom. You are encouraged to read and appreciate that in the original.

In response to the query by Arjuna about the characteristics of a person with steady wisdom, Lord Krishna states that such a person is one who totally abandons all desires

from the mind. He has no desires because he is fulfilled in the Self alone by the Self. In this context, Self refers to Atman which has an infinite status. Thus when all desires of the mind are totally relinquished as a result of being satisfied in the Self, then one is rooted in the Self. This analysis is very close to Brihdārayṇakopaniṣada which states that when all desires are fulfilled the person becomes *Āptakama*. This occurs when one has a desire for Atman. The attraction of the infinite neutralizes all worldly desires. Then one goes to the state of *Akāma* or desirelessness. Lord Krishna further clarifies that one is said to be a Muni (sage) rooted in wisdom when one's mind is not perturbed by sorrow nor does one hanker for joy; one is free from desire, fear, and anger. When a person is free from the desire he will not experience negative emotions of fear and anger and freedom from desire comes from the feeling of void or emptiness. He has to understand that he is in fact full. One needs to have inner independence and learn the skill of withdrawing to the state of peace in and through the fluctuations of body, mind, and intellect. One is established in wisdom when one restrains one's sense organs from their sense objects, like the tortoise which pulls its limbs back from all sides. The tortoise's shell represents intellect which is fortified to withstand the various temptations. When one abstains, the sense objects recede, but the fondness or liking continues. The fondness goes only on the realization of Atman which is infinite happiness.

It should be noted that the stormy senses violently drag the mind of even a persistently striving wise person. Restraining the senses one should meditate and be absorbed in Atman. One whose senses are under control is indeed steadfast or unwavering in wisdom. It is observed that by pondering or thinking over objects, a person gets attached to them. Attachment breeds desire, from desire anger, is born. Anger leads to delusion, from delusion memory gets clouded, from clouding of memory the intellect gets destroyed, when the intellect goes one is ruined. Therefore, one should be extra cautious to make sure that one must have the right kind of thought. A self-restrained person who has gained self-mastery becomes serene. Free from attraction and aversion, such a person may move amidst sense objects without getting attached to them. All sorrows end in that serenity. A serene person's intellect is soon steadied.

Thus the control of senses is the key to movement on the path of steady wisdom. It brings success as well as happiness. The disunited person has neither intellect nor contemplation and without contemplation, there can be no peace; how will there be happiness for the one without peace? Following the restive senses, the mind pulls one's discrimination away as the wind pulls away from a boat in a river. Therefore, one is established in wisdom when one's senses are wholly withdrawn from sense objects. Lord Krishna explains with a metaphor of the ocean. As the ocean which filled from all sides with waters entering it, remains still, so the one in whom all objects of desire enter obtain peace, not the desire of desires. Therefore a person attains peace, who relinquishes all desires, and lives without longing, a sense of mineness, or egoism.

• Attaining an Inclusive Vision

It is clear that the Indian view proposes to strive for attaining a state of happiness unaffected by mundane realities. This state allows enjoying equanimity and inner liberation. The perspective of Vedanta school seeks to align with Brahman. The Brāhmaṇa occupies the entire world (*Sarvam khalvidam Brahma*) and seeing this would lead to the realization that I am Brahman (*Ahambrahmāsmi*). Its natural consequence will be the experience of similarity and oneness with others or non-duality (*Advaita*). Bhagavad gītā also states that only those persons who can see sameness across all beings are the real seer (*Sar vbhūteṣu yenaikam bhāvamavyayamiikshate*). The wise people perceive everybody on equal footing (*Panditah samadarśinah*).

The inclusive vision is expressed in the aspiration of treating the whole earth as a family (*Udāra caritānām tu vasudhaiva kutumbakam*). The broad vision maintains this position and does not discriminate against ‘others’. It is a dogmatic and constricted view to distinguish between self and other.

- **The Pursuit of Dharma and Human flourishing**

It is important to note that the concept of Dharma implies virtues and extends to duties which allow maintenance and sustenance of life. In the social context the duties are performed based on one’s position in society and stage of life. This maintains social order which contributes to cosmic order leading to universal well-being. Human flourishing is brought about by balancing and pursuing the life goals or purusharthas. According to Vaiśeṣik school of Indian thought, dharma includes both prosperity in this world (*Abhyudaya*) and liberation (*Nihsreyas*) from suffering and pursuing Moksha. Therefore, material development and spirituality both have legitimate places in life and they need not be seen as mutually exclusive. In this context, it must be remembered that the four life goals (Puruśārthas) i.e. *dharma* (ethical duties), *artha* (prosperity), *kāma* (pleasure), and *moksha* (liberation) are equally important. This implies that all aspects have to be integrated and form a description of an ideal life. Mahābhārata identifies supreme dharma with compassion (dayā), forgiveness kshamaā, and truth (Satya).

There are some themes in positive psychology which appear quite close to the tenets of Indian psychology. The experience of flow and altruism fall in this category. Flow is a state of intense involvement in an activity and enjoying it. In the words of Csikszentmihalyi (1990), such a person is called ‘autotelic self’. It is quite similar to mindfulness in Buddhism and Yogic practices. However, one may be absorbed in anything good or bad and addictions may take place which is harmful. The yogic practices do not involve such a possibility. The attention to altruistic or philanthropic activities is convergent with service or ‘Seva’.

It may be noted that positive psychology predominantly continues to be culture-bound and has individualism to its core emphasizing autonomy and fulfillment. It does not challenge mainstream psychology’s assumptions except attempting to correct the focus on difficulties and negative emotions. The view that material level existence is the ultimate reality and treating humans as biologically driven animals still forms the core of positive psychology. It holds consciousness as a product of the workings of the brain. Positive psychology is predominantly connected with a search for hedonistic pleasure and meaningful life. The spirit of natural science is maintained in its research programs. It aggrandizes individualistic striving, without altering the structure of the self. It is a lopsided approach to self that provides an impoverished view of human nature as compared to the Indian view.

In current psychological practice, the Indian transcendental state is treated as mystical which is often treated as mysterious, irrational, or dangerous. However, transcendental does not mean negating the mundane. Indeed transcendence and spirituality complement the material pursuits and pleasures. Also transcendental is often connected with the attainment of self-realization which is an inner journey (*Adhyam*) (see Salagame, 2015). The possibility of appropriating Indian psychological ideas without acknowledging them and claiming their own is there but their original purpose and context are stripped away. The Indian perspective views the world as the manifestation of Brahman and views ego as a mode of being that causes suffering but can be overturned by either expanding our sense of identity as in Vedanta or deconstructing and disidentifying from the self as in the Buddhist tradition. Thus the approach is one that emphasizes the transformation of self. The individual self is one with the universal self. It emphasized

non-dual knowledge. We need sustained inner effort (*tapasya*). The inclusion of the non-physical world and relation with the divine are the unique features of the Indian approach. Unfortunately using these constructs is taken to put it in the category of religion and not science.

Self Assessment Questions 3

1. Differentiate between pleasure and pain.
2. What are the categories of pain ?
3. The methods used in systems like Yoga are first-person methods. True/ False
4. The Indian view advocates an integrated view of positive and negative thoughts and emotions. True/ False.
5. What is *Vigyanamaya Kosha*?
6. According to Indian psychological approach, a person with steady wisdom and who remains equidistant from negative and positive states is called as _____.
7. The state of desirelessness is called _____.
8. Name the four life goals according to Indian thought.

3.6 RELIGIOUS AND SPIRITUAL PRACTICES FOR ENHANCING WELL-BEING

The Indian tradition has a rich repertoire of approaches and practices to enhance well-being. However, their understanding requires greater engagement at the experiential level and deeper scholarly engagement (see also Salagame, 2006, 2015). Keeping the context of the present course in view and constraints of time and space, an introduction to select perspectives is given below.

1) Yoga and Well-being

To begin with, it must be realized that the functioning of body and mind are connected. The system of Yoga helps achieve integration of mind and body and facilitates attaining happiness and well-being. Yoga helps nurture positive attitudes and recondition the neuromuscular systems. It enhances the capacity to withstand greater stress and strain and allows harmonious development of all the potentialities present in a person. The meaning of Yoga implies the act of joining. Patanjali, the author of Yoga Sutras, defines yoga as a process of restraining the mind (Chitta) from various modifications (Vritti). In other words, yoga involves regulating mental functions. These fluctuations involve real perception (Pramāṇa), wrong perception (Viparyaya), imagination (Vikalpa), knowledge-based on sleep (Nidrā), and memory (Smṛiti). Practice (Abhyāsa) and detachment from desires (Vairāgya) are the two means to still the movements of the mind.

It is held that the main cause of pain is the association or identification of the seer (Ātman) with the seen (Prakṛiti) and the remedy lies in their dissociation. In this way, the pains which are yet to come can be avoided. It is the presence of discriminative knowledge which destroys ignorance, which is the main source of pain. It is through an unbroken flow of discriminative awareness (Pragya) that one gains knowledge. Patanjali

has identified seven stages of conscious awareness: Emerging consciousness (Vyutthanchitta), Restraining consciousness (Niruddhachitta), Sprouted or individualized consciousness (Nirmanachitta), Tranquil consciousness (Praśāntachitta), Attentive consciousness (Ekagrachitta), Fissured or rent consciousness (chidrachitta) and Ripe or pure consciousness (Paripakvachitta) (Iyengar, 1991).

It is through dedicated practice of the various aspects of yoga that the impurities are destroyed and wisdom shines. The system of yoga involves a family of practices dealing with different levels and domains of human functioning. The eight limbs of yoga (Aṣṭāṅga Yoga) enunciated by Patanjali include **Yama** - moral injunctions or self restraints which includes non-violence (Ahimsa), truth (Satya), non-stealing (Āsteya), continence and chastity (Brahmcharya), and absence of greed and non-possession (Aparigraha). These Yamas are like universal vows as they are not confined to class, place, time, or concept of duty. They need to be followed unconditionally by everyone.

The second limb of yoga consists of **Niyama** (fixed observances) which include cleanliness (*Saucha*), contentment (*Santośa*), burning desire (*Tapas*), self-study (*Svādhyāya*), surrender to god (*Ishvarpraṇidhāna*). Patanjali also says that principles that run contrary to yamas and niyamas are to be countered with wise discrimination. Uncertain knowledge giving rise to violence is caused by greed, anger, and delusion. They lead to endless pain and ignorance. It may be corrected by its opposites (*Pratipakshabhāvana*) through introspection, proper thinking, and action. Patanjali also says that from contentment comes supreme happiness (*Santośadanuttamah labhah*). The other limbs of yoga include **Āsana** (posture), **Pranāyama** (regulation of breath), **Pratyāhara** (internalization of the senses towards their source), **Dhāraṇa** (concentration), **Dhyāna** (meditation), and **Samādhi** (absorption of consciousness in the self).

Stilling the mind and consciousness is the key to yogic practices. To achieve well-being one needs to purify the Chitta because consciousness becomes easily involved with the objects seen and identifies with them. As a result, the seer is subordinated to the oscillating mind. It is important to understand that practicing all the yogic principles from Yama onward is necessary. One should also note that pursuing practices are hindered by various obstacles such as a disease, inertia, doubt, heedlessness, laziness, indiscipline of senses, erroneous views, lack of perseverance and backsliding, sorrow, despair, unsteadiness of the body, and irregular breathing.



Fig. 3.2: Eight Stages of Ashtanga Yoga

The main reasons for afflictions (Kleśa) which disturb the equilibrium of consciousness and cause pain and suffering are ignorance or lack of wisdom (Avidyā), ego, pride of the ego or the sense of “I” (Asmitā), attachment to pleasure (Rāga), aversion to pain (Dveśa), and fear of death and clinging to life (Abhiniveśa). There are accumulated imprints of past lives, rooted in afflictions that will be experienced in the present and future lives. Past actions are the deeds of afflictions which in turn give rise to other actions, necessitating further afflictions. This involves the principle of Karma or cause and effect. The actions rooted in desire, greed, anger, lust, pride, and malice bring afflictions and those who are free from these leads towards bliss.

Patanjali says that through the cultivation of friendliness (Maitrī), compassion (Karuṇā), joy (Muditā), to have indifference (Upekshā) to pleasure (Sukha) and pain (Dukha), virtue (Puṇya) and vice (Apuṇya). In this way positivity increases and the person’s mental state becomes pleasant, serene and benevolent (Ciita-prasādanam). These qualities keep the mind in a state of well-being. The mental adjustment builds social as well as individual health. One must remember that these qualities need to be cultivated along with following the prescribed virtues of Yama. Patanjali says that the practice of yoga reduces afflictions and leads to Samadhi. For this purpose, he describes **Kriyā Yoga** or yoga in action. It includes ‘Tapas’ or burning the impurities of body senses and mind, ‘Svādhyāya’ or self-study, reflection on self, and ‘Īśvar-Praṇidhāna’ or surrender to god. In some sense the first four sages of yoga – yama, niyama, āsana, and prāṇāyāma refer to tapas, pratyahar; dhāraṇa refers to svādhyāya; and dhyana and samādhi refer to Īśvara-Praṇidhāna.

In general most of us are preoccupied and concerned with what others are doing. It has been estimated that roughly about 75 percent of the time goes to it. The remaining 25 percent goes to becoming aware of the “I” identity. Thus the mind is preoccupied with external things either looking at others critically or trying to fulfill desires. Yoga aims at changing internally. The human mind is like a blackboard on which we are constantly writing. So cleaning of mind of sanskaras and karmas while doing purification, we move from awareness to discrimination, performance, and creativity. The journey begins with a desire to develop self-awareness or to discipline the self.

2) Self Mastery: The Path towards well-being

We think that enjoyment comes from the external world and we do everything to entertain ourselves with the alluring world. However, we often find that our efforts are futile as the enjoyment comes only to leave us with a feeling of emptiness. The Bhagavadgītā tells that true enjoyment lies inside us and promotes mastery over ourselves (Misra, 2009). We must remember that our existence consists of a body that receives environmental stimuli and responds, the mind is the home of emotions and feelings, intellect discriminates and brings rationality and spirit or Atman is the real self which breathes life into the lifeless body, mind, and intellect. Only as long as the intellect is in command of one’s personality is the knowledge available to you. This is illustrated when the mind starts playing up with tension and anxiety. To the person who is peaceless, there is no peace (*aśāntasya kutah sukham*, BG, 2,66). The man of self-control attains inner calmness.

Everyone wants to be happy but the trouble is that all kinds of happiness last for a limited span of time. We, therefore, strive for enduring happiness, happiness that is sustainable. However, the usual means adopted for this goal fall short of the expectation, and people suffer and constantly try to achieve more and more. Unfortunately, the

persistent focus on materialistic goals further intensifies the experience of unhappiness because the goal shifts, and the sense of absence of happiness continues. The Indian perspective states, therefore, that self needs to be regulated by self through self-initiated practices. As Lord Krishna advises to Arjuna, “let a man lift himself by his own Self alone, and let him not lower himself; for, this Self alone is one’s friend and this Self alone the enemy. The Self is the friend of the self for him who has conquered himself by the Self, but to the unconquered self, the Self stands in the position of an enemy like the (external) foe” (Bhagavadgītā 6-6).

Indeed mindfulness interventions and different kinds of Yoga (e.g., Vipāsana, Prekshā Dhyāna, Sudarśana-Kriyā), and Seva or service to fellow beings offer immense possibilities of self-renewal and experiencing peace and well-being. The key to sustainable happiness ultimately lies in self-discovery. The Indian perspective visualizes that if a person has self-control, s/he may be roaming among material objects with subjugated senses, and devoid of attraction and repulsion, attains an unshakable inner calmness. The pathway of happiness demands that there should be peace of mind, which comes with wise discrimination. With an adequate degree of self-regulation, one is able to deal with desires, attain peace and enjoy sustainable happiness. Peace cannot be attained by one who lusts after desires (Kāmakāmī). A person realizes peace who, relinquishing desires, lives without craving and is unidentified with mortal ego and its sense of ‘I-ness’ (Bhagavadgītā, 2, 70).

3) Development of Virtues

Bhagavadgītā presents details about the qualities to adopt and those to be abandoned. There are qualities belonging to the divine state (*Daivi Sampat*), which need to be inculcated by a person desiring to move on the path of perfection. Life has to be reorganized and perspective has to change. The right way to live requires effort to develop these qualities (Bhagavadgītā chapter 16 verses 1-3.). They are Fearlessness, Purity of Heart, Steadfastness in the Yoga of Knowledge, Charity, Control of the Senses, Sacrifice, Study of the Scriptures, Asceticism, Straightforwardness, Harmlessness, Truth, Absence of Anger, Renunciation, Peacefulness, Absence of Crookedness, Compassion to all beings, Non-Covetousness, Gentleness, Modesty, Absence of Ficklemindedness, Vigour, Patience, Fortitude, Purity, Absence of hatred, and Absence of pride.

Gītā (Chapter 16, verse 4) also describes demonic qualities (*āsuri sampat*). They consist of Hypocrisy, Arrogance, Conceit, Anger, Harshness, and Ignorance. The demoniac persons do not know the right action and what to refrain from. They lack purity, right conduct, and truth. They think that the world is without truth, without a moral basis, without a God, lacks causal sequence. They behave like enemies of the world and work with impure resolves. They consider gratification of lust as their highest aim. The divine nature is deemed for liberation and the demoniacal is for bondage. Desire, anger, and greed are destructive of self and act as gates for hell. Therefore he should abandon these three. Thus freedom from pride and delusion, the conquest of attachment, dwelling in the Self (Ātman), absence of desires, and freedom from the pairs of opposites like pleasure and pain are recommended. In this context, it may be noted that detachment is never possible without attaching ourselves to something nobler and more divine. The human mind and intellect always need to contemplate. They cannot remain in the void. So in order that the mind may not have evil attachments, it should attach to the Self and live in a spirit of contemplation upon it. Thus we need purification of the mind by removing agitations created by egocentric attachments to

sense objects. Secondly, the intellect has to turn to a correct understanding of the Self through study, reflection, and practice. This only can remove the doubts of the mind. Mere effort without purity of heart cannot lead to liberation.

4) Vipāsanā Meditation

Vipāsanā means insight. It is considered to be the essence of the teaching of Buddha. It is a simple and non-dogmatic technique. It is taught in courses of ten days during which the participants remain within the area of the course site, having no contact with the outside world. They refrain from reading and writing, and suspend any religious activity, working according to the instructions provided. They observe celibacy and abstention from all intoxicants. They maintain silence among themselves for the first nine days, although they are free to discuss meditation problems with the instructor. During the first three and half days, they exercise mental concentration. After this preparation, vipassana proper is introduced on the fourth day. Further steps are introduced each day so that by the end of the course the entire technique has been presented. On the tenth-day silence end and meditators make the transition back to a more extroverted way of life. The course concludes on the morning of the eleventh day. With meditation and self-discovery a meditator gains mental strength. They can apply the learning in everyday life for one's own benefit and for the good of others. Sri S.N. Goenka has made it popular (see Hart, 1987). Suffering is the inordinate attachment towards body, mind, cognition, sensations, and reactions. Clinging to unreal identity is suffering. The fact is that sooner or later I is separated from the mine. If we put an end to ignorance then there will be no blind reactions causing suffering.

Buddha talked about the **noble eightfold path**, which can be divided into three stages of training i.e. *Sīla*, *Samādhi* and *Pāṇna*. *Sīla* is a moral practice, abstention from all unwholesome actions of body and speech. *Samādhi* is the practice of concentration, developing the ability to consciously direct and control one's own mental processes. *Pāṇna* is wisdom, the development of purifying insight into one's own nature. According to Buddha, wholesome actions produce happiness which are real blessings. There are two kinds of blessings, i.e., performing actions that contribute to the welfare of others by fulfilling responsibilities to family and society, and performing actions that cleanse the mind. This leads to mental balance and equanimity which result in other qualities of pure mind i.e. goodwill, love that seeks the benefit of others, compassion for others, and sympathetic joy in their success. These are reflective of Metta Bhavana, the development of goodwill toward others. This is the outcome of vipāsanā meditation. Real happiness lies in peace, equanimity, and goodwill.

1) Prāṇāyāma

It refers to the science of breath. Prana is the vital energy of the universe. According to some Indian thinkers, this universe is sustained by it. Thus prāṇāyāma is the science that imparts knowledge related to the control of prana. Controlling prana allows control of mind and body. The yogic breathing exercises enable controlling the mind and attaining higher states of consciousness. It is through the manifestation of prana that all body functions are coordinated. In terms of functions five pranas are identified *udāna*, *prāṇa*, *samāna*, *apāna* and *vyāna*. *Udana* rules the region of the body above the larynx and regulates the use of our special senses. *Prana* rules the region between the larynx and the base of the heart and regulates speech, vocal apparatus, and respiratory system. *Samāna* covers the region between the heart and the navel and regulated metabolism related to digestion. *Apana* regulates the region below the navel and regulates

the kidney, colon, rectum, bladder, and genitals. Vyāna pervades the whole body and regulates muscles.

The energy of prana is subtle in form. Its most external manifestation is the breath. Prana is the energy that governs the breath. Breath becomes the bridge between mind and body. It is called a thermometer, which registers the conditions of the mind and the influence of the environment on the body (Akhilanand, 1948, 1952; Swami Ram et.al. 1998). It is through the control of respiration that the yogi proceeds to control the other subtle energies of prana. The yoga system states that there are numerous *nādis* or subtle channels through which the currents of prana flow. There are descriptions of ida, pingala, sushumna, bahmani, chitrani and vijnaninadis. The junctions where ida, pingala and sushumna nadis meet along the spinal column are called *chakras*. There are seven chakras mulādhāra, svādhīsthāna, maṇipūra, anahata, viśuddhi, ajyana, and sahasrāra. The nadis radiate outward from chakras to other parts of the body.

Controlling the breath and calming the nerves is a prerequisite to controlling the mind, and controlling the mind is necessary to the ultimate subjugation of the universal energy of prana. The disease is a manifestation of an imbalance in the flow of prana. Mind and body are sustained by prana. It is amply clear that respiration is the most important function of the body. The airflow in the nostrils should be equal. This normally does not occur. This can be achieved by nādiśodhanpranāyāma. Jalāneti (water cleansing) and sutra neti (string cleansing) are also done. It is also recommended that one must adopt rhythmic diaphragmatic breathing, Śavāsana (corpse posture), Makarāsana (crocodile pose), the practice of various forms of Praṇāyāma such as Nādiśodhan, Kapāla-bhāti, Bhaṣṭrikā, Ujjayi, Bhrāmari, Sitali, and Sītkari. Actually, all these types of pranayama involve variations in inhalation, retention, and exhalation of breath. Control over the pause in the breath is critical. The breath and mind are interdependent. Breath awareness is an essential part of meditation. Once the breath is retained, mind starts becoming one-pointed. If the breath is irregular the mind is dissipated.

It may be noted that our physical body is built and organized around the subtle framework of the nadis and is sustained by the flow of pranic energy through this network. In an average person the dynamic and creative aspect of prāṇa is only a very small fraction of the total energy of prana, the major part of it remaining in a seed state. Traditional yoga texts refer to this latent, stored energy as *Kundalinī*, which is symbolically represented as a sleeping serpent coiled in the muladhara chakra at the base of the spine. Also, under normal conditions, prana flows through ida and pingala-nādi, but not through sushumna, this nadi is normally being blocked at the base of the spinal column.

The various kinds of pranayama try to devitalize ida and pingala nadis and simultaneously open up sushumna, with this prana flowing through the middle channel. It is held that this is positive state and under this situation a yogi experiences great joy and is freed from the constraints of time, space and causation. After opening up the Suṣumnā, the yogi rouses the sleeping serpent at the muladhara chakra and channelizes this powerful energy upward along Suṣumnā, piercing the six chakras, which is represented at the crown of the head. The arousal and ascent of the latent kundalini energy and its merging in the sahasrara is synonymous with the union of Śakti (cosmic potency) with Śiva (cosmic consciousness). This union results in liberation from bondage. The individual soul merges with the cosmic soul. The atman meets the Brahman.

5) Meditation

In recent years meditation has received considerable attention. There is growing evidence that the transformation brought by meditation influences well-being and can

bring positive change in your body, affect and outlook and can eliminate decision making ability and eliminate anxiety. There are numerous techniques of meditation. Meditation brings mind, body and spirit in harmony by experiencing equanimity. The basis is the idea that we are not separated into mind and body. We are one whole - the mind responds to the body at the same instant the body responds to the mind. The awakened life is energetic and fully conscious. One has to delve into own awareness. Consciousness is creative, dynamic, holistic and harmonious. Meditation essentially involves looking inward. It involves a variety of practices. They are known by various names such as self-inquiry, mindfulness, reflection, concentration, contemplation, prayer, quiet mind, controlled breathing, bliss. Meditation brings balance and equilibrium is maintained. Chopra (2020) has beautifully summarized these functions. Mindfulness recovers mind from distraction. Self inquiry helps mind in recovering from habits, reflection frees from thoughtlessness. Contemplation helps in recovering from confusion. Concentration allows to recover from pointlessness. Prayer is the way mind recovers from helplessness. Quiet mind helps recovering from overwork. Controlled breathing allows recovery from stress. Bliss is the way to recover from suffering. In recent years neuro-scientific mechanisms involved in meditation are being investigated (see Goleman, & Davidson, 2018). It has been demonstrated that with training we can change our level of consciousness and rise up into levels of consciousness far beyond our ordinary human state.

1) **Guṇas and Svabhāva**

It may be noted that transcending the pleasure-pain duality and experiencing the liberation of consciousness demands a radical transformation in one's awareness. However, anyone may proceed to join the journey, if one desires, which entails modification in svabhāva and that can be understood in terms of three Gunas i.e. **Sattva**, **Rajas**, and **Tamas**. These gunas represent the principles of illumination and creativity, activity and energy, and inertia, respectively. In Bhagavadgītā, triguna is used to explain everything (see Murthy & Salagame, 2007). Thus people are differentiated on the basis of the pattern of relative dominance of the three gunas. A satvic person is described as one who is endowed with discriminative intellect; who is self-controlled, serene, equanimous, and steadfast; who is virtuous, generous, and gentle; and who is detached and duty-bound without expectations, a seeker of self and awareness of the unity underlying all diversities. A rajasic person is one who is driven into action by passion, is restless, is struggling; who has more desires, strong likes and dislikes, and pursues sensory pleasures; who is attached to one's social roles; who lacks clear discrimination and has distorted understanding; and who is egotistic. A tamasic person is depressed, lethargic, disinclined to work, negligent, undisciplined, arrogant, hostile, indecisive, ignorant, inadvertent, uncertain, and dull.

All the Indian perspectives converge on the point that spiritual development involves getting more refined, which means leaving the tamasic and rajasic tendencies and developing more sattvic qualities. Since satva is the principle of illumination transcendental consciousness can be realized only when the mind becomes more transparent. As seen in the earlier analysis the virtues and character strengths that Positive psychology speaks of, are listed as satvic qualities in Indian traditions. Thus one has to get rid of the negative tendencies. The IP emphasizes a comprehensive view of reality and maintains a holistic stance, in which a human being is understood as biological, psychological, and spiritual in nature and is in constant relationship with the whole cosmos.

3.6.1 The Challenge to Sustainable Happiness

The creation of just world and providing opportunities for human development for the majority of the people on planet earth continues to be a remote goal. Only concerted and sustained effort can help to bridge the prevailing gaps. The idea of sustainable happiness, a major goal of both Positive psychology and Indian psychology, requires acknowledging the fragility of the lifeworld and navigating through it by expanding the notion of self and making it more and more encompassing. This requires nourishing the idea of the well-being of everybody or *Sarvodaya* and practicing a certain degree of detachment. This move will allow enjoying greater freedom in life and pave the way for sustainable happiness. It seems that consumption with renunciation (*Tyāga-purvaka bhoga*) is the only solution for a happy and prosperous life. This requires inner engineering to inculcate peace of mind, a sense of gratitude, and partnership with other inhabitants of this world.

It is often believed that money can buy success, peace, fortune and make one happy. The drive to acquire and consume is dominating most of us. Indeed the materialistic worldview has led to a flawed view of development reflected in adopting unsustainable practices and overconsumption. As a result, people spend more time earning more money to buy more things and forget friends, family, community, and God. It is being increasingly clear that overconsumption prevalent in the living style followed in consumer societies is neither the ultimate path to authentic happiness nor the path to sustainability. The trend of overconsumption, especially of non-renewable resources is unambiguously unsustainable. Now it is being realized that there are limits to growth and development. Thus economic development has to be linked with environmental conservation. Keeping this in view the contemporary development discourse is becoming more concerned with the challenges of sustainability.

It is being realized that the individualist worldview and lifestyle of the western culture are unsustainable and less likely to lead to happiness and life satisfaction. Whether we like it or not we have to have interdependent existence, reflecting the eastern collectivistic stance. We are experiencing that in a globalized world, everyone's actions have repercussions on distant places and people. Also, it is felt that there is a considerable degree of interdependence across all the animate and inanimate partners constituting our environment. In this context fostering sustainable happiness through behaviors, and motivating students and teachers to integrate sustainability into their personal lives becomes very significant.

The notion of sustainable happiness implies that happiness must contribute to individual, community, and global well-being without exploiting other people, the environment, or future generations. This notion extends the initiatives in the field of happiness studies and emphasizes the significance of interdependence with all life on earth. Furthermore, it draws attention to the fact that all of us may contribute to the well-being of others and the natural habitat. The extensive human suffering and environmental degradation both suggest that we should take immediate steps to reorient our educational system for promoting sustainable happiness. We need to move beyond raising individual awareness and make endeavors to foster sustainable behaviors.

The shift in focus from happiness to sustainability should not be problematic if we recognize that the self is an interconnected and interdependent structure. As the Indian wisdom has been emphasizing that the goal should be well-being of all (*Sarve bhavantu sukhinah*). The father of the Indian nation, Mahatma Gandhi had not only emphasized

in theory but put into practice a style of life in which genuine need is met but greed is deliberately de-emphasized. The idea of sustainable happiness draws our attention to organizing a life of joy and well-being for everyone. To this end, the Indian perspective offers many insights and practices. By transforming our minds we may improve not our own health and well-being but also those of our communities and the wider world. Enduring well-being can be cultivated by caring for our body, mind and spirit. Flourishing is possible by increasing the scope of generosity, kindness and overcoming the rigid categories of 'us' and 'they'. The empathy and broader vision would foster interdependence, kindness and compassion. In the wake of threat to species survival, focus on individual thriving is insufficient. A calm mind (Śānti), compassion (karuna) and skillful action (Yogah karmasu kauśalam) would help a long way dealing with the challenges of greed, eco-calamities, us/them thinking and selfishness. We have now ever greater need for establishing Dharma.

Self Assessment Questions 4

1. What is Yoga according to Patanjali ?
2. What are the first four sages in Ashtanga yoga ?
3. According to Bhagavadgita, human qualities are divided into which two categories?
4. What are the three stages of training in Buddha's noble eightfold path?
5. Controlling *prana* allows control of _____ and _____.
6. Name the seven chakras in human body.
7. What are the three Gunas?

3.7 LET US SUM UP

The contemporary conditions prevailing across the globe indicate that people are not happy and suffer from various kinds of problems. Therefore search of peace of mind, happiness, and well-being has become prominent. The spirit of materialism and individualism lead to competition causing frustration, conflict, and aggression which compromise our well-being. The idea of happiness has been changing due to changing life circumstances world view and introduction of technology. Psychology is concerned with these issues but the traditional view had adopted a deficit model. The field of positive psychology emerged to attend to human strengths within the framework of mainstream psychological science. However, consideration of distinction between the western and eastern perspectives and role of cultural variety in human experience has led to attention to alternative approaches.

The Indian psychology rooted in the indigenous thought systems of India presents integral approaches to reality encompassing physical, social, psychological, and spiritual layers of existence. It emphasizes harmony and balance. Western and Indian perspectives both acknowledge the need to develop certain human strengths. The Indian psychological approach emphasizes on a holistic view of life and attends to interdependence and complementarity. It views happiness as part of human nature and locates problems in ignorance of true nature of being. The Indian perspective offers a

nuanced analysis of happiness and pain/suffering. Some of the key concepts of Indian perspective include Sākshi-Bhāva or witness consciousness, multilayered notion of human existence in terms of five koshas encompassing bodily existence to bliss, emphasis on avoiding extremes and following the middle path, pursuing samya (balance), understanding the nature of Self (Ātman), realizing perfection following the model of steady wisdom (Sthitapragya), and pursuit of well-being by following Dharma in conduct. The four life goals or Purusharthas (Dharma, Artha, Kama, Moksha) also emphasize on attending to multiple obligations and practices in a balanced manner.

In the Indian psychological tradition, the pursuit of happiness and well-being involves understanding and practicing various traditions of yoga and meditation. They allow addressing the necessary linkages across mind, body and spirit. To this end Patanjali's Aṣṭāṅga Yoga comprising of Yama, Niyama, Āsana, Prāṇāyāma, Pratyāhāra, Dhāraṇā, Dhyāna, and Samādhi offers a very comprehensive and systematic framework for living life holistically. It engages with moral ethical conduct and skills to regulate mind and body and preparing for spiritual journey of the practitioner (Sādhak). The Buddhist tradition of meditation as found in Vipassanā promotes Sīla, Pāṇa and Samādhi. This leads to Metti-Bhāvanā or goodwill towards everyone. The practice of pranayama and meditation have various forms which help significantly in the pursuit of well-being. The conceptualization of Sattva, Rajas and Tamas Gunas indicate the differences in the traits and dispositions of people. For the pursuit of well being it is desirable that the Sattva qualities are promoted. The pursuit of Dharma offers such a vision.

3.8 GLOSSARY OF KEY WORDS IN INDIAN PSYCHOLOGY

Abhiniveśa: clinging to life, fear of death, intensity of affection.

Advaita: non dualistic, identity of spirit and matter.

Ādhibhautika: belonging to the five elements, elemental.

Ādhidaivika: belonging to the gods.

Ādhyātmaika: belonging to the self.

Ahimsā: non-violence, non-injury, harmlessness.

Ānanda: bliss, result of relation of sat and chit, part of divine being and consciousness

Annamaya: material, made of matter

Āntah-karṇa: the internal organ, the mind

Anatta: not self, egoless, without essence.

Aparigraha: freedom from avarice, without greed, non-acceptance of gift.

Artha: wealth

Āsana: sitting in particular posture such as padmasana, vajrasana and virasana.

Asmitā: pride, egoism, I consciousness.

Ātman: the self, often used for self

Avidyā: ignorance, partial knowledge, not knowing

Bhakti: shared, devotee

Bhaktiyoga: the yoga or union with the divine through love and devotion

Bhāvanā: mental development, meditation involving tranquility and development of insight.

Brahma: expanding one, all embracing spirit, the universal soul.

Buddha: enlightened person

Buddhi: intellect, higher mind

Cārvāka: materialistic philosopher

Dharma: duty, virtue, first of the four aims of life

Dhāraṇa: holding, concentrating mind upon before dhyana, meditation

Dhyāna: meditation, reflection before samadhi

Dukha: suffering, sorrow, pain

Guṇa: thread, three major qualities of prakṛti, i.e., sattva, rajas and tamas, reflecting tranquility, activity and inertia.

Harṣa: excitement

Jāgrat: waking, a waking state of consciousness. Other states are svapna, a sleeping state with dreams; susupti, a sleeping state without dreams, and a transcendental state of turiya.

Jīva: living being, the living or personal soul involved in manifestation

Kāma: wish, desire, longing, enjoyment

Karma yoga: yoga of action or work, involves freedom from the fruit of action, freedom from attachment to any action and freedom from the notion of doer.

Kleśa: pain, affliction, distress; Yoga describes five kleśas: avidyā (ignorance), asmitā (egotism), raga (desire), dvesha (aversion), abhinivesha (tendency of mundane existence).

Kuṇḍalinī: a coiling one; according to tantra, it is power hidden in the muladhara chakra coiling in three coils, which when awakened rises to the sahasrarchakra, divine cosmic energy.

Mānas: mind, antahkarana with the functions perception, cognition.

Mettā: selfless love and goodwill. Mettabhavana is systematic cultivation of metta.

Moksha: liberation, deliverance, release - the fourth goal of life (Purushartha).

Muditā: joy

Nāḍī: energy channel through which energy flows in the subtle body.

Nirvāṇa: extinguished state, a state of ultimate peace in which the whole world is seen as unreal, absolute extinction or annihilation of individual existence or of all desires, highest bliss.

Pāṇna: wisdom, insight which purifies the mind, right thought, right understanding.

Prakṛiti: the original or natural form or condition of anything, in sankhyashchool of thought the original producer of the material world.

Satva: true existence, as a guna, it has purity and knowledge.

Sākshī: with an eye, a witness, purush witnessing silently the actions of prakriti.

Samādhi: union with, intense absorption, intense contemplation of any object so that contemplator identifies with the object meditated upon. In vipassana it refers to concentration and control of one's mind, right effort, right awareness, right concentration.

Sīla: morality, purity of vocal and physical action, right speech, right action and right livelihood.

Sukha: good space, happiness, well-being opposed to dukh, bad space as found in suffering, sorrow and unhappiness.

Svabhāva: one's nature, according to the nature of the individual soul.

Svadharmā: one's own law or way of action.

Vidyā: knowledge, avidya refers to ignorance and knowledge of a phenomenon in time and space, vidya and avidya both are needed.

Vipāsanā: introspection, insight into impermanent nature of mind and body which purifies the mind.

Yoga: the act of yoking or uniting; according to Patanjali, it involves cessation of the habitual movements of consciousness; any practice which leads to union with divine is yoga. A variety of yoga have been identified including Karmayoga, Bhaktiyoga, Jnanayoga, Dhyāna Yoga, Rājyoga, Hathayoga, Kriyā Yoga, and Integral Yoga.

3.9 ANSWERS TO SELF ASSESSMENT QUESTIONS

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 1

1. deficit
2. strength and virtue
3. True
4. JadunathSinha
5. True
6. Jiva
7. brain-processed learning (Sravana), mind generated understanding (Manana), and consciousness–accessed realization (Nididhyāsan)
8. False
9. Western perspective focuses on materialistic-deterministic aspects of human existence, whereas Indian perspective assumes a more inclusive spiritual-growth perspective on human existence.
10. empirical or worldly (*Aparā-vidyā*) and higher spiritual (*Parā-vidyā*).

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 2

1. WEIRD refers to people from Western, Educated, Industrialized, Rich, and Democratic societies.
2. The two planes of reality consist of a cosmological and an ordinary.
3. Subjective well-being is the non-western perspective is considered as a universal goal going beyond the individual, focusing on people as a whole, and seeking well-being of everyone.
4. Lao-Tzu, the ancient Chinese philosopher
5. The Buddhist followers of Anatta (not Self)

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 3

1. Pleasure is an agreeable feeling characterized by gratification or satisfaction, whereas Pain is regarded as a disagreeable feeling produced by an undesired object and involves a feeling of being thwarted.
2. *Ādhyatmika, ādhibhoutika, and ādhidaivika*
3. True
4. True
5. *Vigyanamayakośa* refers to higher forms of the mind and the subtle realms like high order insights, intuition, and clarity of awareness.
6. *SthitaPragyā*
7. *Akāma*
8. *Dharma, Artha, Kāma, and Moksha*

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 4

1. Patanjali defines yoga as a process of restraining the mind (Chitta) from various modifications (Vritti).
2. yama, niyama, asana, and pranayama
3. qualities belonging to the divine state (*Daivī-Sampat*) and demonic qualities (*āsurī-sampat*).
4. *Sīla, Samādhi* and *Pāṇna*.
5. mind and body.
6. The seven chakras are *mulādhāra*, *svādhīsthāna*, *manipura*, *anahata*, *vishuddhi*, *ājyā*, and *sahasrāra*.
7. *Sattva, Rajas*, and *Tamas*

3.10 UNIT END QUESTIONS

1. Describe the key parameters on which Indian perspective differs from the western perspective.

2. What are differential ways in which psychological phenomena are treated by Western and Indian psychological perspectives?
3. Why culture should be taken into account while studying happiness?
4. What are the areas in which Indian psychological concepts can help to improve quality of life? Discuss with the help of insights from the study of some Indian psychological concepts.
5. How do you connect personal well-being with social well-being in the Indian and Western psychological perspectives?
6. Discuss the significance of yoga for psychology by identifying any three domains of psychological functioning.
7. Enumerate the attributes of dharma and give examples from your experience.
8. What are the key transformations that take place in a person going on the path of attaining the state of Sthitapragya ?
9. Explain 'attachment' in relation to wellbeing.
10. How inclusive is Vedanta view? Explain.
11. What are potential psychological implications of panchakosha view of human existence?
12. How do you relate the ashtanga yoga prescribed by Patanjali to life style ?
13. How will you explain the influence of Vipassana on the pursuit of happy life?
14. Acquaint yourself with two forms of meditation and indicate their connection with well-being.

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UNIT 4 CHARACTER STRENGTHS AND VIRTUES: INTERPERSONAL STRENGTHS AND WELL-BEING*

Structure

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4.1 LEARNING OBJECTIVES

After studying this Unit, you would be able to:

- *Explain the concept of strengths and virtues, and their importance;*
- *Differentiate between strengths and other related constructs;*
- *Describe the different classifications of strengths; and*
- *Analyze specific interpersonal strengths such as forgiveness, gratitude, kindness, compassion, altruism, and empathy, and their impact on well-being.*

4.2 INTRODUCTION

Take two pieces of paper. On the top of the first paper write 'List 1' and list down all your strengths. Use your mobile phone to time yourself for one minute. Stop writing at the end of one minute.

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Now, take the other paper and write 'List 2' on the top. Here, list down all your weaknesses. Again, time yourself for one minute. Stop writing when the minute is over.

Now hold both the lists in front of you. Which list is longer –list 1 or 2?

If you are an exception, then perhaps List 1 is longer than List 2. Which means you could recall more strengths than weaknesses. But if you are like most people, chances are that List 2 is longer than List 1. This means that in the same amount of time, people can recall their weaknesses or shortcomings more quickly and easily than their strengths. On the other hand, we often struggle to remember what we are good at - our talents, strengths and virtues.

Why is that? Because we are conditioned to think that way. As children, our parents pointed out our mistakes so that we could correct ourselves. In school, if we were weak at Maths, Science or History, our teachers told us to work harder at them. As adults, our bosses tell us to learn skills that we need for a job but do not have. From an evolutionary perspective too, our brains are hardwired to detect imperfections, problems or threats in our environment so that we can overcome or avoid them. None of this is necessarily bad. On the contrary, we *do* need to correct our mistakes, improve ourselves, learn skills required to do our work better, and keep ourselves safe from dangerous situations. However, because of this conditioning, we tend to pay less attention to our talents, strengths and virtues than we should. In fact, we often downplay our strengths so as not to appear boastful! Awareness, acknowledgement and recognition of our strengths and virtues can play a significant role in enhancing our well-being.

4.3 CONCEPT OF CHARACTER STRENGTHS

For more than half a century, psychology and psychiatry focussed on answering the question: “What makes us mentally ill?” Immense research was done to systematically classify mental disorders, identify their causal factors (both biological and psychosocial), and arrive at necessary treatment modalities. This led to the creation of the American Psychiatric Association’s *Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders* (DSM, now in its fifth version) and the World Health Organization’s *International Classification of Diseases* (ICD, currently in its 11th version). However, this fixation with ‘fixing’ all that is wrong with the human mind led psychologists to overlook one significant question: “What makes us mentally well?” This is another, larger scale example of our preoccupation with *weaknesses* rather than *strengths*. It was in 1998, when Martin Seligman highlighted the need for a shift in focus in the field of Psychology. In his Presidential Address at the American Psychological Association he stated, “*Psychology is not just the study of weakness and damage, it is also the study of strength and virtue. Treatment is not just fixing what is broken, it is nurturing what is best within ourselves*” (Seligman, 1998).

- **Defining Character Strengths**

A strength can be defined as a natural capacity for behaving, thinking, or feeling in a way that allows for optimal functioning & performance in the pursuit of valued outcomes (Linley & Harrington, 2006). This definition implies that a strength is partly innate or instinctive. It is something that an individual has a natural inclination towards. However, as is the case with most psychological variables, environmental factors and experiences may nurture and support the development of specific strengths or hinder their

development. For example, appreciating an innately creative child for her novel ways of doing things can foster the child's creative thinking. On the other hand, ignoring or disregarding the child's original thinking, with time, would lead to dampening of her creative instincts.

Manifestation of our strengths can be seen in all aspects of human experience including our affect, behaviour, and cognitions, similar to our personality being reflected in our behaviour, thoughts, and emotions. Putting our strengths to use in the personal, professional, and social spheres helps us in achieving our goals more effectively and efficiently. It enhances our overall performance because we are doing something that comes naturally to us, that we are good at and that we enjoy doing.

What Strengths are Not

- Talents (what we naturally do well): These are naturally occurring patterns of thoughts, feelings, and behaviour. They are *potential* strengths.
- Skills (what we train ourselves to do): These are specific competencies we develop or acquire because they are needed to do our job well, relate better with people or the environment, e.g., computer skills, communication skills, driving skills, etc. Character strengths can push us to building specific skills. The strength of the love for learning can drive us to learning computer skills which also gives us an edge in the job market.
- Interests (our passions): preference towards certain activities or goals that are significant to the individual. Character strengths and interests are closely linked. We might choose interests that give the opportunity to display our strengths. For example, interest in civil services because it helps me to use my strength of leadership.
- Resources (our external supports): these are systems available in our environment that help us to live well, e.g., social network of family and friends, access to health and education etc. We use our character strengths (like gratitude, empathy, and social intelligence) to build and maintain these resources.
- Values (what we internally hold dear): internalized goals and desires that are socially and morally approved. Strengths are values in action. When our values get translated into behaviour, we are displaying our character strengths.

• **Significance of Character Strengths**

The global Gallup Poll shows that most people, across countries and cultures think that focusing on weaknesses will help them improve more than focusing on strengths (Hodges & Clifton, 2004). However, research on the significance of strengths, across cultures, suggests that recognizing, developing, and using your strengths have manifold benefits.

Benefits of Using Character Strengths

- *brings about greater understanding, perceptivity, and perspective in your life*
- *provides a sense of direction*
- *creates a feeling of vitality and energy*

- *helps to buffer against stress*
- *generates hope and optimism*
- *enhances confidence and self-esteem*
- *fills one with a sense of joy and fulfilment*
- *increases motivation and helps achieve one's goals*
- *Improves engagement and performance at work*

(Source: Clifton & Anderson, 2001–02)

Thus character strengths are important not only for people to feel good but also do well in various life domains. Strengths are proposed to be energising to the user, valuable in their own right, and beneficial to society. They contribute significantly to achieving personal well-being, accomplishing life goals, enriching personal relationships, working well with others, and contributing to a better country (Solano & Cosentino, 2016). Martinez-Marti and Ruch (2014) demonstrated that character strengths like hope, zest and humor are consistently correlated with well-being, and that this relationship is consistent across the life span.

Does this mean we ignore our weaknesses? Not at all! While strengths research suggests that one's greatest chances of success lie in areas of one's strengths, it does not imply that one should ignore one's weaknesses. In fact, it is not always possible or even prudent to do so. After all, a salesman who does not enjoy the challenge of meeting new people; in other words, is weak on 'woo' (winning others over), will be in danger of losing his job. Thus, strengths-based programs focus on helping individuals to maximise their strengths and to determine how best to manage their weaknesses.

Self Assessment Questions 1

1. Which of the following is true?
 - a) Strengths allow us to function at our maximum potential.
 - b) Strengths are fixed and unchangeable.
 - c) Skills are abilities that we naturally possess.
 - d) None of the above
2. Which of the following is not true?
 - a) We should focus more on our strengths than our weaknesses.
 - b) We should ignore our weaknesses and not worry about them.
 - c) We should develop our strengths and learn to manage our weaknesses.
 - d) None of the above
3. How do strengths relate to values?

4.4 MEASUREMENT OF STRENGTHS

There are three major approaches to the concept of strengths and their measurement:

1. The Values in Action (VIA) Classification of Strengths and Virtues
2. Clifton's StrengthsFinder®
3. The Search Institute's 40 Developmental Assets

4.4.1 VIA Classification of Strengths and Virtues

History and Development

With a mission to set right the skewed focus of psychology on solely negative aspects of human life and functioning, Christopher Peterson and Martin Seligman (Peterson & Seligman, p.4, 2004) created their own “manual of the sanities” which focused on what is good about people, specifically on the character strengths that allow for a good life. They devised the Values in Action (VIA) framework to conceptualize character strengths - it was their handbook for human health and flourishing. They defined character strengths as a universally recognized subset of morally valued personality traits (Peterson & Seligman, 2004). Peterson and Seligman attempted to enumerate all possible strengths using various methods. They deliberated with leading scholars in the field, held discussions with conference participants, surveyed literature including ancient religious and philosophical texts to arrive at a list of virtues and strengths that were common across cultures.

They refined this list of hundreds of strengths thus obtained based on the following ten criteria:

1. *A strength contributes to a fulfilling, good life for oneself and others:* The strength helps the individual to flourish and thrive. It goes beyond distress and disorder and allows the person to live well, fulfils one's potential and contributes meaningfully to the lives of others.
2. *A strength is morally valued in its own right, even in the absence of obvious favourable outcomes:* The strength is a valuable attribute and worthy of being pursued by itself, irrespective of the desirable effects it brings. Thus, one strives to be courageous or loving because these characteristics make up a ‘good human being’. The fact that they also bring a sense of mastery or contribute to healthy interpersonal relationships is secondary. In fact, actions that are driven only by the consequences they produce cannot be considered character strengths because they are extrinsically motivated rather than internally valued (Peterson & Seligman, 2004).
3. *The display of a strength by one person does not diminish other people. In fact, it generates admiration rather than jealousy as others pursue character strengths:* Because the strength is morally and socially valued across cultures, individuals aspire to reach them. Witnessing a strength in action inspires or motivates others to act in similar ways. Random acts of kindness get paid forward. Being surrounded by optimistic people makes us more hopeful. Perseverance in others inspires us to persist and pursue our goals.
4. *A strength has an opposite that has a negative connotation:* A strength cannot have an opposite that is also seen as good. Strengths may be *bipolar* i.e., they may lie on a continuum that consists of a negative extreme. For example, kindness can lie on a continuum that ranges from extreme meanness on one end and altruism on the other. A strength may also be *unipolar* i.e., it

may not have an opposite that is negative. For example, a sense of humour may vary from no sense of humour to great sense of humour. But it has no meaningful negative range.

5. *A strength is observable across a person's behaviour - thoughts, actions, feelings, and is relatively stable across time and situations:* Strengths can be *tonic* (constant) or *phasic* (overtly seen or unseen depending on their use). For example, constant character strengths include humour and kindness. These can be observed across a variety of situations, are more trait-like and can be easily assessed. Bravery, on the other hand, may be observable only in specific situations that demand brave action. However, the underlying common factor between tonic and phasic virtues is that they are corrective. They are an antidote to naturally inherent negative human tendencies, e.g., bravery is an antidote to cowardice and compassion is an antidote to cruelty.
6. *A strength is unique and distinct from other strengths in the classification:* The final classification consisted of strengths that are mutually exclusive. For example, the character strength of 'patience' is considered a blend of self-regulation, persistence, and open-mindedness (a.k.a. judgement). Therefore, it has not been included in the final list of 24 VIA character strengths.
7. *A character strength is exemplified in cultures in the form of stories, myths, parables, songs, poems, etc.:* Character strengths are glorified and celebrated across cultures in various forms. Parables, songs and stories of virtuous men and women are considered role models for children. The popular bed-time story of the hare and the tortoise teaches the value of perseverance. Raja Harishchandra is exemplified for his virtue of honesty; Rani Laxmibai is regarded for her valor and courage. In fact, examples are drawn not just from folklore or fiction but also from real life. I am sure that if you spend a minute or two, you will be able to identify many of your own acquaintances who are paragons of virtue!
8. *There are prodigies or role models that exemplify the strength:* This criterion may not be applicable to all strengths in the classification but is seen to exist based on anecdotal evidence (Peterson & Seligman, 2004).
9. *Some individuals do not possess the character strength:* There are some people who are completely devoid of one or another character strength. For example, an individual who is completely devoid of all empathy, or another lacking prudence and prone to risky behaviour. Personality disorders categorized in the DSM may be considered examples of individuals who lack one or more-character strengths.
10. *Societal structures and institutions promote and sustain the development of character strengths and virtues:* For example, student councils in schools foster the development of leadership; assigning group projects to students encourages teamwork; award functions in schools and colleges appreciate excellence. These examples also lend support to the fact that character strengths and virtues can be cultivated and nurtured.

Character Strengths and Virtues

This extensive effort resulted in the identification of twenty-four *character strengths*, or mechanisms, that allow us to achieve *virtues* (which are the core universal

characteristics emphasized by philosophers and religious leaders). Thus, these character strengths have been categorized into six virtues:

1. Wisdom – this virtue incorporates strengths related to the acquisition and use of knowledge.
2. Courage – these strengths involve the exercise of will to accomplish goals in the face of internal or external opposition.
3. Love, humanity – interpersonal strengths that involve inclination towards forming connections with others.
4. Justice – civic strengths that contribute to society.
5. Temperance – these strengths buffer us against excesses.
6. Transcendence – these strengths help to establish a meaningful connection with the larger universe.

Table 4.1 Virtues and Character Strengths according to the VIA Classification

Wisdom and Knowledge • <i>Creativity</i>: Original, adaptive, ingenuity, seeing and doing things in different ways. • <i>Curiosity</i>: Exploration, interest, novelty-seeking, openness to experience; finding subjects and topics fascinating. • <i>Open-mindedness</i>: judgment, critical thinking, thinking things through and examining them from all sides; not jumping to conclusions; openness to changing incorrect/false perceptions and beliefs. • <i>Love of learning</i>: Mastering new skills, topics, and systematically acquiring knowledge • <i>Perspective</i>: Wisdom, ability to provide wise counsel to others; seeing the big picture.
Courage • <i>Bravery</i>: Valor, not shrinking from threat, challenge, difficulty, or pain; speaking up for what's right • <i>Persistence</i>: Perseverance, industriousness; finishing what one starts; persisting despite obstacles; taking pleasure in completing tasks • <i>Integrity</i>: Authenticity, honesty; presenting oneself in a genuine way and acting in a sincere way; taking responsibility for one's feelings and actions • <i>Vitality</i>: zest, enthusiasm, vigor, energy; approaching life with excitement and energy; not doing things half-heartedly
Humanity • <i>Love</i>: Both loving and being loved; genuine warmth; valuing close relations involving sharing and caring

• <i>Kindness</i>: Generosity, nurturance, care, compassion, altruistic love; doing favors and good deeds for others; helping them; taking care of them • <i>Social intelligence</i>: Being aware of the motives and feelings of other people and oneself; knowing what to do to fit into different social situations; knowing what makes other people tick
Justice • <i>Teamwork, citizenship, loyalty</i>: Contributing to a group effort • <i>Fairness</i>: Adhering to principles of justice, not allowing feelings to bias decisions about others • <i>Leadership</i>: Organizing group activities to get things done, positively influencing others
Temperance • <i>Forgiveness and mercy</i>: Mercy, accepting others' shortcomings, giving people a second chance, letting go of hurt • <i>Humility / Modesty</i>: Letting one's accomplishments speak for themselves; not seeking the spotlight; not regarding oneself as more special than one is • <i>Prudence</i>: Careful about one's choices; not taking undue risks; not saying or doing things that might later be regretted • <i>Self-regulation</i>: Self-control, disciplined, managing impulses, emotions, and vices
Transcendence • <i>Appreciation of beauty and excellence</i>: Awe and wonder for beauty, admiration for skill and moral greatness • <i>Gratitude</i>: Being aware of and thankful for the good things that happen; expressing thanks, feeling blessed • <i>Hope</i>: Optimism, positive future-mindedness, expecting the best & working to achieve it • <i>Humour</i>: Playfulness, bringing smiles to others, light-hearted – seeing the lighter side • <i>Spirituality</i>: Religiousness, faith, having coherent beliefs about the higher purpose and meaning of the universe

Source: VIA Institute of Character <https://www.viacharacter.org/character-strengths>

Signature Strengths

Every human being possesses each of the 24 character strengths. However, some strengths are more dominant than the others. These are called *signature strengths*. Positive Psychologists emphasize the development and use of one's signature strengths. These are character strengths that an individual possesses, recognizes and uses frequently in various aspects of their life. Signature strengths are those that represent 'the real

you', they bring with them a sense of authenticity. There are three key features that can help us recognize our signature strengths (Niemiec, 2018):

- **Essential**- our signature strengths feel like an integral part of who we are. These strengths represent our positive traits. Others may use these to describe us.
- **Effortless** - using our strengths feels natural and easy. Doing an activity that feels effortless and experiencing a sense of flow in the process indicates that we are using our strength.
- **Energizing** - expressing signature strengths is invigorating and intrinsically motivating. You feel energized doing activities that put these strengths to use, and you look forward to engaging in such activities again.

4.4.2 Clifton's Strengths Finder

History and Development

Another popular method of conceptualizing strengths was developed by Donald Clifton and Edward Anderson from the Gallup Corporation (Clifton & Anderson, 2001–02). They defined a strength as the ability to provide consistent, near perfect performance in a given activity (Hodges & Clifton, 2004). According to them, a strength is a combination of talent, knowledge and skill. Thus,

$$\text{Strength} = \text{Talent} + \text{Knowledge and Skill}$$

This definition too highlights the instinctual aspect of strengths in that it comprises a natural talent. A talent represents a capacity to *do* something. Your talents enable you to excel not once, but repeatedly. Therefore, your achievements and successes are directly related to your talents. Knowledge comprises facts and lessons learnt. Skill refers to the specific steps required to perform a particular activity. A talent when polished, honed and built upon by acquiring the necessary competence and expertise becomes a strength. Thus, for a talent to become a strength one needs to invest time and energy in it, practice and develop it. Talent, knowledge and skills are all important for building a strength. However, talents take precedence. They are the starting point for a strength, are innate and cannot be developed. For example, as a counsellor you can learn the various approaches to counselling (knowledge) and undergo training to ask the appropriate open-ended questions (a skill). However, without the innate capacity to sense the emotions of those around you and experience their feelings as though they are your own, empathy cannot be taught.

Researchers at the Gallup Corporation developed their classification based on their interviews with nearly 2 million people across the world. Their research included successful managers, teachers and employees from a wide range of industries. They found that successful managers used a strengths-based approach in management by matching naturally occurring talents of their employees with the tasks assigned to them. Such employees had the opportunity at work to do 'what they are best at'. They were, thus, more engaged and productive at work and contributed significantly to the growth of their teams and organization. The Gallup researchers observed similar strengths-related gains in the education sector. Development of talent and strengths amongst students led to better academic performance, enhanced self-confidence, reduced absenteeism and lethargy (Clifton & Harter, 2003).

Talents and Themes

According to CliftonStrengths® Finder, there are thirty-four strengths or talents that can be organized into the following four *themes* (groups of similar talents):

1. *Strategic Thinking* - Talents comprising this theme reflect good critical thinking and decision making. If you are dominant in this theme, you are likely to do well in tasks that require accumulation, assimilation, and analysis of information. You might enjoy researching, predicting, and processing information in different ways.
2. *Relationship Building* - Talents comprising this theme reflect interpersonal and peoples' skills. If you are dominant in this theme, you are likely to have high emotional intelligence, relate well to people, are able to build strong relations, keep the team together and help them do well.
3. *Influencing* - Individuals strong in the Influencing theme can take charge, speak up and make sure that others are heard.
4. *Executing* - Talents comprising this theme reflect the ability to get things done. If you are dominant in this theme, you are likely to be hard working, responsible, focussed on putting things into action.

Table 4.2 Clifton Strengths® Themes and Corresponding Talents

Themes	Talents
Strategic Thinking	<i>Analytical</i> (objective, logical, search for patterns and connections) <i>Context</i> (develop a better understanding of the present by reflecting on the past) <i>Futuristic</i> (dreamer, inspired by the future and the possibilities it holds) <i>Ideation</i> (fascinated by ideas, look for connections between seemingly divergent events) <i>Input</i> (collecting and archiving information - facts, ideas, objects, events, etc.) <i>Intellection</i> (introspective, like to think) <i>Learner</i> (desire to learn and improve) <i>Strategic</i> (ability to see clearly amidst the chaos, spot patterns within complexity)
Relationship Building	<i>Adaptability</i> (easy-going and flexible) <i>Connectedness</i> (believe in the unity of humankind, considerate, caring) <i>Developer</i> (recognize others' potential, nurture their growth and progress) <i>Empathy</i> (putting yourself in the other person's shoes and seeing things from their perspective) <i>Harmony</i> (maximize agreement, minimize conflict) <i>Includer</i> (accepting, make people feel like they are part of the group) <i>Individualization</i> (recognize individual uniqueness and use it to create a productive team) <i>Positivity</i> (enthusiastic, energetic, optimistic) <i>Relator</i> (enjoy close, intimate relationships with others)

Influencing	<i>Activator</i> (focus on doing, make things happen) <i>Command</i> (take control, make decisions) <i>Communication</i> (explanation, clarification, good when talking) <i>Competition</i> (desire to win and excel, comparison with others) <i>Maximizer</i> (focus on strengths to achieve personal and group excellence) <i>Self-assurance</i> (self-confident, independent thinking) <i>Significance</i> (wish to make an impact) <i>Woo</i> (form quick connections with people and win them over)
Executing	<i>Achiever</i> (hard working, productive) <i>Arranger</i> (organized, combine individuals and resources in the most productive way possible) <i>Belief</i> (possess enduring core values that give meaning and satisfaction in life) <i>Consistency</i> (equality, fairness, setting clear rules and procedures) <i>Deliberative</i> (careful, vigilant, good decision making, weighing all pros and cons) <i>Discipline</i> (precise, orderly, structured, good planning) <i>Focus</i> (goal/task oriented, good at prioritizing and staying on track) <i>Responsibility</i> (conscientiousness, dependable, ready to take ownership for your words and actions) <i>Restorative</i> (good at analyzing and solving problems)

Source: [www.gallup.com](https://www.gallup.com/cliftonstrengths/en/253715/34-cliftonstrengths-themes.aspx) <https://www.gallup.com/cliftonstrengths/en/253715/34-cliftonstrengths-themes.aspx>

While the CliftonStrengths® and VIA classifications both focus on positive traits there is an important difference. The VIA classification identifies universal strengths that are applicable across life domains. The CliftonStrengths®, on the other hand, focus on talents and strengths in the work setting.

Talents versus Strengths

You may be wondering if your talents can change over time? Your talents are unlikely to change considerably throughout the course of your life because they are naturally occurring. However, by choosing which talents you wish to focus on, invest in and acquire knowledge and skill, you may develop new strengths. This focus may be determined by your life stage, the demands of your environment, your social roles and responsibilities. Talents can be distinguished from other concepts of abilities (e.g., I.Q. and aptitude) that are more global and do not help to identify specific things that a person can do. Talents are also different from academic abilities like reading, language or math as they help an individual achieve success in multiple areas of life (and are not limited to academics or career only).

4.4.3 The Search Institute's 40 Developmental Assets

History and Development

The Search Institute's Developmental Assets (Benson et al., 1998) framework focuses

on children - what makes children healthy, resilient and flourish? Developmental Assets are the relationships, opportunities, and character strengths that are strongly related to children and youths' well-being (Scales, Roehlkepartain, & Shramko, 2017). There are certain external resources in our environment that support and promote psychological growth, resilience and thriving in children. For example, family support, adult role models, positive peer influences, safe neighbourhoods, etc. There are also internal resources specific to every child that nurture healthy psychological development, e.g., high self-esteem, values such as honesty and integrity, social and interpersonal capabilities, etc. These internal and external variables are categorized into two groups of 20 assets each. Together they comprise important factors that contribute to positive youth development. In other words, they foster the development of young people into healthy, caring and responsible adults. These developmental assets are assessed using a 156-item survey - Search Institute Profiles of Student Life: Attitudes and Behaviours. This survey was developed in 1989 by the Search Institute researchers headed by Peter Benson, to identify the resources that can help youth to make healthy behavioural choices and refrain from risky behaviour. It was revised in 1996 to make it developmentally relevant from early childhood through adolescence. The survey measures:

- 40 developmental assets comprising of 20 external supports and 20 internal strengths
- 24 youth risk behaviour elements (e.g., substance use, sexual activity, antisocial behaviour)
- 10 high-risk behaviour patterns
- Key social and emotional skills
- 8 thriving indicators (succeeds in school, helps others, values diversity, maintains good health, exhibits leadership, resists danger, delays gratification, overcomes adversity)
- 5 developmental deficits (alone at home, TV overexposure, physical abuse, victim of violence, drinking parties)

Table 4.3 The 40 Developmental Assets

External Assets
<i>Support:</i> Young people need to be surrounded by people who love, care for, appreciate, and accept them. 1. Family support 2. Positive family communication 3. Other adult relationships 4. Caring neighbourhood 5. Caring school climate 6. Parent involvement in schooling
<i>Empowerment:</i> Young people need to feel valued and valuable. This happens when youth feel safe and respected. 7. Community values youth 8. Youth as resources 9. Service to others 10. Safety

<i>Boundaries and Expectations:</i> Young people need clear rules, consistent consequences for breaking rules, and encouragement to do their best. 11. Family boundaries 12. School boundaries 13. Neighbourhood boundaries 14. Adult role models 15. Positive peer influence 16. High expectations
<i>Constructive Use of Time:</i> Young people need opportunities-outside of school-to learn and develop new skills and interests with other youth and adults. 17. Creative activities 18. Youth programs 19. Religious community 20. Time at home
Internal Assets
<i>Commitment to Learning:</i> Young people need a sense of the lasting importance of learning and a belief in their own abilities. 21. Achievement motivation 22. School engagement-Young person is actively engaged in learning. 23. Homework 24. Bonding to school 25. Reading for pleasure
<i>Positive Values:</i> Young people need to develop strong guiding values or principles to help them make healthy life choices. 26. Caring 27. Equality and social justice 28. Integrity 29. Honesty 30. Responsibility 31. Restraint
<i>Social Competencies:</i> Young people need the skills to interact effectively with others, to make difficult decisions, and to cope with new situations. 32. Planning and decision-making 33. Interpersonal competence 34. Cultural competence 35. Resistance skills 36. Peaceful conflict resolution

Positive Identity: Young people need to believe in their own self-worth and to feel that they have control over the things that happen to them.

- 37. Personal power
- 38. Self-esteem
- 39. Sense of purpose
- 40. Positive view of personal future

Source: www.search-institute.org. Retrieved from:

<https://www.search-institute.org/our-research/development-assets/developmental-assets-framework/>

Different versions of the survey that are suitable for different age groups have been developed. These include four age groups: 3-5, 5-9, 8-12, 12-18. The survey has also been translated into various languages - Acholi, Arabic, Armenian, Bulgarian, Chinese, Farsi, French, Hmong, Japanese, Khmer, Nuer, Russian, Somali, Urdu and Vietnamese.

Higher levels of these developmental assets have been linked to several positive outcomes in both males and females, across racial/ethnic backgrounds, and socio-cultural contexts. These include better grades in school, positive emotions, greater engagement in community activities, better health, ability to delay gratification, and decreased engagement in risky behaviours like violence and alcohol/drug use (Scales, Roehlkepartain & Shramko, 2017; Roehlkepartain, 2015). Studies have also shown enhanced well-being in youth after their participation in Positive Youth Development programs that promote the development of assets like social relationships, positive identity, engagement in constructive activities, character strengths, etc. (Scales, Roehlkepartain & Shramko, 2017). Assets like family, friend and neighbourhood support, positive peer influences, participation in meaningful opportunities like sports, arts, drama, etc. protect against the negative effects of exposure to violence in youth, promote behavioural adaptation and foster resilience (Jain & Cohen, 2013). Thus, programs and interventions targeted towards strengthening these resources would go a long way in acting as a buffer against the negative psychological impact of exposure to violence in youth.

Self Assessment Questions 2

1. A naturally occurring pattern of thought, feeling or behaviour is called _____.
 - a) Talent
 - b) Theme
 - c) Strength
 - d) All the above
2. The ability to provide consistent, near-perfect performance in a given activity:
 - a) Talent
 - b) Theme
 - c) Strength
 - d) Passion

3. Which one of the following is a criteria to identify a strength?
 - a) When you display a strength, it makes people around you jealous.
 - b) A strength is valued because it garners appreciation from people.
 - c) Strengths are mutually exclusive.
 - d) None of the above
4. What are signature strengths?

4.5 INTERPERSONAL STRENGTHS AND WELL-BEING

In this section we will look at specific character strengths that are valuable in the interpersonal domain and contribute to psychological well-being. These strengths enhance our social connectedness, build our social resources and enrich our interpersonal relationships. These include:

- Forgiveness
- Gratitude
- Kindness
- Empathy

4.5.1 Forgiveness

Take a minute and think about a time when someone (a friend, sibling, acquaintance, classmate, etc.) said something hurtful to you or wronged you. Maybe they borrowed your bike and got into an accident, said something nasty behind your back or bullied/harassed you. How did it make you feel? Upset? Angry? Maybe you felt like you wanted to 'give it back to them', 'teach them a lesson'. Or perhaps you wished for some misfortune to befall them. In some situations, however, you might have thought, "It's alright, everyone makes mistakes", "Let me not be too harsh on them", "That's a mean thing to say, but she's human". In other words, you chose to forgive them. Forgiveness is one's capacity to let go. To let bygones be bygones without being driven by the need to seek revenge, hold grudges or harbour resentment against the wrong done towards us.

Forgiveness is a character strength that belongs to the virtue category of temperance. Temperance refers to moderation. This virtue category includes those strengths that allow us to moderate or restrain our thoughts, feelings and behaviour. Thus, the strengths of temperance 'temper' our responses and prevent us from extremes. Specifically, the positive trait of forgiveness protects us from the excess of hatred. It is a character trait that is highly valued across cultures.

Forgiveness may not be easy to practice every time. It may not have an immediate tangible outcome. It may not result in discernible benefits to the one who practices it. And it certainly does not prevent future transgressions. Yet it is intensely fulfilling. It is the ability to let go of an unpleasant situation, not because of internal states like shame/fear/guilt, or external motivation like bribes or threats, but because of a positive strength

of character. While the negative feelings of resentment, animosity, vengeance, etc. leave us feeling empty inside, practicing forgiveness brings a sense of satisfaction and peace at having done the right thing. Witnessing an act of forgiveness is moving.

The Hindi movie *Dor* provides an example of forgiveness where the widowed protagonist, Meera, initially devastated and filled with hatred, eventually forgives her husband's alleged murderer. The movie depicts, beautifully, Meera's journey from being tormented by negative feelings of grief, bitterness and animosity towards the wife of her husband's alleged murderer to experiencing relief, freedom and peace when she decides to forgive him.

Forgiveness and mercy are a *social strength* (Peterson & Seligman, 2004). As Mahatma Gandhi had said, if we were to fight 'an eye for an eye', the whole world, indeed, would go blind. Thus, forgiveness is valuable as it prevents an unending cycle of hostility, aggression and ill will. As such, it helps to restore harmony and cooperation amongst individuals and groups. Hence, it is an adaptive interpersonal strength as it bolsters social relationships. It is easier to forgive if one can take the point of view of the transgressor. Thus, empathy facilitates forgiveness. Other character strengths like hope, kindness and spirituality may also facilitate forgiveness.

What Forgiveness is Not

Forgiveness is not the same as pardoning, condoning or forgetting. Pardoning is a legal concept, often used in the context of the administration of justice. While administration of justice is a social phenomenon, forgiveness is an individual/internal process. Condoning refers to justifying the offense or treating it as acceptable or ignoring it completely, e.g., when you see someone stealing in a shop and you just look the other way. Similarly, forgetting removes awareness about the transgression. True forgiving does not involve a wilful acceptance of the shortcomings/imperfections of others and giving them another chance. Forgiving also needs to be distinguished from reconciliation i.e., restoration of the relationship. Even though the latter may be a related outcome of the act of forgiveness.

Decisional Forgiveness: This refers to a cognitive and behavioural intention to put aside revenge or avoidance and reconcile with the transgressor (Lichtenfeld et al., 2015). However, even though you may decide to restore a cordial relationship with the other and give up the desire to engage in 'tit for tat', you might do so grudgingly. Such an act of forgiveness where negative feelings persist is hollow or superficial forgiveness.

Emotional Forgiveness: This, as the name suggests, involves an emotional component in the process of forgiving. Negative emotions associated with the transgression and transgressor are regulated and one attempts actively to replace them with benevolent ones. This is true forgiveness.

Forgiveness and Well-Being

Longitudinal studies have shown that forgiveness is associated with increased psychosocial well-being and reduced psychological distress (e.g., depression). Specifically, those with high levels of forgiveness also show higher levels of positive emotions and social integration (Long et al., 2020). Not only is forgiveness linked to better mental health outcomes, but it is also related to better physical health. Researchers posit that the reduction in stress and toxic negative emotions like anger because of

practicing forgiveness may have a positive effect on physical health. True forgiveness reduces anxiety, brings a sense of inner peace and strengthens the immune system (Weir, 2017). The positive effects of forgiveness are seen to spill over beyond the relationship with the offender. Individuals who display higher levels of forgiveness are also more prone to donate towards charity or engage in volunteering (Karremans et al., 2005). Thus, the benefits of this character strength are seen at the individual, interpersonal and societal level.

It is true that some people are more forgiving than others. Spiritual orientation and religious beliefs promote forgiveness. On the other hand, those with a tendency to ruminate find it more difficult to forgive. They may continue to think about the wrong that has been done to them over and over again. They tend to holding on to grudges and hurt feelings which interferes with their ability to empathize. However, forgiveness can be cultivated. Psychotherapeutic interventions with a positive psychological orientation have focussed on helping clients develop empathic and perspective taking skills. These promote forgiveness.

Reed & Enright (2006) report an intervention programme called Forgiveness Therapy consisting of four phases: (i) exploring one's negative feelings about the offense, (ii) deciding to forgive, (iii) working towards developing a better understanding of the offender, and (iv) discovering empathy and compassion for him or her. This programme showed a decrease in depression, anxiety, posttraumatic stress symptoms and increase in self-esteem, forgiveness, environmental mastery, and finding meaning in suffering in women who had experienced emotional abuse from their spouses. Moreover, these gains were observed to be long lasting (upto ~8 months post intervention) (Reed and Enright, 2006). Forgiveness can be an important aspect in couples therapy especially when dealing with infidelities. Even though certain scenarios or transgressions may be hard to forgive, they are likely to be equally rewarding should an individual display such character strength in these situations.

Self Assessment Questions 3

1. Forgiveness belongs to the virtue category of _____.
2. Forgiveness means pardoning someone. **True / False.**
3. Negative felings persist in decisional forgiveness. **True / False.**

4.5.2 Gratitude

A noble person is mindful and thankful of the favours he receives from others - The Buddha

Gratitude belongs to the virtue category of Transcendence. Transcendence is the act of rising above something to a superior state. The character strengths listed under this category are those that help us to connect to the larger universe and provide meaning to our lives. Gratitude includes a sense of appreciation towards someone or something, a sense of beneficence towards the other, and a motivation to act kindly towards the other (Fitzgerald, 1998). Simply put, gratitude is a sense of thankfulness in response to something received or a gift. The gift can be tangible, e.g., a birthday card made by your little niece; or intangible, e.g., cool evening rain after a blazing summer day. In both cases, one experiences a sense of grace, of being blessed by the kindness of a human being, object or event. The experience of gratitude generates several positive

emotions. We may feel humbled or inspired to be more kind ourselves. Gratitude fosters kindness and love, and therefore contributes to deeper interpersonal connections.

Personal gratitude refers to thankfulness that one feels and expresses towards an individual for the psychological or instrumental help they have provided.

Transpersonal gratitude transcends the person. It refers to thankfulness that one feels and expresses towards a higher power, God or life.

Trait gratitude is what we refer to as the character strength of gratitude. It involves a stable, long term, sustained attitude and daily practice of gratitude.

State gratitude refers to the momentary feelings of gratitude that an individual experiences in response to specific situations.

Gratitude too is valued across cultures and religions. An example is the tradition of Thanksgiving celebrated in countries across the world! Gratitude is seen as a desirable virtue that benefits both the individual and society. It makes us aware of the generosity of others, value it and act kindly in return. Thus, it supports reciprocity in human interactions, thereby promoting social stability. It also motivates prosocial behaviour after one has been a recipient of the same and makes individuals more prone to acting in moral ways. In this manner, it helps us realise the value of things, people or phenomena and prevents us from taking these for granted. It fosters respect and a deep sense of appreciation. Overall, an attitude of gratitude has significant benefits in terms of individual, interpersonal and social well-being.

Gratitude and Well-being

Psychological benefits of practicing gratitude have been observed in the following ways:

- greater optimism
- greater religiousness and spirituality
- strengthening of interpersonal relationships
- improved self-regulation
- enhanced happiness and well-being
- better physical and mental health

Hill et al. (2013) examined the relationship between gratitude and physical health in a sample of Swiss adults. They reported that those with greater dispositional gratitude also had higher self-rated physical health. They enjoyed high psychological well-being, were more likely to make healthy lifestyle choices and did not neglect health related issues. Gratitude was positively correlated with well-being and negatively correlated with psychological distress in a sample of 198 South African University students (Mason, 2019). Lin and Yeh (2013) examined how gratitude influences undergraduates' well-being via interpersonal and cognitive variables. They found that grateful individuals enjoy greater emotional as well as instrumental support from their companions. This may be attributed to feelings of being loved, valued, and cared for, in addition to other prosocial behaviours. Moreover, social support provides important coping resources in the face of stress. They also found that grateful undergraduates employ more active problem focussed and emotion focussed coping styles. Thus, gratitude leads to a more adaptive coping style (Lin & Yeh, 2013). Tan et al. (2021) conducted a 7-day mindful

gratitude journaling intervention in adult patients with advanced cancer. They found significant reductions in the overall suffering, psychological distress, and quality of life scores for participants in the intervention group but not in the control group. This finding lends support to the significance of gratitude practice in alleviating psychological pain and suffering associated with physical diseases as well. Gratitude interventions have also shown an increase in sport satisfaction and decrease in athlete burnout in college-level student athletes (Gabana et al., 2019).

Gratitude Interventions

Gratitude can be cultivated with targeted interventions and practice. Seligman et al. (2005) compared the effects of a gratitude intervention with a placebo condition on individuals in therapy. Gratitude interventions included (i) a 'gratitude visit' (writing and delivering a letter to someone who had helped them significantly at some point in their lives), (ii) making a list of 'three good things' in their life every day for a week. It was seen that relative to the placebo condition, those who received gratitude interventions showed significant increase in their happiness scores, significant decrease in their depression scores, and these effects lasted for six months after the treatment. The following cognitive-behavioural approach for learning gratitude has been outlined: (i) become aware of and identify non-grateful thoughts; (ii) generate gratitude-supporting thoughts; (iii) substitute the non-grateful thoughts with gratitude-supporting thoughts; and (iv) convert the subjective feeling of gratitude into overt actions. Cultivating gratitude needs discipline and practice. But investing in it helps us to savour the little pleasures associated with every-day life!

Self Assessment Questions 4

1. Explain transpersonal gratitude.
2. Describe state gratitude.
3. What is gratitude visit?

4.5.3 Kindness

Kindness is a character strength under the virtue category of Humanity. Strengths of humanity include positive traits that are manifested in the form of caring one-to-one relationships with others. Kindness means being nice to others - showing compassion and care, being concerned about their well-being and performing good deeds for them. This care, affection and attention directed towards the other is for their own sake as human beings, not out of a sense of duty or principle. Acts of kindness could be big (e.g., donating blood in the hospital) or small (holding the door open for the person entering behind you). These could also be directed towards a stranger (e.g., offering your seat to an elderly person while riding on a bus) or be performed within the context of deeper interpersonal relationships (e.g., taking care of an ailing parent). Kindness involves giving your time, energy, money to support others. Kindness, generosity, nurturance, care, compassion and altruistic love describe a type of other-orientation; an orientation where you give attention and affection to the other for their own sake and not because they serve some purpose for you. Thus, acts of true kindness are not performed with an expectation of a favour being returned, even though reciprocity may be one of the outcomes. In that sense, such loving compassion is unconditional, much like the 'unconditional positive regard' Carl Rogers spoke about.

4.5.3.1 Compassion and Altruism

Compassion, experienced as loving kindness, involves taking action to reduce the other's suffering. You feel a tenderness towards the pain of the other and do something to provide relief. This relief could be instrumental (e.g., feeding/clothing a homeless person) or emotional (e.g., being there for another person in their time of grief). In Hindu traditions, compassion is called *daya* and is one of the three central virtues along with charity and self-control. In the Buddhist tradition, compassion is understood as *karuna*. It is at the heart of the Buddha's teachings. *Altruism* is understood as selflessness. Truly altruistic acts that go beyond generosity towards our kith and kin, or an expectation of reciprocity can help us to evolve spiritually. True selflessness removes the egoistic boundaries between 'me and them' and sees all humanity as one. Three personality traits of altruistic people include:

- a) *Empathy/sympathy* - The ability to view and *understand* things from another person's perspective, feel *with* them what they are feeling, and to have the capacity to see beyond your needs and comfort.
- b) *Moral reasoning* - The ability to objectively differentiate between right and wrong and act accordingly. Individuals with high moral reasoning are more likely to act in helpful ways.
- c) *Social responsibility* - Those with a high sense of social responsibility consider it their duty to act in ways that are ethical, morally responsible, and socially beneficial. They are aware of the social impact their actions will make. They take ownership for their actions and their consequences.

Kindness and Well-Being

Studies have shown that kindness, compassion, generosity, and altruism have significant impact on well-being. Symeonidou et al. (2019) studied the effects of a kindness intervention on subjective well-being. Adult participants were divided into two groups. The experimental group was asked to record their kind actions daily for 7 days along with their feelings and thoughts associated with those actions. Participants in the control group were asked to write their daily routine also every day for a week. All participants were also asked to complete a subjective well-being measure pre-, post- and 2-months after the intervention. Results showed that subjective well-being was significantly enhanced for participants who received the kindness intervention. In fact, happy people become happier by counting acts of kindness performed by them daily (Otake, 2006).

Other studies have found positive associations between the character strengths of compassion and marital satisfaction (Goddard et al., 2016). Compassion promotes a deep understanding between couples and allows them to recognize and accept differences in their personalities, beliefs, thoughts, actions, and values. A recent study by Weziak-Bialowolska et al. (2021) found that consistent thoughts and actions directed towards the good of oneself and others was positively correlated with subsequent life satisfaction and happiness, mental and physical health, social connectedness, purpose and meaning in life. This orientation towards good was also associated with a lower risk of anxiety, loneliness, and depression. This indicates that promoting good thoughts and actions towards others has implications for human flourishing in personal, relational as well as social aspects on one's life.

An example of kindness in action is volunteerism. Volunteering for social causes not only benefits the cause/beneficiary but also has implications on the wellbeing of the benefactor. It enhances the psychological, emotional, and social well-being of volunteers (Balashov et al., 2018). Volunteering enhances our connections with others, gives a sense of mastery, boosts self-esteem, and adds meaning and purpose to our life.

4.5.4 Empathy

Empathy has not been categorically included in the VIA classification of character strengths. It is, however, closely related with the strengths of forgiveness and gratitude (Breen et al., 2010). Empathy has been listed as one of CliftonStrengths® under the Relational theme. Individuals high on empathy are aware of and can understand other people's feelings by putting themselves in their shoes. Empathy allows us to understand situations and experiences from another's perspective. Empathy is different from sympathy. When you feel sad for a person, it is sympathy. When you feel sad with a person, it is empathy. Thus, you can sense and share a person's feelings. Empathy allows us to be in tune with the feelings of others. As an empathetic person, you may not necessarily condone the choices made by the other, but you understand them. For example, you may not approve of/justify your best friend cheating on her boyfriend, but you are able to understand her perspective.

People with high empathy are emotionally intuitive. They can accurately put into words what others are feeling. Thus, other people feel heard, understood, and safe in their presence. They are willing to confide in a person who displays high empathy. Hence empathy is a valuable character trait for people in helping professions like doctors, counsellors, psychotherapists, etc. This character strength allows you to form deeper connections with others. You speak up for others because you can sense that they are upset. You can anticipate the impact a situation may have on a person and take corrective action in advance and avoid making others feel uncomfortable. Thus, empathy requires both cognitive (i.e., perspective taking) and emotional (i.e., warm feelings) skills for accurate understanding and communication of that understanding to the other.

However, being empathetic can be exhausting. Especially if we tune-in easily to others' negative emotions. Negative emotions are draining. Thus, individuals with high empathy need to learn to maintain healthy boundaries to avoid getting overwhelmed with other people's emotions.

Empathy and Well-being

As mentioned earlier in this Unit, empathic individuals are also kinder and more compassionate. All these positive traits require you to go beyond self-orientation and possess an insight into how the other person's experiences influence them. Empathy is increasingly being studied in the context of the workplace. It has been found that employees with empathic managers show lesser somatic complaints (Scott et al., 2010). An empathic individual would not only sense the employees' negative emotions, but also be attuned to positive ones, e.g., an employee's happiness and excitement at having successfully completed a big project would be sensed and shared by an empathic manager.

Self Assessment Questions 5

1. The acts of true kindness are performed with an expectation of a favour being returned. **True / False**
2. In the Buddhist tradition, compassion is called as _____.
3. Name the three personality traits of altruistic people.
4. How is empathy different from sympathy?
5. What is the disadvantage of being empathetic?

4.6 LET US SUM UP

For a long time, Psychology focussed on the negative aspects of human experience. Recognizing the need to study what factors contribute to human flourishing, positive psychologists began exploring personality traits and virtues that contribute to success in interpersonal and intrapersonal domains. This led to the development of the concept of character strengths. These are naturally occurring patterns of thinking, feeling and behaving that help us to maximise performance and achieve our full potential. They constitute innate talents which when refined and developed with the help of knowledge and skills, become our strengths. There are three most popularly used classifications of strengths - the VIA Classification of Character Strengths and Virtues, the CliftonStrengths® and the Search Institute's 40 Developmental Assets. The VIA lists strengths that relate to nearly all domains in our life. CliftonStrengths® pertain to strengths that are especially useful in the work domain. 40 Developmental Assets comprise of internal and external resources that facilitate positive youth development. The strengths of forgiveness, gratitude, kindness and empathy are particularly valuable in the interpersonal domain. They deepen social connections, promote reciprocity, motivate prosocial behaviour and enhance psychological wellbeing.

4.7 KEY WORDS

Strength	: is a natural capacity for behaving, thinking, or feeling in a way that allows for optimal functioning & performance in the pursuit of valued outcome.
Talents	: are naturally occurring patterns of thoughts, feelings and behaviour. They are <i>potential</i> strengths.
Skills	: are specific competencies we develop or acquire because they are needed to do our job well, related better with people or the environment.
Resources	: our systems available in our environment that help us to live well.
Values	: refer to internalized goals and desires that are socially and morally approved.
Virtue	: refers to a quality or characteristic that has positive connotations in a particular society and is considered beneficial to psychological health.
Tonic strengths	: are chronic, trait-like strengths that are observed across a variety of situations.
Phasic strengths	: are strengths that are not observed all the time, instead only in specific situations.
Signature strengths	: refer to those character strengths that are most essential to who we are.
Theme	: are a group of similar talents.
Decisional Forgiveness	: refer to a cognitive and behavioural intention to put aside revenge or avoidance and reconcile with the transgressor.

- Emotional Forgiveness** : involves regulating and replacing of negative emotions associated with the transgression and transgressor with benevolent ones.
- Transpersonal gratitude** : refers to a feeling of thankfulness expressed towards a higher power, God or life.
- Trait gratitude** : is a stable, long term, sustained attitude and daily practice of gratitude.
- State gratitude** : refers to momentary feelings of gratitude that an individual experiences in response to specific situations.

4.8 ANSWERS TO SELF ASSESSMENT QUESTIONS

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 1

1. (a)
2. (b)
3. Strengths are values in action. When our values get translated into behaviour, we are displaying our character strengths.

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 2

1. (a)
2. (c)
3. (c)
4. Signature strengths are character strengths that an individual possesses, recognizes and uses frequently in various aspects of their life.

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 3

1. temperance
2. False
3. True

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 4

1. Transpersonal gratitude refers to thankfulness that one feels and expresses towards a higher power, God or life.
2. State gratitude refers to the momentary feelings of gratitude that an individual experiences in response to specific situations.
3. Gratitude visit refers to writing and delivering a letter to someone who had helped them significantly at some point in their lives.

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 5

1. False
2. Karuna
3. Empathy, moral reasoning, and social responsibility

4. Empathy refers to understanding situations and experiences from another's perspective. Empathy differs from sympathy, e.g., when you feel sad for a person, it is sympathy. When you feel sad with a person, it is empathy.
5. When empathetic individuals do not maintain healthy boundaries to avoid getting overwhelmed with other people's emotions.

4.9 UNIT END QUESTIONS

1. Define strengths? What led psychologists to study character strengths?
2. Describe the relevance of developmental assets.
3. What do you understand by interpersonal strengths? Why are they beneficial?
4. Can interpersonal strengths be cultivated? Give reasons to support your answer.
5. What features help us to recognize our signature strengths?
6. How are the three approaches towards strengths measurement discussed in this section different from each other?
7. Why is forgiveness called a 'social strength'? How forgiveness can be cultivated?
8. Discuss kindness as an interpersonal strength and its implications for the well-being of the individual.

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UNIT 5 CHARACTER STRENGTHS AND VIRTUES: INTRAPERSONAL STRENGTHS AND WELL-BEING*

Structure

- 5.1 Learning Objectives
- 5.2 Introduction
- 5.3 Mindset - Fixed, Growth and Multicultural
 - 5.3.1 Fixed Versus Growth Mindset
 - 5.3.2 Multicultural / Global Mindset
- 5.4 Grit and Determination
- 5.5 Self-Compassion
- 5.6 Self-Forgiveness
- 5.7 Let Us Sum Up
- 5.8 Key Words
- 5.9 Answers to Self Assessment Questions
- 5.10 Unit End Questions
- 5.11 References
- 5.12 Suggested Readings

5.1 LEARNING OBJECTIVES

After studying this Unit, you would be able to:

- *Explain intrapersonal strengths and their importance;*
- *Differentiate between intrapersonal and interpersonal strengths;*
- *Discuss specific intrapersonal strengths such as growth mindset, multicultural mindset, grit and determination, self-compassion, and self-forgiveness; and*
- *Analyze their impact on well-being.*

5.2 INTRODUCTION

In the previous unit we described what character strengths are, and various approaches to study and describe these strengths. We also looked at some specific character strengths that are relevant in the interpersonal domain and their impact on well-being. In this unit we will look at some of the intrapersonal strengths that are particularly relevant for an individual's personal growth and contribute to his/her psychological well-being.

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Intrapersonal strengths are those positive personality traits that help us to be more aware of our internal attitudes and inner processes. These are inner qualities or attitudes that help an individual manage emotions effectively, adjust well to situations and people, pursue and achieve goals, achieve success in life, and become better versions of oneself. They contribute to both hedonic as well as eudaimonic well-being. In other words, they help us not only to feel good (hedonic well-being), but also, to do well (eudaimonic well-being). In this Unit, you will learn about the following intrapersonal strengths:

- Growth mindset and Multicultural mindset
- Grit and Determination
- Self-compassion
- Self-forgiveness

5.3 MINDSET - FIXED, GROWTH AND MULTICULTURAL

5.3.1 Fixed Versus Growth Mindset

‘Mindset’ refers to a set of beliefs that shapes how you make sense of the world, influences the way you think, feel and behave. The Mindset Theory (Dweck & Legget, 1988) suggests that people can have two mindsets or attitudes about intelligence:

- *Entity or Fixed Mindset:* Here one considers intelligence to be fixed, assumes that talents, abilities and understanding are more-or-less fixed or unchangeable. A person with a fixed mindset believes that talents are innate and s/he is born with them – “you are the way you are”.
- *Incremental or Growth Mindset:* Here one considers intelligence to be flexible, and changeable. It is assumed that talents, abilities and understanding can be cultivated, expanded and refined. In other words, the belief that you are a “work in progress”.

Now imagine, as a student, which of the two mindsets would make you more motivated to study for an exam or excel in class? You guessed right! A growth mindset. As an individual, because you believe that you can improve, you are more likely to expend time and effort on learning new things and investing in personal growth. Thus, your mindset influences your motivation, attitude, behaviour and performance. With a growth mindset you are more driven, more committed and put in more effort. All these are important qualities that help a person to succeed.

In fact, a person with a fixed mindset is likely to avoid challenges, give up more easily in the face of failure and feel dejected by negative feedback. In addition, such a person is constantly struggling to ‘prove himself/herself’ at school, at the job or in relationships. Since intelligence, personality and character are traits valued in our society, every situation for a person with a fixed mindset is full of constant self-evaluation - “*Will I be able to do this or not?*”, “*Will I appear intelligent or stupid?*”. On the other hand, a person with a growth mindset welcomes challenges and takes negative feedback constructively. Failure becomes a steppingstone to success as the person learns from it.

A fixed mindset (desire to look smart) Therefore a tendency to: • Avoid challenges • Give up easily • See effort as useless • Ignore useful negative feedback • Feel threatened by the success of others	A growth mindset (desire to learn) Therefore a tendency to: • Embrace challenges • Persist despite setbacks • See effort as a path to mastery • Learn from criticism • Find lessons and inspiration in the success of others
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Common Misconceptions about a Growth Mindset

Carol Dweck (author of *Mindset: The New Psychology of Success*) points out three common misconceptions about a growth mindset:

- a) *Mistaking a growth mindset as a 'positive outlook' that you always have:* A growth mindset is more complicated than just saying 'I am open minded or optimistic'. According to Dweck, everyone possesses, both, a fixed and growth mindset. This combination keeps evolving with experience. An individual could have a fixed mindset in one area of their life and a growth mindset in another. Maybe you believe that you have got no rhythm in your body. So, you avoid any activity or party that involves dancing. You believe people are born with a natural grace and flexibility that you do not have.

On the contrary you feel confident about your language skills, so you look for opportunities that involve writing e.g., writing a project, creative writing or writing blogs. You believe that it is a skill that can be developed with practice. Therefore, you view people's feedback constructively and learn from it. This inspires you to continue improving your language.

- b) *A growth mindset is just about praising and rewarding effort:* While effort is important, one must not lose sight of the outcome. Effort that does not yield results is a waste of time, energy and resources. It should not be rewarded. On the other hand, learning, growth and progress must be acknowledged and praised. This includes rewarding processes that contribute to this progress e.g., reaching out for help when one is stuck, generating alternative strategies to solve a problem, and learning from setbacks to move ahead. For example, telling a student, "*Great effort! You tried your best!*" to make them feel good momentarily even though they did not succeed does not facilitate growth. Appreciating their work but also encouraging them to look for new strategies does. For example, telling a student, "*You're working hard! Now let's look at what you've tried, and what you can try next.*"
- c) *Just espouse a growth mindset, and good things will happen:* Practicing a growth mindset is helpful but not enough for success. It needs to be backed by effort in the right direction. In other words, positive thinking is not enough. It must be complemented with effective action in a meaningful direction (Dweck, 2016).

The capacity of the brain (and mind) to grow is now supported by neurobiological evidence. Years of research in neuroscience has led to the finding that our brain is like a muscle. The more we use a muscle the stronger it becomes. Similarly, the more we use our brain, the more neuronal connections are formed. This leads to our brain literally ‘growing’. Correspondingly, this results in the growth of our mind - new ways of thinking, feeling and behaving.

5.3.3 Multicultural/Global Mindset

With the explosive growth of the internet and the in-roads of the World Wide Web into our daily life, we are now living in a ‘global community’. We are rapidly moving from monocultural to multicultural societies. Individuals with a multicultural mindset adapt to and are open to learning about new cultures. The multicultural mindset is being widely studied in the area of career psychology. Individuals with a multicultural mindset get a boost to their creative and integrative thinking. This is likely to increase their career and job prospects. This mindset allows a person to acknowledge and accept different cultural perspectives, learn about different cultures and use this knowledge.

Mere exposure to diverse cultures is insufficient for personal and professional growth. Maddux et al. (2014) report that even when individuals are exposed to the same multicultural environment, it is their psychological approach and engagement with different cultures that determines the extent to which they are able to integrate diverse ideas, new ways of thinking, conflicting beliefs into their existing set of thought/action repertoires. The successful assimilation of these differences and subsequent broadening of an individual’s cognitive, emotional and behavioural capacities eventually translates into visible advancement in professional opportunities. It requires an active engagement with a new culture so as to develop new ways of thinking and perceiving that will impact one’s values, beliefs and behaviour.

A multicultural mindset is defined as a level of understanding having the following key components:

- a) the availability of a specific knowledge domain, i.e., culturally specific knowledge;
- b) the ability to process information against this knowledge domain;
- c) the ability to monitor one’s thoughts and thought processes, i.e., engage in metacognition; and
- d) the ability to respond in a culturally appropriate manner (Peterson et al. 1996).

The term multicultural mindset largely comes from the organizational literature. As the work and organizational world becomes more and more culturally diverse, career psychologists are looking at interventions that can promote a multicultural mindset in young people. This kind of global mindset needs:

- Drive—interest, curiosity and confidence while interacting in a multicultural environment.
- Knowledge—meaningful understanding of the similarities and differences between cultural groups, without resorting to stereotyping.
- Strategy—awareness and ability to plan effectively keeping these cultural differences in mind.
- Action—being able to adapt when relating and working in multicultural settings.

A multicultural mindset is an asset, especially in the work domain. It helps individuals perform better during international work assignments, equips individuals with effective cross-cultural negotiations skills and benefits sales employees working with culturally diverse customers (Chao, 2018). Like the growth mindset, an individual with a multicultural mindset believes that cultural attributes are changeable, not fixed. They are more open to challenging their own cultural beliefs and attitudes, learn new ones or integrate them into existing ones and act accordingly. As a result, they are less anxious about being in multicultural environments. They are confident that they can create social realities that are in line with their cultural expectations, thereby, reducing awkwardness, embarrassment, or chances of rejection by others. For example, suppose you go to Germany to study or work. You know that language is not a barrier because you can manage well with English. However, if you are an individual with a multicultural mindset, you would show an interest, curiosity, and willingness to learn German. When you do that, you can adapt with ease to the new culture, relate better with the natives, learn more about how Germans think, feel and behave. This helps you to anticipate situations and act accordingly, thereby increasing your chances of success in personal, interpersonal and professional domains.

Self Assessment Questions 1

1. Examples of Fixed Mindset when responding to failure are:
 - a) "I am a failure."
 - b) "There is no point trying."
 - c) Both the above)
 - d) None of the above
2. An individual with a growth mindset is likely to have which of the following responses?
 - i. "Bring on the challenge!"
 - ii. "That is valuable feedback."
 - iii. "I tried my best."
 - iv. "I already know what I need to know."
 - a) i. b) i & ii c) i, ii & iii d) All the above
3. Mere exposure to diverse cultures is sufficient for the development of multicultural mindset. **True/False**

5.4 GRIT AND DETERMINATION

Angela Duckworth, the world's leading expert on 'grit', grew up with her father ever so often telling her, "You are no genius." By Duckworth's own admission, it was true. She was no genius. There were many others who were much smarter and talented than her. However, Duckworth was an ambitious person. She wanted to excel. But as a child who had always been told that she was not smart, she often wondered how, then, would she succeed!? That is what sowed the seeds of this question into her curious mind and she set out to understand the predictors of success. During her stint as a Math teacher, Duckworth made another interesting observation. She found that many of her students who were naturally gifted for Math (could grasp mathematical concepts

quickly) were getting rather poor grades in Math. On the other hand, those who struggled with the subject in class were doing much better than she expected. “Talent for Math was different from excelling in Math”, she concluded (Duckworth, 2016, p.16). In other words, aptitude or talent did not ensure achievement. She noticed that these students who were ‘weak’ in Math made sure that they attended their classes regularly, made notes, asked questions, and sometimes stayed back after class or during lunch breaks to discuss problems. It was their hard work and persistence in the face of failure that was paying off.

What is grit?

Grit can be termed as the Strength of will, that helps us to achieve goals. Grit is a combination of passion and perseverance. It is a personality trait that combines passion, motivation and determination to achieve long term goals (Datu et al., 2017). Passion here does not just mean something you care about. It means something you care about enough to actively prepare for it, work towards a committed goal, and not abandon tasks just because you ‘want a change’ or seek novelty. Thus, passion is not so much about intensity as it is about consistency. According to Duckworth et al. (2007), there are two dimensions that characterize grit: (i) consistency of interest and (ii) perseverance of effort. Grit involves working hard towards long term goals with sustained interest, despite disappointments or failures along the way. Setbacks, challenges and obstacles are inevitable along the path of goal pursuit. Sometimes, the journey may become tedious or tiresome. In either case, we are tempted to give up or change course in the pursuit of a different, novel or seemingly easier goal. But a gritty individual stays on track despite setbacks and boredom.

Grit can be compared to other psychological constructs. Grit resembles conscientiousness in that both are focussed towards completing a task and doing it well. However, while conscientiousness pertains to short-term tasks, grit emphasizes long-term stamina. Grit also differs from the need for achievement. Individuals high on need for achievement are driven by relatively immediate positive reinforcement/success obtained in the pursuit of moderately challenging goals. Gritty individuals on the other hand, deliberately choose and continue to persevere in long-term goals that are not immediately rewarding. Commitment and dedication towards goals that give their life meaning and significance drives them to persevere.

To estimate your level of grit, consider how true the following are for you:

- I enjoy projects that take years to complete.
- I am working towards a very long-term goal.
- What I do each day is connected to my deepest personal values.
- There is at least one subject or activity that I never get bored of thinking about.
- Setbacks don’t discourage me for long.
- I am a hard worker.
- I finish whatever I begin.
- I never stop working to improve.

Source: Angela Duckworth’s Character Lab <https://characterlab.org/playbooks/grit/>

As with other character strengths we've studied so far, grit, too, can be developed. Grit depends on both nature and nurture. In fact, a growth mindset is a precursor to cultivating grit. As we studied earlier, people with a growth mindset possess a desire to learn. They learn from their mistakes, take criticism constructively and persist in the face of setbacks. Because they believe that their abilities are dynamic, rather than fixed, they are willing to work towards improvement and see that as a goal in itself. Gritty individuals are also resilient which is our ability to bounce back from stress.

Following are the **psychological characteristics of gritty individuals**:

- a) *Interest* - "Follow your passion" is a frequent phrase we hear successful people say. But many people struggle to identify *what* their passion is. And the realization that "I don't have a passion" can be rather disappointing. However, the reality is that one can foster a passion. This starts with identifying one's interests. Indeed, research shows that people experience more job satisfaction and are generally happier in life when performing jobs that fit their interests. Their work performance too is better when they do what they are interested in. Duckworth (2016) states that passion for one's work is a three-stage process of discovery, development, and deepening. Discovering what one is interested in entails exploration - trying out different things to see what we feel most inclined towards. As we continue engaging in an activity we are drawn towards, interest deepens. This engagement is facilitated by the support of individuals and the environment. For example, as a child you are exposed to many sports - cricket, football, basketball, swimming, etc. Initially you seem to like (or not) all of them equally. Now, for the annual sports day, spots quickly fill up for all other sporting teams. The only place left is the swimming team. You join it. As the sports day approaches, you spend more time learning and practicing different strokes. Gradually your interest deepens, and you decide to pursue it more seriously.
- b) *Capacity to practice* - Recall the Math students at the beginning of this section. Even though they were not very good at the subject, they were committed to improvement with continuous practice. Interest is not sufficient. You need to spend time on it, work at it, build on it. Gritty individuals are driven to challenge themselves and strive to become better at the task they are doing. In other words, they do not become complacent.
- c) *Purpose* - The intention to contribute to the well-being of others is another source of passion for those with grit. They do not pursue their interests merely because they 'like them'. They pursue their interests because they believe that these contribute to the larger society in some way. They find a deeper meaning in what they do. This sustains motivation despite hurdles and obstacles.
- d) *Hope* - Gritty people expect that their efforts will contribute to improving their future. And this is where the growth mindset comes into play. Instead of getting bogged down by failure, you believe that you can learn from them, do things differently the next time and arrive at an outcome that is in your favour. A growth mindset leads to optimistic self-talk. Example, "That was hard. Don't feel bad if you can't do it *yet*"; "That didn't work. Let's see what you did and what you can do differently." Remember, being optimistic does not mean disregarding the negative. It means that you acknowledge the positive just as much and are confident that things can change for the better.

Benefits of Possessing Grit and Determination

Grit has been related in research to a number of positive outcomes (see Datu, 2021 for a review):

- Academic achievement - Grit has been related to academic achievement in middle-school, high-school, secondary school and undergraduate students in countries across the world. It has also been related to learning engagement, college satisfaction, and leadership skills among military cadets.
- Career outcomes - Gritty individuals are less likely to change jobs frequently. Grit has been associated with higher teacher retention and teaching effectiveness among teachers in the United States, and higher work performance in Chinese Insurance employees. Individuals with grit are also less likely to drop out of demanding career training programmes like medical residency or military training.
- Work-related functioning - Grit is associated with lower levels of work burnout, and engagement in counterproductive work behaviours (e.g., laziness, fraud, workplace bullying, absenteeism, etc.). It is associated with greater work engagement and positive leadership behaviours.
- Well-being and positive psychological outcomes - Grit is associated with higher levels of life satisfaction and psychological well-being in diverse samples belonging to different countries and age groups. It is also associated with better self-esteem, optimism and mental health, prosocial behaviour and good habits. Grit is also associated with lower levels of anxiety, depression and suicidal ideation, lower perceived stress, and lower levels of substance use. Students with higher grit are also less likely to engage in unhealthy internet use, compulsive buying and gambling behaviours.

Self Assessment Questions 2

1. Grit and conscientiousness are the same things. **True/False**
2. Passion can be cultivated. **True/False**
3. A person with a natural talent for music will be a better musician than one who is not as talented. **True/False**

5.5 SELF-COMPASSION

Riya was very nervous. She was about to make her final project presentation today. She had been preparing for it - collecting, organizing and studying the data - for the past two months. She hoped that she would make a good impression on the reviewers as her promotion depended on it. After answering a series of questions correctly, one of the panel members asked her a question that she was not quite sure how to answer. She fumbled a little, attempted to answer, but eventually apologised to the panellist and was dejected. There was no further questions and she came out of the room mad at herself. "You are such an idiot! You were so well prepared and yet you messed it up.. You are good for nothing. There's no chance you'll get that promotion now..." , Riya thought. She obviously spent the rest of the day feeling sad, angry, and frustrated.

If Riya was your friend, what would you say to her? Perhaps you would tell her that she was being too harsh on herself. That she did her best. That those were some tough questions she managed to answer so well. And that it is okay to not have *all* the answers. How do you think Riya would feel now? Perhaps calmer, more relaxed? She would probably also feel more reassured about her abilities and less frustrated about not answering the last question. Now, imagine if Riya could do for *herself* what you, as a friend, did for her - be kind, gentle and more forgiving. That is called self-compassion.

You have already learnt about compassion in the previous unit. Self-compassion is compassion directed inward. It involves being sensitive to our own distress and a desire to reduce that distress. According to Kristin Neff (2003), **self-compassion consists of three components:**

1. *Self-kindness*: We are said to be our worst critics. We tend to be harsher towards ourselves than we would ever be towards others. Self-compassion involves being gentle and benevolent towards ourselves when we falter, are distressed, or feeling incompetent and inadequate. Rather than resisting, denying, or beating ourselves up for our shortcomings, we look at them with a kindness that allows us to take constructive action. *We can't always get what we want. We can't always be who we want to be. And that's okay.* In other words, being patient with our flaws.
2. *Common Humanity*: In times of distress, we often ask ourselves, "*Why me?*" By doing so, we are indirectly telling ourselves that bad things only happen to *me*, and everyone else's life is perfect. This is a distorted view of reality created by tunnel vision. The truth is that trials and tribulations are part and parcel of being human. By understanding that life challenges and personal failure are universal, we feel less isolated and alone in our pain.
3. *Mindfulness*: Mindfulness means being aware of things *as they are*, not more, not less. Thus, neither do we avoid our pain (by resisting or denying it, e.g., "*I wish I wasn't so hurt!*"), nor do we over-identify with it (by ruminating, e.g., "*Why am I always so upset?*"). We observe our thoughts and feelings as they are, without judgment (e.g., "*I feel hurt/upset*").

Importance of Self-Compassion

- *Evolutionary importance*: Nurturance and care is an innate human need. In fact, it is imperative for survival. The physical and emotional nourishment that we receive early in life is vital for our survival and growth. Similar care and compassion are needed for our psychological growth as human beings. But we need not *only* rely on others to provide this care. We can and must be able to fulfil this need for ourselves as well.
- *Mental health and well-being*: Greater self-compassion is linked to less anxiety and depression. Self-compassion is associated with greater wisdom and emotional intelligence (Neff, Rude, & Kirkpatrick, 2007). In other words, people who are self-compassionate have better emotional coping skills. They are less likely to ruminate on or suppress negative emotions, are in touch with their feelings and regulate emotions more effectively. Self-compassionate people tend to experience more happiness, optimism, curiosity, and positive affect than those who lack self-compassion (Neff, Rude, & Kirkpatrick, 2007).

Self-compassionate individuals are also likely to take more initiative and procrastinate less (Williams, Stark, & Foster, 2008). Self-compassion is also seen to have physical health benefits. People high on self-compassion were more likely to get back to their diet routine as they refrained from gorging on unhealthy food to deal with the guilt of having broken their diet in the first place (Adams & Leary, 2007). Considering their challenges while trying to quit smoking with compassion, reduced their smoking to a greater extent than reflecting upon and monitoring their smoking (Kelly et al., 2010). Self-compassion also positively affects interpersonal relationships. It promotes emotional connectedness, acceptance, freedom and independence in relationships while reducing verbal or physical aggression.

- *Balancing our emotions:* Self-compassion helps to sooth ourselves. It balances between our *threat and drive systems*. Human beings are hardwired to look for threat/danger in their environment so that we can protect ourselves. However, human life and living conditions have evolved tremendously. We are no longer looking to protect ourselves from the physical danger of being attacked by a wild animal. Instead, we are looking to protect our psychological and social selves from failure, embarrassment, risk to our health, happiness, relationships, etc. Thus, anything that is negative/weak/wrong catches our attention quickly. However, constant focus on these negatives naturally produces prolonged anxiety, fear, distress and other unpleasant emotions. Overactivity of the threat system is unhealthy. The drive system energises us to move forward and progress in life. It impels us to set goals, achieve them and progress in life. But constant overactivation of the drive system is also unhealthy. It can make us overly competitive, with a compulsion to achieve, such that encountering failure/obstacles makes us extremely frustrated. The latter, then activates our threat system. As a result, we will end up swaying from one extreme to another. Self-compassion activates our *soothe system*. This helps to calm the threat and drive systems when they are active leading to a more balanced emotional state.

What Self-Compassion is Not

1. *Self-pity:* When individuals feel self-pity they tend to get absorbed by their own misery. They brood over their suffering and think they are the only ones going through it. This, as we read earlier, is in contradiction to self-compassion. People who are self-compassionate, in fact, view suffering as universal. They accept pain as an inevitable part of being human that is experienced by everyone. Thus, it reduces the tendency to exaggerate personal distress, prevents us from feeling isolated, and makes us more open to accepting our pain with kindness.
2. *Self-indulgence:* We often feel that being easy on ourselves will make us lazy, careless, and indifferent. We somehow have the notion that self-criticism is a more effective motivator than giving ourselves nurturing, support, and encouragement. Nothing could be farther from the truth. Constant criticism makes us feel worthless and depressed. It might push us to do better only so that we can avoid these negative feelings. But this motivation will be difficult to sustain, and we will lose steam quickly. Self-compassion, on the contrary, motivates us to do well because we care. We feel safe to acknowledge our

weaknesses and to work on them. Thus, we work on them because we want to be a better version of ourselves. This motivating force is long-lasting.

3. *Self-esteem*: Self-esteem is based on a person standing out from a group, on how unique and different he/she is from others around him. We need to see ourselves as being above average or better than others to have high self-esteem, e.g., *I am more competent than my colleague* or *I am more fortunate than my neighbour*. In case of low self-esteem - *I am not as smart as my classmates* or *her life is easier than mine*. In other words, self-esteem is based on comparison. This, again, contrasts with what we know about self-compassion. Self-compassion celebrates the similarity, rather than separateness, of human experiences. It emphasizes the interconnectedness of human beings, e.g., *Struggle is inevitable, everyone goes through it* or *It's human to feel pain*.

Self-Compassion Practices

- Writing a letter to yourself from the perspective of an unconditionally loving imaginary friend.
- Maintaining a self-compassion journal.
- Using supportive touch – activate the parasympathetic nervous system by using supportive touch to help you feel calm, cared for and safe.
- Changing your critical self-talk – paying attention to your critical self-talk and altering it with kinder, gentler words.
- Loving-kindness meditation – involves taking out time to express generous, selfless love towards oneself (e.g., “*May I be well*”, “*May I be healthy*”) and others (e.g., “*May you be at peace*”, “*May you be safe*”).

Self-compassion in Practice – Write a Self-compassionate Letter

- Describe a problem that tends to make you feel bad about yourself, such as a physical flaw, a relationship problem, or failure at work or college. Note what emotions come up—shame, anger, sadness, fear—as you write.
- Next, think of an imaginary friend who is unconditionally accepting and compassionate; someone who knows all your strengths and weaknesses, understands your life history, your current circumstances, and understands the limits of human nature.
- Finally, write a letter to yourself from that perspective. What would your friend say about your perceived problem? What words would he or she use to convey deep compassion? How would your friend remind you that you're only human? If your friend were to make any suggestions, how would they reflect unconditional understanding?
- When you're done writing, put the letter down for a while and come back to it later. Then read the letter again, letting the words sink in, allowing yourself to be soothed and comforted.

Source: *The Science of Compassion*, Neff (2012).

Self Assessment Questions 3

1. Name the three components of self-compassion.
2. Self-compassion is different from self-pity because:
 - a) Self-pity makes us ruminate over our struggles.
 - b) Self-pity makes us ask “*why me?*” when we are in pain.
 - c) Self-compassion helps us see the universality of pain.
 - d) All the above
3. Self-esteem highlights our individuality while self-compassion highlights our same-ness with other human beings. **True/False**

5.6 SELF-FORGIVENESS

In the previous unit, you learnt about the benefits of forgiving others. But what about forgiving ourselves? Is that important, you ask? Think about this... Have you ever felt regret at something that you did or did not do? Maybe you said something insensitive to a friend. Perhaps you did something that deeply hurt your parents. How did you feel afterwards? Guilty? Ashamed? Maybe you kept thinking about it over and over again. You probably wished you could undo what you had done. Perhaps you felt so ashamed that you couldn't look the other person in the eye. Maybe you started avoiding your friend, or even worse, fought with him! Do you see now, the damage that such emotions can do to you and your relationships? Hence, the importance of self-forgiveness.

It is not easy, of course. We have been socialized into feeling guilty when we do something wrong. Our parents scolded us when we broke a friend's toy as a child. That 'bad' feeling could motivate desirable behaviour, like apologizing to the friend and/or replacing their toy; thus, driving us towards corrective action. However, intense guilt and shame can be very detrimental to our well-being. They can give rise to self-resentment, self-hatred, self-punishing and self-destructive behaviour.

Self-forgiveness can be defined as “a willingness to abandon self-resentment in the face of one's own acknowledged objective wrong, while fostering compassion, generosity, and love toward oneself” (Enright, 1996, p. 115). Thus, self-forgiveness is understood as having three components:

1. *Experiencing and letting go of negative emotions directed at oneself:* Prolonged anger, shame, remorse, and other negative emotions associated with an offense, can become toxic. Therefore, one needs to release them. But not before you have experienced them. As that would be suppression, ignorance or denial of the emotions and the offense you are responsible for. Thus, you do not excuse yourself of wrongdoing. In fact, you accept responsibility for it. And move on in a constructive way.
2. *Fostering positive emotions directed towards oneself:* You not only abandon self-directed negative emotions but also cultivate positive emotions like compassion, benevolence, and love. Davis et al. (2015) define self-forgiveness as “an emotion-focused coping strategy that involves reducing negative and increasing positive thoughts, emotions, motivations and behaviours regarding oneself” (pp. 329–330).

3. *Accepting responsibility*: Self-forgiveness does not mean absolving ourselves of the blame. On the contrary, it means accepting responsibility for the transgression and showing a willingness to work through it. If we interpret our behaviour as only mildly inexcusable, justifiable, as not being solely our fault or as being harmless, genuine self-forgiveness cannot happen (Woodyatt et al., 2017).

Self-Forgiveness versus Interpersonal Forgiveness

Self-forgiveness and interpersonal forgiveness are similar in some ways, but there are important differences between the two (see Table 5.1). Usually, behavioural transgressions are involved in case of interpersonal forgiveness. However, objective wrongdoings in self-forgiveness could include behaviours, thoughts, desires, or feelings. Interpersonal forgiveness involves forgiveness for the harm done to the victim. In case of intrapersonal forgiveness, one could forgive either harm done to the victim or to oneself (e.g., *I forgive myself for hurting my parents* or *I forgive myself for cheating on the exam*). While being empathetic helps us to humanize the offender and thus facilitates interpersonal forgiving, empathy towards oneself when one has transgressed is likely to lead to justification of the wrong act rather than true self-forgiveness. Interpersonal forgiveness does not imply reconciliation with the offender whereas reconciliation with the self is necessary in self-forgiveness. One cannot remain alienated from the self for long. Moreover, it is possible to avoid the thoughts, feelings and situations related to the interpersonal transgression if one is able to avoid the offender. This is not possible when one harms oneself or someone else, as the offender must continue to face himself/herself and his/her actions. It is, thus, impossible to escape the situation by avoiding the transgressor. This is another reason why self-forgiveness is highly relevant as in the absence of it one can get sucked into the abyss of self-condemnation.

Table 5.1: Self-Forgiveness versus Interpersonal Forgiveness

Similarities		
- Both processes unfold over time - Both require an objective wrong which makes the offender ineligible for forgiveness but is still forgiven - Both are not equal to excusing or forgetting the wrongdoing - Both require conscious effort and do not occur automatically		
Differences		
	<i>Intrapersonal or Self-Forgiveness</i>	<i>Interpersonal Forgiveness</i>
<i>Type of wrongdoing</i>	Behaviours, thoughts, desires, feelings	Behaviours
<i>Focus of forgiveness</i>	Harm to self or to another	Harm to victim
<i>Empathy</i>	Inhibits forgiveness	Facilitates forgiveness
<i>Reconciliation with victim</i>	Required	Not required

<i>Focus of avoidance</i>	Transgression–related stimuli (e.g., victim, situations, thoughts, etc.)	Offender
<i>Vengeful feelings towards</i>	Offender (i.e., self)	Offender (i.e., other)
<i>Benevolent feelings</i>	Offender (i.e., self)	Offender (i.e., other)
<i>Consequences of unforgiveness</i>	Extreme	Moderate

Source: Adapted from Hall and Fincham (2005)

Why is Self-forgiveness Difficult to Practice?

Accepting responsibility for a transgression conflicts with two basic human needs:

1. Need to maintain moral-social identity - this is related to our need for belonging, seeing ourselves as good and moral people.
2. Need to maintain our sense of agency - to think of ourselves as being in control of our actions.

However, when we commit wrongdoing both these needs come into conflict with each other. For example, suppose you have cheated on your partner. To protect your moral-social identity you may see the betrayal as not representing your true self - *It was a onetime thing, I love my partner*. But in this case, you may become doubtful about your sense of agency - *then who or what made me do it?* On the other hand, you may try to protect your sense of agency and accept your choices - *I just wanted to be adventurous!* But this raises questions about your morality - *How could I do it? Am I a good person?* Given the nature of these dilemmas, one may employ maladaptive strategies to avoid one conflict or the other. These may include becoming overly defensive or severely self-punitive. Thus, successful self-forgiveness requires working through the process of establishing one's sense of both moral-social identity and agency. This requires investment of time and energy and is a psychologically effortful process.

Taking responsibility is difficult,

- As it is likely to increase unpleasant emotions like shame, guilt, and regret. Thus, we try to avoid the emotions by shirking responsibility for the wrongdoing and blaming it on an external entity (person or situation).
- Because doing so also means admitting that our actions went against acceptable group norms and threatens our inherent need to belong.
- Because the possibility of social rejection, hostility and stigma from the victim or the community at large can exacerbate feelings of shame. This makes a person more inclined towards avoiding, rather than accepting, responsibility.

Determinants of Self-Forgiveness

Hall and Fincham (2005) describe various factors that determine/influence one's experience of self-forgiveness. Some promote intrapersonal forgiveness, while others make it more difficult. These are listed below:

A. Emotional

1. Guilt - guilt makes the offender feel bad for the victim and motivates appeasing behaviours like apologizing, making amends or seeking forgiveness. When one does so, it is easier to forgive oneself. But guilt also fosters empathic concern in the offender towards the victim. This empathy can, at times, interfere with the process of self-forgiveness. In other words, if you feel *very* bad for the person you have wronged, you will feel increasingly guilty, and it will be more difficult for you to forgive yourself. Thus, the relationship between guilt and self-forgiveness is complex and is mediated by conciliatory behaviours and empathy felt by the offender towards the victim.
2. Shame - While guilt arises from negative evaluation of one's actions and encourages us to make amends for the wrong done, shame arises from the negative evaluation of the *self*. Such negative evaluation is more destructive for the self and is likely to result in unhealthy self-punishment. Alternatively, feeling shame may lead to an avoidance of the thoughts, feelings or situation associated with the wrongdoing. Such avoidance, we now know, is in direct opposition to accepting responsibility for the transgression, which is the very first step towards self-forgiveness. Thus, the negative relationship of shame with self-forgiveness is stronger as compared to guilt.

B. Social-cognitive

Attributions - External, unstable, and specific attributions for one's own behaviour may facilitate self-forgiveness, while internal, stable, and global attributions may make self-forgiveness more difficult. For example, thinking that you cheated on your partner because *lately he/she has been behaving distantly* will make it easier for you to forgive yourself than thinking that you cheated on him/her because you *are a terrible human being*.

C. Offense-related

1. Conciliatory behaviour - these are actions performed by the offender in order to appease the victim, amend the wrongdoing or seek forgiveness for it, e.g., apologising, compensating, compromising, etc. Performing such actions is more likely for the victim to forgive us thereby reducing our guilt and facilitating self-forgiveness.
2. Perceived forgiveness from victim or Higher power - whether you are forgiven by the victim for your transgression or not, if you *perceive* that you have been forgiven, it is easier to practice self-forgiveness. On the contrary, if the victim forgives you but you do not feel convinced about his forgiveness, you will still struggle to forgive yourself. Thus, perception of forgiveness by the victim plays an important role in determining how easy or difficult it will be for you to forgive yourself. In a similar manner, if you seek forgiveness from God or a Higher Power and believe that He has forgiven you, self-forgiveness is easier.
3. Severity of the offense - the more severe the offense, the more difficult it is for the victim to forgive us and for us to forgive ourselves. Despite the

severity of the offense and its negative outcomes, the offender may realise that there are some positive consequences. For example, one may feel that the experience has taught them a lesson and helped them grow as a person. Or that their relationship with the victim is stronger. Realization of such positive aftereffects fosters more positive emotions and makes it easier to forgive oneself.

The Process of Self-Forgiveness

Self-forgiveness involves a reaffirmation of values. When we hurt someone or commit an offense, we have gone against a value that we hold. For example, maybe our value is to uphold integrity in our actions, but we cheated in an exam. Our action went against our value. Self-forgiveness would involve learning from the experience, restating/reviving our values and committing to act in accordance with them in the future. In this way, we show our commitment towards shared values, thus, protecting our social-moral identity. At the same time, we preserve our sense of agency since we take charge of our actions in the future.

Self Assessment Questions 4

1. Self-forgiveness involves which one of the following steps:
 - a) Accepting responsibility for the wrongdoing, suppressing guilt, justifying your actions.
 - b) Accepting responsibility, working through the guilt, recommitting yourself to your core-values.
 - c) Accepting responsibility for the wrongdoing, punishing yourself for being a terrible person, apologising for your mistake.
 - d) None of the above
2. If I feel highly empathetic towards the person I have offended, it will be easier for me to forgive her. **True/False**
3. Taking responsibility for our wrongdoings is difficult because:
 - a) It conflicts with our need to belong
 - b) We are justified in our actions
 - c) Both the above
 - d) None of the above

5.7 LET US SUM UP

Intrapersonal strengths comprise of those positive personality traits that help us to grow as individuals and contribute to our personal and professional success. Traits like the growth mindset and multicultural mindset are particularly useful in helping us learn, acquire new skills, and adapting better to our environment. These mindsets make us more flexible and open to experiences, thereby enriching our lives and contributing to our well-being. The personality trait of grit allows us to pursue long term goals with enthusiasm and diligence. It keeps us on track despite challenges and failures. It is

known to reliably predict academic achievement, stability in one's career and better work performance. Gritty individuals are also more resilient, cope with stress more effectively and hence, are less prone to psychological ill-health. In addition to these, the capacity for self-compassion and self-forgiveness are valuable positive personal attributes that foster psychological well-being. They allow us to take a balanced perspective towards ourselves, accept our flaws and shortcomings, while displaying a commitment to rise above them. They encourage us to be gentle with ourselves yet firm in our resolve to become a better version of us.

5.8 KEY WORDS

Growth mindset	: the belief that talents, abilities and understanding are dynamic, they can be cultivated, expanded and refined.
Multicultural mindset	: a set of beliefs and attitudes that allows a person to acknowledge and accept different cultural perspectives, learn about different cultures, assimilate and use this knowledge while living/working in multicultural environments.
Grit	: a personality trait that combines passion, motivation and determination to achieve long term goals.
Self-compassion	: an attitude of generosity and benevolence towards ourselves when we falter, are distressed, or feeling incompetent and inadequate.
Common humanity	: realization of the truth that suffering and personal failings are part of the shared human experience – something that we all go through.
Self-forgiveness	: the capacity to go beyond self-resentment/punishment in the face of one's own acknowledged objective wrong, while being compassionate, generous, and loving toward oneself.
Moral-social identity	: seeing ourselves as good and moral people who behave in accordance with social norms.
Agency	: the ability to have control over our actions and their consequences.
Conciliatory behaviours	: behaviours that communicate a willingness to reconcile, end a disagreement with someone or resolve a conflict, e.g., apologizing, listening actively, compromising, offering a compensation, etc.

5.9 ANSWERS TO SELF ASSESSMENT QUESTIONS

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 1

1. (c); 2. (b); 3. False

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 2

1. False; 2. True; 3. False

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 3

1. self-kindness, common humanity and mindfulness
2. (d)
3. True

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 4

1. (b); 2. False; 3. (a)

5.10 UNIT END QUESTIONS

1. Differentiate between fixed and growth mindset.
2. How can one cultivate grit?
3. Elaborate upon some of the common misconceptions about self-compassion.
4. Explain the various determinants of forgiveness.
5. Why is possessing a multicultural mindset of relevance today?

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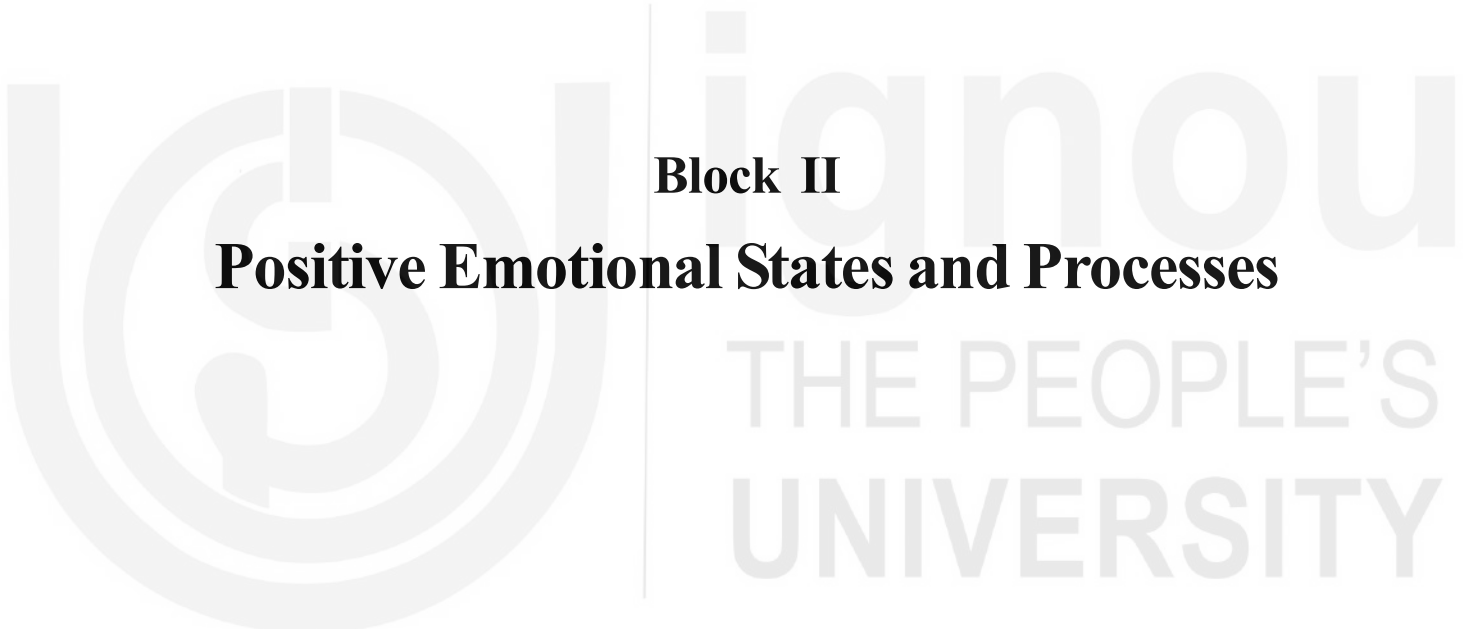
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5.12 SUGGESTED READINGS AND WEB RESOURCES

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The background of the page features a large, light gray watermark of the Open University logo. The logo consists of a stylized 'U' and 'O' on the left, and the text 'Open University' and 'THE PEOPLE'S UNIVERSITY' on the right, separated by a vertical line.

Block II

Positive Emotional States and Processes

UNIT 6 POSITIVE AFFECT AND POSITIVE EMOTIONS*

Structure

- 6.1 Learning Objectives
- 6.2 Introduction
- 6.3 Key Terms
- 6.4 Theory of Positive Emotions
- 6.5 Positive Emotions and Well-being
- 6.6 Managing Emotions Effectively
 - 6.6.1 Adaptive Potential of Emotion-Focused Coping
 - 6.6.2 Enhancing one's Emotional Intelligence
 - 6.6.3 Socioemotional Selectivity Theory
 - 6.6.4 Emotional Storytelling
- 6.7 Developing Emotional Skills
- 6.8 Let Us Sum Up
- 6.9 Key Words
- 6.10 Answers to Self Assessment Questions
- 6.11 Unit End Questions
- 6.12 References and Suggested Readings

6.1 LEARNING OBJECTIVES

After studying this Unit, you would be able to:

- *Explain the term emotion and related terms of affect and mood;*
- *Discuss the broaden-and-build theory of positive emotions;*
- *Describe the role of positive emotions in human well-being; and*
- *Develop emotional skills and manage emotions effectively.*

6.2 INTRODUCTION

After a long day's hard work, Simran just sat down in the evening with a cup of coffee in her hand while listening to her favourite music. While she was taking the sips, her close friend rang up; and she had a good time talking to her.

You have been studying hard for your final exam for the last one month. Today is your final paper and after the exam got over, you went to the mall along with a few of your friends just to relax and enjoy.

The above examples show how positive emotions make us feel good. We look forward to such experiences after we have gone through some hard work or difficulties or challenges so that we offset the negative feelings/ stress/ feeling of exhaustion with a

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positive feeling and enjoyment. But are the positive emotions important only for this – to help reduce our stress? Or positive emotions have their intrinsic value - they are important on their own; and need to be consciously developed for promoting the well-being of the individual? Research indicates the goodness of positive emotions for all the time, and not just when we are distressed (Salovey, Rothman, Detweiler, & Steward, 2000). Since positive psychology aims to move beyond the disease model of health and human functioning, and focuses on studying optimal human functioning and well-being, positive emotions like joy, love, contentment, cheerfulness, happiness can contribute to our subjective well-being.

In this Unit, you will learn about the meaning of positive emotions, how they are important and why they need to be intentionally engaged in to enhance our health and well-being.

6.3 KEY TERMS

Let us first understand certain key terms related to positive emotions. Historically, we have much emphasized the negative emotions for their survival value and evolutionary significance. Such negative emotions as fear and anger can help us in situations of danger to protect us by adopting a flight or fight stance. However, with the emergence of the field of positive psychology, research has started to emphasize on the significance of positive emotions also. **Emotion** refers to a specific feeling and is always associated with an object (Cohn & Fredrickson, 2009). According to Plutchik (2001), emotion includes feelings, psychological changes, impulses to action and specific goal-directed behavior. Thus it is characterized by three elements: a certain physical arousal, a certain behavior that reveals the feeling to the outside world, and an inner awareness of the feeling (Ciccarelli & White, 2018).

We are usually aware of a few predominant emotions commonly perceived such as anger, joy, fear, sad, happy, greed etc. However, there are a variety of emotions and combination of emotions also which make our life complex unless we develop a proper understanding of them. Plutchik (2003) has represented all these emotions in a wheel of emotions (see Fig. 6.1 below). There are *primary emotions* such as fear, anger, sadness, surprise, disgust, joy, anticipation and trust; and *secondary emotions* arising out of the combination of emotions in terms of types and intensity.

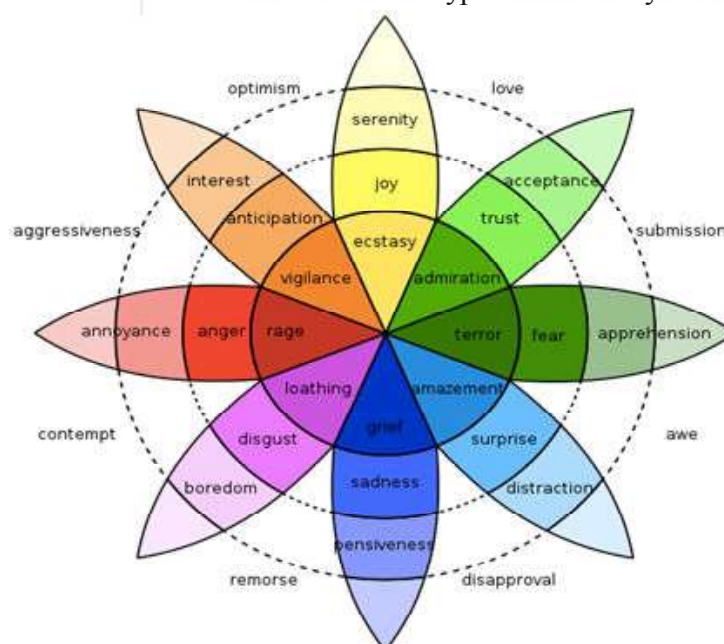


Fig 6.1: Plutchik's Emotion Wheel
(Source: Wikicommons)

Emotion is often confused with mood. However, **mood** is broader than emotion; refers to a general feeling, not associated with any specific object/event. It is described as free floating and lasts for a longer time, e.g., Riya is in a good mood these days because of her job promotion. Thus mood refers to our general emotional state whereas emotions are specific temporary emotional states that are related to specific objects/situations/events. In the span of an entire day, we may experience many related specific emotions such as joy, happiness, love, contentment etc., but our mood may be one type only, that of a pleasant mood.

Another related word is **Affect**, which is mostly meant to be emotion; however these two are different. Affect refers to the immediate, physiological response of an individual to a stimulus and is typically based on an underlying sense of arousal (Snyder, Lopez, & Pedrotti, 2011). This autonomic arousal gives rise to **valence** of the affect, that is, appraising the stimulus/event as pleasurable or painful.

Thus emotions can have physiological as well as psychological effects. It is characterized by physiological response and psychological appraisal resulting in positive affect or negative affect. Positive affect includes such emotions as joy, happiness, contentment, cheerfulness; whereas negative affect involves emotions such as fear, anger, guilt, sadness, disgust etc. The effect of such positive emotions and negative emotions have been indicated by various research studies (e.g., Barrett, 2006; Watson, 2002) which highlight the underlying physiological mechanisms and psychological implications of such emotions. Thus when we are under stress, sad, angry, or we are cheerful, enjoy, and have fun, it affects our bodily functions differently.

The pioneer in the field of research on positive emotions is Dr. Alice Isen who has pointed out many benefits of when we engage in positive emotions (e.g., Isen, 1987; Ashby, Isen, & Turken, 1999): (a) helping others, (b) being flexible in thinking, (c) making better decision, and (d) generating more solutions to problems. Thus positive emotions result in various cognitive and social benefits to the individual.

Self Assessment Questions 1

1. What are secondary emotions?
2. Who has given the wheel of emotions?
3. Differentiate between mood and emotion.
4. What is valence?
5. Who is the pioneer in the field of research on positive emotions?

6.4 THEORY OF POSITIVE EMOTIONS

Barbara Fredrickson has proposed the **Broaden-and-Build Theory of Positive Emotions** to explain the mechanism through which positive emotions have a positive impact. The main points in her theory can be discussed below.

- **Positive emotions elicit more cognitive responses**

When we show negative emotions, it leads to physical reactions involving action tendencies which are specific and limited, e.g., tendency to flight or fight in case of fear or anger. This has significance from an evolutionary perspective where survival is the

primary focus. Thus when a snake suddenly crosses your path as you are taking a walk in a park, the emotions generated narrow down your thoughts and actions to deal with the perceived danger. On the other hand, positive emotions lead to *momentary thought-action repertoires*. That is, it leads to more cognitive responses rather than more physical reactions as in case of negative emotions. As a result a variety of possible behavioural options are generated in contrast to the limited behavioural options as seen in negative emotions. Further, the effect of negative emotions is short-term, as it helps in addressing the imminent threat; however, the effects of positive emotions are long-term as it creates enduring resources that promote overall well-being.

- **Broadening effect of positive emotions**

As we saw above, positive emotions are associated with momentary thought-action repertoires. This helps broaden the individual's repertoire of possible immediate/future actions they will take. Since we are in a cognitive flexible mode after experiencing a positive emotion, we become more open to creative and diverse thinking and engaging in different actions. For instance, your friend throws a mini party in the college canteen as she won a first prize in some coveted arts and painting competition. As she announced this in the canteen, what emotions did you feel and how it made you jovial, light, and energetic afterwards – a pervasive feeling of good mood. On the other hand, when you were eating food with your friend in the college canteen, your friend received a phone call that her father has met with an accident and she has to rush to the hospital immediately. What were your emotions and the resultant behavioral responses/tendencies in the latter case? You were sad and did not feel like doing anything. Thus positive emotions broaden our responses, ideas and actions. Negative emotions limit our thoughts, focusing on the negative emotion only, and leading to a tunnel vision. You might have experienced that when you are angry, you do not listen to others, you close down the options. Later on when you are calm, you realize the possibilities you could have exercised.

- **Positive emotions help build resources**

Broadening effect of positive emotions can lead to building of resources for enhancing the individual's well-being. Positive emotions, of course makes one feel good. But Fredrickson argued that positive emotions can go beyond this simple outcome and play a crucial role in building physical, psychological and social resources that help optimal functioning and well-being. For instance, joy or love will broaden our thoughts, make us less rigid, and more playful. This in turn will lead us to reach out to others, connect with friends, partners more, do things for them, show care and affection towards them. Thus relationship with friend/partner gets strengthened which is a valuable resource. This in turn again leads to experiencing positive emotions of joy and feeling loved. Thus positive emotions lead to a spiraling effect known as the ***upward spiral of positive emotions*** (Cohn & Fredrickson, 2009). We will discuss more about building resources in the subsequent section.

- *Mother did not scold her teenage daughter for being finicky about eating.*
- *Daughter went happily to study afterwards.*
- *Later in the evening, she shared her concerns about her study with her mother. (broadening of thoughts/activities)*
- *This sharing brought the two closer, and made the mother-daughter bond a little stronger. (building of resources of care and support, attachment)*

- *This led to experiencing positive emotions by both. (positive emotions>broadening>building resources>positive emotions)*
- *This enhanced their sense of fulfillment, optimal functioning and promoted their mental health and well-being.*

- **Positive emotions can undo the negative emotions**

According to Fredrickson, positive emotions have the ability to offset or negate the impact of negative emotions (Fredrickson, Mancuso, Branigan, & Tugade, 2000). Both positive emotions and negative emotions cannot go together, e.g., when we are joyful, we cannot be sad or when we are fearful, we cannot be relaxed. Thus engaging in activities that induce positive emotions can lead to offset of physiological responses induced by negative emotions such as increased cardiovascular consequences (Fredrickson, 2001). This has implications for consciously engaging in positive emotions to counter the effects of negative emotions. Fredrickson and Losada (2005) even have researched the ratio of positive to negative emotions that can undo the impact of negative emotions. Known as the *critical positivity ratio*, it was found across varied populations and life domains. They reported a mean ratio of 2.9 of positive to negative emotions, to offset the negative experiences and lead to well-being. That is, the frequency of positive emotions needs to be roughly three times or more than the negative emotions to experience optimal well-being or flourishing state of health. For instance you will need to experience at least nine positive emotions to undo the effect of three negative emotions in a given time period. They have even proposed an upper limit of 11.6 ratio for the positivity to work. However, later on this ratio, popularly known as Losada ratio, was discredited and withdrawn as based on flawed mathematical analyses (Brown, Sokal, & Friedman, 2014).

Although the Losada ratio is not valid now, still it raises certain points which have relevance. That is, experiencing positive emotions is important as it has beneficial impact on our optimal well-being. The more positive emotions, the better it is. However, beyond a point, more positivity does not add to our well-being. Rather, it may harm us. This highlights that negative emotions do play an important role in making us more resilient and building our psychological resources. The underlying point here is that there needs to be a balance between positive and negative emotions that can contribute to our well-being, and this ratio between the two may vary in individuals depending on their unique personality traits and environmental factors.

Thus Fredrickson's broaden and build theory states that positive emotions can broaden our thought and action possibilities, build our resources, and undo the negative emotions. It emphasizes the value of positive emotions beyond the mere sensory or hedonic pleasures and highlights the resource-building capacity of positive emotions contributing to our well-being.

6.5 POSITIVE EMOTIONS AND WELL-BEING

Positive emotions as explained by the Broaden-and-build theory above have a positive impact on our physical as well as psychological well-being. They help us to flourish and achieve optimal well-being by building up various resources. These resources include physical, psychological and social resources which are enduring in nature, that is, they last for long and help improve the individual's well-being. Studies have pointed

out that positive emotions are associated with positive changes in our body and mind, whereas negative emotions are associated with negative or unhealthy physiological functioning, e.g., reduced physical immunity (Isen, 2002; Ryff & Singer, 2002; and Ray, 2004).

The influence of positive emotions on our well-being is mainly through physical, psychological and social resources.

Physical resources involve increased immunity and healthy physiological functioning on various parameters such as cardiovascular activity, blood pressure, digestion etc. The field of psychoneuroimmunology highlights the mind-body relationship in how both mind and body interact and influence each other in a dynamic way. For instance, when we are physically not healthy and suffering from any disease, we may feel negative emotions of anger, resentment, worry, frustration etc. Similarly, when we are in good physical health condition, it leads to various positive emotions such as contentment, interest, happy etc. There is perceived physical pain reduction, less illness symptoms and better health. Positive emotions increase the physical resources (including our immune system, brain, nervous system, endocrine system etc.), which in turn ensures our healthy functioning and mental well-being.

Psychological resources include effective coping strategies and adaptive responses of the individual to the stresses and challenges of life. Positive emotions lead to resilience and improved coping by offsetting the effects of negative emotions created by stressful situations (Baumgardner & Crothers, 2015). There is a positive outlook/attitude as the person is able to engage in a wide variety of possibilities. With regard to coping, there can be two types of coping such as ‘problem-focused coping’ and ‘emotion-focused coping’. Problem-focused coping addresses the source of the problem itself by modifying or removing aspects of problem, e.g., asking for support in solving a problem, changing one’s schedule to avoid the problem of traffic jam etc. Emotion-focused coping deals with the emotions associated with the stress. It tries to reduce the negative emotions by avoiding the situation, or engaging in some other distracting activities such as listening to music, playing musical instrument etc. This type of coping focuses on dealing with the emotions generated in the individual due to the stressful situation.

Positive emotions are also related with ‘proactive coping’ where the person takes a preventive approach by proactively dealing with the situation so that it does not lead to stress, e.g., doing regular health check up or studying regularly throughout the semester rather than just before the exam or doing regular exercise rather than when you develop health issues and the doctor advises you to go for regular walking. Research studies (e.g., Lazarus, 2000; Vaillant, 2000) have pointed out the beneficial role of positive emotions as a psychological resource to prevent stress and deal with stressful situations. It helps in using effective coping strategies and creating valuable resources of hope, optimism and resilience.

Social resources refer to the social support from others around, especially, family, friends and significant others, and the community which conveys a sense of togetherness to the individual. This sense of ‘others are there with me’ creates a good feeling and confidence in the concerned individual. It also builds up resources in the form of strengthening our relationships which has been found to contribute most significantly to our well-being (Ryff & Singer, 2000; Reis & Gable, 2003; Cohen, Underwood & Gottlieb, 2000).

As Baumgardner and Crothers (2015, p. 49) state, “the irony of relationships is that they contribute most to our enduring happiness and joy, but also to our distress and misery”. It is the interpersonal relationship problems and conflicts related to our family, friends and co-workers that to a large extent negatively impact our happiness, life satisfaction and flourishing in life. Thus relationships are a very important social resource that can strengthen or weaken our overall health and well-being. Positive emotions help build up and strengthen this precious resource, which helps us cope with stress and challenges. According to the “buffering hypothesis” (Berscheid & Reis, 1998), social support and relationships provide a ‘buffer’ or reduce/protect us from the negative impact of stressful experiences. Positive emotions contribute to good interpersonal relationships which in turn create more positive emotions and a sense of care and belongingness, having positive impact on our health.

So build up your mental health muscle by focusing on developing these resources in your life through creating opportunities for experiencing positive emotions. All the aspects of our life gain significantly from positive emotions. It leads to happiness and subjective well-being, achieve success, promote our health and attain flourishing – an optimal state of human functioning (Isen, 2003; Keyes, 2002). It does not require elaborate planning and events to experience positive emotions. Ordinary daily activities and small things such as helping an elderly cross the road, putting a fresh flower in the vase, cooking a new dish on weekend, playing with children, etc. can bring one joy, cheer, hope and meaning in life. In a study by Folkman and Moskowitz (2000), the caregivers of people with AIDS reported that small get togethers or receiving a small complement for their work created good feelings in them.

Self Assessment Questions 2

1. Negative emotions lead to momentary thought-action repertoires. True/ False.
2. Explain the broadening effect of positive emotions.
3. Experiencing positive emotions can undo the effect of negative emotions. True/ False.
4. Problem-focused coping does not deal with the emotions associated with the stress. True/ False.
5. Social support acts as a buffer to reduce the negative impact of stressful experiences. True/ False.

6.6 MANAGING EMOTIONS EFFECTIVELY

Given the contribution of positive emotions for our health and well-being, it becomes imperative that we know how to manage our emotions effectively. This will help us deal with the negative emotions and create opportunities for positive emotions. The general perception about emotions is marked by a negative approach towards it, that is, emotions hinder our rational thinking, interpersonal relationships and work performance. However, emotions are full of energy and we need to learn how to use this energy in adaptive ways.

6.6.1 Adaptive Potential of Emotion-focused Coping

You have learned about emotion-focused coping in earlier section. Here we will discuss more about its adaptive potential and impact on health. When we are faced with a

stressful situation, it generates negative emotions. Unless we learn how to manage these emotions, it can lead to maladaptive coping. Emotion-focused coping makes use of the emotions to cope effectively with the stressful situation. Stanton has emphasized that coping through emotional approach carries adaptive potential (Stanton, Parsa, & Austenfeld, 2002, p.150). It indicates using the emotions rather than avoiding the emotions or moving away from it. This approach towards emotions and avoidance of emotions can be explained respectively by two systems such as Behavioural activation system (BAS) and Behavioural inhibition system (BIS) (Depue, 1996).

There are two components in approach oriented emotion-focused coping such as (a) emotional processing, i.e., trying to understand emotions, and (b) emotional expression, i.e., expressing or displaying one's emotions (Stanton, Kirk, Cameron, & Danoff-Burg (2000). These aspects help one to employ emotions for adapting effectively to stressful situations, resulting in better psychological outcomes. The assumption here is that by knowing and understanding one's emotions under stress, one would be in a better position to respond effectively. Thus an emotion-focused coping would result in adaptive behavior.

6.6.2 Enhancing one's Emotional Intelligence

Emotions are an integral part of our life. They influence our each and every thought and action. Hence rather than denying and avoiding the emotions, we need to harness the potential of emotions for better decision-making, problem-solving, improved relationships and enhanced performance. This requires that we use the emotions intelligently so that they can be used for our betterment. Emotional intelligence is a term pioneered by Daniel Goleman in his most popular book "Emotional Intelligence: Why It Can Matter More Than IQ?" published in 1995. It advocates combining emotions with intelligence or thinking that can lead to adaptive outcomes. If our behavior is governed only by emotions or only by thinking, it will not lead to productive outcomes. A judicious combination of the two will help us to achieve success and happiness in our life.

Emotional intelligence can be defined as perceiving and using emotions effectively for positive outcomes. It includes knowing about one's own emotions and others' emotions in emotion-laden situations. Further, it involves being able to handle emotions in oneself and others. Thus emotional intelligence consists of both cognitive abilities and emotional skills that together lead to better learning and achievement, better coping and adjustment, and enhanced well-being.

Peter Salovey and John Mayer have initially proposed the four-branch ability model of emotional intelligence comprising of *Perceiving emotions*, *Using emotions*, *Understanding emotions*, and *Managing emotions* (Salovey & Mayer, 1990). They advocated that skills in these four aspects help one to navigate emotional situations successfully. For instance, you are talking to your friend about the upcoming exam. If you have the competency of perceiving her emotions, observing her body language, you would be able to notice that your friend seems to be afraid of the nearing exam. You will then use this information about emotions to determine your interaction with her. This also helps one to make decisions and guide one's behavior. This further leads to understanding of various emotions in oneself and the other person, how various emotions interact, and influence behavior. The contextual and environmental factors are also taken into account. Given the poor socio-economic status of the friend, she wants to complete her studies successfully on time. Hence this might be adding to her stress of

upcoming exam. Finally, this will lead you to handle her emotions by adopting effective strategies for interaction and guiding her. Managing emotions involve various emotion regulation strategies.

Thus emotions provide important data or input for effective interaction, problem solving and facilitating well-being. According to Goleman (1998), “Emotional intelligence (EI) is the capacity for recognizing our own feelings and those of others, for motivating ourselves, and for managing emotions well in ourselves and in our relationships”. It focuses on knowing about one’s own emotions and learning to regulate them, and being aware about emotions in others and handling them effectively. Goleman’s model of emotional intelligence proposes five main components in EI such as self-awareness, self-regulation, motivation, empathy, and social skills. One needs to develop awareness about one’s own emotions, identify these and be able to regulate the emotions. Motivation includes having a future goal-oriented attitude that helps in exercising self-control. Thus self-awareness, self-regulation, and motivation together refer to developing personal competencies in managing emotions. Empathy and social skills are social competencies which includes perspective-taking and learning to form effective interpersonal relationships.

Emotional intelligence has great implications in various aspects of our life. Reuven Bar-On (2002) highlights the adaptive functioning of EI by stating that it as “an array of non-cognitive abilities, competencies and skills that influence one’s ability to succeed in coping with environmental demands and pressures”. Thus emotional intelligence has been found to impact our happiness and well-being as well as our relationships with others. Whatever we do or whosoever we interact with, the effectiveness of it ultimately boils down to the emotional content in these and how we recognize and manage these emotions. The emotional climate within ourselves and in our relationships with our friends, family, co-workers can help us thrive or hinder us in our progress. Emotions can motivate us to persevere and show resiliency in the face of adverse situations.

6.6.3 Socioemotional Selectivity Theory

How do you feel when you are happy or experience joy? And how do you feel when you are sad or angry or frustrated? Even though we know the difference between the two kind of scenarios when we experience positive or negative emotions, do we consciously make an effort to select positive emotions and experiences? Does age influence the way we look at positive and negative emotions?

The theory of socioemotional selectivity by Laura Carstensen takes a developmental perspective to perceiving and experiencing emotions. It states that older persons tend to select or focus more on positive emotions as compared to the younger people (Carstensen & Charles, 1998). As people grow older, they become aware of the shorter span of life ahead and tend to value more the emotional richness of life such as forming good relationships, enjoying things in life, savoring, finding meaning, appreciating things and so on. Thus there is selectivity as they focus less on negative emotions and more on positive emotions. Positive experiences and positive emotions become our priority as we age and consider our mortality (Snyder, Lopez, & Pedrotti, 2011). This has adaptive significance and enhances one’s mental health and well-being.

6.6.4 Emotional Storytelling

Have you ever felt the need to express when you have undergone a very stressful situation or trauma in your life? How did you feel before you expressed and after you

expressed your emotions, anxieties, insecurities, distress to another person? Narrating your story, especially related to adverse or traumatic experiences has a cathartic effect on the person. It provides an opportunity to express and process the negative emotions, which ultimately results in coping and other health benefits. Studies have found that the narratives can predict health outcomes (Ramirez-Esparza & Pennebaker, 2006). Research on the benefits of Emotional storytelling was pioneered by Jamie Pennebaker in 1989 where she reported numerous health benefits for the emotional storytelling group who expressed their emotional suffering through writing as compared to the control group.

Emotional storytelling either through written or oral disclosure of negative emotions experienced helps the individual to express and release the emotion-related stress. Instead of inhibiting, it allows a safe space to explore, express and let go of the emotionally-charged thoughts and feelings. It helps people to organize their thoughts, engage in cognitive processing of the experience, find meaning in their traumas, and reintegrate their social networks (Niederhoffer & Pennebaker, 2002, p.581).

Since emotions are influenced by the cultural contexts, it is important to take this into account in the process of emotional storytelling. For instance, collectivistic cultures like India value family harmony more and avoid emotional confrontations within the family, whereas individualistic culture of western countries prefer a more direct and aggressive stance. Hence the experience and expression of emotions depend on the social cultural context (Markus & Kitayama, 1991).

Self Assessment Questions 3

1. What is the pioneering book by Daniel Goleman?
2. Who have proposed the four-branch ability model of emotional intelligence?
3. What are the five components of emotional intelligence as proposed by Goleman?
4. What is the focus of the theory of socioemotional selectivity?
5. Explain emotional storytelling.

6.7 DEVELOPING EMOTIONAL SKILLS

An important part of managing emotions effectively is to develop emotional skills. We will now discuss the following three points related to developing emotional skills.

Cultivating Positive Emotions: focuses on developing and experiencing positive emotions frequently. Positive emotions can be described as important *detoxifiers*. They help us overcome stressful feelings and remove the negative energies from within ourselves. However, at the same time, positive emotions can also be described as *nourishers* or *enhancers*; they enhance our life and promote good mental health. Positive emotions can be promoted through various positive psychology constructs such as flow, savoring, optimistic thinking, mindfulness and so on.

The Collaborative for Academic, Social and Emotional Learning (CASEL): is an evidence-based programme which focuses on enhancement of social and emotional learning (SEL) among the school children. It follows an integral approach to school

education where the academic, social and emotional aspects are equally taken care of for the optimal learning and development of children. Studies point out a significant relationship between SEL and children's success in school and life (Zins & Elias, 2006). In a meta-analysis of 213 school-based universal interventions for enhancing students' social and emotional learning (SEL), Durlak, Weissberg, Dymnicki, Taylor, & Schellinger (2011) reported improved social and emotional skills, attitude, behavior, and academic performance of students from kindergarten up to high school.

Emotions do have a role in our academic learning as well as personal life and relationships. Given the increasingly complex world in which our children need to learn and live, socioemotional competencies are the key factor to achieve success and well-being. In addition to achieving academically, they also need to perform equally well in various other aspects of life. The socio emotional learning can foster an all round development of children. The goals of SEL interventions include fostering of five competencies such as self-awareness, self-management, social awareness, relationship skills, and responsible decision making (Collaborative for Academic, Social, and Emotional Learning, 2005).

The RULER technique: is an evidence-based approach to social emotional learning developed by Marc Brackett, the founding director of the Yale Center for Emotional Intelligence. It consists of five key emotion skills of *Recognizing, Understanding, Labeling, Expressing, and Regulating emotions*. Studies have found that the RULER technique helps increase personal wellbeing, effective teaching and leadership, academic achievement, and classroom emotional climate change (Rivers & Brackett, 2010; Brackett, Rivers, Reyes & Salovey, 2012).

Marc has done research on how emotions play crucial role in our learning, creativity, relationship quality, work performance, organizational climate, various life outcomes, and our overall well-being. You can refer to his book on "*Permission to Feel: Unlocking the Power of Emotions to Help Our Kids, Ourselves, and Our Society Thrive*" (2019). He talks about the **Mood Meter** that can be used to ask ourselves a few questions related to our feelings.

Mood Meter

Check out how easy or difficult it is for you to answer the simple questions below:

- *Pause for a while before you are going to say or do anything important.*
- *Ask yourself these questions –*
 - ❖ *What exactly am I feeling?*
 - ❖ *Is it pleasant or unpleasant?*
 - ❖ *How energetic do I feel at the moment?*
 - ❖ *What is the best word to describe my feeling at the moment?*

Marc's mood meter is based on the **Circumplex model of affect** (Posner, Russell, & Peterson, 2005), which measures emotions on the basis of the *affect and arousal dimension* – affect ranging from pleasantness to unpleasantness and arousal/activation ranging from low to high, indicating the level of your energy. Thus the mood meter creates four quadrants based on the intersection of pleasantness and energy. He uses

colour codes to represent the four quadrants(refer to Fig. 6.2 below). Applying this mood meter to the various components of emotions can help us develop a scientific and clear understanding of ourselves in terms of the emotions we are experiencing. This will help us to self-regulate and interact effectively with others.



Fig. 6.2: Circumplex Model of Affect

Are Positive Emotions Always Better?

Positive emotions definitely contribute a lot to our subjective happiness, life satisfaction, better immunity, success in life, and optimal health and well-being. However, we need to exercise a little caution here about over-emphasizing the role of positive emotions.

Positive emotions cannot always help. For instance, in case of a very traumatic event of the death of spouse, war, terminal illness or a disaster, no amount of inducing positive emotions will take the stressful experience or trauma away. The person needs to experience the negative emotions and process it. However, positive emotions can help in a relative term, by providing various levels of support and resources to the individual to deal with the trauma situation/event. Given that the other things are equal, people who experience and cultivate positive emotions may have an edge in terms of the strength of their physical, psychological and social resources for coping with illness and stress, compared to people with less frequent positive emotional experiences (Baumgardner & Crothers, 2015). Thus as the proverb goes, ‘something is better than nothing’ – it is better to have positive emotions than not having them at all or having negative emotions. As research studies indicate, we do better with positive emotions.

Hence it is important to keep a tab on our positive emotions and consciously take steps to create opportunities and occasions for experiencing and expressing positive emotions. Life’s pleasures lie in small things. We need to notice these and value these to bring them more often into our lives to enhance our well-being.

6.8 LET US SUM UP

In the present Unit, you learned about the importance of positive emotions in promoting our well-being. The related terms of affect, and mood were also explained. The broaden-

and-build theory of positive emotions was discussed in terms of the mechanism through which it leads to a flourishing state of mind. Positive emotions impact positively our mental health and well-being. Hence it is important to cultivate positive emotions in our life. Further, it is also important to learn to manage our emotions through emotion-focused coping, emotional storytelling, and socioemotional selectivity so that we can harness the energy of emotions in a proper way and learn to deal with the negative emotions effectively.

6.9 KEY WORDS

Emotion	: includes feelings, psychological changes, impulses to action and specific goal- directed behavior.
Affect	: refers to the immediate, physiological response of an individual to a stimulus and is typically based on an underlying sense of arousal.
Emotion-focused coping	: makes use of the emotions to cope effectively with the stressful situation.
Proactive coping	: involves taking a preventive approach by proactively dealing with the situation so that it does not lead to stress.
Buffering hypothesis	: states that social support and relationships provide a ‘buffer’ or reduce/ protect us from the negative impact of stressful experiences.
Emotional intelligence	: consists of both cognitive abilities and emotional skills that together lead to better learning and achievement, better coping and adjustment, and enhanced well-being.
Circumplex model of affect	: measures emotions on the basis of the <i>affect and arousal dimension</i> – affect ranging from pleasantness to unpleasantness and arousal/activation ranging from low to high, indicating the level of your energy.

6.10 ANSWERS TO SELF ASSESSMENT QUESTIONS

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 1

1. Secondary emotions are combination of emotions in terms of types and intensity.
2. Plutchik
3. Mood refers to our general emotional state whereas emotions are specific temporary emotional states that are related to specific objects/situations/events.
4. Valence refers to appraising the stimulus/event as pleasurable or painful.
5. Dr. Alice Isen

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 2

1. False

2. Broadening effect of positive emotions refers to being in a cognitive flexible mode after experiencing a positive emotion, where we become more open to creative and diverse thinking and engage in different actions.
3. True
4. True
5. True

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 3

1. Emotional Intelligence: Why It Can Matter More Than IQ?
2. Peter Salovey and John Mayer
3. self-awareness, self-regulation, motivation, empathy, and social skills
4. It states that older persons tend to select or focus more on positive emotions as compared to the younger people.
5. Emotional storytelling involves narrating your story, especially related to adverse or traumatic experiences, that provides an opportunity to express and process the negative emotions.

6.11 UNIT END QUESTIONS

1. Discuss the broaden-and-build theory of positive emotions by Barbara Fredrickson.
2. Explain upward spiral of positive emotions with suitable example.
3. Compare and contrast between problem-focused coping and emotion-focused coping.
4. Explain the importance of emotional intelligence in managing emotions effectively.
5. Analyze the benefits of emotional storytelling and highlight the role of culture in this.

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UNIT 7 HAPPINESS*

Structure

- 7.1 Learning Objectives
- 7.2 Introduction
- 7.3 Concept of Happiness
- 7.4 Models of Happiness
- 7.5 Indian Perspectives on Happiness
- 7.6 Factors affecting Happiness
- 7.7 Enhancing Happiness and Well-being
- 7.8 Let Us Sum Up
- 7.9 Key Words
- 7.10 Answers to Self Assessment Questions
- 7.11 Unit End Questions
- 7.12 References and Suggested Readings

7.1 LEARNING OBJECTIVES

After studying this Unit, you would be able to:

- *Discuss the concept of happiness;*
- *Explain the various models of happiness;*
- *Describe the Indian conception of happiness;*
- *Describe the factors affecting happiness; and*
- *Know the various ways for enhancing happiness and well-being.*

7.2 INTRODUCTION

If you are asked, “What do you want in life?”, what would be your reply? Write down your answers in order of their priority. It may be that you want to be successful, earn lots of money, you want to own a big house in a posh locality, own a big car, go for vacation abroad, or just enjoy life, be happy, or pursue your passion of music, go trekking, work for the cause of disability and so on. The ultimate goal in all these is that you want to derive satisfaction, feel good, and seek meaning and purpose in your life. When you say you want to be successful, or own a big car, or pursue music, or work for the orphaned children, ultimately you want to be happy in whatever you want to do. Finding meaning in our life also gives us happiness.

Happiness is a multidimensional construct where we can aim for simple pleasures and enjoyment, as well as pursuing our hobbies and passions, and also devoting ourselves to various social causes, and contributing meaningfully to the society.

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Activity 1: What is Happiness?

Talk to people across developmental stages, such as a school child, an adolescent, a young adult, an adult in middle age and an elder about “What do they want in life” and “What makes them happy”. Analyze their responses and check for any variations in their life goals and conception of happiness. Further, analyze how the demographic factors such as their gender, socioeconomic condition, education, and disability if any, affects their responses.

7.3 CONCEPT OF HAPPINESS

You might have found from Activity 1 that many people want a happy and satisfying life. They want a life majorly dominated by the experience of positive emotions. Such a life Seligman calls as ‘**Pleasant life**’, which is characterized by deriving pleasures in life (signifies fulfilling various needs of the individual). However, one can also go beyond this and achieve a more stable happiness when one focuses on realizing one’s strengths and potentials, e.g., pursuing music, or excelling in a sport, engaging in one’s interest in gardening or swimming etc. This gives you a ‘**Good life**’ where you make use of your strengths and skills to feel capable and confident. This makes you feel good and happy about yourself.

Finally, when you go beyond this and use your unique strengths to contribute to others, devote yourself for a greater cause, it provides you a ‘**Meaningful life**’. Here you look beyond the pleasures and the feel good factor about yourself, and look for a larger meaning and purpose in life. Thus Martin Seligman has talked about three types of life to indicate the various dimensions of happiness (refer to Fig. 7.1 below).

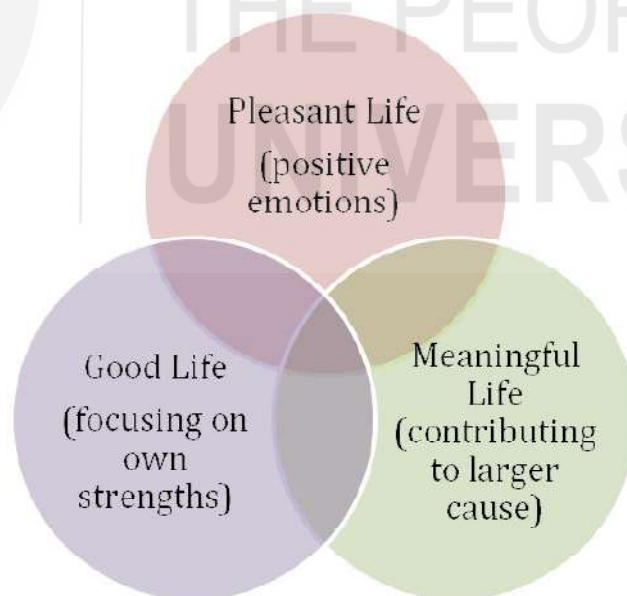


Fig. 7.1: Three Types of Life by Martin Seligman

Authentic and sustainable happiness can be achieved only with a meaningful life as it provides a deeper sense of fulfillment and achieves a flourishing state of well-being. However, it does not mean that we do not pursue the other two types of life. Rather, Seligman advocates an integrative approach where one pursues the pleasures in life, works towards using one’s strengths, and aims at going beyond oneself - being altruistic, and working for greater cause. This helps in conceptualizing happiness comprehensively.

Let's Apply

Sit down with a pen and paper at the end of the day. Draw three columns with headings Pleasant life, Good life, and Meaningful life. Think of what all you did today and list them under appropriate heading. Do this for a week. At the end, check the trend for each day and the overall trend. What is the proportion of activities related to pleasant life, good life and meaningful life on each day and overall? Were the pleasant activities more as compared to meaningful activities? Is there a change in this trend towards the end of the week?

Hedonic and Eudaimonic Perspective

The pleasant life of Seligman refers to the hedonic aspect of happiness. In this sense, happiness is described as satisfaction of needs, fulfillment of which provides pleasure to the individual. **Hedonic happiness** focuses on personal happiness involving pleasure, joy and satisfaction, for instance, you enjoyed a good meal at the restaurant, you had fun with your friends in the party, or you felt so satisfied with your life basking in the sun in the sea beach. This is the common sense of happiness where the good life involves enjoyment and satisfaction. In the scientific research,

Research in Psychology focuses on the concept of **Subjective Well-being (SWB)** as a synonym for happiness (Diener, 1984, 2000). SWB refers to the subjective evaluation of one's life, i.e., how does one perceive and evaluate/judge one's life. Subjective well-being is defined as consisting of three components: (a) life satisfaction, (b) presence of positive affect, and (c) a relative absence of negative affect (Baumgardner & Crothers, 2015, p.17). Thus there is a preponderance of positive emotion experiences than negative emotions in one's life. It involves a cognitive component of evaluation in terms of life satisfaction and an affective component marked by prevalence of positive emotions rather than negative emotions (Di Fabio, & Palazzeschi, 2015). SWB can include Seligman's pleasant life as well as good life.

Eudaimonic happiness, on the other hand, refers to a deeper sense of meaning in life. No one will probably want to be always on the pleasure mode, being happy and cheerful; one will then miss the variety of emotions that enriches our life, and develops appreciation for life. Aristotle's eudaimonic view of happiness states that the good life involves living according to one's "*diamon*", or 'true self'. Thus it states that happiness comes from realizing one's potentials and striving towards self-actualization. Maslow's hierarchy of needs talks about self-actualization as one of the highest needs which gives meaning to one's life (Maslow, 1968). When one lives life as per one's talents and values, it leads to an authentic life, being true to oneself. This makes one's life meaningful and provides authentic happiness.

Thus eudaimonic happiness involves utilization of individual's strengths, abilities, talents, values and skills. Hence it is also called the **Psychological Well-being (PWB)**. Hence psychology research focuses more on well-being instead of happiness, because happiness centres on a limited view of pleasures and life satisfaction. But a broader concept of well-being adds meaning to our pleasure life and good life to make it more comprehensive, and leads towards flourishing (refer to Table 7.1 below). In addition to minimizing negative experiences and maximizing positive experiences in life, well-being also consists of achieving full human potential and to live life fully with meaning and authenticity and purposefulness (Waterman et al., 2010).

Hedonic and eudaimonic conceptions of happiness may seem to be in opposition and hedonic pleasure may seem to lack in merit. However, research suggests that positive affect can contribute to meaning in life by helping the individual to think in terms of a larger context (King et. al. 2006). Experiencing positive emotions may make one feel happy and engage in different meaningful activities; similarly meaningful engagement and purpose in life will make one experience various positive emotions including being happy. Both hedonic and eudaimonic happiness contributes to one's well-being.

Table 7.1: Hedonic and Eudaimonic Happiness

Hedonic (Subjective Well-being)	Eudaimonic (Psychological well-being)
Presence of positive mood	Sense of control or autonomy
Absence of negative mood	Feeling of meaning and purpose
Satisfaction with various domains of life, eg., work, leisure	Personal expressiveness
Global life satisfaction	Feelings of belongingness
	Social contribution
	Competence
	Personal growth
	Self-acceptance

Source: <https://www.counsellingconnection.com/index.php/2010/08/30/happiness-and-positive-psychology/>

Self Assessment Questions 1

1. What is a pleasant life?
2. What are the three components in subjective well-being?
3. Explain the eudaimonic view of happiness.
4. Who has proposed the three types of life?

7.4 MODELS OF HAPPINESS

• Carol Ryff's Six-Factor Model of Psychological Well-Being

According to Carol Ryff, subjective well-being (SWB) focuses on positive emotions and life satisfaction, but it does not highlight the aspect of positive functioning. She states that well-being and happiness needs to include human strengths, growth, and striving towards goals (Ryff, 1989). Thus it should also include psychological and social functioning such as autonomy, resilience, purpose, and mental health. Ryff has proposed the Six-factor model of Psychological Well-being. These six factors of self-acceptance, personal growth, positive relations with others, environmental mastery, autonomy, and purpose in life together contribute to happiness in one's life.

• Corey Keyes' Dual Continuum Model of Mental Health

Taking the concept of psychological well-being, Keyes has extended its application to our mental health and proposed a comprehensive model of mental health (Keyes,

2003, Keyes & Lopez, 2002). According to Keyes, complete mental health includes *emotional well-being*, *psychological well-being*, and *social well-being*. Each consists of various components as given in Fig. 7.2 below.

Emotional Well-being	Psychological Well-being	Social Well-being
• Presence of positive affect • Absence of negative affect • Life satisfaction • Happiness	• Self-acceptance • Autonomy • Environmental mastery • Positive relations with others • Personal growth • Purpose in life	• Social acceptance • Coherence • Integration • Contribution • Actualization

Fig. 7.2: Components in the Three Types of Well-being by Keyes

According to the dual continuum model by Keyes, mental health is represented by two dimensions which gives rise to four categories as given in Fig. 7.3 below.

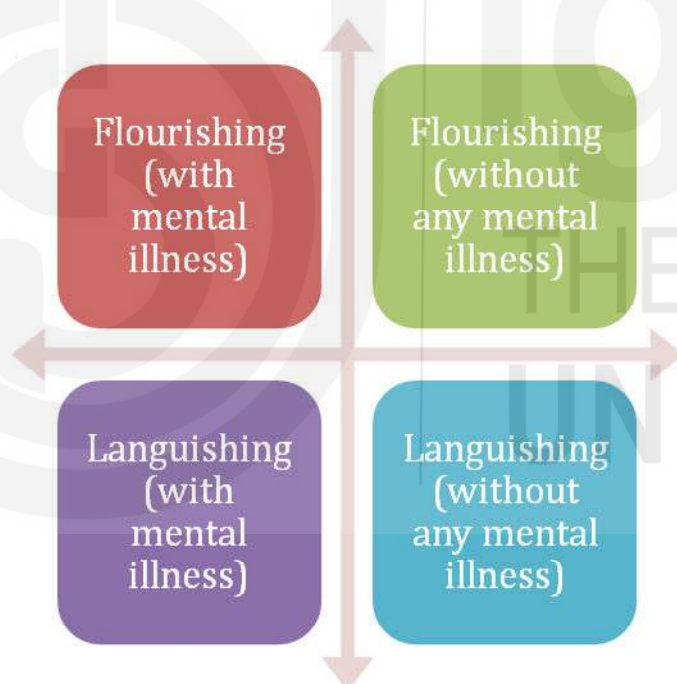


Fig. 7.3: Keyes' Dual Continuum Model

The horizontal dimension ranges from presence of mental illness on the left to absence of mental illness on the right side. The vertical dimension ranges from poor mental health at the bottom to good mental health towards the top of the axis. Intersection of these two dimensions/continuum results in four categories:

- Flourishing - Good mental health and no mental illness is there.
- Flourishing - Good mental health despite having mental illness.
- Languishing - Poor mental health and mental illness is there.
- Languishing - Poor mental health despite having no mental illness.

Keyes' model draws our attention to the fact that the presence of mental health and well-being in the individual does not necessarily mean there is no mental illness in them, that is, we can be happy, achieve things, and lead a meaningful life even if we are suffering from any illness. Similarly, absence of any mental illness in the individual does not necessarily mean that there is happiness and good mental health in them, that is, even if we are not suffering from any illness, we may not be happy and leading a meaningful life.

- **PERMA Model of Seligman**

Developing on the hedonic-eudaimonic aspects of happiness, Seligman(2012) added further dimensions and proposed the PERMA model of happiness which is more comprehensive. The acronym stands for Positive emotions, Engagement, Positive relationships, Meaning and Accomplishment, which can be considered as the five major components contributing our well-being.

- *Positive emotion* refers to those activities and experiences that give rise to positive emotions in us such as joy, happiness, pride, contentment, love, compassion and gratitude. They provide a good feeling, a sense of satisfaction, help us in savoring good things in life, and improve well-being.
- *Engagement* refers to being involved in an activity to such an extent that it creates a sense of “flow” in the individual, e.g., you lose track of time when you are engrossed in reading your favourite author’s novel or playing guitar which you enjoy so much. It involves utilization of our values, strengths, and talents. For instance, you are completely focused while trying to solve a puzzle or playing Sudoku. The challenge needs to be of such optimum level that meets your strengths and skills, but is neither too hard nor too easy for you.
- *Relationships* refer to inculcating positive relationships characterized by positive emotions, love, acceptance etc. that contributes to our social well-being. Relationships occupy a major part of our life, which involves our relationship with our family, partners, friends, colleagues, supervisors etc. Hence they play a major role in enhancing our well-being.
- *Meaning* consists of finding a purpose in our life which gives us an opportunity to use our “signature strengths” to contribute for causes beyond ourselves. It generates a sense of worth in our life. This makes our life meaningful and enhances our well-being. For instance, you can contribute greatly through your profession, creative pursuits, social causes, and/or religious/spiritual activities. All these help in self-actualization and achieving meaning in one’s life.
- *Accomplishment* includes our various achievements, which increase our positive emotions, self esteem, sense of competence, mastery etc., all of which contribute to our good mental health. However, our accomplishments can lead to well-being when these are guided by internal motivation, i.e., achieving for the sake of it rather than for any external reward or recognition.

According to Seligman, each of the five components of the PERMA model is characterized by three properties: (a) they contribute to well-being of the individual, (b) many people pursue them for its own sake, and (c) they are defined and measured independently of each other (Seligman, 2012, p. 16).

• Self-Determination Theory of Ryan and Deci

Ryan and Deci (2001) have proposed the Self-determination theory (SDT), which is a general theory of human motivation. It advocates that human motivation, and consequently, their well-being depends on the fulfillment of three basic psychological needs such as (a) *Autonomy*: people can exercise their free will and choice in doing things as per their values, beliefs and talents, (b) *Competence*: people feel confident and a sense of mastery upon achieving the desired goals and outcomes, and (c) *Relatedness*: people have positive connections or relationships with others around which provides a sense of love and support, contributing to well-being. Fulfillment of these needs makes people self-determined and motivates them to grow, change and pursue their goals. The SDT theory has a eudaimonic perspective to human happiness and flourishing.

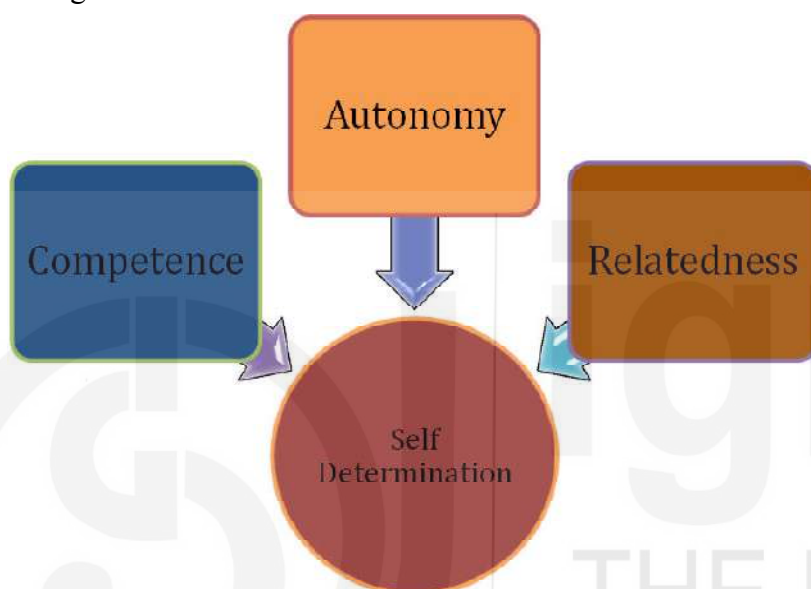


Fig. 7.4: Self-determination Theory of Ryan and Deci (2001)

The Self-determination theory has implications in various aspects of our life. For instance, in child-rearing practices, opportunities can be provided to children where they can take their own decisions, make own choices, and use their strengths to achieve things. This will help build self-confidence and further motivation in them to pursue goals. Similarly, when employees in the workplace are enabled to exercise their autonomy and competence, they can be more productive and contribute meaningfully towards their work. Thus the self-determination theory emphasizes on intrinsic rewards rather than external rewards for motivating people to utilize their strengths and skills. Rather than being controlled or governed by outside sources, they are self-determined and their behaviours are relatively autonomous. This leads to self-actualization, a meaning-based life and a flourishing individual.

Self Assessment Questions 2

1. What are the six factors in Ryff's model of psychological well-being?
2. Explain complete mental health according to Keyes.
3. What are the two dimensions in the dual continuum model?
4. What is engagement in the PERMA model?
5. Name the three basic psychological needs stated by the Self-determination theory.

Gross National Happiness (GNH)

The concept of GNH originated in Bhutan. It was first proposed by the Fourth king of Bhutan, His Majesty Jigme Singye Wangchuck in the early 1970s. Bhutan's ancient legal code of 1629 stated that, "if the government cannot create happiness for its people, then there is no purpose for government to exist". Gross Domestic Product (GDP) as a measure of a country's progress was questioned as happiness and well-being of the people need to be accorded top priority rather than economic progress only. Focus needs to be on achieving a "flourishing human society living in harmony with nature". Article 9 of the Constitution of Bhutan states that "The State shall strive to promote those conditions that will enable the pursuit of Gross National Happiness." GNH adopts a "multi-dimensional development approach seeking to achieve a harmonious balance between material well-being and the spiritual, emotional and cultural needs of society."

Source: <http://www.gnhcentrebhutan.org/what-is-gnh/history-of-gnh/>

7.5 INDIAN PERSPECTIVE ON HAPPINESS

Ancient Indian texts like the Vedas, Upanishads, and the Bhagwad Gita provide us lots of insights into the nature and working of human mind, and how it can contribute to our happiness 'sukha', and unhappiness 'dukha'. In common parlance, happiness is termed as 'khushi'. These texts provide the social framework and ground rules regarding leading a good life and enhancing well-being in individuals (Kumar, 2003).

Kumar (2003) proposes three perspectives on Indian conception of happiness and well-being:

(a) Charvaka philosophy

The Indian perspective in ancient times focused on the pleasure concept of happiness similar to hedonic happiness. This is reflected in the Charvaka principle which says "*Jaavatjivetsukhamjivet, Rinamkritwaghratampibet*," i.e., take loan or credit, but enjoy the pleasures, live happily till you live here in this world. It focused on the life now and advocated to live it to the fullest extent seeking pleasures only and avoiding any pain and suffering. This reflected the principle of "Living for the moment". However, this approach/conception did not gain popularity at that time.

(b) Transcendent perspective

As emphasized by the eudaimonic approach, Indian views on happiness and well-being also focuses on meaning in life but goes beyond it to transcendence state. This is the ultimate in well-being where it talks about the state of 'Ananda' or pure bliss. The individual transcends the worldly limitations and enters into the divine world which gives the ultimate happiness – the blissful state of happiness. Maslow had also extended his theory of Hierarchy of Needs by proposing the need of transcendence after the self-actualization need, which can lead to true happiness.

(c) Collectivist perspective

In between the extremes of pleasure approach of Charvaka and the spiritual approach of transcendence lies the collectivistic approach followed by a

majority of people in India (Kumar, 2003). According to the collectivistic approach to life espoused by Indian tradition, a life of moderation, focus on the collective goodness, living for others and other such human values and principles are advocated for promoting well-being.

It is reflected by such prayers as below which focuses on collective happiness:

“*Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam*” (The whole world is one family)

“*Sarve bhavantu sukhinaha, sarve santu niramaya,*

Sarve bhadrani pasyantu, ma kaschid dukha bhagabhavet.”

(May all be happy, may all be free from disease, May all perceive good and may not suffer from sorrow)

Indian perspective on happiness is dominated more by spiritual and collectivistic aspects than the materialistic view. As mentioned by Kumar (2003), Indian ‘Munis’ and ‘Rishis’ (Sages and Seers) focused on what is permanent (truth) and what is not permanent (mithya) in their quest for ultimate truth. The everlasting happiness comes from knowing one’s Self (Atman), transcending the Self, and developing a higher consciousness where one realizes that “I am That” or “*So Hum*”. I am the same as the universe or the ultimate reality. There is no difference between you and me, we all are connected. This leads to true well-being and everlasting happiness or bliss (“ananda”).

Further, Indian thought and philosophy proposes **four major goals in human life**: *Dharma*, *Artha*, *Kaama*, and *Moksha*, that is, pursuit of values, wealth, desires, and liberation respectively. Individuals whose life is dominated by artha and kaama, they are engaged in acquisition of wealth, and satisfaction of their desires related to biological as well as psychological aspects. These represent lower level of human existence dominated by materialism. Dharma represents life governed by values, which can be said to represent a good life with discipline, responsibility, utilization of one’s strengths, meaning and purposefulness. Moksha, the ultimate goal aims at transcendence and liberation from this worldly existence. The relative emphasis that we give to the pursuit of these four goals in life will influence our happiness and well-being. Artha and kaama focuses on “what is *preya*” (what we desire), whereas dharma and moksha represents “what is *shreya*” (what is good). A life lived with strengths, values, and virtues which are the focus of research in positive psychology) enhances our well-being.

The PanchKosha Model of Well-being

According to the Taittiriya Upanishad, there are five koshas or sheaths/layers starting from the physical/material body to the blissful state. These are *Annamaya kosha*, *Pranamaya kosha*, *Manomaya kosha*, *Vijnanamaya kosha*, and *Anandamaya kosha*. These are different parts of the human system, which gradually takes you to the higher consciousness state. Annamaya is nourished by ‘anna’ (food); Pranamaya is nourished by ‘prana’ (bioenergy); Manomaya is nourished by ‘education’; Vijnanamaya is nourished by ‘ego’; and Anandamaya is the segment nourished by ‘emotions’ (Srivastava, 2012). Similar to Maslow’s hierarchy of needs, the Panchakosha theory also represents a hierarchical order. The ultimate objective is to attain the state of ananda or bliss. Self-realization (the transcendent self) is given more importance than self-actualization (Kumar, 2003).

Table 7.2: Koshas and their Characteristics

Kosha	Represents	Characteristic
Annamaya	Physical body	Passivity
Pranamaya	Vital air	Activity, Movement
Manomaya	Mind and mental functions	Passive knowledge
Vijnanamaya	Ego, Intellect	Discerning, Decision making
Anadamaya	Intuition	Sustainable happiness, Bliss

7.6 FACTORS AFFECTING HAPPINESS

Research has found lots of benefits of happiness such as good physical health, boosting immunity, and reducing stress (Davidson, Mostofsky, & Whang, 2010; Papousek, Nauschnegg, Paechter, Lackner, Goswami, & Schuler, 2010; Steptoe & Wardle, 2011). Before we go on to describe measures for increasing our happiness to reap the benefits, let us discuss various factors that can affect our happiness. Understanding the demographics of happiness can help us devise and implement effective strategies for enhancing happiness and well-being.

Money

The common perception is that if one earns a lot of money, has all the material comforts, one will be happy. It is believed that people with low financial status face difficulty in meeting their needs and hence are less happy and more stressed with life's challenges. However, research points out that although income increases our happiness, beyond a point, addition in income does not lead to further increase in happiness. This explains the strong relationship between income and well-being among the impoverished but an insignificant relationship between the two variables among the affluent (Diener, Diener, & Diener, 1995). Thus it indicates that money is necessary for meeting the needs, and hence may affect our happiness; but beyond a point, there are other factors (mainly psychological factors) that determine our happiness and well-being. As stated by Baumgardner and Crothers (2015, p. 76), happiness is a subjective psychological state that depends more on the quality, rather than the quantity, of our lives.

Marriage

Those who are married are believed to be happier than those not married or divorced/separated (Myers, 2000a). Can we infer from this that marriage makes one happy? Is it possible to deduce a cause and effect relationship here? Studies also indicate that married people were already happier before marriage. So it is the quality of marital relationship that is more important in contributing to happiness in marriage.

Reflect

Whatever stage of life you are in now, look back on the previous stages. And also look further and visualize your later stages of life.

- Will you describe your present stage of life as happiest? Or,
- Will you describe any of your previous stage of life as happiest? Or,
- Would you be more happy in any of the later stages of life ?

Think and reflect on the above and give your answer. Also write down the "Why" for whatever response you choose.

Age

Findings indicate that happiness varies across the life span. Usually, the adolescence stage is seen as the worst stage marked by ‘storm and stress’, various challenges of growing up and understanding the biological and psychological changes. Adult life is beset with many responsibilities regarding earning, having a family, raising children, taking care of the older people etc. The college years, the stage of young adults, are typically tension-free without any major responsibility and full of more fun time. However, contrary to the popular beliefs, research indicates a general stability of subjective well-being across the life span (Baumgardner and Crothers (2015, p. 86). That is, the level of happiness remains more or less similar across the age.

Gender

What do you think – whether men are more happy or women are more happy? Whatever the common perception, studies report approximately the same level of happiness in men and women (Inglehart, 1990). Other studies have shown less than 1% difference in perceived well-being of men and women (Fujita, Diener, & Sandvik, 1991). However, there is gender difference in their emotional life, the way emotions are expressed and experienced (Fujita et. al., 1991).

Thus research studies point out that the demographic variables may not have that strong relationship with our happiness and well-being. Although our common perception tells us that if a person has a big bank balance, owns a bungalow, has a luxurious car, goes on expensive vacations, is young and doing a very good job and so on – these are the signs that indicate that the person will be happy and enjoying good mental health. On the other hand, findings point out that the demographic variables and the life circumstances have a much weaker relationship to happiness. This is called the *paradox of well-being*. (Mroczek & Kolarz, 1998). That is, there is no linear relationship between the demographic indicators of happiness and happiness. Our happiness and well-being depends on factors beyond the demographic factors.

Culture is an important aspect to be factored in while discussing well-being of individuals. Research has reported differences in the SWB of people from individualistic and collectivistic cultures (Diener, Diener, & Diener, 1995). As discussed earlier in the Indian perspectives on happiness, our nation reflects a collectivistic culture where well-being is marked more by self-realization, compassion towards others, and altruism rather than focusing on the individual pursuits and achievements. Kitayama and Markus (2000) point out that independence, autonomy, and agency are the predictors of happiness in the Western culture as compared to the interconnectedness of self and others in the Eastern culture.

Happiness Economics relates economic issues such as wealth, income, employment with individual satisfaction measures, and happiness. The concept of economics of happiness or happiness economics was first given by Richard Easterlin in the early 1970s. It focuses on studying factors affecting well-being and quality of life of individuals rather than its earlier focus on the concept of utility. The traditional utility theory does not account for the internal subjective experiences of individuals received from market products and goods. Thus happiness economics employs survey methods to collect responses from people regarding their level of happiness on various factors related to quality of life. As Graham (2005) states, the economics of happiness attempts to complement the income-based measures of welfare with broader measures of well-being.

7.7 ENHANCING OUR HAPPINESS AND WELL-BEING

The measures to enhance our happiness can follow a multi-pronged approach. It needs to take into account various aspects of happiness ranging from positive emotional experiences, satisfaction of needs to utilization of one's signature strengths, values, being mindful, finding one's life purpose and cultivating a higher consciousness.

Reference to the *Broaden and build theory of positive emotions* discussed in earlier section, steps can be taken to create positive emotions, which will help us in developing resources to meet with life challenges. This will further enhance our self-esteem and utilization of skills and talents, that will lead to a good life. Other models of well-being have also highlighted the role of positive experiences, positive relationships, positive achievement and meaning in enhancing well-being.

Constructs related to positive psychology such as *gratitude, resilience, kindness, optimism, hope, mindfulness* etc. play an important role in achieving happiness. Various interventions have been researched for promoting happiness and well-being such as gratitude through writing letters (Emmons & McCullough, 2003), increasing optimistic thinking through visualization of one's best possible future self (King, 2001), appreciating and savouring the positive experiences of life (Bryant & Veroff, 2007), finding meaning in life, and using one's strengths (Meyers, & van Woerkom, 2017).

Mindful Breathing	Mindful Eating
Sit comfortably and notice your breath, how are you inhaling and exhaling – is it fast, shallow, noisy, calm, shorter or longer duration etc. Do not try to change it, just notice the way it is, become aware of your breathing. If your mind diverts to other thoughts in the process, just notice these, and gently bring back your attention to your breath.	When you are eating, pay attention to the sight, smell, taste and texture of what you are eating. First look at the food on your plate and notice every aspect of it. Then bring a small amount of your food near your mouth, notice it, then gently put it in your mouth. Notice all the sensations – the taste, flavor, texture etc. – and slowly chew it, paying your attention to this process throughout. Notice how the food is breaking down and mixing with saliva and how going down to your stomach, and how your stomach is feeling full gradually.

It is pointed out that when the individual intentionally engages in such activities, it leads to flourishing and good positive mental health in the individual. In an experimental longitudinal intervention to boost well-being, it was reported that the interventions for enhancing happiness are most successful when participants know about, endorse, and commit to the intervention (Lyubomirsky, Dickerhoof, Boehm, & Sheldon, 2011).

The widely cited “**Happiness pie-chart**” of Lyubomirsky points out that we need to focus on our own initiatives and actions impacting our happiness (Lyubomirsky, Sheldon,

& Schkade, 2005). According to this, 50% of our happiness is determined by our genetic factor, 10% is determined by circumstances; whereas 40% is influenced by our own intentional activities (Refer to Fig. 7.5).

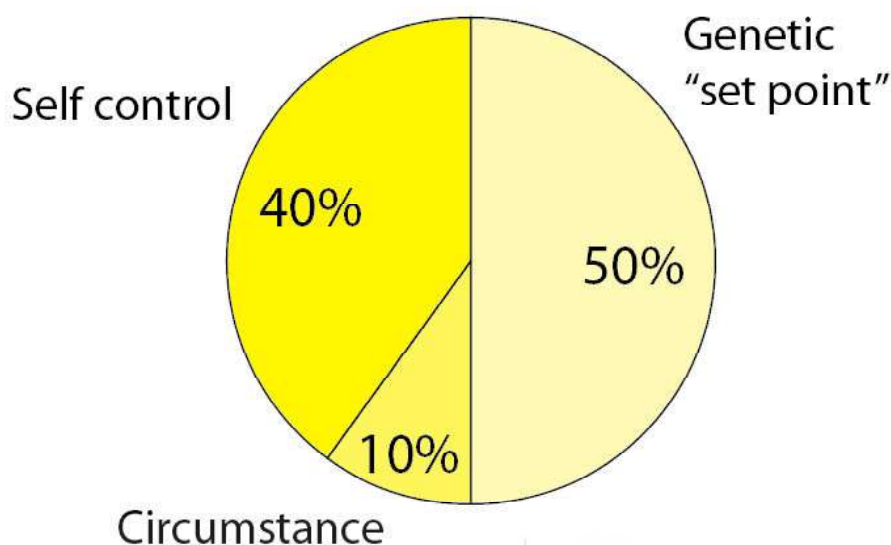


Fig. 7.5: Happiness Pie-chart by Lyubomirsky

Even though it highlights a genetic set point, as with every other aspect of our behavior, it is the dynamic interaction between the nature and the nurture that will influence the outcome. Further, one needs to focus on the 40% intentional activity component – engagement of the individual in conscious positive cognitive, behavioural, and goal-based activities (which is under one's control), which can account for individual differences in well-being (Sheldon & Lyubomirsky, 2007).

A major benefit of the practice of volitional positive activities is that they may serve as a natural antidote to the process of *hedonic adaptation* (Lyubomirsky, 2011). Hedonic adaptation refers to the phenomenon that the newness or the pleasure derived from anything gradually wears off, e.g., the amount of joy, excitement and the care you show when you buy a new car or a house does not last for long. Thus there is a tendency to adapt to positive life experiences relatively quickly. However, when we intentionally engage in activities to increase our happiness, their effect may last for longer periods of time (Seligman, Steen, Park, & Peterson, 2005; Lyubomirsky, King, & Diener, 2005).

Hence we need to guard ourselves against hedonic adaptation that may act as a barrier to our happiness. Certain other barriers to happiness include *Affective Forecasting* (Wilson & Gilbert, 2003), which refers to the prediction people make about the emotional impact of specific events. They found that the individuals' predictions and their real life reactions differ and the anticipated outcomes (predictions) are usually more intense in their severity and duration, which is called as *Impact Bias* (Gilbert, Driver-Linn, & Wilson, 2002). One of the reasons for such impact bias where the future anticipated outcomes are exaggerated can be *Focalism* (Wilson, Meyers, & Gilbert, 2001), which refers to focusing only on one aspect of the situation and neglecting the other aspects involved in it. As a result, we do not see the situation or event in a holistic manner.

Measures to Boost Your Happiness

- Engage in any activity, utilizing all your senses
- Create meaning in whatever you are doing, this will help you to be more engaged in it.
- Show kindness towards others
- Express gratitude towards others
- Share with others and care for others
- Practice meditation
- Engage in hobbies
- Do relaxation exercise
- Take life as it is. Cultivate a sense of acceptance.
- Decide on your life priorities.

Indian conception of happiness offers a rich repertoire of broader concepts and principles to enhance well-being. Indian thought system advocates for a balanced approach to life that can result in a good life and meaningful life. It focuses more on leading a value-based life (based on Dharma), rather than indulging exclusively on artha and kama (which reflects a pleasure dominated life). The highest goal is moving towards the realization of “Atma Dipa Bhava” (You be the Light) and “Aham Brahmasmi” (I am the Universe). This reflects transcending one’s Self and experiencing the Bliss that we are. To reach this higher state, one needs to focus on one’s life style whether it is dominated by artha, kaama, and dharma; and to what extent each dominates, whether it is more artha-kaama oriented life, or it is more a virtuous life focusing on values. The objective is to lead a dharma-based life, achieve self-actualization and move towards self-realization, the ultimate state of well-being.

Ashtanga Yoga is one of the measures advocated by Indian tradition, which aims to regulate the agitations of mind, make the mind calm, cultivate detachment, and move towards altruism. This can contribute to a psychologically healthy person enhancing our health, happiness and well-being (Rao & Paranjpe, 2016, p. 219). It consists of eight limbs or parts that focus on different practices to discipline oneself, develop attentional practices, and enhance one’s ultimate well-being. The eight parts are Yama, Niyama, Asana, Pranayama, Pratyahara, Dharana, Dhyana, and Samadhi about which you will learn more later in Unit 13. It can be just noted here that the practice of these eight steps will help one to focus on one’s physical health as well as mental health, emotional health and spiritual health.

One can practice the ‘five mantras’ (refer to Fig. 7.6 below) to take care of different aspects of our happiness and well-being: proper food, good sleep and adequate exercise improves our physical health; thinking well which includes rational thinking and balancing our emotions promote our mental health and psychological well-being; and relating well refers to good interpersonal relationship (social well-being) as well as connecting to a higher being (spiritual well-being).



Fig. 7.6: Five Mantras for Happiness and Well-being

Happiness in the Indian psychological thought is broad-based, covering not only physical, social, emotional but also spiritual aspects of our life. It is oriented towards a higher state of being, a deeper meaning in life. It emphasizes sustainable happiness for the benefit of all humankind.

Self Assessment Questions 3

1. According to Indian thought, what is the ultimate state of well-being?
2. What are the four major goals of life according to Indian philosophy?
3. What is Moksha?
4. What is pranamayakosha?

7.8 LET US SUM UP

You learned about happiness and the related terminologies in the present unit. You also learned about how happiness and well-being is viewed in the Indian thought and philosophical tradition. Happiness needs to be conceptualized and studied in terms of well-being as a multidimensional construct. Factors affecting happiness were highlighted. Further, various measures to enhance happiness and well-being were discussed. However, the formula of being happy may not be that simple as we need to understand the dynamic interaction of various factors contributing towards our flourishing and well-being.

7.9 KEY WORDS

Good Life : refers to a life where you make use of your strengths and skills to feel capable and confident, which makes you feel happy.

Subjective well-being : refers to the subjective evaluation of one's life, i.e., how does one perceive and evaluate /judge one's life.

Hedonic happiness	: focuses on personal happiness involving pleasure, joy and satisfaction.
Eudaimonic happiness	: refers to a deeper sense of meaning in life, which comes from realizing one's potentials and striving towards self-actualization.
PERMA model	: refers to Positive emotions, Engagement, Positive relationships, Meaning and Accomplishment, which can be considered as the five major components contributing our well-being.
Ananda	: refers to the state of pure bliss which occurs in the ultimate state of transcendence.
Dharma	: represents life governed by values, which can be said to represent a good life with discipline, responsibility, utilization of one's strengths, meaning and purposefulness.
PanchaKosha	: refers to the five layers/sheaths of body, namely Annamaya kosha, Pranamaya kosha, Manomaya kosha, Vijnanamaya kosha, and Anandamaya kosha.
Hedonic adaptation	: refers to the phenomenon that the newness or the pleasure derived from anything gradually wears off.

7.10 ANSWERS TO SELF ASSESSMENT QUESTIONS

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 1

1. Pleasant life is characterized by fulfilling various needs of the individual and deriving pleasures out of it.
2. The three components in subjective well-being are: (a) life satisfaction, (b) presence of positive affect, and (c) a relative absence of negative affect.
3. Eudaimonic view of happiness states that the good life involves living according to one's "*diamon*", or 'true self'.
4. Martin Seligman

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 2

1. Self-acceptance, personal growth, positive relations with others, environmental mastery, autonomy, and purpose in life.
2. According to Keyes, complete mental health includes emotional well-being, psychological well-being, and social well-being.
3. The two dimensions are (a) the presence or absence of mental illness, and (b) poor or good mental health.
4. Engagement refers to being involved in an activity to such an extent that it creates a sense of "flow" in the individual.
5. Autonomy, competence, and relatedness

1. Transcendence state
2. Dharma, Artha, Kaama, and Moksha
3. Moksha, which is the ultimate goal of human life, aims at transcendence and liberation from this worldly existence.
4. Pranamaya kosha refers to the vital prana or the bioenergy inside the body.

7.11 UNIT END QUESTIONS

1. Explain the three types of life proposed by Seligman. How these are related to hedonic and eudaimonic happiness?
2. Differentiate between subjective well-being and psychological well-being.
3. Explain Keyes' model of well-being and highlight its implications for happiness.
4. Discuss the Panchakosha model of well-being.
5. Elaborate on the factors affecting happiness.
6. Discuss various measures to enhance happiness and well-being.

REFLECTIVE EXERCISE

What Makes A Good Day?

We all want our day to be good. Isn't it? But have we ever thought consciously what makes our day good? Think and reflect on

- *What activities and experiences make your day good?*
- *How much of these activities originate from your own actions and intentions, and how much of these are influenced by external situations/events?*
- *Can you do anything to bring the focus more on personal characteristics, intentions, and behavior to achieve well-being?*
- *Reflect on the relative role of internal and external factors in determining your happiness and well-being.*

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The logo of Ugnou University, featuring a stylized 'U' and 'G' intertwined in a circular design.

Block III

Positive Cognitive States and Processes

Ugnou
THE PEOPLE'S
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UNIT 8 SELF AND RELATED CONCEPTS

Structure

- 8.1 Objectives
- 8.2 Introduction
- 8.3 Concept of Self
 - 8.3.1 Different Aspects of Self
- 8.4 Self-Concept
 - 8.4.1 Real Self and Ideal Self
- 8.5 Self-Esteem
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- 8.7 Self-Regulation
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- 8.12 References
- 8.13 Suggested Readings

8.1 LEARNING OBJECTIVES

After studying this Unit, you would be able to:

- *Describe the concept of self;*
- *Understand different aspects of self;*
- *Differentiate between real-self and ideal-self;*
- *Explain the concept of self-esteem;*
- *Explain the concept of self-efficacy; and*
- *Learn about strategies for self-regulation of behaviour.*

8.2 INTRODUCTION

The question “Who am I” is a central point that can arise in each stage of our life, though it is more pertinent during the adolescence stage. Whatever developmental stages you are in by now, you must have formed some notions about yourself, though you may or may not be aware about it. Self is and has always been the intriguing concept to understand. All of us have certain views and beliefs about ourselves - our abilities, skills, interests, likings, dislikings, strengths and weaknesses etc. Thus we know what we are, what are our aims in life, how do we want to live our life, what are our guiding principles and values. These play a significant role in directing us, guiding

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us, and regulating our emotions and actions. So how do we develop this concept of self? Are there different aspects of self? There are various terms related to the self such as self-concept, self-esteem, and self-efficacy. One needs to have a good self-concept, high levels of self-esteem and self-efficacy to function effectively and engage in positive behaviour. This will indicate a positive self. So in the present Unit, you will learn about the self and its related concepts such as self-esteem, self-efficacy, and self-regulation.

8.3 CONCEPT OF SELF

If you ask yourself ‘Who am I?’, ‘What makes me?’ , you might answer with “I am a student,” or, “I am a singer,” or may be, “I am a God fearing person” etc. Or, perhaps you may answer, “I am *good* in studies,” “I am a *trained* dancer,” or “I am a *popular* sportsperson.” Here you may note that you are qualifying your abilities. Further answers might include the type of traits: “I am a *caring* person,” “I am an *introvert*,” or “I am a *disciplined* and *punctual* person”. These answers arise from what you think about yourself, which is developed from your experiences and evaluation from early life, and it keeps adjusting or changing throughout life.

Mostly when people go for interview, the most common question asked is “describe yourself or tell us about yourself”. What you answer is all about how you perceive your ‘self’. You may describe physical features, traits, qualities, goals, motives etc. Thus, your concept of self is made up of varied information about yourself, which you gain from your own experience and also receive from others in your environment.

Reflective Activity 1:

Let us try to have some preliminary notion of yourself (i.e. who are you?) by completing the following sentences. You can write more number of points also by taking a separate sheet (it will be a good idea to note down the time you will take to finish this activity of writing about yourself) Starting Time: _____

I am

I am

I am

I am

I am

Ending Time _____

Reflect on the following:

1. How easy was it for you to complete these sentences?
2. How much time did you take?
3. Different people take different time to answer these questions. Why?

It might have been very easy for you or might have not been as easy as you may have thought of at first. You were describing your ‘self’ when you were answering the above statements. As you are aware of various objects and people around you, similarly you are aware about your ‘self’. When a child is born, they develop their self-concept

gradually in interaction with their parents/caregivers, family members, friends, teachers and other significant people around. Our interaction and experiences with other people and the way we perceive these help us to form the foundation of our self-concept. Further, different social and cultural systems and institutions around us including societal expectations, cultural values, social media usage and technology etc. also affect our perception of ourselves.

If you see the list of yours and your friends/family members in the above Reflective activity 1, you will realise that how different we are because of our different experiences and interpretation we make of these.

When we analyse these various descriptions about ourselves, we can categorize them into various categories such as those describing our abilities and skills, i.e., what can we do (*self-concept*); those describing us in terms of affective value, i.e., how do we value or respect ourselves (*self-esteem*); and those expressing our belief in ourselves that we are capable of doing things, a sense of personal control (*self-efficacy*).

8.3.1 Different Aspects of Self

Self can also be described as an **Agent/ Subject** when we say that I play hockey or I sing, here self is described as a doer who is doing something and in control of self. Thus it represents self as “I”. It includes self-awareness, self as consciousness, self as user of coping strategies, self as adapting to environment, and self-regulation. Secondly, self can also be described as an **Object**, when we say that ‘he made me angry’, we are describing self as an object (which gets affected). Thus it represents self as “me”. It includes self-representation, self-concept, self-esteem, self-efficacy. These two aspects of self, that is, self-as-subject and self-as-object (Robins et.al., 1999) can represent the total self.

Our ‘self’ can also be described in terms of personal, social, cognitive, and behavioural aspects. The **personal self** is mainly concerned with one’s own self related to personal aspects, whereas the **social self** develops in relation with others and is primarily concerned with family and social relationships (socio-cultural context). Therefore, it is also known as **familial** or **relational self**. The self can also be understood in terms of cognitive and behavioural aspects.

If you reflect on your answers in the Reflective activity 1, you will realise that self is made up of your personal and social self. If you identify yourself with your personal information or attributes such as your name, your quality, your abilities or your beliefs/values, you are referring to your personal self, whereas if you say that you belongs to Kerala or Rajasthan, you are a Hindu/Muslim, etc. you are referring to your social or cultural self. Sometimes you may wonder why some feel offensive if something is said about their place or religion or family, now you can understand that it affects their social self or identity that is why they probably feel bad and react in that manner. Thus, the way people describe themselves as a person, defines their ‘self’. Self as a whole is about the person’s thoughts, feelings, experiences, and ideas, with respect to herself or himself which define the person at both, the personal and social levels.

These different aspects of self get shaped up by the result of our interactions with our physical and socio-cultural environments. Therefore, it is multi-faceted. The origins of self may be observed in infancy when the infant is aware that s/he is hungry and cries to be fed by the caregiver. So, this biological need of food and hence crying, later on modifies according to the socio-cultural environmental context. For example, while

you may feel hungry for a pizza, a tribal adult is not. Another example is that fasting is given importance in all the religions. Although you have a biological need of food and you feel hungry everyday normally, but on the day of the fast, you ignore or may not even feel hungry because of the social-cultural conditioning.

8.4 SELF-CONCEPT

Self-concept is a basic notion about who we are in terms of physically, emotionally, socially, and spiritually (Neill, 2005). From the time of our birth, we develop and regulate our self-concept based on the information received from others about ourselves. Thus self is a multi-dimensional concept. It is affected by multiple factors, which in turn influence the individual aspects. For instance, you may think and describe yourself in terms of your physical aspects, and in terms of your relations or emotions. Your perception about yourself in physical aspects, e.g., you are very fat or very thin, may impact your interaction in social situations or your emotions.

A few definitions of self-concept are given below.

- According to Roy Baumeister (1999), self-concept is “the individual’s belief about himself or herself, including the person’s attributes and who and what the self is.”
- The self-concept is defined as “the composite ideas, feelings, and attitudes people have about themselves” (Hilgard, Atkinson, and Atkinson, 1979: p.605).
- According to Purkey (1988), self-concept is “the sum of a complex, organized, and dynamic system of learned beliefs, attitudes and opinions that each person holds to be true about his or her personal existence”. Let’s understand the important terms in this definition. According to him, the self-concept is:
 - **Learned:** We are not born with the concept of self (and that is why it is said that the child is like a blank slate), it is learnt steadily, formed and re-formed by significant others and events in our life. Basically a child’s self-image is a learnt one which is influenced by the feedback given by significant others such as parents, family, peers and teachers. Here we need to remember that we all have our own way of seeing the things so the feedback given to the child may not essentially be the accurate one. For example, if a parent or teacher constantly tell the child that s/he is obedient, the child starts believing and see her/himself as obedient, or when they tell the child that s/he is mischievous, the child begins to think so. Though, it may not be true, as it is the subjective opinion of parents and teachers. Thus, two children with a similar behaviour pattern would have different self-pictures according to the message relayed by their respective parents. Teachers are considered the second parents and influence children’s life in a very significant way (Lawrence, 1996). Teachers too may have judgements about children like parents. The judgments or assumptions of teachers about the child may be similar to parents or it may be different.
 - **Organized:** Our self-concept is organized which is characterized by orderliness and harmony (Damon and Hart, 1991) that provides consistency to the personality of an individual. That is why personality is defined as the individualistic characteristics which is relatively permanent in nature.

- **Dynamic:** Life is all about ups and downs, success and failure which impacts our self-concept making it dynamic in nature which changes and develop according to our experiences and situations. In order to develop a healthy personality, an individual needs to work constantly on assimilating the new thoughts into old ones throughout life.

Self Assessment Questions 1

1. If a person says, “I am good in studies”, s/he is referring to her/his social self. True / False
2. When an individual says that s/he belongs to South India, s/he is referring to her/his social self. True / False
3. The self as a whole is made up of individual’s:
 - a) thoughts and feelings
 - b) experiences, and ideas
 - c) only A
 - d) both A and B
4. From the following which is not true about ‘Self’:
 - a) Learned
 - b) Dynamic) Static
 - d) Organised
5. “Self-concept is a basic notion about who we are in terms of physically, emotionally, socially, spiritually” Who said this?
 - a) Hilgard, Atkinson, and Atkinson
 - b) Roy Baumeister
 - c) Purkey
 - d) Neill

All of us have some sense of who we are and how different we are from others. Our perception and ideas about our capabilities and qualities is known as self-concept. This view about our self or our self-concept can be positive or negative, depending upon our experiences and mind set. The way we would respond to the question, “Who am I?” tells about how do we see ourselves, positively or negatively. The positive response to this question makes us feel good or rather we can say that if we feel good about our self then our answer would be positive. It can be that we may like some of our qualities and may not like other. For example, one may feel good about his/her social skills but may not be positive or confident about the academic skills. Although it is not easy to find out an individual’s self-concept, yet you may get a fair idea by the way an individual describes about him/her.

Our positive self helps us to view the world as a safe and positive place to be in. On the other hand, the negative response makes us feel unhappy about who we are and make

us view the world as unsafe and bad place to be in. According to Rogers, self-actualizing tendencies drive all human behaviour to achieve at their fullest level of potentials. A person forms the basic structure of self and related concepts based on the result of his/her interactions with the environment and others. Thus self-concept is an organized, dynamic, conceptual pattern of ideas and values related to the self.

Reflective Activity 2:

Think and write about “Who am I?”

- Based on your answer, find out whether you have a negative or a positive self-concept?
- Reflect on your experiences that led you to develop this particular self-concept?
- Can you plan some strategies to modify the negative self-concept or develop further the positive self? Discuss with your friends and/or family members and write.

8.4.1 Real Self and Ideal Self

The ‘self’ has two parts: the Ideal self and the Real self. According to Carl Rogers, we all visualise ourselves into our ideal self, which we would like to be; whereas the real self is what we actually are. Our real self can be very different from our ideal self. The more the gap or disparity between what we like to be (ideal self) and what we are (real self), the more the disharmony within our self. That is why Rogers emphasized that we essentially need to work towards attaining the harmony or consistency between these two selves. We achieve harmony or the congruence by making our thoughts and actions of real self, similar to our ideal self. In short, when our self-concept is accurate, we achieve congruence or harmony within self.

It is very important to focus on bringing or maintaining this congruence, as high congruence is essential to have a greater sense of self-esteem and a healthy, fruitful life. On the other hand, if the discrepancy is more between our ideal and actual selves, we experience a state of incongruence, which can lead to low self-esteem, anxiety and maladjustment. So adults especially, the parents and teachers, need to provide unconditional positive regard, or unconditional love to children, which can help our children achieve high congruency in their ideal and real self. Rogers (1980) mentioned that, “as individuals are accepted and valued as they are, they tend to develop a more caring attitude towards themselves” (p. 116).

Reflective Activity 3:

“What would you like to be?”

- We all must have formed some views about our ideal selves. Think on this and imagine that you have realised or achieved your ideal self. Now with this picture of your ideal self, describe briefly your attitudes towards: (a) school, (b) friends, (c) family, (d) society and (e) money.
- Now identify two of your friends and two family members and ask them to write down briefly about you on these five aspects, as they perceive you. This

will depict your real ideas are or how people in your life perceive your real attitudes towards these categories.

- These four persons will describe your real self as they know you. Compare your ideal descriptions with others' real descriptions in detail. Are they very similar or dissimilar? And why?

8.5 SELF-ESTEEM

Another important aspect of our self is **self-esteem**. As a human being, we constantly evaluate our self or make some judgment about our own value or worth which is termed as **self-esteem**. People vary in viewing their self-esteem, some have high self-esteem, whereas others may have low self-esteem. Self-esteem reflects a personal psychological characteristic relating to self-judgment based on one's values about humans (Alesi et. al., 2012). It indicates being aware of one's value system and an emotional evaluation of one's self-worth (Schunk, 1985).

Self-esteem is a multi-dimensional construct. We have a global overall self-esteem based on general judgements of self-worth and various subtypes of self-esteem based on evaluations of self-worth in different contexts such as, within the family, school, work setting, leisure setting, or peer group (Mruk, 1999). Self-esteem is different from self-confidence. Self-confidence indicates that you are confident of your ability to carry out a particular thing. On the other hand, self-esteem refers to how high you hold yourself in your own eyes, how much respect and worth you give to yourself.

There are many self-report measures to assess self-esteem of individuals such as giving a variety of statements and asking a person to indicate whether the statements given are true for her/him or not.

For instance:

- "I am good at sports"
- "I am the one usually chosen for the cultural programmes or competitions"
- "I am highly liked by my teachers"
- "My friends consider me a trustworthy person"

If a child says 'Yes' to the above statements, it shows that s/he has high self-esteem in comparison to the child who says "No". Generally by 6-7 years of age, children's self-esteem is formed at least in four areas: *academic competence*, *social competence*, *physical/athletic competence*, and *physical appearance*, which improve with age and experience. Rosenberg's Self-esteem inventory (Rosenberg, 1965b) is a most commonly used uni-dimensional measure of self-esteem. Coopersmith Self-Esteem Inventory (Coopersmith, 1981, 2002) is a multi-dimensional measure of self-esteem in areas of family, school, peers, and general social activities.

Self-esteem is more or less stable across the life span, though it may vary at lifecycle transition points (Robins et.al., 1999). For instance, teenagers may experience a drop in self-esteem due to the various physical and psychological changes they go through. Self-esteem develops early in life based on the experiences and interactions during the early years. It has a great impact on our everyday behaviour. For instance, individuals

who have high academic self-esteem perform better in studies and are liked by their peers than those with low academic self-esteem. Conversely, individuals with low self-esteem may have high levels of anxiety, depression, and antisocial behaviour than those who have high self-esteem. People with high self-esteem are better in their social adjustment (Martin et al., 2014). It also positively affects their psychological well-being and quality of life (Boyd et al., 2014).

Therefore, it is extremely important for parents, families and schools to create a warm and positive environment, which can help in the development of high self-esteem among children. It makes them feel acknowledged, accepted as capable and valuable. Not allowing children to take their decisions and nagging often results in low self-esteem among children. It may be noted that it is important to have a healthy self-esteem than a very high self-esteem which is not realistic or functional.

Here, one needs to be aware of “**defensive self-esteem**” which refers to reporting of a high self-esteem as a defense against negative self-evaluation (Carr, 2004). Such individuals feel insecure and anxious when their competence is challenged. They resort to defense mechanism of overcompensation by bragging about themselves; or they use the defensive displacement of self-directed criticism onto others and display an unhealthy way of criticizing others (Carr, 2004).

Role of Culture

Culture/environment of an individual plays a critical role in developing his/her self-concept and self-esteem. Some cultures focus on the importance of being together whereas other cultures value the individual beings more than the group. Understanding of ‘self’ in Indian cultural context is distinct from the Western cultural context. One of the differences is the boundary we draw between the self and the others. In Indian culture, this boundary of self is not clearly defined or fixed and gets extended to others like family and friends. For example, whenever an individual takes some decision about self (e.g. study, job, etc.), usually one tends to think his/her decision in relation to others as well. Thus, sometimes our self includes the others and sometimes it withdraws and focuses completely on individual self (e.g., our personal needs or goals). Whereas, if we see the western culture, this boundary of self appears to be relatively fixed and clearly defined where individuals keep their individuality. In the Indian culture, the self is usually attached with one’s own group and both maintain the state of harmonious co-existence. On the other hand, in the Western culture an individual often keep a distance from the others/groups which makes the Western cultures as *individualistic*, and Indian and many Asian cultures as *collectivistic*.

Increasing Your Self-Esteem: Some Tips

- Learn a new skill in areas such as academic, cognitive, social, and work-related
- Go beyond your comfort zone
- Question your self-limiting beliefs, challenge your thoughts
- Focus on your strengths
- Engage in affirmative talk, tell yourself positive and kinder words
- Visualize things in a positive way

- Cultivate a positive attitude
- Be clear about your goals and values
- Do not hesitate to talk to others and take their help
- Take self care
- Recognize the ‘hero’ within you, tap onto your inner strengths
- Remember that you are more than your circumstances, the way you respond matters more
- You are unique, so do not compare with others

Self Assessment Questions 2

1. Who developed the concept of the ideal self and the real self?
2. The more the gap or disparity between what we like to be (ideal self) and what we are (real self), more the harmony within our self. True / False
3. Match the terms of column A with the appropriate description given in the column B.

Column A

(a) Self-concept

(b) Self-esteem

(c) Self as a subject

(d) Self as an object

(e) Collectivistic culture

Column B

(i) judgment about our own value or worth

(ii) Our perception and ideas about our capabilities and qualities

(iii) do not have clearly defined and fixed boundaries

(iv) described as a doer who is doing something

(v) self gets affected by others

8.6 SELF-EFFICACY

Self-efficacy is another important concept of self. The term ‘self-efficacy’ was proposed by psychologist Albert Bandura (1977). He was a Canadian-American psychologist who worked as a professor at Stanford University. According to him, “self-efficacy is a person’s particular set of beliefs that determine how well one can execute a plan of action in prospective situations”. We all have different views about our ability to control the life outcomes. People who believe that they are capable and can control what happens to them are having high self-efficacy whereas people who believe that the things and life events are not in their control and they cannot do anything about the life outcomes displays low self-efficacy. For example a child, who thinks that if I study hard I can pass the examination, demonstrates high self-efficacy. On the other hand, a child who thinks if I am lucky, the paper will be easy or I wish the examiner checks the papers leniently, displays low self-efficacy as s/he thinks that the outcome is not in their control and is in control of fate or luck or other situational factors. Hence, an individual who believes that s/he has the capacity or behaviours to deal with a particular situation, shows high self-efficacy. Such a person will accordingly put in the effort required to achieve the desired outcome/ consequence.

The idea of self-efficacy is founded on Bandura's social cognitive theory (Bandura, 1997, 1986). According to this theory, human beings actively engage with their environment to shape their lives. People learn by observing and imitating others. So if a child is exposed to people who demonstrate high self-efficacy, s/he tends to imitate the same behaviour. Also people will engage in behaviours for which they have mastery, high expectations of success and conviction about their own effectiveness, as this will lower the amount of risk they would undertake. High self-efficacy makes people to choose, influence, and even create the circumstances of their own life. Further, they feel more confident and less fearful.

Self-efficacy is different from self-esteem in the sense that self-esteem refers to judgments about self-worth whereas self-efficacy refers to judgments about self-capabilities. However, like we have a general self-esteem and self-esteem related to specific domains (multi-dimensional self-esteem measures), similarly self-efficacy can be general/global self-efficacy as well as we have self-efficacy specific to different domains. There is also collective self-efficacy, which refers to "the extent to which we believe that we can work together effectively to accomplish our shared goals" (Maddux, 2009a, p. 340). For instance, a sports team competing for an Olympic medal pursues shared objectives at a collective level.

Self-efficacy includes the following aspects/components (Carr, 2004):

- a) *Cognitive*: the person with high self-efficacy demonstrates greater cognitive resourcefulness, strategic flexibility, effective problem-solving and future-time perspective.
- b) *Motivational*: they are motivated to perform and persist because they view challenges as surmountable, believe that their effort will result in good consequences, and ascribe failure to controllable factors such as less effort or negative situations rather than uncontrollable factors like lack of ability.
- c) *Emotional*: self-efficacy reduces negative affective states and thinking by using problem-focused coping, and views potential threats as manageable challenges. It also involves the use of self-soothing techniques such as relaxation, humour etc. to reduce the emotional arousal in the face of threatening/difficult situations.
- d) *Physical*: self-efficacy beliefs lead to improved immune system, improved physical functioning and psychological well-being.

Self-efficacy refers to a sense of perceived control. It includes a focus on the goal and planful thinking for achieving the goal, which underlies the person's belief about their capabilities to achieve the goal. This is also called the "efficacy expectancies" (Snyder, Lopez, & Pedrotti, 2011). As we have seen in earlier sections, ideas about our 'self' is formed by our experiences, our mind set and the people around us; this suggests that self-efficacy can be developed. Self-efficacy has been linked to successful coping and improved physical health (Maddux, 1995, 2009a). Children with high self-efficacy perform better in all spheres of life. People with high self-efficacy have been found to have high determination. So it is very important for the society, parents and teachers to create positive experiences and present positive role models for children to develop a strong sense of self-efficacy during their formative years in childhood.

Strategies for Enhancing Self-Efficacy

Self-efficacy is a learned phenomenon. There can be various strategies that can help develop self-efficacy.

- **Self-mastery:** One needs to build success by mastering tasks. The sense of mastery and achievement can help improve belief in our capabilities or effectiveness.
- **Role modelling:** Observing others in similar situations who have achieved success can inspire one to undertake those activities. Observational learning is also used when we make use of role models to imitate their behaviour.
- **Visualization:** One can visualize oneself behaving effectively, thereby generating positive emotions and increasing efficacy expectancies.
- **Verbal persuasion:** Being persuaded by people who are expert in the field, powerful, and trustworthy can build self-efficacy in the individual.
- **Creating positive emotions and regulating arousal:** If we are highly aroused, it may lead to negative emotions and hamper self-efficacious thinking. Hence one needs to lower the arousal by engaging in meditation, biofeedback, relaxation and other techniques. Regulation of negative emotions and creation of positive emotions will help one to develop self-efficacy.

Activity 1

Enter into your stretch zone

There are three personal zones of achievement: comfort zone, stretch zone, and panic zone. One needs to go beyond the comfort zone (where the person does not want to enter into new arenas or put in more efforts), and also the panic zone (where the person does not want to take any risk). Stretch zone is where you are willing to take reasonable risks based on self-awareness and can take failures as learning experiences to move forward. Doing what we like, trying out the unknown, being vulnerable can help us to be flexible and open to new learning experiences. This will increase our self-belief or self-efficacy.

8.7 SELF-REGULATION

We all must have faced situations where we were required to control our desires or behaviour. We might have been successful at it or might not have been. For instance, you might have got very angry that your assistant staff at office did not do a task on time which was urgent. How did you control your anger? Or you might have bursted at a passer-by who just suddenly came in front of your car when you were taking a left turn on the road. Or you gave in to the temptation of eating sweets at a dinner party and ate too much. The crucial aspect in all these examples is exercising control over our desires, impulses and actions.

Self-regulation involves regulating our thoughts, emotions and behaviour so that it leads to a desirable or positive outcome. Self control and self-regulation are defined as people's ability to initiate and guide their actions toward the achievement of a desired future goal (Karolyi, 1999). Although self-regulation is used synonymously with the word self-control, there is a difference. **Self-control** is used in a limited sense where you suppress or stop your desires or behaviour. However, **Self-regulation** is a wider term which considers your long-term goals and value system and aims at using appropriate strategies or responses to achieve effective outcomes. There is emotional self-regulation which refers to managing our emotions in a proper way and respond

effectively to the situation. We have behavioural self-regulation also which refers to how we behave in a particular situation keeping in mind our values and goals; whether we respond by thinking about the situation, or we react on an impulse without thinking?

Self-control leads to better adjustment and positive outcome (Peterson & Seligman, 2004). The famous Marshmallow experiment by Walter Mischel is an example of self-control (Mischel, 1974). It depicts self-control in the form of the *ability to delay gratification of desires*. In this experiment, small children were given a choice that if they want, they can get one marshmallow now which is in front of them, or if they wait for a period of around 15 minutes, the experimenter would get them two marshmallows. It was found that those children who could wait and displayed the ability to control and delay the gratification of their desires, obtained positive outcomes in their later years in life also (Mischel & Mendoza-Denton, 2003; Goleman, 1998). Self-control and self-regulation abilities helped them adjust effectively, achieve better academically and manage stress successfully.

For example, it is very important to teach a child to delay or defer the immediate satisfaction of certain needs. This will help in learning the ability to regulate oneself and delay gratification of one's needs. We all know how important self-control is in achieving the long-term goals. For example a child is having an examination tomorrow and today his/her favourite movie is coming on television. If s/he has poor self-control and watch movie instead of revising for the exam, s/he may not perform well in his/her exam. You can also think and discuss with your friends or family some other examples where self-control is required in our day-to-day life. Think of the situation at traffic red light. If a person has a poor self-control and difficulty to wait, imagine what could happen to him/her or they can cause accidents to others. There are many good practices in Indian culture which provides us with some effective mechanisms (such as keeping fast (*vrata* or *roza*)) for developing self-control among individuals which can also be very beneficial for physical system to detoxify and rest.

Thus self-regulation involves looking at the future goals and accordingly sacrifice the short-term desires and pleasures, e.g., if one wants to achieve better a particular body weight, a long-term goal, one needs to follow the health routing in a disciplined way and forgo the short-term pleasures of eating sweets or fast food. One needs to stay focused on the goal and take necessary steps, modify one's behaviour, acquire various skills in the way to achieve that long-term goal. So it is a dynamic process of interaction with the environment and changing one's strategies and plans to attain that end goal.

Aspects of Self-Regulation

There are two parts to self-regulation: the goal or the desired outcome, and the process/path to reach that desired goal. The former is called the “**Goal intentions**”, e.g., your desire to achieve the goal of a particular body weight. The latter is called “**Implementation intentions**” that refers to the specific actions taken and strategies used by the individual to achieve the goal (Gollwitzer, 1999). It refers to actually implementing the plans made for attaining the desired outcome/goal. For example, to achieve the goal of attaining a desired body weight, I will exercise regularly from 6 a.m. to 7 a.m. in the morning, have early dinner at 7 p.m. everyday, will not eat refined flour at all and so on. Thus it is not enough to have goals, but planning to achieve the goal is necessary, and further implementing the specific plans and steps is required to achieve the goal. Planning things and implementing the steps/strategies consistently will help bring automaticity in behaviour control (Bargh, 1996; Bargh & Chartrand, 1999). This

makes it easier to engage in self-controlled behaviour and facilitates self-regulation. Thus when you consistently exercise everyday morning, you will find it easier to get up and do it without having to exercise too much self-control to do it.

Let us see now how much regulated you are in your behaviour related to your academic learning. Do you set goals for your study? Are you able to prepare plans for your study? Do you spell out specific strategies regarding achieving your goals and implement them? What do you do when obstacles come up while carrying out the strategies? How do you keep yourself motivated throughout the process of achieving your desired goals?

Self-regulated learning (SRL) is a core conceptual framework that involves the cognitive, motivational, and emotional aspects of learning (Panadero, 2017). Various models of self-regulated learning have highlighted the role of metacognitive and motivational processes (Zimmerman & Campillo, 2003; Zimmerman, 2000). When you engage in self-regulation related to your academic behaviour, it is called **academic self-regulation**. It helps you to focus on achieving your academic-related goals despite various distractions in the short-term. Students lacking in academic self-regulation display low self-control.

Academic self-regulation has three important components (Brier, 2010):

- *Planning*: Academically self-regulated learners set goals and prepare plans to achieve it. They prioritize the goals and regulate their behaviour according to the goals. They are motivated to persevere in their efforts to attain the goals.
- *Problem-solving*: Such students implement various strategies to achieve the goals. They are aware of the performance standards they have set and work towards any obstacles related to it. They adjust and readjust the strategies to overcome the barriers in achieving the goals.
- *Self-evaluation*: It involves monitoring the progress towards the set goals. It assesses if their actions are consistent with the goal intentions and their value systems. If it is not consistent, they take steps to modify their behaviour according to the desired goals. A positive evaluation enhances their motivation further to engage in academic behaviour.

Are You a Self-Regulated Learner?

Answer the following questions with a **Yes** or **No**.

Do you . . .

1. Have a plan before you begin to do your schoolwork (what you will do, when you will start, where you will work, in what order you will do your work)?
2. Set a goal before you start working?
3. Visualize your goal and imagine how you might tell whether you are acting in the way that you want to act (that you are keeping to your standards)?
4. Create priorities (put your tasks in an order) and a schedule to do your work?

5. Think out specific strategies or ways to achieve your goals?
6. Expect to do well before you start doing your work?
7. Feel interested in the work?
8. Think the work is important or relevant?
9. Feel motivated to put forth as much effort as you can?
10. Feel able to stay focused while working?
11. Keep track of whether you are paying attention while you work?
12. Notice whether you are making progress toward being as successful at schoolwork as you want to be?
13. Try to figure out what you would do differently to help yourself improve?
14. See a relationship between how hard you work, your strategies, and how you actually do?
15. Self-correct and adjust your effort, revise your strategies, or ask for help if you see you are not doing as well as you want to do?
16. Give yourself a reward (for example, a compliment) or punishment (feel ashamed or self-critical) when you finish your work, depending on how you think you did?

Source: *Promoting Academic Self-Regulation in Adolescents* by Norman Brier, 2010, Champaign, IL: Research Press (www.researchpress.com, 800-519-2707)

<https://www.researchpress.com/wp-content/uploads/2012/02/6615.pdf>

Self-Control Failure

There are occasions when we fail to exercise self-control. There is inability to regulate ourselves to follow the planned out steps because of various reasons. These reasons for failure to self-control may relate to personal factors or to external situational factors. These factors can also be under one's control to change or not under one's control. **Excuses** are the explanations that we give for our self-control failure when factors were under our control, but we could not do so. It avoids taking personal responsibility and attributes the failure to external factors. Thus it helps us to preserve our self-esteem and self-image. At other times, of course, uncontrollable factors can hinder the implementation of our plans. **Cultural factors** related to belief system may also affect our ability to self-control or failure of self-control. Individuals internalize the socio-cultural belief systems that influence their own belief of self-control or lack of it. The amount of self-control exercised by people may have less to do with the power of the impulse, and more to do with culturally internalized beliefs about whether they should, or can, exercise self-control (Baumgardner & Crothers, 2015). There are also individual differences in self-control that govern the ability to control oneself. As Carver (2005) points out, personality characteristics such as ego-resilience, ego-control, and hardiness affect one's self-control ability.

Life may not always go according to our needs and desires. We need to adjust according to life situations on many occasions. There may be occasions in life, which involve battles between situational pressures and our self-control. We require will power,

determination and strategic planning to control and regulate our behaviour in accordance to our long-term goals.

There are number of psychological techniques to develop self-control which have been suggested below:

- **Observe your own behaviour.** If you make this a habit, you will notice and gather necessary information about yourself which may help you to alter, adapt, or strengthen certain aspects of your 'self'. You need to be more observant or mindful of your thoughts, feelings and behaviour.
- **Self-instruction** is another essential technique. If you are observant of yourself, you would find that this technique would be more beneficial. Have you noticed the self-talk which is going on in our mind constantly? We all often talk and instruct ourselves to do something and behave the way we want to. Such instructions are quite effective in self-regulation especially when you observe yourself to be thinking or doing something negative or destructive.
- **Self-reinforcement.** This technique involves rewarding behaviours that have positive consequences. For example, you may go to play with friends, if you have finished your assignments. These techniques are quite effective to develop self-regulation and self-control in people. You can try these techniques to make yourself better.

Reflective Activity 4: Go back to your childhood and reflect how many times your parents have asked you to wait before giving you something. The wait could be few minutes to few hours to few days or months, even if they could have given you the things which you asked immediately. Have you wondered why?

Write down two-three such instances which you remember.

Now ponder on the questions:

- Why have they delayed or made you wait?
- What important things it must have taught you?
- Discuss with your friends and write a short note on that.

Self Assessment Questions 3

1. The individual's belief that s/he is capable and can control what happens to her/him is known as _____.
2. According to Rogers, _____ drive all human behaviour to achieve at their fullest level of potentials.
3. Self-regulation refers to our ability to organise and monitor our own behaviour. True/False
4. Self-regulation focuses on the short-term goals than long-term goals. True/False
5. What are the two parts/aspects in self-regulation.

6. Which of the following is NOT the psychological techniques to develop self-control?
- a) Self-observation
 - b) Self-instruction
 - c) Self-reinforcement
 - d) Self-indulgence

8.8 LET US SUM UP

In this unit, you learned about how self is formed, different forms of self and how different cultures influence our self. All human beings strive for betterment, which creates the concept of ideal self, but reality may be very different. The discrepancy between ideal self and the real self can affect an individual negatively. You also learned about the different concepts related to self, such as self-concept, self-esteem, self-efficacy and self-regulation and briefly about how to develop these. Self-concept is an important part of our 'being'. Positive self refers to viewing our own self in a positive way, valuing oneself, believing in oneself, and being able to regulate one's emotions and behaviour to achieve positive outcomes and desired goals. Strategies for developing self-esteem and self-efficacy were described. You also learned about the different psychological techniques to develop self-control behaviour and regulate oneself.

8.9 KEY WORDS

Collectivistic Perspective	: In collectivistic perspective, the self is usually seen as attached with one's own group and both maintain the state of harmonious co-existence.
Congruence	: state of being in which our thoughts about our real and ideal selves are very similar.
Incongruence	: state of being in which there is a great discrepancy between our real and ideal selves.
Self	: Self as a whole is about the person's thoughts, feelings, experiences, and ideas, with respect to herself or himself which define the person at both, the personal and social levels.
Real self	: what we actually are.
Ideal self	: which we would like to be.
Social Self	: is primarily concerned with family and social relationships.
Positive-self	: The positive view about our self which helps us to view the world as a safe and positive place to be in.
Self-concept	: Our perception and ideas about our capabilities and qualities is known as self-concept.
Self-esteem	: The evaluation or the judgment about our self or our own value or worth is termed as self-esteem.

- Self-efficacy** : The individual's belief that s/he is capable and can control what happens to her/him is known as self-efficacy.
- Self-regulation** : refers to our ability to organise and monitor our own behaviour.
- Self-reinforcement** : Rewarding our self for those behaviours that have positive consequences.

8.10 ANSWERS TO SELF ASSESSMENT QUESTIONS

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 1

1. False; 2. True; 3. D. both A and B; 4. C. Static; 5. D. Neill

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 2

1. Carl Rogers, 2. False
3. Match the columns A and B
- (a) (ii), (b) (i), (c) (iv), (d) (v), (e) (iii)

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 3

1. Self-efficacy; 2. Self-actualizing tendencies; 3. True; 4. False; 5. Goal intentions and Implementation intentions; 6. Self-indulgence

8.11 UNIT END QUESTIONS

1. Define self-concept. Differentiate between self-as-subject and self-as-object.
2. Differentiate between individualistic perspective of culture from the collectivistic perspective with examples.
3. Explain the importance of congruence between the ideal self and the real self with examples.
4. Explain the concept of self-efficacy and suggest ways to develop it among children.
5. Define self-regulation and describe different techniques to develop self-control.

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UNIT 9 RESILIENCE*

Structure

- 9.1 Learning Objectives
- 9.2 Introduction
- 9.3 Resilience: Background and Early Research
- 9.4 Four Waves of Resilience Research
- 9.5 Methodological Considerations
- 9.6 Evolution of the Concept of Resilience
- 9.7 Key Concepts in Resilience Research
- 9.8 Theoretical Models of Resilience
- 9.9 Debates and Discussions in Resilience Research
- 9.10 Application of Resilience
- 9.11 Let us Sum Up
- 9.12 Key Words
- 9.13 Answers to Self Assessment Questions
- 9.14 Unit End Questions
- 9.15 References
- 9.16 Suggested Readings

9.1 LEARNING OBJECTIVES

After studying this Unit, you would be able to:

- *Explain the meaning of resilience;*
- *Know about the early research in the field of resilience;*
- *Describe the methodological considerations and the focus of research in resilience;*
- *Explain the key terms in resilience;*
- *Discuss debates and discussions in the field of resilience; and*
- *Describe application of resilience in different areas.*

9.2 INTRODUCTION

Think of people around you who, according to you have led a 'difficult' life. That is, they have faced adverse situations which have threatened their existence, development, or well-being. Such adversities may include natural calamities, unemployment, financial loss, violence, or physical illness. Usually, individuals are not expected to successfully

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recover from these extreme challenges. However, some of us are more likely than others to not only overcome but also thrive in the aftermath of such events.

Besides the examples of adversities cited above, individuals commonly face challenges stemming from novel situations such as the move from school to college or getting promoted at work. These events are not necessarily adverse, however, the transition from a familiar situation to a new one does require some level of resilience for healthy adaptation. If we observe people around, we will notice that some of us handle changes better than others. For instance, students who move to a hostel in a new city for higher education are perhaps moving away from the security and comfort of their homes for the first time. In such situations, some students are able to adapt to their new surroundings better and quicker, as compared to others.

Resilience researchers have defined this phenomenon as the ability to display adaptation despite significant challenges.

Illustrative biography

Srinivasa Ramanujan, the great Indian mathematician faced some initial struggles as a child. After experiencing illness, death of siblings and being moved between his grandparents' and parents' house, he discovered his mathematical abilities at a young age. However, he continued to struggle with ill-health, finances and college education. Despite being hailed as a mathematical genius, he had to leave college without a degree due to his poor interest in non-mathematics subjects. Throughout all these challenges, he continued to pursue his work in mathematics. Finally, he obtained his formal degree from the University of Cambridge. In his brief life while being faced with several challenges, he was able to make significant contributions to the field of mathematics.

9.3 RESILIENCE RESEARCH: BACKGROUND AND EARLY RESEARCH

For many decades, research in psychology was based on a deficit-based approach, that is, it focused on investigating what is wrong with individuals and found ways to fix it. This is akin to the approach of disciplines such as medical science, psychiatry and clinical psychology where professionals detect symptoms and then attempt to alleviate them through medication and/or therapy. Therefore, over time, abundant evidence was gathered on what is wrong and how to fix it. But there was less focus on what is right with individuals, and how to enhance it. Issues like suffering, vulnerability, and symptoms received more attention as compared to other topics such as resilience. This may be attributed to specific events of that period such as the World Wars, which led researchers to prioritize the study of psychological symptoms and disorders over other areas of work. Moreover, psychodynamic approach popularized by pioneers including Sigmund Freud and Alfred Adler had a powerful influence on research and practice in that era. Subsequently, explorations in that period majorly addressed suffering and vulnerability as compared to positive adaptation. This deficit-based approach led to ample studies on children growing up in disadvantaged situations such as poverty and natural calamity who display maladaptive outcomes in adulthood. On the other

hand, research on children from disadvantaged backgrounds who have shown positive outcomes in adulthood, was comparatively less common. This approach also known as the psychopathological approach, continued to dominate psychology research for many decades.

In 1998, when Professor Martin Seligman became the President of the American Psychological Association, he drew attention to the fact that while it is important to study suffering, understanding how people thrive is also imperative (Refer to Unit 1 where you have already studied about the rise of positive psychology). The increasing popularity of the positive psychology movement led by Professor Seligman, encouraged researchers to shift their attention from *why people fail* to *why people succeed*. The idea was to employ a balanced approach that targets alleviation of symptoms along with enhancing strengths.

In longitudinal studies beginning from 1950's, pioneers such as Michael Rutter, Emmy Werner and Ruth Smith focused on studying maladaptive outcomes in children from disadvantaged backgrounds involving parental mental illness, prenatal complications and poverty. To their surprise, they discovered that some children within this cohort, did not display the maladaptive outcomes as expected of them. In fact, their functioning and overall adaptation were almost similar to those who did not face such hardships in early life. These reports indicated that there must be certain factors that protect individuals from the impact of adversities. Following such findings, researchers became interested in discovering what is right with these children, and how this information can be used to help other children growing up with such adversities.

As investigations in the area progressed, researchers were able to identify a list of risk factors and protective processes important in understanding resilience. Early research was largely limited to early life adversities and mostly specific groups like children and adolescents. But over the last few decades, resilience research has expanded to include different age groups, environmental factors, and various adversities including natural calamities, socioeconomic disadvantage, childhood abuse, mental illness, community violence and academic challenges.

Illustrative biography

Sir Charles Spencer Chaplin, actor and filmmaker known for the art of comedy had a very troubled childhood. He elaborates on this in his autobiography, highlighting several tragic incidents that he experienced while growing up including his mother's mental illness, father's absence, and poverty. Usually, children coming from such disadvantaged backgrounds are not expected to display successful outcomes in adulthood. However, Charlie Chaplin, as he came to be known, grew up to establish a prosperous career in films. Even several decades after his death, he continues to be popular for his work which had the ability to entertain audiences worldwide.

9.4 FOUR WAVES OF RESILIENCE RESEARCH

Investigators have suggested that resilience research may be understood to have emerged in four waves. This is elaborated by Wright, Masten and Narayan (2013). The focus of investigation in each of these waves is depicted in Figure 9.1 below.

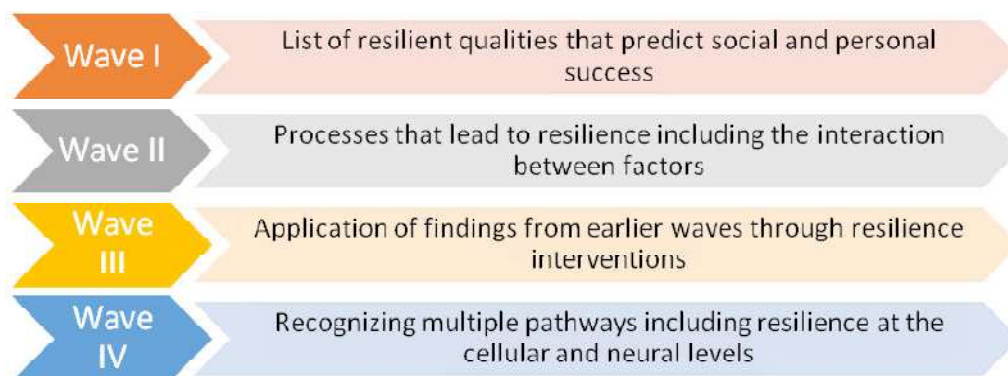


Figure 9.1: The Four Waves of Research in Resilience

The first wave of resilience research identified a list of factors that contributed to competence considered as a marker of resilience. These included factors specific to the individual such as internal locus of control and self-efficacy. The second wave focused on the interaction between the person and the environment in the process of reintegration after disruption. Waves I and II helped to establish descriptions of the phenomenon of resilience, provide clarity to related concepts and explore methodologies. Initially, the primary focus of researchers was on the individual and later it also emphasized on the system.

In the third wave, researchers attempted to understand how resilience may be developed from this interaction. Wave III researchers started exploring the ways in which findings from Waves I and II may be implemented to enhance and promote resilience through resilience interventions. Finally, the fourth wave was directed at understanding resilience at multiple levels involving cellular and neural factors. This also led to a multidisciplinary approach to resilience research involving neuroscience, sociology, social work and related areas.

Activity 1

This is a list of famous personalities and their fields of expertise. These individuals faced difficult circumstances in early life such as poverty, mental illness, childhood abuse, work related challenges, societal stigma and discrimination. Yet they continued to display resilience eventually gaining exemplary achievements in their field of work.

- (a) Fill in the blanks: In the blanks provided, write the names of other individuals who have struggled against all odds to display resilience. You may read their life stories for a better understanding of their resilience.

Viktor Frankl, Martin Seligman, _____	Psychology
Anandi Gopal Joshi, Sigmund Freud, _____	Medicine/Psychiatry
Alexander Graham Bell, APJ Abdul Kalam, _____	Science and Technology
Gayathri Ramprasad, Reshma Valliapan	Mental health advocacy
Milkha Singh, P.T. Usha, _____	Sports
Kailash Satyarthi, Nelson Mandela, _____	Social reform
Dhirubhai Ambani, Steve Jobs, _____	Entrepreneurship

9.5 METHODOLOGICAL CONSIDERATIONS

Resilience research follows both quantitative as well as qualitative approach. Investigators studying resilience must take into consideration situational and participant characteristics in developing the objectives and methodology for their study. The nature of the adversity being studied, sample characteristics, expected and actual outcomes, as well as subjective experiences are crucial features in this regard.

9.5.1 Quantitative approach

For several years, psychologists largely approached resilience research through a quantitative lens. Researchers from various countries have developed several resilience measures specific to their sociocultural contexts and different adversities. Some of the most popularly used resilience measures are displayed in Table 9.1 below.

Table 9.1: List of Commonly Used Resilience Measures

Resilience measures	Author(s)
Connor–Davidson Resilience scale	Connor & Davidson (2003)
Resilience Appraisal Scale	Johnson et al. (2010)
The Brief Resilient Coping Scale	Sinclair & Wallston (2004)
The Brief Resilience Scale	Smith et al. (2008)
The Child and Youth Resilience Measure-28	Resilience Research Centre (2009)
The Resilience Scale	Wagnild & Young (1993)

It may be noted that this is not an exhaustive list. In a comprehensive effort by Gill Windle, Kate M. Bennett and Jane Noyes in 2011, resilience measures that are commonly used in investigations were screened. This quantitative methodological review reported 19 tools. The authors recommended that all these measures require further validation work and that relevant validation statistics of tools to be developed in future, must be reported by authors. Furthermore, they agreed with recommendations by previous researchers that participants' own perceptions must be taken into account while developing tools so that context-specific data can be captured. Similar reviews by future researchers will contribute towards developing an efficient assessment system in resilience.

Quantitative measures are helpful in understanding the statistical relationships between risk factors, resilience, protective factors and adaptation outcomes. Quantitative surveys are also useful when studying resilience in large groups of people.

9.5.2 Qualitative approach

While quantitative methods are useful in the situations mentioned above, they do not provide in-depth information about the personal process of adaptation. Since a major part of the resilience experience is subjective in nature, it is important to employ methods that investigate personal contexts. Thus, qualitative techniques are advantageous in understanding individual differences and unique adaptation strategies in the resilience experience.

A mixed method approach also offer a comprehensive understanding about the whole resilience experience. Further, resilience research benefits from an interdisciplinary approach as it has implications for various disciplines such as social work, education etc. In their investigations on youth across different cultures, Liebenberg and Ungar (2009) used mixed methods approach. These researchers claim that besides individual and environmental factors, larger contexts such as governments and cultures play a crucial role in the individual's process of resilient adaptation. Thus, exploration of cultural and contextual factors is vital in the understanding of resilience.

These recommendations can help future researchers to design their studies carefully. For instance, even if two individuals report the same diagnosis, they should not be expected to display exactly similar outcomes. Outcomes depend on several factors within the context such as precipitating and perpetuating factors, treatment procedures, prognosis, and protective factors. Therefore, acknowledging the sociocultural dynamics in a given situation is of crucial importance in exploring these factors. Techniques such as interviews and focus-group discussions are commonly used to probe into such subjective experiences in resilience.

Arts-based and participatory action research

Besides the familiar techniques presented above, resilience investigators have incorporated arts-based and participatory action techniques in their work on different populations such as teachers, refugee children, and individuals diagnosed with mental illness. In their book, *Youth Resilience and Culture: Commonalities and Complexities*, Theron, Liebenberg, and Ungar (2015) support the use of innovative qualitative research methods and draw attention to the importance of methodological choices.

Some arts-based techniques explored in resilience research include dramatization, drawing, painting, and photography. In participatory action-research, participants are not merely passive observers but also play the role of research partners in the project. Besides unearthing information that are usually not captured through other techniques, arts-based and participatory methods have additional advantages. Through direct involvement in the work, participants have the opportunity of voicing their opinion as well as benefitting from self-appraisal. Self-reflection allows participants to identify and express their emotions and appraise the risk and protective factors in the given context. Participation contributes to resilience through increased awareness and better engagement.

Due to benefits associated with the different methods discussed above, contemporary resilience researchers employ different mediums to collect data for their work. In-depth exploration has led to the revelation of several contextual factors. This will contribute towards the understanding of the complex relationship between resilience, culture and specific contexts.

Research on Resilience in India

The multicultural aspect of the Indian society makes it a fascinating but complex area for resilience research. In India, resilience research gained momentum following the popularity of the positive psychology movement. Researchers have covered diverse populations and adversities in India ranging from large-scale natural calamities to more common occurrences such as mental illness. For instance, Dash, Dayal, and Lakshminarayana (2006) explored resilience in the aftermath of the earthquake in Gujrat and the supercyclone in Orissa respectively. Additionally, Herbert, Manjula, and Philip

(2013) reported protective factors such as social support that contributed to resilience among individuals whose parents had a diagnosis of schizophrenia; whereas Aswini and Deb (2020) described resilient outcomes that are generally not expected from those with mental illness in the given sociocultural context.

Other researchers in India including Dash, Dayal, and Lakshminarayana (2006), Annalakshmi and Abeer (2011) and Singh, Junnarkar, and Kaur (2016) have attempted to develop resilience measures. Findings from Indian studies led to information pertaining to specific features of the collectivistic culture such as familial and societal attachments. These usually operate as protective factors as expected, but certain aspects of these systems can function as risks, for instance high expectation to conform to sociocultural and traditional norms could function as risk factors. This was highlighted by Khan and Deb's (2021) investigation which reported that the family can function both as source of risk and resilience among adults who had experienced childhood adversity. Kapur's (2013) discussion on resilience with reference to the concept of Triguna presented Satva as the essence of resilience. The author further recommended that Satva can be both inherited and developed by the individual to achieve functioning in times of adversity.

Following the COVID-19 pandemic, several investigations have explored the contribution of resilience in the process of adaptation. Of these, a longitudinal study conducted by Gopal, Sharma, and Subramanyam (2020) found that higher levels of resilience and social support was related to lower levels of anxiety, stress, and depressive symptoms. Also, individual resilience was negatively associated with adverse psychological outcomes.

It is expected that future researchers will expand this work to other priority areas such as resilience in the aftermath of the ongoing pandemic and culture-specific determinants in adaptation. This information will help in developing interventions and policies suitable for the Indian contextual and cultural milieu.

Activity 2

- Reflect and list out certain culture-specific determinants in adaptation in the context of India.
- How various religions of India and spiritual approach/practices in India help develop resilience among individuals?

Self Assessment Questions 1

1. Which wave of resilience focused on finding out resilient qualities?
2. Name any one scale on resilience.
3. Which approach dominated the earlier psychological research?

9.6 EVOLUTION OF THE CONCEPT OVER TIME

Resilience, Invincibility and Invulnerability

In the initial years of resilience research mostly focused on children, those who functioned well despite adversity were sometimes described as invulnerable and invincible. Later, researchers suggested that such descriptions may not be accurate as it is realistically

impossible for human beings not to be impacted by events occurring in their life. Transitions do have some bearing on emotions and cognitions and consequently on behaviour. However, terms like invulnerable and invincible give the impression that resilient individuals are unaffected by stressors. This is a flawed assumption and thus the terms invincibility and invulnerability are no longer used synonymously with resilience.

Resilience and Coping

Another term that is sometimes used synonymously with resilience, is coping. Although on the surface it might appear that coping and resilience mean the same, it is not so. The essential difference between coping and resilience as reported in psychology literature is that the idea of coping is largely associated with one's response to negative events such as death of a loved one, conflicts in relationships, financial, professional, or academic setbacks. However, the phenomenon of resilience is not restricted to unfavourable events only. As discussed above, resilience is required to handle all kinds of transitions whether desirable such as getting one's dream job; or undesirable such as being terminated from one's dream job. While resilience is helpful to cope with unfavourable transitional events, it is also important in events that are favourable but challenging; such as being selected as the college representative for an inter-college competition.

The similarity between resilience and coping is that both are involved in adapting to stressful circumstances. However, coping may involve both adaptive and maladaptive processes including dysfunctional outcomes. For instance, a person diagnosed with hypertension may display maladaptive coping through denial of the diagnosis and non-adherence to treatment. From the patient's perspective both maladaptive and adaptive responses are ways of coping. However, while the former leads to management of symptoms, the latter is an impediment to recovery and well-being. In comparison, resilient individuals engage with the situation actively instead of maladaptive coping by avoidance or denial. Therefore, it may be appropriate to posit that resilience develops from exposure to risk and developing strengths to address it; rather than running away from it. In other words, resilience is a form of healthy coping often resulting in learning and growth. Thus, the broad umbrella term coping does not necessarily indicate positive adaptation in the way as resilience does. Therefore, resilience is more than coping.

Resilience and Other Overlapping Concepts

A number of related variables such as post-traumatic growth, positive adaptation, personal growth, and benefit finding are often studied in the aftermath of adversity. However, any positive change following trauma and adversity is not akin to resilience. Resilience is the phenomenon that contributes to these processes and outcomes. It helps to achieve positive outcomes in situations where growth is unexpected. This is the reason investigations have reported associations between resilience and these variables.

Resilience as Bouncing Back and Bouncing Forward

In the initial years of resilience research, resilience was often described as bouncing back from adversity. This phrase indicates that resilient individuals come back to their original or improved levels of functioning after facing disruption caused by the adversity. This flexibility is similar to that of a spring. Even after being stretched or distorted, the property of a spring allows it to continue to function as before, when placed back into a device.

In later years, the concept of bouncing forward instead of bouncing back, was recommended by researchers (e.g., Walsh, 2002). The replacement of *bouncing back* by *bouncing forward* emphasizes that the move is in a positive direction. That is, the resilient individuals move ahead from a position of disadvantage to a position of advantage.

Activity 3

Pens with click mechanisms have a spring in the shaft that plays a crucial role in their operation. Despite regular use and sometimes even rough use, the spring continues to perform the function that it is supposed to. Springs thus possess the ability to absorb a reasonable amount of stress without breaking. In physical sciences, a spring is often cited as an example of a resilient or flexible object. Some items we encounter in our daily life are mentioned below. Which of these items would you treat as fragile and which as comparatively flexible?

- Rubber band, glassware, steel ware, mirror, iron picture frame, elastic headband, soap bubbles

Fragile: _____

Comparatively flexible or resilient: _____

Resilience as a Trait, Process, Skill and an Outcome

Resilience as a trait: Findings show that in the initial years, resilience was studied as a trait. It was perceived as an attribute that can lead to positive adaptation outcomes such as well-being or post-traumatic growth. Research studying resilience as a trait sought to link its contribution to other variables. Resilience as a trait was found to contribute to positive adaptation outcomes such as personal growth.

Resilience as a process: As research progressed, investigators claimed that resilience is also a process as it involves a journey of towards a positive adaptation outcome. For instance, the process of resilience involves negotiations with several protective factors. These may include both internal strengths such as self-efficacy and autonomy; and external protective factors such as close friendships and supportive communities.

Resilience as a skill: In recent times, researchers have suggested that resilience is, at least partially, a skill. Like other broad skills such as effective communication or specific skills such as art or music, resilience can be learned and cultivated further. For example, just as regular practice can help a singer to refine their musical abilities, engaging with challenging situations can help individuals discover and hone their protective mechanisms. Resilience, as a skill can be developed through interventions such as therapy.

Resilience as an outcome: Several research investigations have pursued the topic of resilience as an outcome in the aftermath of adversities. Resilient outcomes such as post-traumatic growth, benefit finding, and well-being are indicators of positive adaptation. Researchers studying resilience as an outcome have sought to explore both internal and external protective factors that contribute to resilient outcomes. In the early years of resilience research, most researchers sought to use psychosocial competence as the indicator of resilience. For instance, the ability to fulfil age-appropriate developmental tasks in a given cultural context was selected as a resilient outcome.

Additionally, healthy peer relationships and successful academic outcomes were characterized as resilient outcomes among children and adolescents.

9.7 KEY CONCEPTS IN RESILIENCE RESEARCH

Decades of resilience research have led to the identification of certain keywords. Wright, Masten, and Narayan (2013) have elaborated upon the most relevant terms in this area. A description of some of these keywords are presented below with suitable examples.

- **Resilience**

Resilience is described as positive adaptation in response to adversity. Positive adaptation outcomes such as recovery, well-being and post-traumatic growth may be observed among individuals with high levels of resilience.

Example: Survivors of natural calamities such as an earthquake are likely to face serious setbacks in several life domains following the event. Social and occupational functioning as well as mental health may be impacted due to severe adversities. Individuals' journey from these disruptions to a life of functioning and growth is indicative of their resilience.

- **Adversity**

Adversities refer to any experiences that disrupt the regular course of development of a system or an individual. Adverse events disturb the individual's homeostasis eventually impacting functioning.

Example: Adversities can include events that cause large-scale destruction such as war, political conflict, and natural calamity. It can also refer to individual-specific circumstances such as loss of employment, financial crisis or symptoms of chronic illness. Presence of significant adversity is regarded as one of the essential criteria for the identification of resilience.

- **Risk**

A risk indicates high possibility of an unfavourable outcome. In a given situation, risk factors are those features which can predict this negative outcome.

Example: The chance of an infant developing malnutrition is higher if born into circumstances such as poverty. Additional risk factors within the same situation include premature birth, congenital disorders, and parental negligence. Likewise, a weak immune system is a risk factor during a viral outbreak. Research has shown that for individuals recovering from mental illness, lack of support from family and community is a major risk factor.

- **Cumulative risk**

Any risk factor may be a deterrent to healthy adaptation. However, the presence of several risk factors leads to increased likelihood of unfavorable outcomes. Likewise, repeated occurrences of the same risk factor are likely to amplify its impact.

Example: Children growing up in poverty are likely to be subjected to several environmental stressors. The lack of access to facilities such as safe shelter,

healthcare, and schooling are crucial risk factors that hinder healthy development. The presence of any one of these risk factors is damaging; however, the presence of all these factors suggests cumulative risk.

Likewise, physical and emotional abuse by family members on one occasion is a risk factor. However, repeated occurrences of such abuse, intensifies its impact. These examples represent cumulative risk, which is far more impactful than that of isolated events.

Quick check 1:

1. What are the possible cumulative risks associated with the following situations?
 - (a) Child abuse: _____
 - (b) Chronic physical illness: _____
 - (c) Mental illness: _____
2. Indicate whether the following statements are **True** or **False**.
 - (a) Family history of illness does not pose any health risks for an individual.
 - (b) Repeated instances of financial loss are likely to have a more serious impact on an entrepreneur than experiencing one financial setback.
 - (c) For a person who is temperamentally anxious, new situations may act as risk factors in adaptation.

- **Proximal risk**

Proximal risk includes all risk factors which are experienced directly by the individual. This may be understood in the light of Urie Bronfenbrenner's Ecological Systems theory. According to this framework, the microsystem refers to the immediate environment. Proximal risk factors are usually present in the microsystem.

Example: Family conflict is a proximal risk as the outcome of this adversity directly impacts the person living in the same household. Similarly, poor doctor-patient communication is a proximal risk as it directly impacts the doctor-patient relationship as well as treatment.

- **Distal risk**

Risk factors present within the environment but not within the immediate surroundings are known as distal risks. These factors impact the person indirectly through other factors. With reference to Urie Bronfenbrenner's Ecological Systems theory, distal risk factors may be present in extended circles such as the macrosystem.

Example: Conflicts within the extended family or community do not impact the individual as directly as conflicts within the immediate family. However, the former situations do have the potential to threaten the individual's development or adaptation in an indirect manner.

Quick check 2:

Categorize the following into proximal and distal risks:

- Lack of parental involvement in child's school work, community violence, inadequate nutrition, political unrest

Proximal risks: _____

Distal risks: _____

- **Protective factor**

While risks are detrimental to development and adaptation, protective factors buffer the impact of adversities. Early resilience researchers identified that the presence of protective factors indicate that the individual will display resilient outcomes when faced with adverse circumstances. Protective factors may be internal or external. Internal protective factors refer to strengths within the individual including self-esteem, self-efficacy, or internal locus of control. External protective factors include resources such as supportive relationships within the family and community.

Example of internal protective factors: Personality traits such as conscientiousness may be a protective factor in academic resilience. In relationship conflicts, skills pertaining to problem-solving, communication, and negotiation play a protective role in helping the individual navigate through the situation.

Example of external protective factors: In India, helpline numbers such as 100 for police and 101 for fire brigade are external protective factors. Retirement pensions for senior citizens and scholarships for students may be regarded as resources that help them to adapt to both regular and unanticipated stressors. Besides family and friends, community and peer groups, hospitals and non-government organizations are important sources of external support.

- **Cumulative protection**

Research indicates that the presence of several protective factors is more useful in building resilience as compared to a few protective factors.

Example: A student who has achieved poor academic grades will benefit if she has access to supportive parents, classmates, and teachers. The combined contribution of these protective factors is likely to make a stronger impact than the presence of only one protective factor. Individuals will experience higher levels of resilience if they have both internal and external resources to tackle challenges, as compared to those who lack support from family, colleagues and friends.

Self Assessment Questions 2

1. Resilience is synonymous to invincibility. True / False.
2. What is resilience?
3. What is distal risk?
4. Explain cumulative protection.

Activity 4

Protective Factors in Resilience: Individual, Family, and Community

- A summary of internal and external protective factors commonly reported by research studies on resilience is presented below.
- Think of a personal situation that had seemed very challenging to you initially. But you were able to adapt to the change brought about by this event. Write down the internal strengths and external protective factors that helped you to overcome this adversity, in the blank rows in the box below or tick mark the ones you can relate to.

Internal Protective Factors	External Protective Factors	
Individual	Family	Community
Self-esteem	Stable home environment	Access to basic facilities such as clean air, water
Self-efficacy	Secure attachment with primary caregivers	Affordable education, compassionate teachers recreational activities
Internal locus of control	Positive sibling relationships	Safe community
Problem solving skills	Supportive connections with family members	Employment opportunities
Ability to build and maintain relationships	Socioeconomic advantages	Access to health care, legal and welfare services
Hope	Parental resilience	Supportive policies in the area of education, law and health

9.8 THEORETICAL MODELS OF RESILIENCE

Resilience has been explained with the help of several theoretical models. Unlike psychopathological models, these frameworks expect the individual to succeed and even thrive despite the presence of adversity. The following resilience models focus on internal strengths and the protective resources in their environment.

Grotberg's Paradigm of Resilience(1999) was constructed with the aim of enhancing strengths to deal with adversities that typically tend to result in depression among the

youth. This model uses three components namely *I have*, *I am*, and *I can* to present five blocks of resilience. *I have* includes trusting relationships that provide support. *I am* refers to the building blocks of autonomy and identity which contribute towards building internal protective factors such as responsibility and self-esteem. *I can* refers to the building blocks of initiative and industry which contribute towards building skills such as interpersonal and problem solving skills. Figure 9.2 below displays the three components of resilience, building blocks and their description as presented by Grotberg (1999). Grotberg (1999) recommends that these building blocks can assist in facing, overcoming, being strengthened, or transformed by adversity.

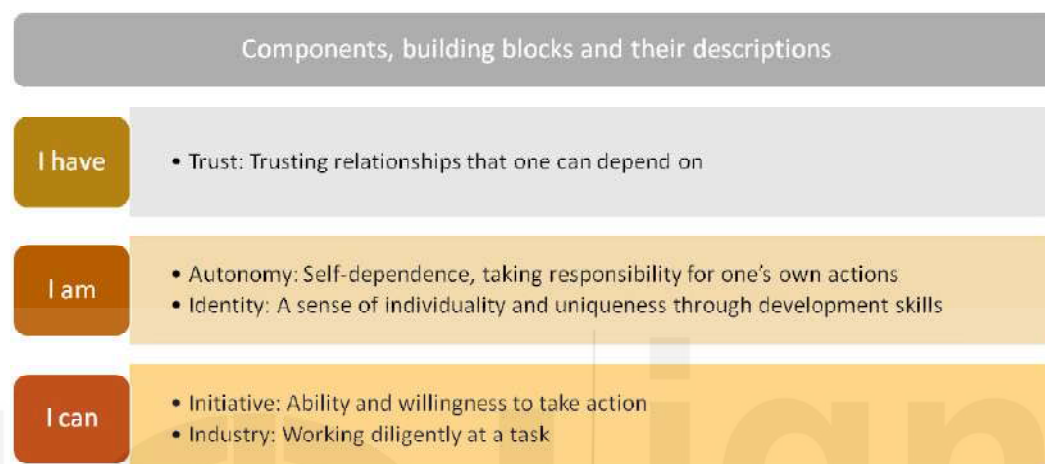


Figure 9.2: Grotberg's (1999) Paradigm of Resilience

Other resilience models such as those proposed by Kumpfer (1999) and Richardson (2002) illustrate individuals' journeys from being faced with disruptions to displaying resilient reintegration. In 2020, Ungar and Theron presented a dynamic multisystemic model of resilience. This model acknowledges the role of biopsychosocial ecological systems in resilience. It proposes that addressing cultural and contextual processes ranging from rituals to community activities is important in resilience research.

These models have been widely used by researchers in designing their research, interpretation of data and application of findings.

9.9 DEBATES AND DISCUSSIONS IN RESILIENCE RESEARCH

Findings from Wave I, II, and III of resilience have led to several pertinent questions. The debates that followed helped to clarify the concepts further. Some crucial discussions in this regard are presented below.

9.9.1 Criteria for defining resilience

Researchers have unanimously agreed that the judgement of resilience must involve two conditions:

- Presence of a significant adversity
- Display of positive adaptation despite the adversity

Unless the individual reports significant stressors in the situation, the phenomenon of resilience is not applicable. If an individual displays positive adaptation under any other

circumstances, they are usually described as competent or well-adjusted; but not as resilient. The term resilience is used only when the event has been severe enough to cause significant threat to adaptation or development.

9.9.2 Resilient individuals also experience trauma and vulnerability

Resilient individuals are not unaffected by trauma. This is the reason terms like invincibility and invulnerability are no longer used to describe resilient individuals as we have learned earlier in this Unit. Resilient individuals experience emotions such as anger, fear, and helplessness but over time, they are able to discover their protective factors and use them successfully in adapting to the event.

The unpredictability of life in general and uncertainties in day-to-day experiences expose us to vulnerable circumstances. Thus, distress and discomfort are expected responses. Resilient individuals are not invincible or unaffected by vulnerability. The journey from this state of trauma and vulnerability to positive adaptation is representative of resilience.

9.9.3 Resilience is domain-specific

Researchers have pointed out that resilience is domain specific. Thus, it is possible to display positive adaptation in one area of life while experiencing vulnerability in another domain. Some individuals who display excellence in their professional or academic lives, experience anxiety in trying to maintain their success. Such domain specificity is observed in case of other psychological concepts, such as locus of control wherein an individual may be internally controlled in the social domain and externally controlled in the domain of health.

Despite the domain specificity of resilience, there is indication that success or failure in one domain can impact adaptation in another domain. In certain conditions, protective factors that have led to success in one domain can be used to improve circumstances in another domain. For instance, if family support has helped students to achieve resilient outcomes in academics, it may also be utilized to achieve resilient outcomes in the social domain.

9.9.4 The dangers of apparent resilience

The assumption that resilience in one domain is evidence for resilience in another domain is faulty and could have serious mental health implications. In the 1990's research by Suniya Luthar, a pioneer in this field, found that some resilient inner-city adolescents displayed high social competence under conditions of high stress. When probed further, the researchers discovered that they were not doing as well in the mental health domain. In fact, these adolescents were significantly more depressed than highly competent adolescents from low-stress backgrounds. Luthar termed this as 'apparent resilience' indicating that there is a tendency for some individuals to internalize symptoms. This gives the impression that they are highly resilient when in reality, they may be experiencing serious mental health concerns. Researchers have reported that if internalized symptoms are ignored, they are likely to lead to greater distress over a period of time. Therefore, researchers and practitioners must be cautious in making conclusions on overall resilience based on adaptation in one domain. Resilience can be displayed in one or several domains, however, the idea of absolute resilience is problematic.

9.9.5 Resilience varies over time

In consideration of the Developmental task theory which suggests that adaptation is an evolving process, it is gathered that resilience is variable in different circumstances and through different periods in life. As we journey through life, we are faced with a range of situations comprising of a variety of risk and protective factors. These constantly changing situations can either have a beneficial or detrimental impact on resilience. Also, sociodemographic factors such as age play a role in the process. For example, infants are protected from several environmental calamities by their caregivers. They step in immediately to fulfil any demands created by tragedies such as death of a family member. Moreover, the inability to grasp the anticipated consequences of these events protect infants from emotional pain. But for older children and adolescents, the understanding of the severity of the situation increases their distress. At the same time, the ability to communicate with others and seek support helps older children to independently take actions towards positive adaptation. This shows that, with age, our exposure to adversities increases but cognitive and emotional maturity also places us in a better position to display resilience.

If certain life events restrict our access to protective factors, a highly resilient individual can become less resilient. Losing employment can limit positive experiences in the domain of mental health, finance and even relationships. Protective factors associated with employment such as self confidence and financial stability may be lost following unemployment. This is likely to have a detrimental impact on resilience. In certain societies, strong stigma surrounding mental illness may lead to prejudice and discrimination even from family members. In such cases, decrease in external support can transform a person from a highly resilient person to a vulnerable one.

9.9.6 Resilience as ‘ordinary magic’

Resilience is described as an experience that is ordinary but magical. Ann Masten, a pioneer in this field has often referred to the ordinariness of resilience in her work. She posits that resilience is an ordinary, rather than an extraordinary phenomenon. This indicates that it is possible for all to experience it. Despite the ordinariness of the phenomenon, the outcome is perceived as magical. This is because resilience makes it possible for individuals to succeed in circumstances where they are usually expected to fail. Masten’s (2001) observation on the ordinariness of resilience provides hope to at-risk populations. It is now believed that with the help of protective factors, individuals can discover resilience and display positive adaptation amidst challenges.

9.9.7 Multisystemic resilience

Researchers from various disciplines, besides psychology have acknowledged the interaction of multiple systems in resilience. Urie Bronfenbrenner’s Ecological Systems theory is often cited in this context. For a complete understanding of resilience, it is crucial to refer to the complex interactions between multiple systems. Even in cases where individual factors are generally implicated, such as poor performance in school, researchers and practioners must probe into multisystemic factors to determine the nature of intervention. Academic resilience can be more effectively addressed if multiple systems such as family and school are involved instead of simply working on improving the child’s academic efforts. This is true for other adversities ranging from domestic violence, physical illness to mental illness. Survivors, in such cases not only need to find and enhance internal protective factors in their lives but also need to be provided with a safe and inclusive atmosphere where they feel reassured.

In case of some challenges, individuals are able to survive with the help of internal protective factors alone, however, the journey is less overwhelming if there is support from the environment as well. For instance, individuals with an illness may put great efforts into their recovery by displaying adherence to prescribed medication and treatment protocols but the rehabilitation process is boosted when the patient receives structural and emotional support from medical professionals, family, workplace and friends. The onus of resilient adaptation should not be placed on the individual if the socioecological environment is not supportive.

This multisystemic conceptualization of resilience is important from the point of interventions. In his book on multisystemic resilience, Michael Ungar cites evidences from investigations that integrate contexts including cultural practices into interventions.

In view of the above discussion, it is clear that the concept of resilience is not easy to define. Resilience researchers therefore must consider a number of factors in operationally defining the concept for their investigations.

9.10 APPLICATION OF RESILIENCE

Applications of findings from resilience research have helped to improve several favourable outcomes such as mental health and well-being.

Interventions: With progress in understanding and identifying resilience, researchers developed interest in enhancing it. Wave III researchers started applying the findings obtained to promote resilient adaptation among vulnerable populations. While most of the initial interventions were directed at children and adolescents, the initiatives now include a variety of samples worldwide including indigenous populations.

Some interventions were directed at reducing risk factors while the others attempted to enhance protective factors. At times, detachment from a hostile environment protects the individual from future harm. This was displayed in previous studies on familial abuse where individuals were able to achieve positive outcomes by distancing themselves from their abusive family. In some cases, however, it is not possible to disconnect from the risk factors entirely as in situations of bereavement. Developing resilience in experiences such as death of a loved one usually involve a combination of internal and external protective factors that buffer the impact of the event. Interventions should enhance resources as well as the skills required to access them.

Public participation: As of now, public engagement in resilience work is confined to certain areas only. This is identified by Raanaas, Bjøntegaard, and Shaw's (2020) scoping review and Shadowen, Guerra, Beveridge and McCoy's (2020) work in rural India on participatory action research. The findings available confirm that this is beneficial as it allows participants' voices to be heard. Participants make decisions pertaining to the research including objectives, methodology, and outcomes, and work with the researchers as collaborators, not as passive viewers. Participatory methods work well when the objective is to bring about changes in sociocultural and community contexts. The participation of stakeholders from different areas including academicians, community members and policymakers are useful in addressing such concerns as all perspectives can be integrated into the work. This process of bringing together different participants is challenging. However, it has a more wide-reaching impact as compared to studies with a singular focus on individual resilience. In highlighting the advantages of public

participation methods, Sanders and Munford (2009) observed that these projects mostly employed at the group or community typically involve community development.

Interventions and public participation may be applied to different adversities and across populations, covering a variety of sociodemographic and socioecological contexts. Besides, ecological data from multisystemic resilience investigations have valuable implications in policies pertaining to education, clinical and therapeutic settings, community and mental health.

Finally, the study of resilience testifies that human beings have the capacity for surviving against all odds. One can not only overcome challenges but even thrive despite uncertainties and vulnerabilities. It is therefore crucial to identify the protective factors that can contribute to the process in different cultures and contexts. Thus resilience is a universal phenomenon and awareness and promotion initiatives can contribute towards building personal and systemic resilience across contexts.

Self Assessment Questions 3

1. What is domain-specific resilience?
2. Who termed resilience as ‘ordinary magic’?
3. What are the criteria for defining resilience?
4. Explain public participation in resilience research.

9.11 LET US SUM UP

Resilience is crucial in the process of adapting to various transitions and challenges of life. Researchers have presented several concepts which are important in understanding resilience. These include risk factors, protective factors, cumulative risk, cumulative protection among other key terms related to resilience. An overview of the four waves of resilience research illustrates that resilience has been variously presented as a trait, process, skill and an outcome. While much of the initial research focused on the individual and their immediate environment, research has expanded to include multiple systems in resilience. Larger contexts such as society and culture and their interaction with other factors are particularly important in a comprehensive understanding of resilience. A mix of quantitative and qualitative techniques including participatory and arts-based methods are increasingly being used to capture subjective experiences of individuals. Research on resilience aims to enhance resilience in everyday lives as well as in the aftermath of adversities ranging from natural calamity to relationship conflicts. This goal may be fulfilled through interventions, public participation and policy changes. In conclusion, resilience is a universal phenomenon and awareness and promotion initiatives can contribute towards building personal and systemic resilience across contexts.

9.12 KEY WORDS

- Resilience** : Displaying positive adaptation despite significant adversity
- Adversity** : Events that interrupt the regular course of development of a system or an individual. These challenges disrupt homeostasis, eventually impacting functioning.

Risk factors	: Those features in a given situation that predict high possibility of unfavourable outcomes.
Protective factors	: Factors that help individuals to display resilient outcomes when faced with adverse circumstances
Cumulative risk	: Presence of several risk factors leads to increased likelihood of unfavorable outcomes. Likewise, repeated occurrences of the same risk factor are likely to amplify its impact.
Cumulative protection	: Presence of several protective factors is more useful in building resilience as compared to a few protective factors.
Apparent resilience	: The tendency of some individuals to internalize mental health symptoms while displaying competence in other domains. This gives the impression that the person is resilient when actually they may not be.
Multisystemic resilience	: The idea that multiple systems are involved in the process of resilience. This approach allows researchers to look beyond individual factors into biopsychosocial ecological contexts.
Resilience interventions	: Initiatives that seek to enhance resilience by addressing risk and protective factors
Ordinary magic	: A way of referring to resilience indicating that while the outcome is magical or unexpected, the phenomenon is universal.

9.13 ANSWERS TO SELF ASSESSMENT QUESTIONS

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 1

1. First wave
2. Connor–Davidson Resilience scale (Connor & Davidson, 2003)
3. psychopathological approach

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 2

1. False
2. Resilience is described as positive adaptation in response to adversity.
3. Cumulative protection refers to combined contribution of several protective factors in building resilience
4. Risk factors present within the environment but not within the immediate surroundings are known as distal risks.

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 3

1. Domain specific resilience refers to that, it is possible to display positive adaptation in one area of life while experiencing vulnerability in another domain.
2. Ann Masten

3. Presence of a significant adversity; and display of positive adaptation despite the adversity.
4. Public participation refers to participants making decisions pertaining to the research including objectives, methodology, and outcomes, and work with the researchers as collaborators, not as passive viewers.

Activity 1 Answer:

Abraham Maslow, Erik Erikson	Psychology
Elisabeth Kübler-Ross, Kadambini Ganguly	Medicine/psychiatry
Nikola Tesla, SundarPichai	Science/ Technology
Deepika Kumari , Mary Kom	Sports
Mahatma Gandhi, Ruth Bader Ginsberg	Social reform
Steve Jobs, SundarPichai	Technology
Chinu Kala, Madam C.J. Walker	<i>Entrepreneurship</i>

Activity 3 Answer:

Fragile: glassware, mirror, soap bubbles

Comparatively flexible or resilient: rubber band, steel ware, iron picture frame, elastic headband

Quick check 1 Answer:

1. Cumulative risks associated with,
 - (a) Child abuse: poor parenting, lack of access to law, absence of childcare protection services
 - (b) Chronic physical illness: irregular sleep, nutrition, poor adherence to medication
 - (c) Mental illness: low mental health literacy, fear of stigma, poor family and medical support
2. True or False,
 - (a) Family history of illness does not pose any health risks for an individual: False
 - (b) Repeated instances of financial loss are likely to have a more serious impact on an entrepreneur than experiencing one financial setback: True
 - (c) For a person who is temperamentally anxious, new situations may act as risk factors in adaptation: True

Quick check 2 Answer:

- Proximal risks: lack of parental involvement in the child's schoolwork, inadequate nutrition
- Distal risks: community violence, political unrest

9.14 UNIT END QUESTIONS

1. Describe risk and protective factors in resilience.
2. Why is resilience described as ‘domain-specific’? Illustrate with the help of an example.
3. Do you agree that resilience is ‘ordinary magic’? Provide examples in support of your answer.
4. Cite an example of apparent resilience that you might have observed in your life or in people around you.
5. Why do researchers recommend the use of mixed methods in studying resilience?
6. If you are asked to develop a resilience intervention on college students in India, which risk and protective factors will you focus on?
7. Provide a description of some of the multiple systems and protective factors that can contribute to resilience among individuals diagnosed with a chronic physical illness.

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UNIT 10 OPTIMISM AND HOPE*

Structure

- 10.1 Learning Objectives
- 10.2 Introduction
- 10.3 Optimism
 - 10.3.1 Dispositional Optimism
 - 10.3.2 Learned Optimism
 - 10.3.3 Unrealistic Optimism
- 10.4 Development of Optimism
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- 10.6 Risks Associated with Optimism
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- 10.12 Let Us Sum Up
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- 10.17 References
- 10.18 Suggested Readings

10.1 LEARNING OBJECTIVES

After studying this Unit, you would be able to:

- *Explain the meaning of optimism and describe its different types;*
- *Describe the benefits of optimism;*
- *Define hope and describe the benefits of hope; and*
- *Discuss the measurement of hope.*

10.2 INTRODUCTION

Sudha is doing her graduation and wants to get into a decent job after completion of her graduation degree. What makes the case of Sudha unique is that she comes from a family where she is the first girl to study upto graduation level. In her

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community, girls are not allowed to study and do jobs to earn money. However, Sudha despite her hard situation since the beginning of her education, looks forward to completing her graduation and join a good job to be financially independent.

To achieve her dreams, she takes determined steps and follows a charted out path to achieve what she has thought out for her life.

The above case provides an example of optimism and hope in Sudha. Optimism and hope are two vital elements for maintaining positive mental health. Positive mental health is a key to happiness and satisfaction in life. It is state of wellness where individuals can function fully and deal effectively with the challenges of life. Hope and optimism both may seem to be very similar and overlapping constructs, based upon positive future expectancies; however, there are differences in how they have been conceptualized by theorists. In this Unit, you will learn about these two positive constructs in detail.

10.3 OPTIMISM

Optimism is a cognitive expectancy for desirable events or things to happen in future. On the other hand, pessimism denotes expectancy for undesirable outcomes to happen. Optimism is also characterized as a disposition or trait, which people are endowed with in varying degrees. It is considered to be a relatively stable and enduring trait, which guides how people perceive and address particular situations.

The early understanding and usage of the term was either neutral or negative, as evident from the works of eminent philosophers and psychologists like Descartes, Freud, Hegel, and Nietzsche (Domino & Conway, 2001). This was because of dominant negative outlook towards human nature in the field of psychology at that time. With advancements in research in psychology and dominance of humanistic school of thought towards the end of twentieth century, there was a change in perspective towards the concept of optimism.

Based on contemporary research, there are two dominant approaches and theoretical models to optimism: Dispositional Optimism Model by Scheier and Carver (1985) and Optimism as an Explanatory Style by Seligman (1990).

10.3.1 Dispositional Optimism

Scheier and Carver first discussed the concept of optimism in their theory of self-regulation, where it was conceptualized to be a personality dimension. Later they coined the term 'dispositional optimism'. They defined it as 'the extent to which people differ in regard to having expectancies of favorable outcomes in their future' (Carver et al., 2010). The model proposed by Scheier and Carver is considered to be the most popular model of optimism, and has relatively stronger construct validity evidence (Bryant & Cvengros, 2004).

The definition highlights optimism as a general expectancy and does not relate it to any specific context (Carver et al., 2010; Scheier & Carver, 1985). Being a personality dimension, it differentiates between optimists and pessimists, where optimists are people who have an orientation towards having positive expectations and predictions about their life in general, as compared to pessimists who have a tendency to expect negative future outcomes in life (Carver et al., 2010). They argued that optimists would have

much stronger valued goals, and a higher persistence to pursue those goals in the face of difficulties using effective coping mechanisms leading to a higher likelihood of them achieving their goals (Scheier, Carver and Bridges, 2000). In contrast, pessimists being more doubtful and hesitant, have more negative affect. Scheier and Carver believed it to be a relatively stable and fixed dimension of personality.

Many research studies supported this stability dimension of optimism, although it was lower in value than other personality traits (Carver et al., 2010). However some studies have found the optimism trait to be changeable over time to some extent. The results of Segestrom (2007) longitudinal study over ten years showed shifts in optimism of participants over the course of study. This and some other researches also (Feldman et al, 2015) point towards the changes over time in optimism, and how it can be enhanced with interventions.

Scheier and Carver (1994) constructed the **Life Orientation Test (LOT)** to measure the concept of dispositional optimism. LOT measures optimism as a personality trait. It was intended to evaluate the individual differences which exist related to positive expectancies about the probability of occurrence of positive events in general. The revised form consists of four-point rating scale on 10 self-reported statements. Three questions among them measure optimism, three questions measure Pessimism, and four are fillers. Thus the statements assess the possibility of good or bad outcomes in life resulting in a total score based on direct or inverse relationship.

10.3.2 Learned Optimism

The other perspective in the conceptualization and measurement of optimism is 'Optimism as an explanatory style' or Learned optimism model by Martin Seligman. The theory of optimism as an explanatory style derives from theory of attribution and theory of learned helplessness (Seligman, 1990). Explanatory style is defined as the manner in which an individual explains the events of his/her life, making attributions for their causes. Attributions can be made on the three dimensions: internality/externality, unstability/stability and specificity/globality (Weiner, 1985). Internality/externality dimension refers to individuals' tendency to ascribe either internal (self, dispositional) or external (people or situational) reasons while explaining their life events. Stability denotes causes that are fixed and stable over time, while unstable causes are variable and do not remain same over time and context. Globality refers to propensity to generalize the causes to all situations, or causes are specific to situations.

Learned helplessness is a feeling resulting from inability to escape from obnoxious or painful stimuli. The model of learned helplessness attempted to explain the phenomena of depression. Abramson and colleagues (1978) realized the capability of certain attributions to explain the learned helplessness. They found that learned helplessness can be a result of attributing *internal* ('it was due to my carelessness'), *stable* (I will be like this forever) and *global* ('my carelessness will spoil everything I will do') causes to negative life events. Taking it forward, Seligman coined the term '**Learned Optimism**' to describe the tendency of ascribing *external* ('I met with an accident because of faulty traffic signal'), *unstable* ('It does not happen all the time to me'), and *specific* ('I didn't notice the faulty signal, otherwise I am observant') causes to negative life events. Optimists thus are not too disturbed by the setbacks or negative life events; they see these events as occasions for learning and hope for better outcomes in future.

Seligman (2003) pointed out that the essential difference between the optimist and the pessimistic explanatory style was the differential appraisal of the reasons for success

and failure; the prevalence of good and bad events and capability to sustain hope. Explanatory style is modifiable according to Seligman, and can be transformed from pessimistic to optimistic style (Seligman, 2013).

Peterson et. al. (1982) developed the Attributional Style Questionnaire (ASQ) to measure learned optimism. It is a self-report measure which assesses people's tendency for learned helplessness or optimism. It does so with the help of 12 hypothetical situations, which are balanced with respect to good and bad outcomes. For each situation the respondents are expected to write one main cause. Thereafter they rate the cause from 1-7 across three attribution dimensions. The scores are summed across good and bad situations. Peterson and colleagues (1987) gave support for the internal consistency and temporal stability, reliability and demonstrated evidence for the predictive validity of the ASQ for depressive symptoms. In addition, Seligman developed a children's version of the ASQ (Seligman et al., 1984; Seligman, 1998). Another tool to assess optimism as explanatory style is Content Analysis of Verbal Explanations (CAVE) (Peterson et. al., 1992).

10.3.3 Unrealistic Optimism

There can be a tendency of attribution which can entail holding particular perceptions and self-evaluations that are unduly positive, too exaggerated to be called objective or fair. This perception of self or others is called unrealistic optimism; this might appear impractical but can serve the purpose of calming people when worried and doubtful in challenging situations, and can aid them in persisting towards their goals.

Unrealistic optimism can be defined as a general propensity to anticipate a higher probability of positive events to happen to self, and a greater likelihood of negative events occurring to others (Weinstein, 1980). The concept is similar to what is called 'Positive illusions' (Taylor and Brown, 1988, 1994) which is common among so called mentally healthy, happy, and well-adjusted people. Positive illusions consist of an over exaggerated assessment of one's abilities, an amplified sense of control and unrealistic optimism about future. People with unrealistic optimism are less likely to think about the possible risks or hazards involved in a problem situation, and visualize themselves in situations where they are successfully dealing with the challenge.

Other than the above mentioned concepts, literature also cites many related constructs like unrealistic pessimism (Heine, & Lehman, 1995), defensive pessimism, selective attention, self-deception, and strategic optimism (Norem, & Cantor, 1986).

Self Assessment Questions 1

1. _____ optimism considers optimism as a personality dimension.
2. Optimism as an explanatory style is also known as _____ optimism.
3. Learned optimism model is given by _____.
4. What are the three dimensions in which people usually make attributions?

10.4 DEVELOPMENT OF OPTIMISM

The presence of optimism as a disposition or explanatory style is dependent on number of factors, the most important being parental socialization. Parents play a very important

role in development of optimism through role modelling and reinforcement of optimistic behaviors (Abramson et al. 2000). Parental mental health is a determining factor and it has been shown that there are higher chances for optimists to belong to families in which none of the parents are suffering from depression. Optimists are more likely to come from families where parents use optimistic explanatory style and are good role models in that. Children who belong to families that have witnessed many traumas and struggles, display optimism when their families show resilience and healthy coping strategies. This is because parents in such situations encourage children to cope with stressors and challenges in a positive way and reinforce optimistic behaviors and perseverance.

On the other hand pessimists are believed to come from those households where either parents are complaining, use self-criticism or criticism of child, are depressed or use a pessimistic explanatory style. Inattention to child, child abuse and rejection are other factors which can lead to a development of pessimistic explanatory style (Carr, 2004).

10.5 BENEFITS OF OPTIMISM

Optimism has many useful consequences for people ranging from mental health, healthy psychological functioning, performance to effects of aging etc. (Rudhig, Perry, Hall, & Hladkyj, 2004). The topic of optimism has gained a lot of popularity among researchers since the last two decades because of these affirmative outcomes. Research indicates that people having positive beliefs about (i) their capabilities to achieve desired goals, (ii) a positive perception of their personal attributes and (iii) their future, perform better than those who are pessimistic or doubtful (Brown & Marshall, 2001).

(a) *Optimism and Academic Performance*

A number of studies have been conducted to understand the relationship of optimism with student's academic performance. The effect of expectancies on task performance among undergraduate students was studied by Brown and Marshall (2001) in the lab setting. They found that under difficult task condition, students having high or moderately high expectancies for task performance performed better academically in comparison to those who had low expectancies. Another study by Pajares (2001) on a group of middle school students tried to find if there was any correlation between positive psychological attributes including optimism and academic achievement. The data pointed out that there was a significant relationship between optimism, motivation and academic achievement in terms of GPA. Based on the findings he suggested that it's important to develop those personality traits that have positive effects on human performance.

In another study, Solberg Nes, Evans, and Segerstrom (2009) investigated the effects of optimistic orientation on the rate of college retention in undergraduate college beginners. Their findings revealed optimism was a favorable personality dimension that influenced the motivation and adjustment of students, thereby playing an important role in retention of college freshers in their first years.

(b) *Optimism, Physical Health and Well-being*

There is plethora of researches that support the positive contribution of optimism in enhancing the well-being and health of individuals. There is a strong evidence to

support the claim that optimists are healthier than pessimists (e.g., Carver et al., 2010; Gallagher & Lopez, 2009; Rasmussen, Scheier, & Greenhouse, 2009). The likelihood of a strong link between optimism and health is plausible and can be explained by the self-regulation model, which proposes optimists are likely to be more focused towards self and goals, which lead to goal attainment for optimists and avoidance of goals for pessimists. Optimists are more likely than pessimists to manage their behaviors and work proactively to stay healthy whenever there is a gap between present and desired state of health.

Another reason for higher well-being in optimists is their attribute of constructive thinking. Optimism as a trait is associated with positive expectancies and constructive thinking in life (Lobel, DeVincent, Kaminer, & Meyer, 2000). As optimists anticipate to have more positive outcomes, they are more hopeful that their efforts will be fruitful and not be wasted. Thinking constructively is also responsible for more effective handling of negative life circumstances and promote resilient behaviours (Carver et al., 2010).

Optimism is believed to result in better physical health, by lowering experienced stress. Optimists tend to have higher self-efficacy or perception of control over situations and more positive thought processes because of which they perceive situations to be manageable and consequently experience lower level of stress (Carver & Scheier, 2014). Studies also point towards the role of optimism in promoting health protecting behaviors and refraining from health compromising behaviors resulting in a healthy lifestyle (Carver & Scheier, 2014). This healthy lifestyle boosts their immune system and prevents them from developing illness. Even on developing illness, they tend to comply more with medical advice for a faster recovery (Carr, 2004). On the contrary pessimism was linked to negative health effects (Carver et al., 2010). Pessimism was also found to be correlated positively with involvement in health compromising behaviors like substance abuse, suicide (Carver et al., 2010).

(c) Optimism and Psychological Well-being

Optimism also contributes to enhanced psychological well-being. Research shows that people with dispositional optimism are more likely to use reappraisal, problem focused coping and adaptive emotion focused coping at the time of stressful situations. Pessimists, on the other hand have a higher tendency to use avoidant coping strategies like escape avoidance or denial in the face of a challenge (Carver et al., 2010).

It is important to understand that optimism does not always result in positive outcomes. In the next section you will learn about the risks involved in being too much optimistic.

10.6 RISKS ASSOCIATED WITH OPTIMISM

(a) Failure to assess personal risks

One of the factors in order to lead a healthy life is caution and judgment for anticipating risks and threats in the future or present environment. However, in being hopeful and overly positive, optimistic people may fail to recognize and judge the potential risk. For example an optimist who feels that a disease like

cancer is not likely to affect them, can be unwilling to get the screening medical examination done, making them more vulnerable to the disease. However the negative outcomes are more likely to occur for those characterized by unrealistic optimism than those who make objective assessments of these risks. Dillard, Midboe and Klein (2009) identified unrealistic optimists in a group of college students. The categorization was based on the students' scores on two measures: alcohol related risk perception and alcohol consumption. The dispositional optimism was also assessed in students. According to results, dispositional optimism did not indicate any negative effects. But unrealistic optimism was predictive of higher number of alcohol linked negative events that were found later in follow up interviews during the next one and half years.

(b) *Inability to disengage from unrealizable goals*

We all acknowledge at some point in our life about goals that cannot be realized due to number of reasons like aging, lack of sufficient resources, socio-cultural constraints etc. This realization requires an adaptive regulation wherein one can modify one's goals or chase different set of goals, according to the demand of the situation. Therefore to achieve a sense of well-being one has to disengage from these unattainable goals and reconnect with alternative goals. It seems plausible that optimistic people being hopeful would have greater difficulty in disengaging with goals though they are unattainable. However, the studies are not conclusive in this direction. While some studies counter this blind persistence hypothesis for optimistic people (Aspinwall and Richter, 1999), others provide evidence wherein there is less adaptive functioning among dispositional optimists when faced with goal unattainability for an extended period (Segerstrom, 2006).

Thus hopeful and optimistic orientation can have adverse effects in case of overly positive perceptions of threatening situations leading to higher predisposition towards physical illness and reduced well-being.

Self Assessment Questions 2

1. Constructive thinking is one of the reasons for higher well-being in optimists.
True or False.
2. Reappraisal is more likely to be used by the pessimists than the optimists.
True or False.
3. Overly positive and optimistic people are always able to recognize and judge the potential risk. **True or False.**

10.7 HOPE

Hope is an interdisciplinary concept studied in different disciplines like Anthropology, Sociology, Psychology, Philosophy, Nursing/Medicine and Theology. In philosophy, it is studied as a spiritual virtue; in nursing literature, hope is associated with survival and coping. Psychology conceptualizes hope as goal achievement. Hope, according to Staats (1989), is "the interaction between wishes and expectations." Stotland (1969) investigated the function of expectancies and cognitive schemas in the development of hope, which he defined as a set of important goals with a high perceived possibility of realization. According to Gottschalk (1974), hope is having positive expectations about

particular favorable consequences, and it motivates a person to overcome psychological challenges.

A number of conceptual frameworks have been proposed by theorists like Nikolaichuk (1999), Scioli et al(1997), and Snyder (1994). Within a multidimensional framework, Nikolaichuk et.al. (1999) suggest a hope model that highlights three dimensions of hope: personal spirit (an individual dimension), risk (a contextual dimension), and authentic caring (a relational dimension). According to Scioli (1997), individuals realize hope through four dimensions: mastery (goals), survival (coping), attachment (trust) and spirituality (faith). Several other perspectives to hope such as, “hopeful thinking or cognition” (Snyder, 2000), “positive emotional experience” (Fredrickson, 2009), as a “character strength” (Peterson and Seligman, 2004) and also a “transcendental phenomenon” (Emmons, 2005, Vaillant, 2008) have been proposed.

From a Positive psychology perspective, hope involves positive feelings like optimism, but it is also a cognitive- motivational state that comprises of individual’s beliefs about the self and one’s actions that shapes attainment of desirable results. Developed by Professor Charles Richard Snyder (1994), the concept of hope is conceptualized to consist of three components: (i) goals, (ii) thoughts about means or pathways to achieve specific goals, and (iii) thoughts about the agency or abilities to attain those goals. Hope is believed to be the sum of ‘pathways’ and ‘agency’ components. In other words, hope is the combination of perceived *abilities* to choose routes towards desirable goals and the perceived *motivation* to make use of those routes. It indicates the person’s belief that s/he will be able to find the path towards the desired goals and utilize these pathways for attainment of goals. As evident from the definition, Snyder emphasized hope to be a cognitive-motivational phenomena, and emotions to be a byproduct of these thoughts. Hope theory predicts that unhindered goal pursuit should result in positive emotions, but goal impediments may result in negative emotions.

Snyder (2000) believed hope to be a multi-dimensional concept which can act both like a stable personality trait and contextual state. As a trait, people can have individual differences in the extent to which they possess the trait. People high on hope are thought to use different means to reach their goals, they have more clarity about the alternate routes and are more likely to have a strong belief about accomplishing their goals, as compared to people who are low on hope (Bailis and Chipperfield, 2012).

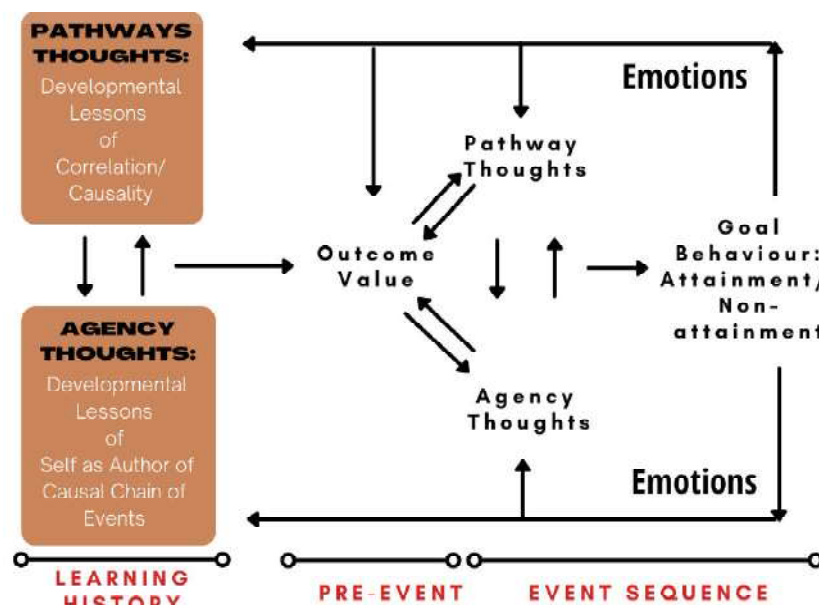


Fig. 10.1: Snyders’s Model of Hope
Source: Adapted from Snyder (2000)

According to Snyder's model as depicted in Fig 10.1, hope will be high when it involves goals that are valued and there is average or above average probability of realizing the goals in the face of obstacles that are difficult but not overwhelming. Hope loses its relevance where one is sure of reaching the goals; and hopelessness results when it is believed that goals are not achievable. Hopeful thoughts lead to positive emotions and hopelessness results in negative emotions. Snyder pointed out that at any point in time and situation, hope is determined by the interplay of three factors:

- The extent to which any goal is valued
- The pathways/means and expectancies about the effectiveness of these pathways in attainment of desirable goals, and
- One's agency or energy, abilities and self-efficacy in using these pathways to goals

The above mentioned factors do not operate in a vacuum, the thoughts about pathways and agency are dependent on past experiences. The developmental learnings related to correlation and causality in pathways thinking and agency thoughts derived from one's experiences in the past guides one's expectancies in the present.

In addition to goals, pathways thinking and agency thinking, Snyder also talked about the **barriers** to goal achievement. Goal attainment is not always a smooth process and involves number of blockages. When faced with obstacles to goals, most people can think of at least one alternative route, but there are some who can think of multiple routes to the desired goals. This ability to find multiple pathways is more characteristic of high hope people (Snyder, 1994a, 1994b).

False Hope

True hope is thought to have a basis in reality, on the other hand, false hope is believed to result from recognizable distortions of reality. Many scholars and psychologists have raised concerns about the potential dangers of "false" hope (Snyder, Rand, King, Feldman, & Woodward, 2002).

According to literature, false hope tend to occur for three reasons: when expectancies are based on illusions instead of reality (e.g., Beavers & Kaslow, 1981); when unreasonable goals are chased (Rule, 1982, as cited by Snyder et al., 2002); and when inadequate approach and procedures are followed to attain the desirable goals (Kwon, 2000, 2002). However, Snyder argued that false hope was not necessarily a result of distortions in reality. He believed that high hope individuals can make use of positive illusions that can shape their perception of reality, but they do not inevitably involve in counterproductive illusions resulting in major reality distortions (Snyder, 1998)

Another important topic investigated by researchers is the phenomenon of **Collective Hope** (Snyder & Feldman, 2000). Collective Hope indicates the extent of goal-directed thinking of a group of people or communities. Collective hope becomes functional when a large number of people pursue a goal that cannot be achieved by any single individual. The operation of collective hope is visible in community efforts towards common goals like environment protection, health promotion, and government plans.

10.8 DEVELOPMENT OF HOPE

Although hope is conceptualized both as a trait and state, it has not been found to have any hereditary component (Snyder, 1994b). It is believed to be a cognitive set about

goal-directed thinking that is completely learnt and shaped by the socialization process. The elements of hope - the pathway and agency thinking are coached by parents or caregivers and are visible by the tender age of two in children, although these thoughts are acquired much before that. Agency thoughts in babies is their recognition of their self to be a causal factor in many cause and effects events in their surroundings. Healthy attachment to caregivers which is based on trust is important for development of hope in children (Snyder, 1994b). Threatening environment and traumatic experiences during childhood like loss of parents have been associated with decrease in hope (Rodriguez-Hanley & Snyder, 2000).

10.9 NEUROBIOLOGY OF HOPE

The ability to anticipate pathways to desired goals despite impediments and be motivated to use these pathways, suggests that study into the neuroscience of incentive-driven, goal-directed behaviour may shed insight on the subject (Snyder, 2000). Professor Jeffrey Gray (1987) of the Institute of Psychiatry, London has argued that the central nervous system has two antagonistic control centres namely the behavioural activation system (BAS) and the behavioural inhibition system (BIS) that regulate much goal-directed behavior (Pickering and Gray, 1999). The BAS system is thought of as a system that responds well to incentives or reinforcement, whereas the BIS is thought of as a system that responds well to punishment. The BAS is stimulated by reward signals and regulates approach behaviour. It's a 'go' structure. The BIS is aroused by punishment messages and regulates passive avoidance. It's a 'stop' system. The BAS is fed by mesolimbic and mesocortical dopamine pathways, which are likely important for hopeful behaviour.

Professor Richard Depue (1996) of Cornell University in New York demonstrated that a behavioural facilitation system (BFS) stimulated by reward signals explains for much of the evidence on incentive seeking in animals and humans. The BFS regulates incentive-driven or goal-directed behaviour and activities such as obtaining food, a mate, and a nesting site, as well as pursuing other essential objectives and rewards. The neurological reward system is a colloquial term for it. The mesolimbic dopamine pathways originate in the ventral tegmental area of the midbrain and project to the limbic system's amygdala, hippocampus, and nucleus accumbens. The mesocortical dopamine pathways, which begin in the ventral tegmental region and extend onto all sections of the cortex, are also part of the reward system. People with an active BFS are highly driven to achieve their goals by incentives and rewards. Within the population, the efficiency with which the BFS operates has a normal distribution, and hope is likely linked to more efficient BFS operation.

Self Assessment Questions 3

1. Differentiate between hope and optimism.
2. According to Snyder (1994), hope consists of _____ and _____ components.
3. What is 'false hope'?
4. What are BAS and BIS?

10.10 BENEFITS OF HOPE

Hope has been found to have beneficial results in the area of academics, sports, physical health, adjustment, and psychotherapy.

a) *Academic Performance*

A number of research investigations involving various student populations have revealed a link between hope and academic performance. Snyder et al. (1991) identified the characteristics of high-hope students as self-assured, inspired, enthusiastic, and driven by their intended goals. Higher Hope Scale scores at the start of college have been shown to predict better overall grade point averages and whether students will continue school (Snyder, Shorey, et al., 2002). Furthermore, among college students, higher levels of hope were linked to higher academic life satisfaction and higher use of problem-solving skills and coping mechanisms (Chang, 1998). The studies are reflective of hope being a potential human strength aiding in improving achievement.

b) *Health and Well being*

As a personal attribute, hope has been linked to a number of positive health benefits (Snyder, 2002). Snyder (2002) linked high levels of hope to higher participation in preventative actions that help people avoid developing physical and mental illnesses. For example, people scoring high on hope showed a greater involvement with cancer prevention initiatives (Irving, Snyder and Crowson, 1998) and higher motivation to do physical work out (Harney, 1990 in Snyder, 2002).

The correlation between hope and psychological functioning has also been revealed in numerous research studies. Higher levels of hope were associated with improved mental health in high school students (Marques, Pais-Ribeiro, & Lopez, 2011), reduced levels of depression in undergraduates (Snyder et al., 1991), and better life satisfaction scores in law school students (Rand et al., 2011). High hope in cancer patients was also associated with reduced psychological distress in them (Berendes et al, 2010). Elliott, Witty, Herrick, and Hoffman (1991) carried out a study on 57 persons with major physical disabilities and found that hope had a favorable impact on depressive symptoms and dealing with physical handicap. People with higher levels of hope had lower degree of depression and had stronger social relationships in comparison to individuals with lower levels of hope.

Michael (2000) studied the effects of hope on anxiety reactions. His study discovered that hope can be used as a resource to keep anxiety from overpowering and incapacitating the patient. As a result, hope seemed to have a moderating influence on anxiety; hopeful individuals have the ability to overcome the ramifications of anxiety by consciously focusing on achieving their goals. Energy produced by anxiety can also be channeled into goal-oriented action. Hope is thus considered to be a valuable human strength with the potential to result in beneficial outcomes with regard to health and well-being (Seligman and Csikszentmihalyi, 2000).

c) *Coping and Adjustment*

A large number of studies have investigated the effects of hope on dealing with stress. Snyder (2000) showed a positive effect of dispositional hope on ability to cope with problems. Based on research findings, Snyder and Pulvers (2001) stated

that individuals low in hope are more likely to have a tragic view of future, as compared to high hoppers who tend to use healthy and productive coping strategies on a regular basis. It is intriguing to know if there is a difference between high hoppers and low hoppers in terms of types of coping strategies used by them. This question has been dealt by one of the studies by Slezackova&Piskova (2017). The study was carried on 196 adults in the age range of 19-33 years old. They found that people scoring high on hope used coping strategies like problem-solving, positive cognitive restructuring and support from family, friends. These people exhibited a higher level of happiness and positive perceptions of health. Individuals with low hope scores, on the other hand, displayed coping strategies like wishful thinking, self-criticism and social withdrawal.

In the domain of personal and social adjustment, higher Hope scale scores have been linked to numerous indices of increased happiness satisfaction, positive emotions, quality of social relationships, and so on (Snyder, Harris, et al., 1991). Furthermore, hope has been proposed as a common component underpinning the positive effects of psychological therapeutic treatment. (Snyder, Ilardi, Cheavens, et al., 2000).

10.11 MEASUREMENT OF HOPE

Snyder et al (1991) developed a trait based hope scale called The Adult Dispositional Hope Scale to measure hope in adult population. The scale consists of twelve items, out of which four items measure pathways thoughts, four items measure agency thoughts and the rest four are fillers. The response is made by participants using the 4-point scale from definitely false to definitely true. The internal consistency (alpha level) and test-retest reliabilities have been found to be in the range of .80. Further, they developed a state based self-report measure known as State Hope Scale, which consisted of six items, in which three items assessed successful agency and three measured successful pathways. The items were modified version of dispositional scale referring to hope in the present moment.

To assess hope in children, the Children's Hope Scale (Snyder et al, 1997) was created for school aged children. It is a six-item self- report measure for the age group of 8-15 years. Three items assess agency thinking, three measure pathways thinking, which children answer on a 6-point Likert scale (1= none of the time, 6= all the time). The test-retest reliability for the scale range between 0.70-0.80. For the pre-school children, Young Children Hope Scale was constructed. Observational rating scales for all these tests were also developed to be filled by parents, teachers and research raters. Other than these scales, another scale called Adult Domain Specific Hope Scale was developed to assess hope in various spheres of life: family, academic, love relationships, social, occupation and leisure activities.

10.12 LET US SUM UP

In this Unit, you learned about two important constructs in positive psychology, that is, optimism and hope. Development of optimism and hope was described and their benefits were elaborated.

Looking at the positive outcomes of optimism in different spheres of person's life, it is crucial that optimism be developed from childhood. Programs have been developed

by researchers (Seligman, 1998) to assist individuals of different age groups to alter their explanatory style from pessimism to optimism. Participants, in these programs, get trained to recognize and analyse the situations which are mood altering, and thereby change their negative beliefs by positive reappraisal so that it leads to optimistic explanatory style. Thus knowledge of one's ability to change and transform one's thought processes towards optimistic thinking can be really empowering and advantageous in the direction of positive mental health and well-being.

Similarly, hope is also a multifaceted process, which is necessary for human survival and indispensable for life. Hope has been found to be strongly related to happiness, physical wellness, academic performance and psychological well-being for people of all ages. It can act like protective shield while facing life difficulties and stressors. Research findings reflect it can be development from early childhood. A number of factors can affect hope: age, sociocultural factors, socialization etc. Although it is predominantly considered to be an individual phenomenon, it can be experienced collectively and can result in attainment of group goals. Hope has an important role to play in the present unprecedented times, whereby it can help people find a direction, guide pathway, and reinforce one's belief in reaching meaningful goals despite troubles, failures, negativity, and despair.

10.13 KEY WORDS

Optimism	: is a cognitive expectancy for desirable events or things to happen in future.
Explanatory style	: is defined as the manner in which an individual explains the events of his/her life, making attributions for their causes.
Learned Optimism	: refers to the tendency of ascribing <i>external, unstable</i> and <i>specific</i> causes to negative life events.
Unrealistic Optimism	: refers to the tendency of attribution which entails holding particular perceptions and self-evaluations that are unduly positive, too exaggerated to be called objective or fair.
Hope	: refers to having positive expectations about particular favorable consequences, and it motivates a person to overcome psychological challenges (Gottschalk, 1974).
Collective Hope	: indicates the extent of goal-directed thinking of a group of people or communities.

10.14 ANSWERS TO SELF ASSESSMENT QUESTIONS

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 1

1. Dispositional
2. Learned
3. Martin Seligman
4. Internality/externality, unstability/stability and specificity/globality

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 2

1. True
2. False
3. False

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 3

1. Hope involves positive feelings like optimism, but it is also a cognitive-motivational state that comprises of individual's beliefs about the self and one's actions that shapes attainment of desirable results.
2. pathways and agency
3. False hope results from recognizable distortions of reality.
4. behavioural activation system (BAS) and behavioural inhibition system (BIS) that regulate much goal-directed behavior in individuals and are located in the central nervous system.

10.15 UNIT END QUESTIONS

1. Discuss the two dominant perspectives in optimism.
2. What are the probable risks associated with optimism?
3. Describe the measurement of optimism.
4. Discuss Snyder's Model of Hope citing relevant examples.
5. Explain the neurobiological aspects of hope.
6. Elaborate on the various benefits of hope.

10.16 REFLECTIVE EXERCISES

1. Think of different instances/events in your life. Do you use internal/external, stable/changing, or specific/general attributions while explaining the events of your life?
2. Take the example of a pessimistic explanatory style either in your case or in people known to you. Write down how can you modify it from internal to external; stable to dynamic; and general to specific attributions.
3. Have you ever not been able to detect a potential threat in your environment because of your optimistic attitude? Do you tend to be overly optimistic at some times?
4. What is the function of hope in the life of an individual? Is it always beneficial? Reflect with examples from your life or of people you know about.
5. Based on your personal experiences can you differentiate between Hope and False Hope, and the consequences of both in goal attainment?
6. Recall a challenging situation in the past, and the corresponding agency and pathways thoughts you experienced and the results of these on your goal behavior.

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UNIT 11 FLOW AND MINDFULNESS*

Structure

- 11.1 Learning Objectives
- 11.2 Introduction
- 11.3 Flow: The Optimal Experience
 - 11.3.1 Components of Flow Experience
- 11.4 Flow and Engagement: Are They Same?
- 11.5 Flow: An Indigenous Perspective
- 11.6 Benefits of Flow
- 11.7 Assessment of Flow
- 11.8 Mindfulness
- 11.9 Meaning of Mindfulness
- 11.10 How does Mindfulness Work?
- 11.11 Benefits of Mindfulness
- 11.12 Mindfulness Based Interventions
- 11.13 Assessment of Mindfulness
- 11.14 Let Us Sum Up
- 11.15 Key Words
- 11.16 Answers to Self Assessment Questions
- 11.17 Unit End Questions
- 11.18 References
- 11.19 Suggested Readings

11.1 LEARNING OBJECTIVES

After studying this Unit, you would be able to:

- *Explain the meaning of flow and describe its different components;*
- *Describe the benefits of flow and how to assess it;*
- *Define mindfulness and describe its components;*
- *Explain the mechanism of mindfulness;*
- *Describe the assessment of mindfulness; and*
- *Discuss various mindfulness-based interventions and how they impact the well-being of individuals.*

11.2 INTRODUCTION

Rita loves dancing and has performed on stage in many functions in her college. When she practices in her dance class in the evening, she becomes so engrossed

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that she forgets all the tiredness after her college classes. She gets immersed in her dance and loses the track of time. Have you ever felt that time has flied while doing anything, e.g., reading a favourite novel or playing a game.

Rahul has gone for a movie in the evening with his college friends. They dined out and it was quite late by the time he returned home. His father got angry and scolded him for being so irresponsible and staying out so late into the night. Rahul also got angry and was about to retort back saying that he is grown up now and can take care of himself. But then he thought that he is not going to ruin his sleep and the enjoyable experience he had by getting into an argument with his father so late in the night.

Have you ever found yourself in situations similar to the cases described above? These examples depict two important constructs in positive psychology, namely **Flow** and **Mindfulness**. The field of positive psychology focuses on such aspects which make one's life more flourishing, meaningful and worth living. It aims at finding out what is good in life and how we can enhance our life?

The process of engagement in any activity and in life refers to the process of immersing oneself and getting absorbed in the work we do or task at hand. Engagement and particularly the concept of 'flow', is important in making life worth living and promoting a profound sense of well-being for people who have flow experience. Mindfulness also contributes to living a balanced and enriching life by paying attention to the present moment experiences.

In the present Unit, we will discuss about these positive psychology constructs of flow and mindfulness.

11.3 FLOW: THE OPTIMAL EXPERIENCE

The concept of 'Flow' originated from the works of Mihály Csíkszentmihályi (1975, 1990), a Hungarian-American psychologist, and a Professor at Claremont Graduate University, California, who first recognized and coined the term. He studied people from creative field or artists where work is integrated with leisure like dancers, painters, athletes, etc. based on which he propounded the concept of flow.

The flow state was defined as the one where a person is fully engaged or immersed in the activity they are doing. It is a feeling which is characterized by a state of concentration, fulfillment, complete absorption, engagement and competency, and a disregard of the sense of time, ego, bodily needs during the activity. According to Csíkszentmihályi (2005), flow involves being fully present and engrossed in the activity and utilizing one's skills to the fullest. The characteristic feature of flow is a deep involvement in the moment-to-moment activity.

In his popular work, 'Flow: The Psychology of Optimal Experience', Csíkszentmihályi has proposed that when, in a state of flow, people feel the happiest. It is a kind of involvement and focus in one's work that nothing else seems to matter (Csíkszentmihályi, 1990). In 1996 he added, flow is "extremely enjoyed optimal experience in which total concentration and enjoyment with great interest for the activity is experienced" (Csíkszentmihályi, 1996). This flow experience can be felt during play, games, creative pursuits, spiritual experience, and other contexts, however, it is not limited to these. Maslow's (1962, 1971) concept of 'peak experiences and de Charms (1968) idea of 'origin' state share many commonalities with flow.

Based on the interviews findings of artists, sportsmen etc., Csíkszentmihályi has underlined certain elements of flow experience.

11.3.1 Components of Flow Experience

- ***Merging of action and awareness***

One of the most defining features of flow experience is the merging of action with its awareness. Here the individual is very much aware of his/her actions, but do not reflect on that awareness itself. For example in a chess game, the player has undivided attention on the game on its every move but is not perceptive of that awareness.

To quote an example from the interviews of artists by Csíkszentmihályi,

“You are so involved in what you are doing, you aren’t thinking of yourself as separate from the immediate activity... you don’t see yourself as separate from what you are doing...” (Csíkszentmihályi, 2014).

For this kind of merging between action and awareness, the activity carried out must be achievable i.e., the person doing it must be confident about his/her ability to perform. However, this flow experience is not easy to sustain for longer periods of time and is sometimes disrupted by momentary interruptions in the form of outside perspective like ‘Am I doing well’? The moment activity is perceived from outside, the awareness is split from the action, and the flow experience is interrupted.

- ***Centering of attention***

The flow experience is achieved when one’s attention is undivided and centered on a single stimulus field. This focusing of attention involves keeping out of attention the unnecessary, irrelevant, or distracting stimuli. It is also named as the ‘narrowing of consciousness’. This concentration or narrowing of attention is attained by a number of factors during play or games like rules and structure of the game, competition, material rewards, and sometimes, even physical danger. Although flow is not limited to games only, it can be experienced in any kind of activities. The determining element here is the pure involvement, and finding joy in that involvement.

- ***Loss of ego***

Loss of ego here denotes, a temporary loss of self-consciousness or one’s identity, and individuality. It is a brief forgetfulness of one’s self and becoming one with the activity. When a person is involved in the activity completely, self-interests become superfluous. The self or ego here is seen from the intrapsychic perspective and not physical body. The person does not lose touch with one’s physical reality, on the other hand, in some flow activities like yoga and certain sports, the individual becomes considerably more aware of one’s internal processes or changes. It’s the absence of awareness of self as a role or ego.

As described by one person in the creative field,

“You yourself are in an ecstatic state to such a point that you feel as though you almost don’t exist. I’ve experienced this time and time again. My hand seems devoid of myself, and I have nothing to do with what is happening. I

just sit there watching it in a state of awe and wonderment. And it just flows out by itself.”(Csikszentmihályi, 2014).

- **Control of action and environment**

Another element of flow is a feeling of sense of control over one’s actions and one’s environment. It is not as much a feeling of mastery, as it is a state of not being bothered about by the likelihood of loss of control. Retrospectively, while thinking about the event, a person with flow experience, feels that he had adequate skills and competencies for meeting the demands of the environment at that time, leading to a sense of positive self-regard and a positive self-concept

An excerpt from Csikszentmihályi study explains this point,

“I feel in control. Sure. I’ve practiced and have a good feeling for the shots I can make... I don’t feel in control of the other player-even if he’s bad and I know where to beat him. It’s me and not him that I’m working on.”(Csikszentmihályi, 2014).

- **Demands for action and clear feedback**

The demands for action which results in flow experience have the characteristics of being clear, consonant or coherent. In addition it involves explicit and clear feedback to the person for his actions. The task is defined clearly and the person is required to do things which are coherent or compatible with the goals. In other words the goals and the means are aligned with each other. In the words of a climber from Csikszentmihályi’s study, the phenomenon is described as,

“I think it’s one of the few sorts of activities in which you don’t feel you have all sorts of different kinds of demands, often conflicting, upon you...”(Csikszentmihályi, 2014).

To put in other words, flow experience involve participating in orderly activities, where there is no conflict between the goals, the action towards the goals, and where the feedback of the action follows the action. Flow is enhanced in the presence of clear and timely feedback. Feedback is important as it lets know the person how well s/he is doing in the activity, and signals to either modify or continue the ongoing course of action. It provides a direction and clarity to the person about the course of action.

- **Autotelic in nature**

One of the most defining characteristics of flow is autotelic, that is, it is self-rewarding and the activity does not require any rewards external to itself. Most or all of flow activities like play, dance, games, artistic drawing etc. are inherently rewarding to the person doing those activities. Although external rewards can be there in most of the above-mentioned and other flow activities yet the people experiencing flow are primarily motivated by the experience and not the external rewards attached. A music composer when asked by Csikszentmihályi why he composes answers,

“One doesn’t do it for money. One does it for, perhaps, the satisfaction it gives. I think the great composers, all the great artists, work for themselves, period.”(Csikszentmihályi, 2014).

- **Altered sense of time**

We all have experienced at some point or other how time seems to fly very fast when we are enjoying something, and it seems to standstill in periods of boredom, agony or stress. William James (1890) commented how boredom is heightened when we become attentive to the process of time passing. In the flow, attention is focused on the moment to moment activity, the person is not at all oriented towards the mental processes that signals the time duration. As a result the person fully engaged in an activity feels that time has passed too quickly (Conti, 2001).

This is expressed in one of the verbatim of a chess player interviewed by Csíkszentmihályi,

“Time passes a hundred times faster. In this sense, it resembles the dream state. A whole story can unfold in seconds, it seems.”(Csíkszentmihályi, 2014).

The excerpts from the interviewees showed that all the components of the flow experience are interconnected to each other. By limiting their attention to a limited stimulus field and evading distractions, persons in the flow activity can feel a sense of control over their environment. Being involved in an activity where goals are clear and unambiguous, this intense concentration can lead to temporary detachment from their identity, self and sense of time. All these elements result in a feeling of intrinsic satisfaction which is rewarding in itself.

It is important to note here that for the optimal or flow experience the challenge or opportunities for action needs to be consonant with perceived capabilities. When the demands are experienced to be more than what one can handle, it can lead to stress or anxiety. On the other hand, if the skills are perceived to be greater than the demands of the situation, it can result in boredom. Therefore, flow is experienced when there is a match between the opportunities for action (challenges) and the perceived skills of the person.

There are *other conceptualizations of flow* as well by different researchers. Most of them derive from Csíkszentmihályi model of flow. Jackson and Eklud (2002) proposed that the optimal experience can be explained by nine dimensions: consciousness-action fusion, complete concentration, lack of awareness, balance-skill challenge, time distortion, feedback, target clarity, and autotelic experience.

Bakker (2005) came up with a slightly different approach, with three broad dimensions of flow: Absorption, Enjoyment and Intrinsic Motivation.

Another group of researchers, Chen, Wigand and Nila (1999) suggests the proposition that optimal experience can be achieved by three initial dimensions which can lead to the experience of flow:

- Goal and challenge perception
- Perception of the abilities adjusted for the action
- Immediate feedback

Thus the flow experience consists of a number of elements as described above. Various other factors such as clarity of goals, optimal challenges, high achievement motivation, and importance of activity for the person also influence the extent to which the person engages in an activity and finds it intrinsically rewarding.

11.4 FLOW AND ENGAGEMENT: ARE THEY SAME?

Flow is often used interchangeably with engagement. Many find the two terms overlapping, or an extension of each other. There is a very thin line differentiating the two. Due to the commonalities between the two concepts, and the manner in which they are conceptualized, there are different perspectives in the literature about which causes what, i.e., if flow leads to engagement or engagement results in flow? There is no consistent empirical evidence in one direction.

Kahn (1990) contended engagement to be one of the elements of flow. Schaufeli, Salanova, Gonzalez-Rokmá and Bakker (2002) suggested that flow is climax experience of engagement. They argued that engagement is a positive psychological state of work that can be described by vigor, dedication and absorption. Engagement can be a reflection of one's internal motivation at work, it can be referred to as a more persistent cognitive-affective state, as compared to flow which can be a specific, transient, peak experience. The most common difference cited between the two is temporality. While flow is a slightly more complex concept and includes various elements, it signifies a particular, time bound, transient 'peak' experience, as compared to a more consistent, and extensive psychological states such as engagement (Schaufeli et al., 2002). The absorption dimension of engagement comes very close to flow. Furthermore, engagement is generally referred in work context and "indicates one's identification with one's work" (Schaufeli et al., 2009), while flow can be experienced in any of the activities or unlikely situations.

11.5 FLOW: AN INDIGENOUS PERSPECTIVE

The concept of flow has parallels in the Hindu philosophy of Karma Yoga, underlined in the Hindu's sacred text Bhagavad Gita. Both Flow and Bhagavad Gita propound enjoying the journey or process of work itself, rather than being focused about the end goal, in order to experience inner satisfaction and peace. In the Bhagavad Gita, Lord Krishna instructs his disciple Arjuna to follow this principle:

कर्मण्येवधिकारस्ते मा फलेषु कदाचन ।
मा कर्मफलहेतुर्भूर्मा ते सङ्गोऽस्तवकर्मणि ॥ 47 ॥

Invest your energies in doing your duty in the best possible manner, but do not concern yourself with the results. Let the motive of action be the action, and not the hope of reward.

बुद्धियुक्तो जहातीह उभे सुकृतदुष्कृते ।
तस्माद्योगाय युज्यस्व योगः कर्मसु कौशलम् ॥ 50 ॥

Shree Krishna explains - by getting rid of the attachment to the results of the work, one can attain excellence in the work we do. This excellence in work is Yoga. Shri Krishna clarifies that working without personal interests, does not dampen the spirit of work or quality of work; contrary to this, we become more skillful in comparison to when we work with an eye towards personal rewards.

Flow can be experienced in any kind of work. To quote the Gita “the one devoted to his duty (work, action) attains perfection” [18.45].

Csikszentmihalyi’s conceptualization of flow and how to achieve the highest form of fulfillment- enjoying the moment-to moment activity without aiming at the end goal, is very similar to the path of peace and self-realization prescribed by Lord Krishna – the elimination of desire for rewards and detachment from fruits of actions.

11.6 BENEFITS OF FLOW

Although flow can be a very personally and internally rewarding experience, it has broader positive consequences. The two direct consequences of flow often discussed in literature are enjoyment and pleasurable absorption. These two in turn can lead to a number of benefits for the person and in the work context. The pleasurable absorption experienced in the leisure and sports activities has been associated with many crucial outcomes in the work arena like enhanced interest in task (Csikszentmihalyi, Rathunde, & Whalen, 1993), positive mood (Eisenberger et al., 2005), in-role and extra role work behaviors (Demerouti, 2006), organizational spontaneity (Eisenberger et al., 2005), and overall physical as well as psychological well-being (Steele, 2006).

A number of studies have highlighted the positive effects of flow in creative fields like journalism. Flow was found to influence enjoyment at work and sense of professional efficacy in journalists (Burke & Mattheisen, 2004). Studies are abound in the positive effects of flow in sports and creative activities. However, there is dearth of studies of flow in the other work context like academics. Flow can have many relevant outcomes in the workplace such as improved performance and organizational citizenship behaviour. Additionally it can be promoted by various job characteristics like leadership, freedom, autonomy, open communication channels etc. at work; thereby making flow an empirically modifiable variable, which can be enhanced by changing specific job characteristics. Therefore pleasurable absorption and enjoyment resulting from flow, can lead to positive work outcomes in diverse fields and have the potential to reduce stress at work and promote well-being. Although studies in the domain are limited, it has been found that flow can be concluded by work characteristics in the academic context and brings about better physical and psychological well-being in students (Steele, 2006). Findings from flow experience can be utilized in aiding institutional practices to enhance students’ involvement in studies and academic work in general.

Exercises to trigger a Flow Experience:

- *When faced with a challenging situation, try taking not a standard route instead a different approach, stretching your imagination.*
- *Think outside of the box and look at the problems from an unconventional angle.*
- *Try taking part in activities that you never took part in, explored or never thought to be a possibility for you like playing a new sport, exploring a new place etc.*

- *Practice immersing yourself in new experiences and environments*
- *Chalk your personal mission statement – identify your competencies and write your personal goals and ask yourself, “What do I want to achieve?”*

11.7 ASSESSMENT OF FLOW

The construct of flow evolved during the study undertaken by Csikszentmihalyi (1975). Csikszentmihalyi utilized the technique of qualitative interviewing to investigate the experiences of people involved in creative activities. The flow experience can be assessed by using a variety of methods, which can be qualitative, quantitative or both. Interviews are the most popular means to attain qualitative measures of flow. Another method is Experience Sampling Methodology (ESM) (Csikszentmihalyi & Graef, 1980; Csikszentmihalyi & Kubey, 1981).

The survey method is the most common method to measure flow quantitatively. Two psychological tests: The Flow State Scale II (FSSII) (Jackson & Eklund, 2002) and the Work related Flow scale (WOLF), (Bakker, 2005) are used to measure Flow. The FSS II derives from the Csikszentmihalyi (1988) nine dimensional model of flow and consists of 36 items (four items for each of the nine dimensions of flow). The scale has high internal consistency reliability (Jackson & Eklund, 2002). The other test, WOLF is more applicable to and is based upon work context. It draws from Bakkar (2005) theoretical proposition of flow experience, which is defined by absorption, work enjoyment and intrinsic work motivation.

Flow is thus an internally rewarding experience, when individuals are completely immersed in any activity, to the extent of forgetting their identity, self, sense of time, and everything else in their background but the activity itself. People can experience this at the time of writing a novel, dancing, participating in sports, playing a musical instrument, and all other kinds of activities where a person feels involved and skillful. There are many dimensions to it, however the defining characteristics of flow include deep involvement at the moment, challenge and skill balance, and autotelic in nature. This functioning at one's fullest capacity is rewarding in itself and gives a feeling of bliss and the need to relive the experience again and again.

Self Assessment Questions 1

1. Who has contributed to the concept of 'Flow'?
2. Name a few characteristics of flow experience.
3. The concept of flow has parallels in which Hindu philosophy?
4. Name the psychological tests used to measure flow.

11.8 MINDFULNESS

What most of the respondents in Csikszentmihály qualitative interview study experienced in the state of flow was a feeling of connectedness (mind, body and action), bliss and peace resulting from intense focus and concentration in the act being performed. One

wishes to be in this state again and again. What is actually causing this bliss in action is mindfulness. This brings us to another related topic of mindfulness, defined by heightened awareness or being in the moment.

Mindfulness, an attribute of consciousness, plays an important role in improving the psychological well-being of people. One of the major stressors of life for most of the individuals is worrying about future or getting stuck in the past leading to negative feelings like guilt, regret, resentment, grievance, anxiety, bitterness etc. A healthy state of mind requires one to focus one's attention in the present. However, day-dreaming, worries, excessive planning cause individuals to act mechanically without conscious awareness, thus develop behavioral patterns which are unhealthy and mindless.

A disconnect between mind, body and heart is a very common and accepted way of being in the world for so many of us. People of all age groups can be prone to this and particularly those who have to balance and manage multiple roles, responsibilities and relationships at a given time. However, this can have serious effects on individuals' physical and mental health, particularly their emotional well-being.

A number of psychological, philosophical and spiritual schools of thought have underscored the relevance of development of consciousness for the presence and improvement of well-being. An aspect of consciousness that has been much discussed and studied with respect to well-being is **Mindfulness**. In simple terms it is construed as the state of being attentive to and aware of what is going on in the present. It helps one to train its mind to stop being bothered about what has happened in the past or can happen in future and respond effectively to what is happening in the moment - not only to the events outside, but paying close attention to one's inner states like thoughts, sensations, feelings and emotions. This can promote well-being by facilitating self-regulatory behavior and positive mental health.

11.9 MEANING OF MINDFULNESS

The term mindfulness is a translation of the word *Sati* in Pali language, and has its roots in Buddhist traditions, though its origin dates back at least as far as the third millennium B.C.E. as part of the Brahmanic traditions in the Indian subcontinent, from where emerged the Buddhism (Cousins, 1996, cited in Lomas et al, 2017 p. 133]. Mindfulness is generally used to indicate both: (i) a state or quality of mind; and (ii) a form of meditation that helps one to bring up and nurture this particular state/quality (Lomas et al., 2017).

With respect to its first meaning, Kabat-Zinn (2003) defines mindfulness as “the consciousness that comes through paying attention on purpose, in the present moment, and nonjudgmentally to the flow of experience moment by moment” (Lomas et. al., 2017, p. 133). The main attributes of mindfulness involve a ‘pre-conceptual awareness’ and ‘acceptance’ of one’s experiences; flexible control of attention; a detached or unbiased openness to experience; and an orientation to be ‘here-and-now’ (Brown, Ryan, & Creswell, 2007a; Howell, 2008, p. 773).

Nyanaponika Thera (1972) called mindfulness “the clear and single-minded awareness of what actually happens to us and in us at the successive moments of perception” (Brown and Ryan, 2003, p. 822). Hanh (1976) defined mindfulness as “keeping one’s consciousness alive to the present reality” (Brown and Ryan, 2003). However, ‘paying

attention' here indicates concentrating on what one is doing, at the same time being aware of one's affective state, thoughts, and memories that arise in that moment, and also observing when the mind digress so that it can be refocused (Baer & Krietemeyer, 2006).

A central aspect of mindfulness that has been described is open or receptive awareness and focus (Deikman, 1982; Martin, 1997, in Brown and Ryan, 2003, p. 822). Prof. Ronald D. Siegel of Harvard Medical School concur the notion of non-judgment, and acceptance to the concept of mindfulness. He defines it 'as awareness of present experience with acceptance' (Siegel, 2014). According to him, there are three components of mindfulness: awareness, present experience and acceptance. Mindfulness requires training to devote our focus to what is occurring at the moment, with open-minded inquisitiveness and approval (Kabat-Zinn 1996, in Weare, 2014, p.4). Shapiro, Carlson, Astin and Freedman (2006) specified three components of mindfulness: intention (i.e., motivation for paying attention in this way); attention (i.e., the cognitive mechanisms through which said attention is enacted); and attitude (i.e., the emotional qualities with which one imbues one's attentive focus, like compassion) (Lomas et. al., 2017, p. 133).

Mindfulness is also considered as a trait, which indicates that people differ in terms of level of mindfulness, some being more mindful than others. Higher levels of mindfulness is linked with good number of positive aftereffects, like better mental health, enhanced satisfaction in relationships, and much better coping with pain (Brown et. al., 2007). Trait mindfulness is strongly linked with higher subjective well-being (Baer et. al., 2008; Brown, Kasser, Ryan, Linley, & Orzech, 2009; Falkenstrom, 2010, cited in Schutte and Malouff, 2011, p. 1116).

Another way mindfulness is defined is as a meditational practice. Meditation refers to:

“A collection of self-regulation practices that focus on training attention and awareness so as to bring mental phenomena under one's self-control, fostering general mental well-being and development of specific abilities like calm, clarity, and concentration” (Walsh & Shapiro, 2006, p. 228, in Davis and Hayes, 2011, p. 199).

As a meditational practice, mindfulness meditation, specifies a diversified realm of activities relating to mind, with a common purpose of teaching the self-regulation of attention and awareness (Lomas, Ivtzan, & Fu, 2015), with the aim of improving one's control of mental processes, leading to enhanced sense of wellbeing (Walsh & Shapiro, 2006, in Lomas et al 2017, p.134). Its foundation lies on conventional mindful meditation but as a psychological concept is separate from spiritual beliefs and Buddhist practices (Kabat-Zinn 1982, cited in Khan and Zadeh, 2014, p.70). Mindfulness meditation is often used reciprocally with Vipassana, a form of meditational practice that derives from Theravada Buddhism (Gunaratana, 2002; Young, 1997). Vipassana is also a Pali word for insight and clear awareness and carried out in a manner to gradually enhance mindfulness (Gunaratana, 2002 in Davis and Hayes, 2011, p. 199).

Mindfulness meditation came to be popular in the western world owing to the efforts of Kabat-Zinn (1982), who utilized it for a novel “mindfulness-based stress reduction” (MBSR) programme. There are number of interventions based on mindfulness meditation that we will discuss later on in this unit.

Dimensions of Mindfulness

Based on the above discussion on the meaning of mindfulness, Shapiro et al., (2002) outlined the following qualities of mindfulness, which a person can experience during the ‘moments of mindfulness’.

- *Non-judgmental*: Witnessing the passing thoughts and the present moment without evaluating or putting them in any categories.
- *Non-striving*: Not trying to achieve any specific goals, not getting attached to desirable outcomes.
- *Acceptance*: Being open and accepting of things as they are in the present. It does not indicate passive resignation or unwillingly accepting, but recognizing one’s experiences with awareness and openness.
- *Patience*: Having a composed mind to let things unfold at their own pace. Being patient with ourselves, people around, situations and present moment.
- *Trust*: Having trust in one’s body, one’s feelings and that whatever is happening in life it is supposed to be like that
- *Openness*: Receiving everything as it is happening for the first time. Recognizing possibilities by being fully in the present moment.
- *Letting Go*: Not getting attached to any thought, feeling or experience
- *Gentleness*: Quality of being soft, tender and considerate.
- *Generosity*: Being and giving in the present with love and compassion without getting attached to gains in return.
- *Empathy*: Trying to understand other person feelings, perspective and situation in the present
- *Gratitude*: The quality of appreciating and feeling grateful for the present
- *Loving-Kindness*: The feeling of forgiveness, compassion and unconditional love

11.10 HOW DOES MINDFULNESS WORK?

(a) Biological changes in brain and body

Studies of the biological basis of higher levels of trait mindfulness (e.g., Frewen et al., 2010) propose that mindfulness is linked to differential brain activation during emotional processing (Schutte and Malouff, 2011, p. 1116). Recent advancements in the field of neuroscience have revealed that the brain structure and its functions are not permanent from childhood, rather brain remains plastic and moldable throughout life. A large number of studies using brain imaging/MRI techniques and Randomized Control trials (RCT) methodology to inquire the impact of mindfulness are propounding that mindfulness training have a profound altering effect on the brain’s structure and functioning to enhance the quality of cognitions and feelings. Mindfulness meditation apparently reshapes the neural connections, thereby enhancing the complexity and density of connections in centers linked with thinking abilities (attention, focus, awareness of self, introspection etc.) as well as emotion

areas responsible for kindness, compassion and rationality. At the same time they tend to decrease the activity and growth in brain areas associated with negative emotions like anxiety, hostility, worry and impulsivity (Davidson and Lutz, 2008; Hölzel et al, 2011a and b, in Weare, 2014, p. 5).

Research based on RCT have shown that subjects in a mindfulness meditation group had a significantly higher number of immunoglobulin (antibodies) in the blood in reaction to an influenza vaccine as compared to people in the wait-list control group (Davidson et al, 2003; Davidson and Lutz, 2008). A study using pre-post analysis found that twenty five minutes mindfulness meditation for five days by adults improved their immune-reactivity and led to decrease in stress hormone cortisol (Hölzel et al, 2011a, in Weare 2014).

(b) Personal-psychological changes

Those who practice mindfulness meditation report that over a period of sustained practice and training of mind they learn to focus their attention and consciousness in the present and accept their experience open mindedly as it is, rather than judging and typing it (as positive, negative, right-wrong etc.), by concentrating their attention on the felt physical sensations of the breath and the body to hold the wandering mind. Thoughts are perceived in a detached manner as mental events that come and go. This re-perception helps one to have control and reduce the habitual, mindless automatic mental activity including depressing thoughts, rumination, worrying and leads to less reactivity and impulsiveness, and a better ability to examine thoughts and emotions more objectively, to own them rather than deny or blame others. Conclusively, it can be remarked that meditational practice helps one to gradually come over and modify habitual mental sets and behavioral patterns leading to negative psychic states like stress, depression, frustration, and promote positive mental states like compassion, calm, happiness, receptivity (Weare, 2014).

11.11 BENEFITS OF MINDFULNESS

Research has shown a number of benefits and positive effects of mindfulness in different facets of people's life.

(a) Mindfulness and Well-being

Keyes (2005) regarded well-being as constituting of three domains: *emotional well-being*, involving the combination of positive emotions and life satisfaction; *psychological well-being*, involving contentment with one's achievements and believing in having a larger purpose in life and developing as a person; and *social well-being*, including the quality of one's proclivity toward others. (Howell, Digdan & Buro, 2010, p. 419).

Researchers have contended that mindfulness not only has a direct effect on well-being, but it is also an indirect predictor of wellbeing through its impact on enhanced self-regulated functioning (Brown & Ryan, 2003; Brown, Ryan, & Creswell, 2007b; Shapiro & Schwartz, 1999, 2000 in Howell, Digdan & Buro, 2010, p. 420). Shapiro et al. (2006) propounded that re-perceiving/decentring can have a beneficial impact upon wellbeing (in Lomas et al, 2017, p.134). Mindfulness is regarded to be leading to increased levels of well-being; particularly, mindfulness

is believed to be directly enhancing well-being by making any experience more richer and fuller. Mindfulness can indirectly promote well-being by boosting healthy self-regulation, including a heightened focused attention to, openness and approval of one's personal needs or values and an enhanced ability to act in accordance to them (Brown & Ryan, 2003; Brown et al., 2007a, in Howell et al, 2008, p. 773).

(b) Mindfulness and Physical Health

Research studies indicate that mindfulness meditation results in number of health benefits like enhanced immune functioning (Davidson et al., 2003; see Grossman, Niemann, Schmidt, & Walach, 2004, in Davis and Hayes, 2011, p. 201). Randomised control trial methodology (RCTs, involving comparison of two groups, one who receives the intervention and the other does not, with randomly distributed participants) indicate that mindfulness leads to a decrease in varied physiological problems including chronic pain, fatigue, heart disease, type-2 diabetes, cancer etc. both in adults and youth (Baer 2003; Mental Health Foundation, 2010 in Weare, 2014, p.6). Mindfulness is associated with better heart functioning through a reduced degree of cigarette smoking, greater physical movement, and a healthier body mass index (Loucks, Britton, Howe, Eaton, & Buka, 2015). Furthermore, mindfulness is also positively related with improved blood pressure (Tomfohr, Pung, Mills, & Edwards, 2015), successful weight loss for obese adults and improved eating behaviours (Rogers, Ferrari, Mosely, Lang, & Brennan, 2017 [cited in Ackerman, 2017]).

Mindfulness-based stress reduction (MBSR) has been carried out for patients with a vast variety of chronic clinical ailments, as well as among groups of comparatively healthy individuals who have made efforts in the direction of developing their capacities for coping with stressors of day-to-day life. Initial reports have indicated significant improvement for individuals suffering from chronic pain, fibromyalgia, cancer, anxiety disorders and depression (Arcari, 1997, Astin, 1997, Baime, 1996 in Grossman, Niemann, Schmidt, & Walach, 2004, p. 36).

(c) Mindfulness and Cognitive Functioning

To be able to function and perform to the fullest capability, one requires optimum cognitive functioning like attention, memory, thinking, reasoning, decision making, language etc. When we engage in multitasking, it becomes difficult to carry out focused attention when it is required. Focused attention is not only important for better performance but also for one's sense of psychological well-being. Low level of focused attention can also result in experiencing greater anxiety as our thoughts get us to worry about the future (Cabrera, 2016). The practice of mindfulness meditation can help people to pay focused attention to the present moment and enhance their sense of well-being by reducing stress levels.

Corcoran et.al.(2010) propound that mindfulness meditation develops metacognitive awareness, reduces rumination by way of disconnection from persisting cognitive activities, and promotes attentional abilities through improvement in working memory; these cognitive benefits, consecutively add to effective emotion regulation strategies (in Davis and Hayes, 2011, p. 200).

Mindfulness-based interventions diminish those mechanisms that produce and cause cognitive distortions (Ong, Shapiro, & Manber, 2008; Yook et al., 2008 in Howell et al, 2010 p. 419).

Thus it is helpful to healthy sleep-related functioning.

(d) Mindfulness, Emotional Well-Being and Psychological Health

Mindfulness can help individuals to attain and maintain a positive state of mind, an acceptance of one's self and being comfortable with it. Mindfulness as a trait perspective assumes some people to be more mindful than others; thus people can be trained to be more mindful. Studies have shown dispositional mindfulness (the extent to which a person is mindful) to be associated positively with self-esteem, and self-acceptance (Thompson and Walz, 2008 in Weare, 2014, p. 14). Research has also shown that when mindfulness is improved with the help of interventions like meditation training, it results in subsequent increase in well-being (Falkenstrom, 2010; Fredrickson, Cohn, Coffey, Pek, & Finkel, 2008; Zautra et al., 2008 in Shutte and Malouff, 2011, p. 1116). Other research studies point out that higher levels of mindfulness are linked with more adaptive emotional functioning, termed as emotional intelligence (Baer, Smith, & Allen, 2004; Brown & Ryan, 2003 in Shutte and Malouff, 2011).

Weinstein, Brown, and Ryan (2009) proposed that the more mindful individuals gave more positive stress appraisals and displayed a lower use of avoidance coping, resulting in higher subjective well-being (SWB). Studies have also showed that mindfulness has the capacity to lower negative emotional outcomes resulting from neuroticism (Barnhofer et al., 2011; Feltman et al., 2009). Neuroticism is believed to lead to mood spillover effects because of its association with rumination (Nolen-Hoeksema, Wisco, & Lyubomirsky, 2008). Considering mindfulness intervention programs can reduce ruminative thinking (Deyo, Wilson, Ong, & Koopman, 2009), it seems possible that mindfulness will lower the effects of neuroticism on well-being. (Wenzel et al, 2015, p. 69).

An experimental study by Manaset.al. (2011) examined the effectiveness of mindfulness training to lower the levels of stress and sick leave taken by 31 secondary teachers, wherein 16 were there in the experimental group and 15 were kept in the control group. Findings indicated significant decrease in stress levels of teacher and the duration of sick leave, in addition to decrease in feelings of pressure and feelings of being demotivated and better coping in the experimental group as compared to the control group (Weare, 2014, p. 12).

(e) Mindfulness and Social Well-being

A healthy relationship with one's family, society and community is integral to experience a sense of well-being. Studies have also revealed mindfulness to be effective in relationship building, and predictive of a higher sense of relatedness and interpersonal proximity (Brown and Kasser, 2005; Brown and Ryan, 2003 in Weare, 2014, p. 14). Many scholars in the field are trying to find the link between mindfulness and interpersonal behavior and are examining concepts like "mindful relating" (Wachs & Cordova, 2007), "mindful responding" in couples (Block-Lerner, Adair, Plumb, Rhatigan, & Orsillo, 2007), and "mindfulness-based relationship enhancement" (MBRE) (Carson, Carson, Gil, & Baucom, 2006) [in Davis and Hayes, 2011, p. 201].

There is research evidence to support that trait mindfulness predicts a number of interpersonal issues and behaviors such as ability to manage relationship stress constructively, competence in identifying and expressing emotions to partner, relationship satisfaction, frequency of relationship conflict, level of negativity, and empathy (Barnes, Brown, Krusemark, Campbell, & Rogge, 2007; Wachs &

Cordova, 2007). Barnes et al. (2007) report that individuals with better dispositional mindfulness expressed low level of emotional stress when faced with relationship conflict and reported low level of anger and anxiety during conflict discussion. Studies also show that mindfulness is conversely related to 'distress contagion' and positively linked to the tendency to be aware in one's actions in social situations (Dekeyser, Raes, Leijssen, Leyson, & Dewulf, 2008 in Davis and Hayes, 2011, p. 201).

The above mentioned benefits relating to physical, psychological and social well-being is achieved and maintained by a number of mindfulness based interventions, some of which are discussed below.

11.12 MINDFULNESS-BASED INTERVENTIONS

Mindfulness meditation has been popularized in the West by Kabat-Zinn who has conceptualized and developed a mindfulness-based stress reduction program at the University of Massachusetts Medical Centre in 1979. In 1995, he came up with 'The Center for Mindfulness in Medicine, Health Care, and Society'. The beneficial effects of mindfulness-based interventions (MBIs) in the area of physical and mental health are supported by a plethora of research and have been discussed above. Some of the most popular mindfulness-based interventions are outlined below:

(a) Mindfulness-Based Stress Reduction (MBSR)

MBSR was the first mindfulness-based program for relieving stress and advancing physical-mental health and well-being of individuals. It involves an 8-week course structured in a group format in order for participants to learn and benefit from their collective experience. It is designed to be both education-based and experience-based, combining conventional Buddhist mindfulness meditation techniques (where participants learn to center their focus on the breathing and moving it towards a heightened awareness of other objects of attention like sensations, feelings, thoughts), simple yogic and muscle stretching exercises, practices like the 'body scan', whereby participants concentrate on their bodily parts with mindful awareness and journal tasks to help them integrate mindfulness into daily practice (Kabat-Zinn, 2003).

The program was conceptualized with the purpose of determining the possibility of mindfulness and relaxation exercises to benefit people with chronic health issues like BP problems, anxiety disorders and chronic pain. The intent is to promote overall well-being by helping individuals to focus their attention on their thoughts, feelings and internal states in the present (Mental Health Foundation of New Zealand, 2011).

During the meditation, participants try to do (a) body scanning, which includes nonjudgmental awareness of sensations and feelings in different bodily parts; (b) meditation while sitting, where participants concentrate on their breath, at the same time having a nonjudgmental awareness of any thoughts that crop up; and (c) Hatha yoga involving stretching exercises for strength-ening and easing the musculo-skeletal system. (Cabrera-Caban et al, 2016).

MBSR can be better discerned through the four processes suggested by Hölzel and colleagues (2011): (a) attention regulation, (b) body awareness, (c) emotion

regulation, and (d) change in self-perspective (cited in Cabrera-Caban et al, 2016, p. 122). Generally, participants first learn *attention regulation* by the way of focused meditation, wherein they are cognizant of and pay attention to a given thought, feeling, or object. Over a period of time, with practice, participants are able to focus attention for a longer duration and are better equipped to filter out distractions of the mind. Another technique, *body awareness*, entails focusing attention on sensory experiences and breathing to help individuals to align their thoughts and feelings with the outside world. This is expected to result in better clarity (Marianetti & Passmore, 2009) and emotional intelligence (Keng et al., 2011). The third process, *emotion regulation*, refers to the modification of emotional responses from impulsive reactivity to reflective thinking assisting participants in recognizing their experiences in an accepting, non-judgmental manner. At the last, *change in perception of the self* refers to a transformation from a feeling of static-rigid self-perception to a more dynamic self-image. The belief here is when people feel less static about self, they become more liberated and experience a more positive self-image (Flaxman & Bond, 2010, cited in Cabrera-Caban et al, 2016, p. 123).

(b) Mindfulness-Based Cognitive Therapy (MBCT)

MBCT has its roots in the collective-based, eight-week programme MBSR, but was developed by Zindel Segal, Mark Williams and John Teasdale (2002) to be used by individuals who were suffering from or had experienced multiple incidence of depression in their lives. It combines characteristics of cognitive therapy with mindfulness practices. MBCT is different from cognitive therapy as it involves non-judgmental acceptance of one's thoughts and emotions, instead of making an attempt to assess or modify the content of thoughts. This idea of perceiving the mind as a place of 'being' rather than 'doing' reduces rumination and helps depression-prone individuals to prevent relapse. In their book *Mindfulness Based Cognitive Therapy*, Segal, Teasdale and Williams (2002) proposed that:

'The ultimate aim of the MBCT program is to help individuals make a radical shift in their relationship to the thoughts, feelings and bodily sensations that contribute to depressive relapse'. It also aims to 'help participants choose the most skillful response to any unpleasant thoughts, feelings or situations they meet'.

(c) Dialectical Behaviour Therapy (DBT)

Dialectical behavior therapy (DBT) was given by Marsha Linehan, as a cognitive-behavioural and mindfulness-based therapy for Borderline Personality Disorder (BPD). It was the first psychotherapy propounded to be effective in successfully treating BPD in controlled clinical trials. The essential dialect is between the contradictory forces of change and acceptance, i.e., accepting the things as they are, at the same time working towards their improvement. In DBT mindfulness is learnt as a skill set with the help of systematic exercises. These involve observing, comprehending and engaging in one's present moment experience in a non-judgmental, singular focus and effective way. DBT trains one in how to make use of the 'wise mind' – the latent ability to have clear awareness of one's thoughts and feelings. DBT currently has a substantial research support and is regarded as one of the most effective therapy for BPD as evident from the documented success rates.

(d) Acceptance and Commitment Therapy (ACT)

Acceptance and Commitment Therapy (ACT) is a psychological intervention, based on observations and experience, which aims to improve 'psychological flexibility' in individuals by combining acceptance and mindfulness strategies, with commitment and behaviour change strategies. It is regarded by American Psychological Association as an empirically validated intervention for treating depression. 'Psychological flexibility' here means complete engagement with the present moment having full consciousness and, based on what the situation entails, modifying or persisting with the behavior aligning with the person's preferred values. The therapy draws heavily from cognitive-behavioral framework but diverge in its dominant application of mindfulness exercises to help individuals in attaining flexibility.

The effectiveness of MBIs is undeniable based on the outcomes of meta-analytic studies. However, there are a number of methodological rigor issues that interferes in the global acceptance of MBIs as established psychotherapeutic interventions. The validity of MBI studies gets limited by factors such as wide variations in MBI program design; lack of adequate control for probable confounding factors; paucity of long-term follow-up data assessing the maintenance effects of MBIs; over-dependence on self-report measures etc. Questions have also been raised about the trustworthiness and competence of MBI facilitators. Despite these criticisms mindfulness has witnessed a tremendous increase in popularity over the years and has carved a powerful niche in mainstream psychotherapy (Shonin, Gordon, Griffiths, 2013).

Self Assessment Questions 2

1. The term mindfulness is a translation of which word in Pali language?
2. According to Siegel (2014), what are the three components of mindfulness?
3. What is '*Vipasana*'?
4. Name certain dimensions of mindfulness.
5. Who developed the mindfulness-based stress reduction program?
6. What is Acceptance and Commitment Therapy (ACT)?

11.13 ASSESSMENT OF MINDFULNESS

Having understood the effectiveness of mindfulness based programs on physical and psychological health of participants, it may be helpful to gain awareness about various assessment tools and psychological tests that have been constructed to evaluate mindfulness. This is important for those interested to work in this area, and also to gain an insight about one's own mindfulness. Some of the questionnaires that measure mindfulness as abroad, trait-like inclination for being mindful in day-to-day life are: Freiburg Mindfulness Inventory (Buchheld, Grossman, & Walach, 2001); Kentucky Inventory of Mindfulness Skills (KIMS: Baer et al., 2004); Mindful Attention Awareness Scale (MAAS: Brown & Ryan, 2003); Five-Facet Mindfulness Questionnaire (Baer et al., 2006); Cognitive Affective Mindfulness Scale-Revised (Feldman, Hayes, Kumar, Greeson, & Laurenceau, 2007); Toronto Mindfulness Scale-Trait Version (Davis, Lau,

& Cairns, 2009); Philadelphia Mindfulness Scale (Cardaciotto et al., 2008); and Southampton Mindfulness Questionnaire (Chadwick et al., 2008, in Keng, Smoski and Robins, 2011, p. 3).

Few of these questionnaires conceptualize and assess mindfulness as a uni-factor construct, i.e., based on a unitary factor. For example, the MAAS (Brown & Ryan, 2003) uses a one-dimensional structure of open/receptive attention and awareness to assess mindfulness as the overall inclination to be aware of and observant of daily life situations. There are other questionnaires which assess mindfulness as a multi-factor/multi-dimensional construct. For example, the 'KIMS' (Baer et al., 2004) entails subscales that comprises of four mindfulness competencies underlined in DBT's framework: being aware of one's moment-to-moment experiences, detailing one's feelings and experiences in words, participation with awareness, non-judgmental receptivity of one's experiences. Besides trait measures of mindfulness, state measures of mindfulness are also given to assess transient mindful states. The psychological tests for this purpose include the Toronto Mindfulness Scale (Lau et al., 2006) and Brown and Ryan's (2003) state version of the MAAS (in Keng, Smoski and Robins, 2011, p. 3).

Mindfulness is not limited to meditation exercises, it can be practiced in each and every action of ours in daily living including day to day activities like speech, listening, walking, eating, exercise etc. Some of the common practical applications of mindfulness are given in the boxes below.

Mindful Eating

- Is an increased awareness of what, how, why and when one is eating
- Involves eating slowly and focusing on food while eating, avoid distraction activities like watching Television or seeing mobile etc.
- being aware and able to distinguish between physical and psychological hunger cues and triggers for eating
- Paying attention to the taste, colour, smell, flavors of the food being eaten
- Is beneficial when trying to make changes in one's diet, or lose excess weight, avoid binge eating

Mindful Stretching Exercises

- Involves stretching body muscles, strengthening exercises and simple yoga poses done at slow pace with increased awareness of one's breath at each moment
- Help reduce stress and calms one's mind
- Helpful in connecting with one's body

Mindful Breathing and Meditation

- Involves deep breathing and heightened awareness of one's bodily sensations at the here-and-now
- Choose any comfortable space to sit

- Can choose to place or not place a timer
- Focus on breathing, and each passing breath in and out of your nostril
- Witness the passing thoughts, watch them from a distance as an observer
- Do not get bothered by wandering thoughts, come back again to focus on breathing
- Attention can be focused on any object, sound, image, sensation, thought

11.14 LET US SUM UP

In the present Unit, you learned about flow and mindfulness, two important positive psychology constructs. The meaning of flow was explained and it was differentiated from engagement. Further you learned about how to assess flow and how it impacts our well-being. Mindfulness was described in detail and the benefits of mindfulness on our physical, mental, emotional and social well-being was discussed. Research is abound with the positive impact of mindfulness on different aspects of an individual's being: physical, intrapersonal, interpersonal, cognitive and other aspects. Various mindfulness-based interventions were described such as MBSR, MBCT, DBT, and ACT. People of all age groups, gender orientation, and societies can benefit from mindfulness based programs. Mindfulness based approaches represent an emerging area in the field, one with much potential promise.

11.15 KEY WORDS

Flow	: is a feeling which is characterized by a state of concentration, fulfillment, complete absorption, engagement and competency, and a disregard of the sense of time, ego, bodily needs during the activity.
Autotelic	: refers to the activities like play, dance, games, artistic drawing etc. which are inherently rewarding to the person doing those activities.
Mindfulness	: is the state of being attentive to and aware of what is going on in the present.
Non-striving	: refers to not trying to achieve any specific goals, and not getting attached to desirable outcomes.
Loving-Kindness	: refers to the feeling of forgiveness, compassion and unconditional love.
Dialectical behavior therapy	: (DBT) trains one in how to make use of the 'wise mind' – the latent ability to have clear awareness of one's thoughts and feelings.

11.16 ANSWERS TO SELF ASSESSMENT QUESTIONS

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 1

1. Mihály Csíkszentmihályi (1975, 1990)

2. A few characteristics of the flow experience are altered sense of time, merging of action and awareness, centering of attention, loss of ego etc.
3. Hindu philosophy of Karma Yoga
4. The Flow State Scale II (FSS II) (Jackson & Eklund, 2002), and the Work related Flow scale (WOLF), (Bakker, 2005)

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 2

1. *Sati*
2. The three components of mindfulness are awareness, present experience and acceptance.
3. *Vipassana* is a form of meditational practice that derives from Theravada Buddhism.
4. Non-judgemental, non-striving, acceptance, trust, patience, openness, loving-kindness etc.
5. Kabat-Zinn
6. Acceptance and Commitment Therapy (ACT) is a psychological intervention, based on observations and experience, which aims to improve 'psychological flexibility' in individuals by combining acceptance and mindfulness strategies, with commitment and behaviour change strategies.

11.17 UNIT END QUESTIONS

1. Explain the meaning of 'Flow'.
2. Differentiate between flow and engagement.
3. Discuss mindfulness as a meditational practice.
4. Discuss the mechanisms of mindfulness.
5. Explain how mindfulness contributes to our well-being.

REFLECTIVE EXERCISES:

- *Based on your understanding of the concept of Flow, identify and reflect on those activities where you have a feeling of enjoyment, absorption and flow.*
- *Attempt to make nonjudgmental observations when interacting with classmates, family or friends.*
- *While travelling try to practice some of the skills of mindfulness like letting go, acceptance, moment-to-moment awareness of your thoughts.*
- *When out for a walk, try to be observant of your surroundings, the outside environment, and focus on your bodily sensations.*

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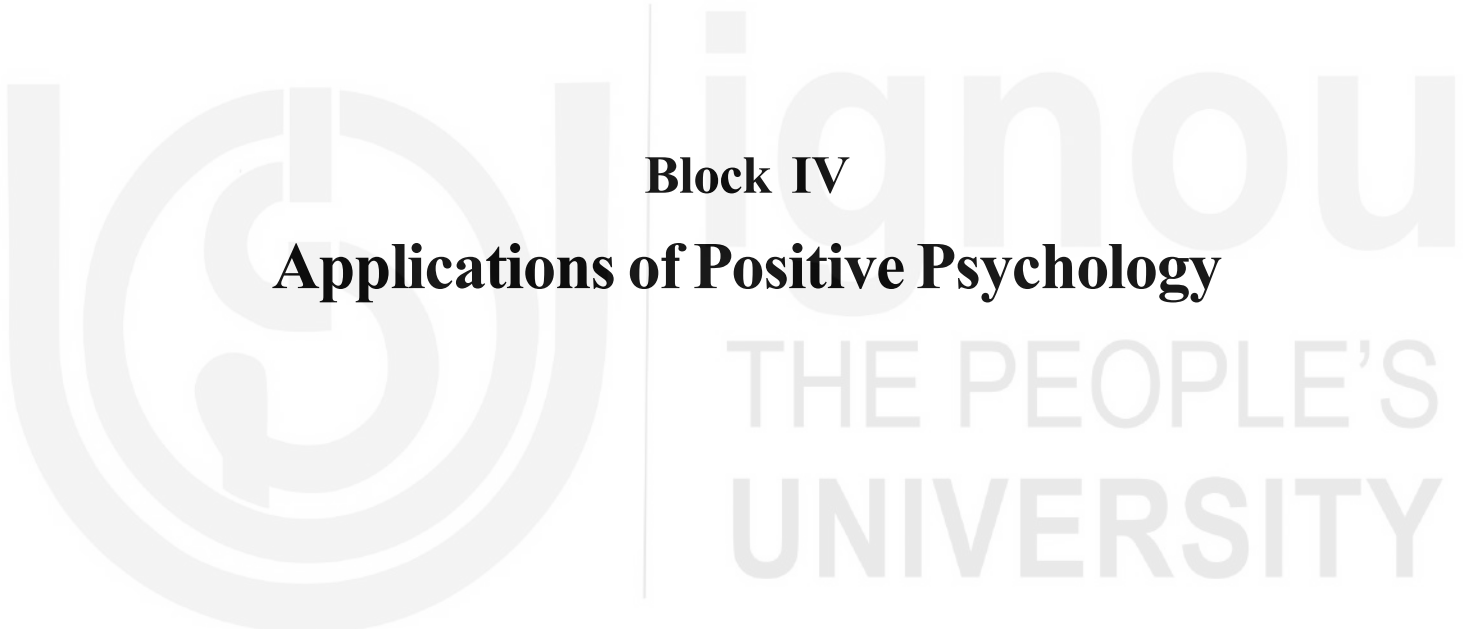
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11.19 SUGGESTED READINGS

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Block IV

Applications of Positive Psychology

UNIT 12 POSITIVE SCHOOLING AND POSITIVE PARENTING*

Structure

- 12.1 Learning Objectives
- 12.2 Introduction
- 12.3 Positive Schooling
- 12.4 Challenges in Indian Schools
- 12.5 Applying Positive Psychology to Schools
 - 12.5.1 Components of Positive Schooling
 - 12.5.2 Theoretical Models of Positive Schooling
 - 12.5.3 Positive Interventions
- 12.6 Positive Parenting
 - 12.6.1 Mindfulness in Parenting
- 12.7 Ways to Practice Positive Parenting
- 12.8 Let Us Sum Up
- 12.9 Key Words
- 12.10 Answers to Self Assessment Questions
- 12.11 Unit End Questions
- 12.12 References and Suggested Readings

12.1 LEARNING OBJECTIVES

After studying this Unit, you would be able to:

- *Explain the concept of positive schooling and positive parenting;*
- *Discuss the components of positive schooling;*
- *Describe the meaning and importance of positive interventions on the well-being of students;*
- *Explain mindfulness approach in parenting; and*
- *Describe the different aspects of engaging in positive parenting.*

12.2 INTRODUCTION

In the previous units you have learned about the constructs of positive psychology. In this unit and subsequent units, you will learn about how we can use positive psychology constructs and principles in different areas to improve various aspects of our lives. In this Unit, you will learn about applications of positive psychology in two crucial areas of parenting and schooling, which are responsible for building the foundation of children.

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Children are the future of any nation that needs to be nurtured. They need to be equipped with necessary life skills so that they reach their optimum development and contribute to the progress of the nation. However, our young generation is not a homogenous group. They come from diverse backgrounds that can impact their growth and development differently. Two significant sources of influence on the lives of children are their parents and their school. Hence it is important to understand these two aspects in a child's life so that they can facilitate comprehensive development of the child. Positive psychology with a focus on "what is good" and "what are the strengths" in the individual, has the potential to contribute to the all round development and well-being of children. In the present Unit, you will learn how positive psychology principles and constructs can be applied in the school context and in parenting practices resulting in a happy, healthy, and resilient future generation.

The Centre on the Developing Child, Harvard University (2021) outlines three core principles as the building blocks to promote positive outcomes for the growing children. These are (a) Responsive relationships with parents, (b) Strengthening of core skills such as cognitive skills, emotion regulation skills in the child, and (c) Reducing sources of stress in children that will make them resilient and contributing members of the society. Both schools and parents can play a huge role here in creating conducive environment at school and home to reduce stress and facilitate positive development of children.

Children enter the school with various levels of expectations, motivation, fear and anxiety regarding how their needs will be met, how others will interact with them, how they will perform, and how they will maintain their self-esteem. These are influenced by various demographic and cultural factors. Hence parents need to be aware and responsive to their children's worries, fears and concerns. At the same time, both parents and school can take care of building up skills in children so that it reduces stress.

12.3 POSITIVE SCHOOLING

Schooling can be considered as the foundation of a child's life. The type of school, nature of the teachers in the school, interaction with the school staff, experience acquired at school – all influence the development of the child. A positive school experience facilitates learning, achievement, skill acquisition and personality development in children; whereas a negative experience at school hampers proper development of children and leaves them inadequate in their knowledge and skills.

What does schooling aim at? Schools are the second home for children and teachers are like their second parents in the early years of schooling. Schooling needs to provide the best of experience to children so they feel cared for. It should impart such education as to instill confidence, and make them self-reliant. Children should not be overloaded with information in the name of education. The aim of education is not only to impart knowledge, but going beyond it to develop character and wisdom in children. The ultimate objective is the harmonious development of a child in physical, mental, social, emotional, moral, and spiritual aspects. This will help children to achieve happiness, success and well-being for themselves, and also contribute to the welfare and happiness of others.

When a child goes to school for the first time, what do they look for? They look forward to being given love, care, affection and support; that they are listened to, feel

involved and given opportunities to explore and learn. What are their parents' apprehensions and expectations? They expect their children are taken care of, are safe, no harm is caused to them, and they learn, acquire knowledge, and gain success and achievement later in life. All this is possible when we create a positive school environment. All children, irrespective of their background and abilities, must feel safe, welcome, and included in the school, and not discriminated, stigmatized, or humiliated and punished. Principles of equity and inclusive education must be embedded in the learning environment to support a positive schooling climate (Deb, 2018).

How do we achieve this positive schooling experience? There are three dimensions to positive schooling:

- **Physical dimension:** It includes proper infrastructure in the classroom and also in the school, proper facilities such as good laboratories, playground, availability of clean drinking water, sufficient toilets for all, provisions for children with disabilities and so on. School should have clean and green space and an inviting, stimulating ambience.
- **Psychological dimension:** It needs to provide opportunities to promote the cognitive capabilities and psychological well-being of children. Use of innovative teaching methods can sustain the interest of children in learning and lead to creativity in them. Proper disciplinary practices will help children develop self-regulation and promote their mental health.
- **Socio-emotional dimension:** The school climate needs to feel warm and welcoming. Schooling needs to develop self-awareness in terms of their emotions, attitudes, beliefs and values; and interpersonal skills. It provides various support services to take care of the emotional and mental health needs of children.

Thus positive schooling aims at creating a positive school climate where children feel safe, included, and accepted, and it actively promotes positive behaviours and interactions (Deb, 2018). It attempts to integrate body, mind, and heart to achieve comprehensive development of children. Schooling aims to not only educate children, provide them training in different subjects and make them ready for future career; schools are also the training ground for inculcating values and disseminating culture, developing compassion and promoting well-being of all.

A Whole School Approach

In addition to the focus on children in school, positive schooling also needs to address the other stakeholders to create a positive climate at school, which will foster positive development in children. Thus a "whole school approach" needs to be followed when we talk about positive schooling. It proposes to adopt whole school thinking where everyone in school thinks and acts in terms of ensuring a positive school climate. Promoting mental health and well-being is everyone's concern. As Weare (2015) puts it, well-being and mental health is "everyone's business" in an authentic whole school approach. A whole school thinking needs to engage the whole school community and start with a positive and universal focus on well-being (Weare, 2015). It is characterized by the following main aspects:

- Engaging students in different aspects of schooling such as learning, voicing their opinions, decision-making
- Explicitly teaching social and emotional skills, attitudes and values to students

- Engaging well-trained teachers and conducting periodic training of teachers to update their knowledge and skills
- Providing support services and interventions to help students facing difficulties, disabilities or any hardship
- Engaging parents and families in school activities
- Engaging specialist staff to cater to specific needs of students with “difficulties”, follow a teamwork approach, and have provisions for referral service.

Thus a whole school approach has multi-components, which encompasses and mobilizes the totality of the school experience to promote well-being and address mental health issues (National Healthy Schools Programme, 2006). It needs to focus on students, teachers, school leaders, school staff, and parents – all working towards a common overarching goal of creating a positive school climate, which will ensure mental health and well-being of all. An example of a successful whole school approach to using positive psychology approaches in the school context is the Positive Education programme of Geelong Grammar School of Australia (Seligman, M. E. P., Ernst, R. M., Gillham, J., Reivich, K., & Linkins, M. (2009). It used the science of positive psychology to improve student and staff well-being and help them flourish. According to Seligman et. al. (2009), positive education, which aims at preparing children for achievement and success in life (which most schools teach), and also increasing their happiness, well-being, resilience, and flourishing (which most parents want), can form the basis of a new prosperity, which values both wealth and well-being.

Positive Schooling and Positive Education: Is there any difference?

Positive schools and positive education both are similar, but they differ in significant ways. Both started around 2008 and aim at achieving well-being of the school community. However, they are different in various key aspects. Positive education focuses on the individual wellbeing, thus indicating that ‘being well’ is an individual responsibility; whereas positive schools considers the entire school as a “social system” which highlights the “contextual responsibility” (e.g., you are not only concerned for your well-being but also that of others around you). Thus context is the primary focus in positive schooling. All the teaching and learning practices are rooted in a healthy contextual development instead of having them as distinct teachings on well-being. It focuses on creating a cultural ethos that supports implementation of various well-being strategies. Further, unlike positive education, which utilizes extrinsic motivators for positive behaviours, positive schools focus on “autonomous motivation” that will actually facilitate well-being in action in the schools. Thus positive schooling adopts more of a socio psychological approach, putting more emphasis on the context.

Source: Street (2021) <https://www.linkedin.com/pulse/positive-schools-education-might-one-day-do-you-know-positive-schools>

Activity

1. Find out examples of various positive schooling programmes in India and also in international scenario. Analyze each and write down the aspects of positive schooling involved in each programme.
2. Observe aspects of positive schooling in any particular school context. Note down the methodology of implementation of it. Further evaluate the outcomes of these programmes.

12.4 CHALLENGES IN INDIAN SCHOOLS

Although discussion of the concept and meaning of positive schooling can be universal, implementation of it needs to consider the sociocultural context. The contextual factors including the demographic variables, the socio-economic background, and the value system will influence the methodology and approach to positive schooling. A basic challenge of Indian education system is - does our schooling system promote learning or achievement only? (Chander, 2022). As stated by Chander, creating conducive learning experiences for adolescents will not only lead to academic achievement but also facilitate holistic development of children and adolescents.

School education also emphasizes more on cognitive development while neglecting the social-emotional learning and mental health related aspects. Krathwohl's taxonomy of affective domain of learning highlights the need for focusing on the affective/emotional aspects in any learning context. As pointed out by Kuboja and Ngussa (2015), affective knowledge significantly impacts our cognitive learning. If the child does not see a "need to learn", then there will be lack of involvement and lack of motivation to learn.

There are a number of other challenges faced by our schools which include lack of infrastructure, lack of facilities, lack of space, student teacher ratio, insufficient number of teachers, disrespect for teachers, bullying, problem behavior, low attendance in school, drop out from school, and lack of parent involvement. Further, it is an exam-driven system with disproportionate focus on marks. The school curriculum lacks in practical application and relating to context of the students. Although with the implementation of the National Education Policy (2020), learning is expected to have more relevance for students as it will involve multidisciplinary and interdisciplinary approaches.

These challenges need to be addressed for having successful outcome from a positive schooling approach. Thus focus needs to be on the following. There needs to be proper infrastructure in the school, a comprehensive curriculum focusing on the all round development of the child, ensuring quality education, well-trained teachers having dedication and commitment, appropriate disciplinary methods, caring and supportive school staff, motivated students, and a visionary leadership. Addressing the mental health concerns of not only the students, but also that of the teachers and the staff – the entire school community is important to create a positive and happy school. Parent-school partnership needs to be strengthened, and there needs to be more collaboration among all the stakeholders in the school system. Adequate budgetary provisions need to be ensured and policy changes be made for achieving the goals of positive schooling.

Self Assessment Questions 1

1. The aim of education is not only to impart knowledge, but going beyond it to develop _____ and _____ in children.
2. Principles of equity and inclusive education will help create a positive schooling climate. True / False
3. Positive schooling focuses on students only, not the entire school. True / False
4. Name the three dimensions of positive schooling.

12.5 APPLYING POSITIVE PSYCHOLOGY TO SCHOOLS

Children today live in a very complex world dominated by media and technology. Their lives and interactions are governed through social media. This has affected their development in all aspects. Digital world is the reality and changing ways of functioning and interacting is also a reality that cannot be avoided. However, we need to equip our children with the core values and strengths that they are resilient enough, can function effectively in the ever-changing world, and thrive in their life. They learn the life values to share and care, and contribute to humanity.

Positive psychology with its focus on bringing out the best in human beings can transform the school experience of children and enable them to achieve success and well-being. Children and adolescents today are facing lots of stress and anxiety due to the changing nature of the society, increasing use of media and technology, and decreasing value systems. As reported by research, at least one in eight adolescents is at risk of mental health problems (Nair, Ganjiwale, Kharod, et al., 2017). Hence it is crucial that we address this need of ensuring positive mental health and promote flourishing within the school community (Norris et al., 2013). As Waters (2014) points out, "a school curriculum that incorporates wellbeing will ideally prevent depression, increase life satisfaction, encourage social responsibility, promote creativity, foster learning and even enhance academic achievement".

12.5.1 Components of Positive Schooling

When we apply positive psychology in the school context, we need to ensure that the foundation of the positive schooling is based on care, trust, and inclusivity. Snyder, Lopez, and Pedrotti (2011) have advocated ***six components of a positive schoolhouse***: foundation level of this house consists of *care, trust, and respect for diversity*; first floor consists of *plans, and motivation*; the second floor consists of *goals*; third floor consists of *hope*; and the roof indicates *contributions to the society*. All these six parts together form the structure of the positive schoolhouse.

A caring attitude by the teachers towards the students and a sense of trust for the teachers by the students are important in contributing to good academic performance as well as psychological benefits (Gilman, Huebner, & Buckman, 2008; Collins, 2001). Care and trust become crucial concerns in case of children from disadvantaged, and difficult background. There also needs to be an acceptance of the diversity of attitudes, beliefs and functioning of the child based on socialization, culture, class, race, ethnicity, age and gender.

Positive schooling approach talks about deciding the goals for each student, i.e., the contents of learning and the curriculum. It needs to involve practical learning experiences, relevant to the sociocultural context of students. To achieve these learning outcomes or goals, planning is required and the students need to be motivated for it.

Hope is a very important component of positive schooling that underlies the aim of education and schooling, i.e., "learning how to learn" (Snyder, Lopez, & Pedrotti, 2011). Teachers are not there just to pass on the information and facts, but to develop ideas in students, empowering them for lifelong learning, and instilling hope in them that they can achieve in life. It is hope only that sustains life and can do wonders.

Finally positive schooling enables the student to look beyond oneself and contribute to the greater good, do something meaningful for the community and society, that can help in the progress of humankind. It is passing the light onto others where you learn or receive things, get enlightened, and then you give back to others. It helps one to create meaning in one's life, leading to authentic happiness.

12.5.2 Theoretical Models of Positive Schooling

Two important models among others that inform positive schooling are *the Values in Action (VIA) Classification of Strengths* (Peterson & Seligman, 2004), and *the PERMA model of well-being* (Seligman, 2011). The **VIA classification** can be considered similar to the classification system of mental disorders that we have such as, Diagnostic and Statistical Manual (DSM) and the International Classification of Diseases (ICD). Given the focus of positive psychology on what is good in people, it becomes natural that we have a classification system for our psychological strengths. This will help understand the strengths and virtues in human beings and take steps to cultivate them to achieve success, happiness and well-being. Such a strengths-based classification system will also change the traditional way of diagnosis and treatment of mental disorders. Peterson and Seligman (2004) thus proposed a Values in Action classification system that consists of 24 character strengths organized under six overarching virtues. These six virtues are Wisdom and knowledge, Courage, Humanity, Justice, Temperance, and Transcendence.

Table 12.1: Virtues and Character Strengths in VIA Classification

VIRTUES	CHARACTER STRENGTHS
Wisdom and Knowledge	Creativity, Curiosity, Judgement, Love of Learning, and Perspective
Courage	Bravery, Perseverance, Honesty, and Zest
Humanity	Love, Kindness, Social intelligence
Justice	Teamwork, Fairness, Leadership
Temperance	Forgiveness, Humility, Prudence, and Self-regulation
Transcendence	Appreciation of beauty & excellence, Gratitude, Hope, Humour, and Spirituality

Schools need to focus on these character strengths to create a positive school climate as well as make each student feel confident, capable and valuable.

The **PERMA model of well-being** is given by Seligman (2011) which talks about five pillars of well-being indicated by the acronym PERMA – *Positive emotions, Engagement, Relationship, Meaning, and Achievement*. Positive schooling needs to focus on creating opportunities for the child to engage in each of these aspects.

Positive emotions refer to the feel good emotions such as happiness, pride, joy etc. When children are involved in activities they like, they enjoy and can excel in those activities also. For example, a child who enjoys singing will put in more effort in learning singing, that is experienced by the whole school community in positive schooling.

Engagement refers to being involved and immersed in an activity so much that you are

in a flow and do not notice the time pass by. Mostly, when one uses one's strengths while doing an activity, one feels engaged and in flow.

Relationships refer to having positive and authentic relationship with others which acts as an important source of happiness and fulfillment.

Meaning indicates deriving a meaning and purpose in whatever we do. Living a meaningful or purposeful life is what makes us go beyond our limited existence and look at a greater perspective. It instills confidence in the person, motivates and inspires the person to contribute to something larger than the self.

Achievement indicates excelling in any field/aspect or experiencing a sense of success. It can be in small things such as completing a story book in two days, keeping your study desk neat and organized, doing exercise for 20 minutes daily, or going for a walk for 30 minutes daily. It will depend on the age of the child. Achieving the set goals helps build confidence, self-esteem and sense of competence in the child.

Thus PERMA offers a multi-dimensional view of happiness and well-being. Applied in the context of schooling, it involves taking up of different activities focusing on feeling good, engaging in meaningful activities, experiencing flow, forming good relationships, and developing a sense of mastery. All these will help in creating a healthy and happy climate in schools.

12.5.3 Positive Interventions

In a review study, Devi and Patra (2020) have highlighted the importance of school-based positive psychology interventions that aim at promoting mental health among the adolescents. Keyes (2002) points out the need for programs focusing on building the positive factors in addition to removal of negative factors. Thus positive psychology interventions (PPIs) aim at promoting positive behavior among students, enhancing their strengths, and helping them flourish. It enhances their resilience, builds positive attributes, and promotes their cognitive-social-emotional skills. The emphasis needs to be on developing the 'whole student' through social, emotional, moral and intellectual development (Noddings, 1995; Palmer, 2003; Cain & Carnellor, 2008).

Positive Psychology Interventions (PPIs) are characterised as "programs, practices, treatment methods, or activities aimed at cultivating positive feelings, cognition, and behaviour" (Sin & Lyubomirsky, 2009). Examples of programmes that have been used effectively for meeting the various objectives of positive schooling include "Bounce Back" programme on resilience (Noble & McGrath, 2008); Hope-based intervention programme (Marques, Lopez, & Pais-Ribeiro, 2011); Positive psychology at school, a school-based intervention programme (Shoshani & Steinmetz, 2013); The Happy Schools Project by the UNESCO in Bangkok (UNESCO, 2016); Improving positive emotions programme (Sanghani, Upadhyay & Sharma, 2013); Promotion of mental health and psychological well-being programme of NIMHANS (Vranda, 2015); and Happiness curriculum programme by the Government of Delhi.

The 'Happiness Curriculum', launched by the Government of Delhi in July 2018 for the students of Nursery to Class 8th in the government schools, focuses on a holistic education. The curriculum involves a "happiness period" of 45 minutes and consists of four parts such as Mindfulness, Stories, Activities and Expression. Studies report satisfaction with the Happiness Curriculum by majority of students, teachers as well as parents (Devi & Patra, 2020). Khanna (2016) has also studied positive psychological

interventions including gratitude, character strengths and stress management among Indian school students.

Majority of the intervention programmes focus on development of character strengths and enhancement of well-being among students and to some extent among teachers. However, as the concept of positive schooling indicates, a whole school approach focusing on creating a positive culture and positive climate in the entire school community needs to be followed, that will facilitate functioning of all school staff and students and their well-being.

The Collaborative for Academic, Social, and Emotional Learning (CASEL) of USA is a school-wide programme which advocates for a systemic social and emotional learning (SEL) along with the academic component across all grades from kindergarten to high school. It focuses on Goleman's five competencies of emotional intelligence such as self awareness, self management, social awareness, relationship skills, and responsible decision-making. The SEL programme involves the entire school community to build a caring and supportive community in which children can thrive and achieve success.

The Panchakosha model mentioned in Indian scriptures (you have learned it in earlier units) can also contribute towards the holistic well-being of school children. Schools can promote the first three levels in this model namely, Annamaya kosha (focusing on proper food and exercise), Pranamaya kosha (focusing on proper breathing), and Manomaya kosha (focusing on training one's mind).

Self Assessment Questions 2

1. What are the six components of a positive schoolhouse ?
2. Name the six virtues in the VIA classification.
3. Who was the target group for the Happiness Curriculum by the Government of Delhi?
4. What are the five competencies proposed by Goleman?

12.6 POSITIVE PARENTING

Parents always try to give their best for the proper development of their children. They want their child to be happy, healthy, and be successful. However, along with having the intention to see our children flourish, it is also important to know the strategies and know-how of achieving that goal. Since each child is uniquely placed in the particular sociocultural context, parenting practices and methods need to take cognizance of these. However, there are common grounds and principles, which need to be ensured for parenting to be effective and help children reach their optimum development and thrive in their life. As stated by Patra (2022), "the larger goals of parenting are usually neglected in the competitive world where every parent wants their child to be the best amongst others, not the best of herself/himself. As a result, the child may gain wide knowledge, acquire various skills, achieve a lot, but may not develop self-awareness, self-connection and self-realization that will give a true purpose to one's life."

Positive parenting refers to the use of positive psychology principles and techniques in child rearing practices. Thus instead of focusing on what is wrong in the child, it emphasizes what is right and good in the child. It also focuses on the parents themselves

– being self-aware, being mindful, and learning to see the larger goal of parenting. Listening to the child, understanding the needs of the child and being a good role model will help the child feel loved and confident.

According to Seay et al. (2014, p.207), positive parenting is the continual relationship of a parent(s) and a child or children that includes caring, teaching, leading, communicating, and providing for the needs of a child consistently and unconditionally. Thus it involves nurturing the child, and enabling the acquisition of skills, development of potentials, empowering and thriving of them. This requires a balanced approach to cater to their needs and at the same time making them learn a disciplined way of functioning and good value system.

Two main issues in parenting involves how demanding and how responsive the parents are towards the child. This intersection between demandingness and responsiveness gives rise to four parenting styles namely, authoritarian, authoritative/democratic, permissive, and negligent/indifferent parenting (Baumrind, 1971; Maccoby & Martin, 1983).

Table 12.3: Four Parenting Styles

	HIGH CONTROL	LOW CONTROL
	AUTHORITATIVE	PERMISSIVE
HIGH RESPONSIVENESS	Firm & consistent control	Frequent expression of warmth & affection
	Monitor & impart clear standards for their children's conduct	Low enforcement of rules & authority
	Give priority to child's needs & abilities	High acceptance
	Implying age appropriate maturity demands	Taking the role of friend rather than parent
	Encourage children to be independent	Allow the child to make their own decisions
	Attentive	Minimal punishment
	Forgiving	
	Offering democratic climate	
	AUTHORITARIAN	NEGLIGENT
LOW RESONSIVENESS	Expecting strict, unquestioned obedience to parental authority	Inattentive behaviour
	Not Notready to accept child's individuality	Neglecting the child
	Disobedience is dealt by forceful & punitive discipline	Little interaction with the child
	Little communication between parent & child	
	Highly directive behaviour	

Source: Patra, S. (2021). Unit 12 Positive Childhood. BPCG 175: Psychology for Living, Bachelors Degree Programme, IGNOU, New Delhi.

Authoritative parenting style has been found to be the most effective one as it brings in a positive approach to parenting practice and parent-child relationship. It reflects a democratic approach towards parenting and considers children as individuals in their own right. Such parents exude warmth along with firm discipline, they guide as well as provide instruction, set limits as well as provide freedom to their children. They are caring, supportive and convey the feeling of acceptance to the child. They value their children for who they are, not for what they lack or achieve. They also have open and clear communication with their children without judging. They exhibit mindfulness in their parenting behavior and interaction with the child.

Let's Apply

Look for any instance where parents have to face the tantrums of a child, e.g., in a mall, restaurant, family function etc. Observe how the parents behaved in that situation. Reflect on how would you bring in an authoritative parenting approach in that situation.

12.6.1 Mindfulness in Parenting

Parenting is a challenging task and can be a stressful experience in the background of various factors such as lack of support, dual working families, competitive world, influence of social media on the young generation, and so on. This requires that we bring in a mindfulness approach to the parent-child relationship that will enable the parents to focus on themselves and their approach to child-rearing and also help realize the goals of parenting by developing the child into a good human being (Patra, 2022). Mindfulness has the potential to enhance the family system and interaction patterns (Dumas, 2005). Being mindful helps the parent in reducing stress, more aware of the child's needs, suspend judgement at the moment, focus on parent-child relationship itself, and become aware of child's well-being (Patra, Unit -12, BPCG 175, IGNOU).

Mindfulness refers to awareness of any object, stimulus or experience in the present moment without passing any judgment on it. As stated by Kabat-Zinn (2003, p.145), mindfulness refers to the moment-to-moment awareness that occurs when we pay attention, on purpose, in the present moment, and with a non-judgmental attitude towards any stimulus/ experience. Usually, we are not aware of our thoughts, emotions and how they impact our behavior in the present moment. There is a habitual pattern, which we may not notice in a given situation. We function in an autopilot mode. Parents need to notice their own thoughts and emotions while interacting with their child so that they can regulate their behavior for an effective response rather than reacting to the child. Mindfulness helps one to engage in self-regulation (Brown, Ryan, & Creswell 2007).

Mindful parenting is defined as parents' abilities to pay attention to their child and their parenting in a way that is intentional, present-centered, and nonjudgmental (Kabat-Zinn & Kabat-Zinn, 1997). A model of mindful parenting developed by Duncan, Coatsworth & Greenberg (2009) focuses on mindfulness in the social context of the parent-child relationship. It included the following five dimensions of mindful parenting: (a) listening with full attention; (b) nonjudgmental acceptance of self and child; (c) emotional awareness of self and child; (d) self-regulation in the parenting relationship; and (e) compassion for self and child. Various studies have pointed out the benefits of mindful parenting (Sondhi, 2017; Sharma & Singh, 2016; Bawa et. a., 2015; and Kang et al., 2018).

Parents with an authoritative or democratic style of parenting reflect mindfulness in their approach. They take cognizance of their own thoughts and emotions in the specific situation, empathize with the child's needs, and take action keeping in mind the larger parenting goals. For instance, when the child throws out a tantrum when visiting a shopping mall, the parent needs to be first aware of her emotions in the situation, regulate them, and be clear in her approach to child. The parent needs to be firm but loving and understanding towards the child throughout.

Let's Apply

You must be having children at your home or in relative's or friend's place. Observe the interaction of parents with their child. Does the parent-child relationship reflect mindfulness on the part of the parents? Write down how mindfulness is reflected in their expression of emotions and behavior.

12.7 WAYS TO PRACTICE POSITIVE PARENTING

As discussed in the earlier sections, a democratic approach to parenting reflects the best style of parenting. It consists of various skills that help create a positive family atmosphere in which children can learn optimally and achieve their potentials. It ensures a positive parent-child relationship which makes the child self-confident and flourish. Positive parenting focuses on the care and development of both the child as well as the parent. Here we discuss five main aspects of positive parenting that will help one to practice positive parenting.

- **Safe and Stimulating Environment:** Create a safe base for the child in which they can explore, learn and grow. Children need to feel secure so that they can develop properly. A secure attachment and strong emotional bonds will help the child deal with any type of developmental challenges. Positive parenting also ensures to provide such an environment that is stimulating enough for the optimal development of the child.
- **Realistic Expectations:** Parents need to have realistic expectations from their child. It is important to remember that children have their own life and they are not mere extensions of parents. As Kahlil Gibran says,

Your children are not your children

They are the sons and daughters of life's longing for itself

They come through you but not from you

And though they are with you yet they belong not to you.

Further, each child is different and influenced by the context, both immediate and larger context in which they live. The ecological theory of Bronfenbrenner (1977), later revised as Bioecological model (Bronfenbrenner & Morris, 2006) highlights the influence of multiple systems of surrounding environment on the child's development. The contexts of family, school, neighbourhood, community, society and nation, with their laws, customs, and value system, social media and digital world, technological advancements etc. – affect the child development and functioning. Later on, he focused on the developmental processes experienced by the individual across the developmental stages.

Hence parents need to understand the child in the context of dynamic interaction of these environments and developmental processes, and have realistic expectations.

- **Positive Discipline:** Positive parenting does not use discipline in the commonly used sense, that is, it does not use it in a negative sense such as shouting, physical punishment, threatening, shaming, blaming etc. Rather, it uses positive discipline which includes clear and open communication, behaving in an assertive manner, and at the same time understanding the needs of the child and using positive reinforcement. Parents exhibit mindfulness in listening to their child and also being aware of the impact of child's behavior on themselves. Positive discipline as the name suggests, emphasizes the positive aspects of behavior. It states that there is no bad child, only bad behavior and good behavior. Thus it clearly outlines the good and appropriate behaviours for the child and also the consequences for showing good or bad behavior. It combines firmness with loving and empathetic behaviour towards the child.
- **Self Care:** The main focus in parenting is usually the child. However, parents also deserve the focus equally. Parents need to take care of themselves so that they can be self-aware and regulate their emotions. It will also help them be empathetic, kind and compassionate towards their own self. Parenting is a round the clock responsibility. Parents will always do their best to serve their child's interests. They need to take a break for their own sake so that they can meet their child's needs better.

Parenting can be considered as a full time job. It is definitely a very challenging experience. However, the use of positive parenting can help us make it a satisfying and fulfilling experience rather than being a stressful one. Positive parenting makes the child feel loved, respected and valued. It helps the parents to be sensitive, mindful, and responsive to the parent-child relationship. It can reduce behavioural problems in the child, develop the necessary skills in the child for self-regulation, makes the child responsible, self-confident, and thrive in life.

Self Assessment Questions 3

1. The four parenting styles are based on which two dimensions ?
2. Which parenting style is considered as a positive parenting style ?
3. Mindfulness helps one to engage in auto-pilot mode of thinking. True / False.
4. The ecological theory of Bronfenbrenner emphasizes on the context of the child affecting development. True / False.

12.8 LET US SUM UP

The present unit focused on two key aspects in a child's life, that is, parents and teachers – how these need to be informed by a positive psychology approach so that we achieve the ultimate goals of parenting and teaching. The meaning and components of positive schooling and positive parenting were described. You also learned about the models of well-being that influence the application of positive psychology in the

school context. Mindfulness as an important approach to parenting was described. Further, you learned about various aspects in the practice of positive parenting.

12.9 KEY WORDS

- Positive Schooling** : aims at creating a positive school climate where children feel safe, included, and accepted, and it actively promotes positive behaviours and interactions (Deb, 2018).
- PERMA Model of Well-being** : describes well-being in terms of five pillars such as Positive emotions, Engagement, Relationship, Meaning, and Achievement.
- Positive Psychology Interventions** : (PPIs) aim at promoting positive behavior among students, enhancing their strengths, and helping them flourish.
- CASEL** : (Collaborative for Academic, Social, and Emotional Learning) of USA is a school-wide programme which advocates for a systemic social and emotional learning (SEL) along with the academic component across all grades from kindergarten to high school.
- Positive Parenting** : refers to the use of positive psychology principles and techniques in child rearing practices which focuses on the strengths of the child.
- Authoritarian Parenting** : is characterized by highly directive behaviour from the parents, parental expectations of strict compliance from the child and punitive discipline.
- Authoritative Parenting** : refers to being consistent and firm in their disciplinary behaviour and creating a democratic climate in the process of child-rearing.
- Mindfulness** : refers to the moment-to-moment awareness that occurs when we pay attention, on purpose, in the present moment, and with a non-judgmental attitude towards any stimulus/experience
- Mindful Parenting** : is defined as parents' abilities to pay attention to their child and their parenting in a way that is intentional, present-centered, and nonjudgmental (Kabat-Zinn & Kabat-Zinn, 1997).

12.10 ANSWERS TO SELF ASSESSMENT QUESTIONS

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 1

1. character and wisdom
2. True
3. False
4. Physical, psychological, and socio-emotional

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 2

1. The six components of a positive schoolhouse are (a) care, trust, respect for diversity, (b) plans, (c) motivation, (d) goals, (e) hope, and (f) contributions to the society.
2. The six virtues are Wisdom and knowledge, Courage, Humanity, Justice, Temperance, and Transcendence.
3. students of Nursery to Class 8th in the government schools of Delhi
4. self awareness, self management, social awareness, relationship skills, and responsible decision-making

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 3

1. demandingness and responsiveness
2. authoritative parenting style
3. False
4. True

12.11 UNIT END QUESTIONS

1. Explain the challenges in Indian school system and discuss how they can be overcome to bring aspects of positive schooling.
2. Discuss the theoretical models of well-being that explain positive schooling.
3. Discuss the positive interventions that can help in creating positive behavior and positive school climate.
4. Explain the concept of positive parenting in the light of the challenges to parenting in the modern age.
5. Discuss the ways to practice positive parenting.

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UNIT 13 APPLYING POSITIVE PSYCHOLOGY IN RELATIONSHIP, FAMILY AND AGING*

Structure

- 13.1 Learning Objectives
- 13.2 Introduction
- 13.3 Close Relationships
 - 13.3.1 Understanding Love
 - 13.3.2 Understanding Adult Attachment Security
 - 13.3.3 Understanding Friendships
- 13.4 Applying Positive Psychology in Close Relationships
- 13.5 Context of Family
 - 13.5.1 The Circumplex Model of Family
- 13.6 Applying Positive Psychology in the Family Context
- 13.7 Concept of Aging
 - 13.7.1 Successful Aging
 - 13.7.2 Theories of Successful Aging
- 13.8 Applying Positive Psychology for Successful Aging
- 13.9 Let Us Sum Up
- 13.10 Key Words
- 13.11 Answers to Self Assessment Questions
- 13.12 Unit End Questions
- 13.13 References
- 13.14 Suggested Readings

13.1 LEARNING OBJECTIVES

After going through the Unit, you will be able to:

- *Describe the concept and constitution of close relationships and family;*
- *Learn to apply positive psychology constructs in enhancing close relationships and in the family context;*
- *Explain the concept of aging and theories of successful aging; and*
- *Learn about positive aging.*

13.2 INTRODUCTION

Ramya and Ajay had to do work from home due to the COVID 19 pandemic. Initially they were quite excited that they would be able to spend more time together

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*with their 4-year old child as a family. However, working from home in reality did not have any fixed work timings. They did not have much privacy to work in peace, had to manage household tasks, and also attend their kid's online classes as per the school's instructions. Staying together 24*7 turned into bickering and feelings that one was contributing to home chores more than the other. One weekend, Ramya and Ajay decided that they need to work things out. They talked for hours and figured out a routine for themselves. In the process, they realised that they were both doing things that the other was not acknowledging. While things still do get chaotic for them sometimes, they remember to support and thank each other for the little things they do. Their mood would instantly change and would willingly help out each other.*

The above scenario reflects the application of concepts in positive psychology. Amidst all the challenges, Ramya and Ajay maintained a positive outlook, communicated with each other about their feelings, and expressed gratitude for each others' presence and help. Positive psychology is the science that builds on the premise that human beings have the potential and strengths to deal with adversities and overlook shortcomings. Applied positive psychology makes use of the principles and concepts of positive psychology in various aspects of our life. It facilitates optimal functioning in terms of better mental status and physical health through positive psychology research.

Applied positive psychology is an approach that reverses our general focus from disorder and distress to a positive uplift of human functioning and fulfilment. Seligman (2004) delineated the process of positive psychology as follows:

- Facilitation: Applied positive psychology does not force any perspective rather helps you to explore and achieve your objectives.
- Optimal functioning: It addresses our level of subjective wellbeing (eg. "How much do we enjoy our everyday life?") and psychological wellbeing (eg. "How well do we engage with opportunities and challenges of everyday life?").
- Value position: The intention of positive psychology is not to undermine the specific ways in which people choose to live their life. Positive valuing of choices is not dictative in applied psychology. For example, a homemaker may enjoy their activities throughout the day, and engage in self fulfilment rather than subjugate to choices made by the society.
- Full range of human functioning: Positive psychology aims not to simply focus on symptomatic psychopathology. The target is to equip clients to identify value characteristics and gain a state of wellbeing.
- A collective identity: Positive psychology entitles every person to a journey of being better. In this context, Duckworth, Steen, and Seligman (2005) have aptly explained positive psychotherapy as "build what's strong" as opposed to "fix what's wrong".

In the present Unit, we will discuss about the applications of positive psychology in achieving flourishing relationships, a harmonious family, and in successful aging.

13.3 CLOSE RELATIONSHIPS

Wife: Look I bought a new pair of jeans, isn't it nice?

Husband: You bought another one! How you waste our hard earned money!

Wife: What about the useless things you spend money on? It's my money too. I will spend the way I like it. It was stupid of me to show it to you. You wouldn't have noticed it anyway.

Just like in the above situation, we tend to forego appreciation and almost automatically criticise each other in long spanned relationships. It is a fact that our close relationships hold a very high place in our life. If you feel supported in your relationships, you tend to feel or do well in other areas of your life too. Reciprocally, if you feel unhappy in your relationship, the frustration spills over in other domains of life. The importance of relationships has been aptly pointed out by Dr. Martin Seligman in his model of PERMA (Positive emotion, Engagement, *Relationships*, Meaning, Accomplishments) that explained contributors of flourishing in humans (Seligman, 2002). Precisely so, Dr. Christopher Peterson too, described the foundational basis of positive psychology in three simple words: “*Other people matter*”.

It is a common notion that affiliation oriented societies would expect lower divorced rates or languished marriages. Is that the reality, though? More frequently than not, we blame fate/chance/luck in matters of relationship in case of marital disharmony. For instance, if you would like to score well in your exams, would studying once in six months be enough? Like any other area of our life where we desire to be successful, relationships too shall flourish if we put in consistent efforts.

How do we distinguish close and casual relationships? Close relationships are characterized by high levels of:

- *Trust*: no threat felt with self disclosure
- *Knowledge*: mutual understanding of each other's preferences
- *Care*: concern and responsibility for each other
- *Interdependence*: intertwined lives
- *Commitment*: dedication towards the relationship during good and bad times
- *Intimacy*: emotional connection and sharing of thoughts, feelings, etc.

Close relationships can further be understood in two ways: platonic friendships versus romantic relationships; where the latter is marked by sex and passion, and typically involves attachment to one person at a time.

In the following sections we will discuss close relationships by understanding love, attachment, and friendships.

13.3.1 Understanding Love

- ***Sternberg's Triangular Theory of Love***

A good index of positive functioning in romantically inclined couples was postulated by Sternberg in the Triangular Theory of Love (Sternberg, 1986). According to this theory, a relationship has three major components: intimacy, passion, and decision/commitment. A number of combinations of these components gives rise to different experiences (eg. romantic love is composed of passion and intimacy), different importance levels (eg. admiration for a successful person in your community—infatuation), in different points in time of our life (eg. a young adult looking for a partner—companionate love). When all the components are

expressed, it composes an ideal relationship, the absence of which may result in an unsatisfactory relationship.

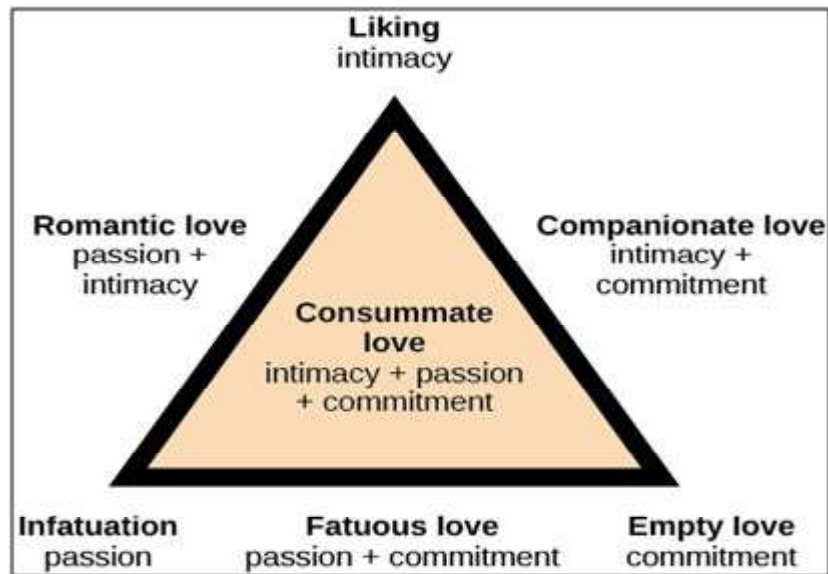


Fig.13.1: Types of Love according to Triangular theory of love

<https://psych2go.net/according-sternbergs-love-theory-three-components-love-commitment-passion-intimacy/>

- **Lee's Theory of Love**

Lee's (1977) understanding of love styles was compared to a color wheel, in which love existed in many styles such as primary, secondary, and even tertiary. There are three primary styles: Eros (passionate, romantic love), Ludus (playful love), Storge (friendship love). The secondary styles are a combination of two primary styles: Pragma (practical, rational love; a combination of Storge and Ludus), Mania (obsessive or addictive love; a combination of Eros and Ludus), and Agape (altruistic/selfless or unconditional love; a combination of Eros and Storge). A comprehensive summary of love styles and their characteristics can be referred to in Table 13.1 below.

Table 13.1: Love styles and their characteristics (Lee, 1977)

Love styles	Main characteristics
Eros Primary style	It is typical of persons with passionate and romantic attitude toward love; it is based on passion feeling as well as physical and emotional attraction toward partner
Ludus Primary style	It is a typical attitude of persons who see love as a game; the focus of ludus people is on having fun in the moment and therefore they live their relationship in an uncommitted way
Storge Primary style	It is a friendly love attitude, as the persons with this love style tend to express friendship feeling toward the others; their couple relationships are based also more on similar interests and commitment with the partner rather than on passion
Mania Secondary style	It is the expression of a manic attitude towards love, implying possessive and obsessive behaviours; the persons with this love style need to be loved by one's partner and they are possessive and jealous lovers
Pragma Secondary style	It is typical of persons who express a pragmatic and rational attitude toward love; for this reason, they tend both to choose the partner basing upon the characteristics they believe are important to them and to look for partners with whom they can share common goals
Agape Secondary style	This love style distinguished persons with altruistic attitudes and behaviours; they tend to live an unconditional, selfless love, and they tend in willing to sacrifice anything for the others to whom they provide support, care and respect

Source: (Raffagnino & Puddu, 2018)

Based on Lee's theory of love, *The Love Attitude Scale* was developed to assess different love styles among couples (Hendrick & Hendrick, 1986). This questionnaire is predictive of satisfaction and relational involvement. It is a useful map for psychologists to understand the areas of distress in couples.

13.3.2 Understanding Adult Attachment Security

Attachment is described as a psychological connectedness between human beings (Bowlby, 1979). It has four main characteristics: (a) maintaining proximity with the person, (b) feeling safe with the person, (c) returning for security to the person, and (d) anxiety in the absence of the person. Observations of Ainsworth (1979) in infant caregiver relationship correlate with attachment styles in adults—secure, avoidant, and fearful avoidant. On similar lines, Hazan and Shaver (1987) explored attachment in romantic relationships. It was also suggested that adult relationships work just like children-caregiver relationship, and these childhood representations are reflected in the choice of relational experiences.

Brennan, Clark & Shaver (1998) findings suggest that there are two elementary dimensions of adult attachment (Refer to Fig. 13.2 below). One dimension is 'attachment related anxiety' and the other is 'attachment related avoidance'. High scorers in case of anxiety prone attachment are typically worried about responsiveness, availability, and attentiveness of their partner. Low scorers tend to be secure about their partner's responsiveness. Similarly, avoidant type attachment is bipolar indicating that high scorers are poorly adjusted and aloof, compared to low scorers who enjoy the closeness of relationships. An individual scoring low on both these dimensions would be identified as a secure adult in relationships.

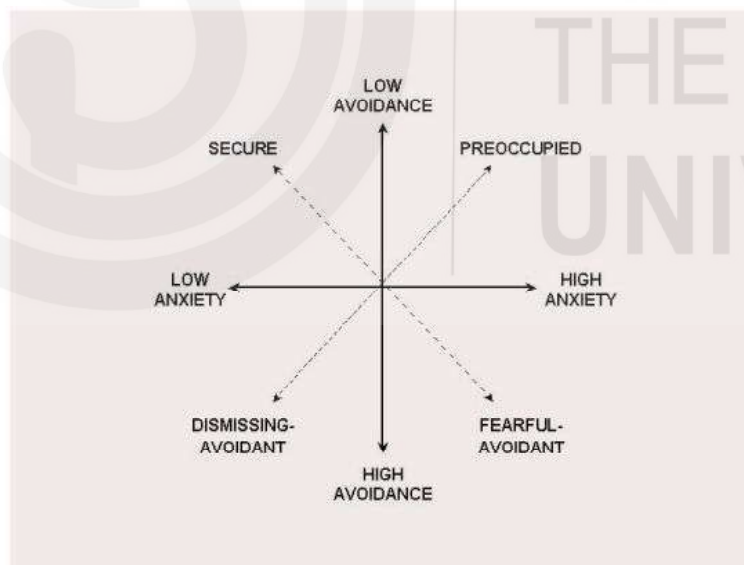


Fig. 13.2: Adult attachment styles (Brennan, Clark, & Shaver, 1998)

<http://labs.psychology.illinois.edu/~rcfraley/attachment.htm>

13.3.3 Understanding Friendships

Friendship is a “voluntary interdependence between two persons over time that is intended to facilitate socio-emotional goals of the participants, and may involve varying types and degrees of companionship, intimacy, affection and mutual assistance” (Hays, 1988). Friends are a part of our micro system that is based on mutual respect, appreciation and liking. The *social support hypothesis* also recognizes the protective

effect of supportive interactions in the face of stress. Friendships are quite dynamic in nature, and may be short lived too. However, the proximity or emotional intimacy with friends depends upon our need for emotional connection/emotional loneliness (Cacioppo & Patrick, 2008); it also highlights the two benchmarks that qualify for friendship: quality (degree of intimacy) and conflict (number of psychologically distressing situations).

Oswald (2017) documented four important factors that help to maintain friendships:

- Emphatic happiness— Sharing of good news or positive events
- Availability of social support
- Non-judgemental acceptance
- Quality and quantity of time spent in company

Several studies have pointed out that these qualities help to enhance happiness (Mikulincer & Shaver, 2013), satisfaction and wellbeing (Braithwaite & Holt-Lunstad, 2017), feelings of trust (Keltner et al. 2018).

Self Assessment Questions 1

1. What does positive psychotherapy aim at?
2. What does PERMA stands for?
3. Differentiate between close and casual relationships.
4. What are the three components of Sternberg's Triangular Theory of Love?
5. What are the three primary styles of love in Lee's theory of love?
6. What are the major types of attachment styles found in adults?

13.4 APPLYING POSITIVE PSYCHOLOGY IN CLOSE RELATIONSHIPS

The various concepts of positive psychology that we have studied in earlier units can be applied in the context of close relationships to help it thrive. Some of the strategies to enhance our close relationships using positive psychology constructs are described below.

(1) Spotting Strengths

When you are angry with a person, what are the usual things that come to your mind about that person? Phrases like “She is always indecisive”, and “He is always temperamental”, and so on. Well, we are well versed with weakness spotting or problem spotting. Positive psychology urges us to practice the contrary, i.e. to spot strengths in our relationships. Linley (2008) has defined strength as “*a pre-existing capacity for a particular way of behaving, thinking, or feeling that is authentic and energizing to the user, and enables optimal functioning, development and performance.*” Kashdan et al (2018) in their research study involving couples in romantic relationships reported that partner strength perceptions predicted better daily relationship satisfaction.

Box 1: Tips to help Strength Spotting:

- Listen for passion and energy while they talk about things that excite them.
- Elicit strengths by asking: What are you good at? What are your aspirations? How did you reach so far in life?
- Observe energy and engagement in patterns of success while discussing a project or a household task.
- Look for strength within: When you notice your own strengths, it is more likely you would notice others' strengths too.

(2) Strengths and Fulfilled Dreams Genogram

Adapted from the family genogram technique (McGoldrick and Gerson, 1985), this technique is a visual diagram of significant relationships. It reconstructs positive characteristics and achievements. This helps to materialise the unacknowledged traits and past experiences. Further, it may be used constructively in framing positive inquiry such as: How would you use your strength to resolve this issue? (Kauffman & Silberman, 2009). Cook and Poulsen (2011) have additionally suggested the use of photographs in the genogram method for it to be a more dynamic and enriching experience for the couples. Figure 13.3 below provides an example of strengths and fulfilled dreams genogram.

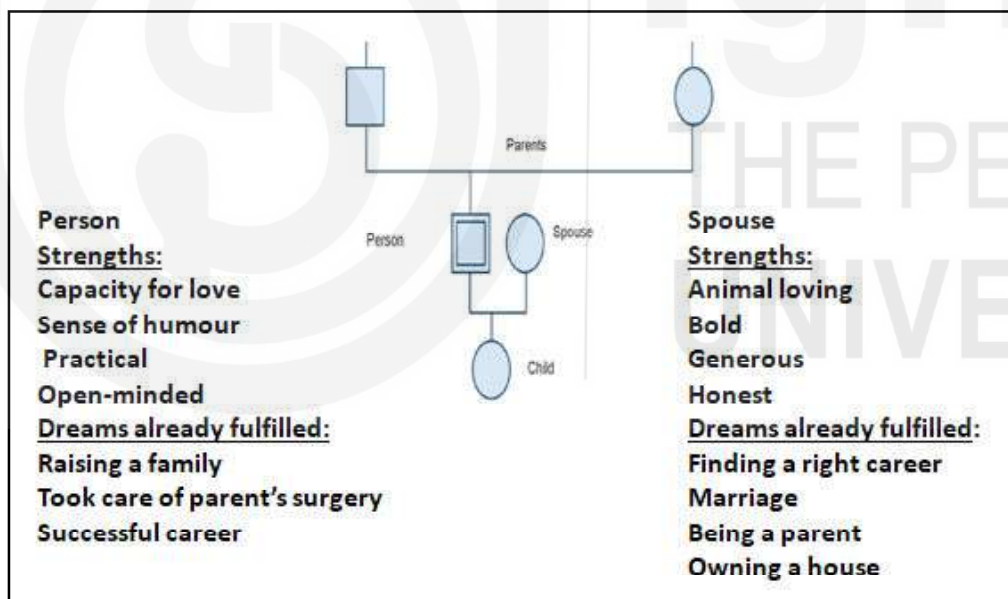


Fig.13.3: Strengths and Fulfilled Dreams Genogram (Adapted from Perloiro, Neto, and Marujo, 2010)

(3) The Sound Relationship House

The Sound Relationship House is a metaphorical house of a secure relationship. Based on decades of research on divorced and sustained marriages, Dr. John Gottman and Dr. Julie Schwartz Gottman developed the Gottman model (2013). They spotted the Four Apocalyptic Horses (a Biblical reference) of marriage that could destruct a marriage. They are

- Criticism
- Defensiveness

- Contempt
- Stonewalling, or withdrawing from interaction

These factors are accountable for an obstructed communication pattern which has to be negated to achieve a flourishing relationship.

The Sound Relationship House (Fig. 13.4) helps to ascertain a developable skill essential to a healthy relationship. Each floor of the house gradually builds into a concrete structure symbolic of a flourishing relationship.



Fig. 13.4: Gottman's Sound Relationship House

(Source: McNulty, 2013)

<https://www.gottman.com/blog/an-introduction-to-the-gottman-method-of-relationship-therapy/>

Gottman also categorized marital conflict into two kinds: (a) resolvable conflicts, which eventually get solved over time, and (b) perpetual conflicts, which are the ones that always exist and require crisis management. Positive therapy sourced on this concept was seen to be effective in improving marital adjustment and couples' intimacy in 16 couples who were part of a semi experimental study (Davoodvandi, Nejad, and Farzad, 2018). Similar effectiveness of this therapy was reported in a study of 106 gay and lesbian couples (Garanzini et. al., 2017).

(4) Emotional Bank Account

Centred on the Gottman Relationship model described above, the emotional bank account is a good exercise for couples to work on their intimacy, conflicts, and emotional distance. This system is identical to a financial bank based on deposits and withdrawal. Imagine a scenario where your spouse gets hurt accidentally. You can do one of the two things, turn towards or turn away. Turning towards may be as simple as acknowledging, "Oh! I am sorry you got hurt, does it pain?" This is simple emotional connection with the partner (making a deposit). On the other

hand, just ignoring it altogether is taking away the chance to make an emotional connection (withdrawal). Just like reality, a zero balance bank account can make one feel insecure and lonely, and a negative one is sign of danger. A general rule of thumb is to have at least 5 positive interactions to 1 negative reaction during a conflict and 20:1 in everyday life. This way the benefit of doubt will tend to outweigh the negative approach to conflict.

Invest in your Emotional Bank

- *Be mindful of each others' needs*
- *Express appreciation for small things and big*
- *Talk about your stress*
- *Don't try to solve the problem; rather understand it*
- *Show physical gestures of affection*

(5) Three Good Things

Another great way of dealing with negative ruminations of a conflicted relationship would be to explore the “three good things”. For this activity, each partner is supposed to note three positive behaviour of the other. Not only this, they can be encouraged to reflect upon their own contribution to the positively noted act/gesture. Regular appreciation will tend to decrease the likelihood of ignored positive emotions. A mixed method study by Boiman-Meshita, and Littman-Ovadia (2021) reported that this activity increased intimacy in the 40 couple belonging to the intervention group. In the qualitative follow-up, most couples said that noting three good things had a positive implication on their emotions, behaviour, and thinking.

(6) Instilling Hope

Hope is linked with the pursuit of goals. Snyder (2002) conceptualized hope as a belief—that identifies the journey towards a goal (pathway) and the sustenance required towards the certain goal (agency). In relationships, individuals with high hope are able to map personally meaningful goals and believe their capabilities to reach that goal. For example, in order to resolve a conflict (goal), let us suppose the husband is somebody with high hope, he will be able to recognize strategies that may work to dissolve the anger between them (identify pathways). It is not enough that he recognizes the ways to apologize or confront, but he must also have the motivation and courage to do it (identify agency). Dependent on whether the individual has an extremely low pathway or extremely low agency, a positive psychologist may develop individualized therapy like development of specific goals, identification of resources, build pathways and agency. Koshkaram & Golzari (2011) reported significant improvement in marital satisfaction with the help of hope therapy in insecure attachment style married individuals.

(7) Minding of Relationships

Harvey and Omarzu (1997) theorized that minding in relationship is essential to enhance emotional proximity. It is meant to facilitate reciprocation of thoughts, feelings, and behaviour between people in a relationship. The basic tenets of this theory are:

- Familiarization with each other: This requires seeking and knowing each other's preferences, vulnerabilities, and secrets
- Relationship enhancing attributions: This strategy ascribes positive behaviour to the internal dispositions and negative to external factors.
- Acceptance and mutual respect: This involves acknowledging the positive and negative traits in the partner and nurturing empathy and social skills.
- Reciprocation: This requires both partners to have equal stake and responsibility in the relationship in order to enhance the relationship.

Activity 1: Positive Psychology in Relationships

Practice writing three good things about your partner (family member or close friend) and encourage them to do the same. Use a title and then follow it up with a short description. Try to recall how it made you feel and how you feel now. The final and most important step is to identify what caused it. It's perfectly normal if you are not able to pick 3 things "good enough" to be on your list every day. Pick atleast one thing initally as it gets easier with time to identify more and more. Do it for 10 days especially till it becomes a habit. Use this especially if you get into a fight or conflict!

1. Ride to my office: My wife didnt let me take the metro today and drove me to my office instead. It made me feel so special and happy that she wanted to spend more time with me.

2.

3.

13.5 CONTEXT OF FAMILY

Alok and Ruhani live in a family of six comprising of a younger sister, Alok's parents, and Ruhani's widowed mother. Both of them financially and tangibly contributed to manage the house. One day Alok had an accident and was advised bed rest for at least 6 months for his leg to recover. Alok's office could not accommodate his medical leave for more than a month and was suggested to go without pay beyond that period. This was a difficult situation for the family. However, Ruhani stepped up and said that she would manage the household expenses by taking tuitions in the evening. Alok's parents offered a portion of their pension. Ruhani's mother offered to look after Alok's medical needs. His younger sister offered to help with the household chores and any work that Alok used to take care of.

Each family differs in terms of structure, rules, values, language, cultural factors, and multigenerational patterns. In the above example, we observe a family who stepped up for each other and concentrated on their strengths to overcome the adversity. Family dynamics have often been observed in several Bollywood movies like *Dil Dhadakne Do*, *English Vinglish*, etc. The goals of positive psychology in this context may be

understood in a similar way, i.e. improve the psychological home environment, enhance flexibility and acceptance among members, facilitate and improve communication, and strengthen the family systems by working on what's strong and not by fixing what's wrong.

What is Family-centred Positive Psychology?

- *Therapy that is concerned with the process and outcomes*
- *Mobilizes family strengths and resources*
- *Needs are determined by family than professional*
- *Emphatic on building social support network*
- *Acquisition of new skills and competencies through professionals*

“**Familism**”, a term used by Bardis (1959) and Sabogal et. al. (1987) connotes a strong identification with nuclear and extended kin enmeshed with high cooperation and affiliation. Familism typically consists of social norms, personal attitudes, and behaviour measured by the extent of endorsement of its central components (Campos, Ullman, Aguilera, & Dunkel Schetter, 2014) which are:

- A sense of responsibility towards the family
- Primary emotional support sourced in family
- Interconnectedness among family members
- Considering the opinion of family members during important decisions
- Being considerate of own behaviour to maintain family honour
- Willingly choosing family preferences over individual preferences

These typical features of familism is quite prevalent among collectivistic cultures such as Indian, Latino, and other Asian cultures that are dominantly characterized by their intimacy among family members, living in the same household, sharing finance, considering work choices, creating a balance between peer and family time, and mainly prioritising family over self (Schwartz et al., 2010; Yeh & Bedford, 2003). It may seem that family centrism may lead to self negligence but studies conducted (Schwartz et al, 2010; Corona, Campus, & Chen, 2017) found otherwise. These studies emphasised upon the value of familism and its association with wellbeing and its role in buffering stress.

13.5.1 The Circumplex Model of Family

Over the years, more than 50 variables have been used to describe familial relationships which condense 11 theories to 3 major dimensions: Cohesion, Flexibility, and Communication (Refer to Fig. 13.5) below. The map provides a graphical description of family balance helpful in delineating the perception of each family member.

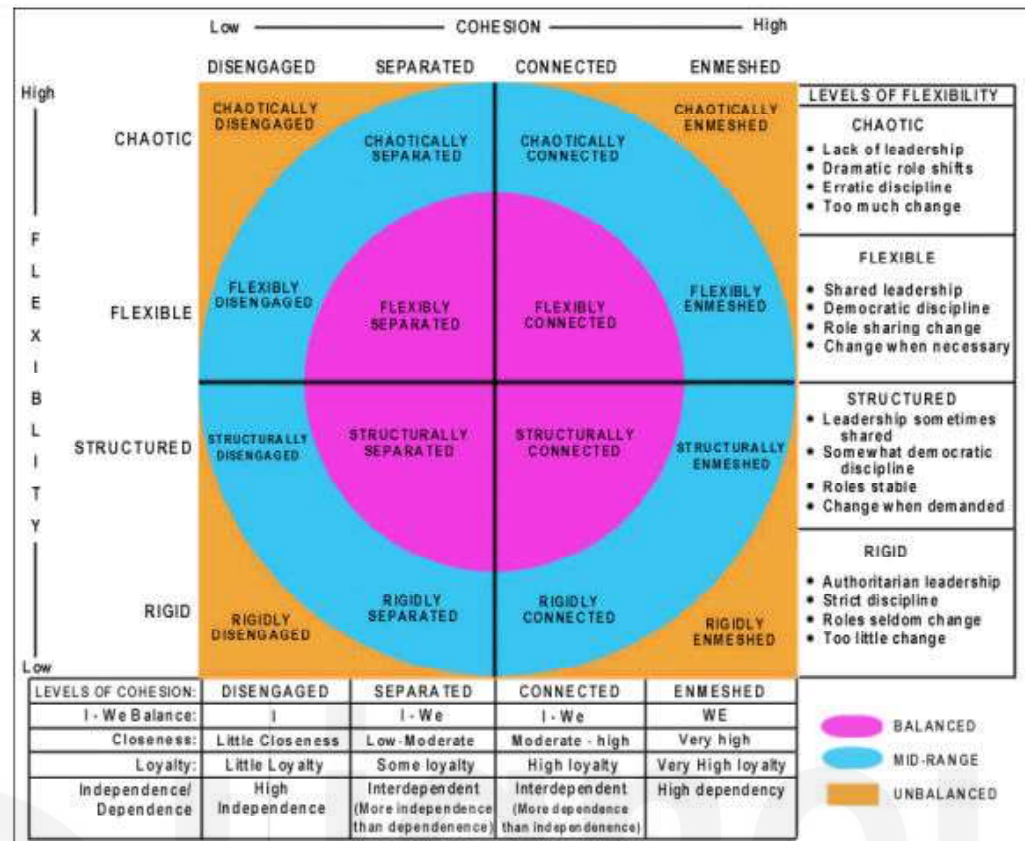


Fig. 13.5: The Family Map of Circumplex Model (Olson, D. H., 2000)

The family map provides levels of balanced, unbalanced, and average functioning based on the combinations of the three dimensions.

- Family cohesion** symbolizes emotional bonding between family members that balances apartness and togetherness, boundaries and coalitions, sharing time, space, friends, and recreations, and interest in decision making. This bonding ranges among four levels from very low to very high (disengaged, separated, connected, and enmeshed). When cohesion levels are very low there is almost no attachment to the family. Contrarily, when cohesion levels are very high, it is indicative of high commitment to the family with little room for independence. Usually it is the occurrence of extreme levels of cohesion that are a call for help. The ones who fall within the average range (separated and connected) are more balanced and functional in a familial system. The 'separated' prioritise being alone vs. togetherness. The reverse is applicable for 'connected' individuals in the family.
- Flexibility** is the modification in roles and rules of leaderships and relationships within the family. Here again, the focus changes from very low to very high (rigid, structured, flexible, chaotic). The ability to change according to need is indicative of a functional family naturally expected of structured (democratic leadership and negotiation with children) and flexible (egalitarian leadership and active involvement of children) types. An unbalanced family is one highly rigid (paternalistic in charge highly controlling in nature) or highly chaotic (erratic leadership with frequent shift in roles and rules, very impulsive).
- Communication** is a facilitator among family members with regard to their listening (empathy and active listening), speaking for oneself, sharing feelings about oneself, clarity with regard to topic and intentions, and the affective mindset. Naturally, balanced families will have high communication compared to unbalanced families.

During a situation of stress, balanced systems adapt while unbalanced families remain rigid to the extreme pattern which trigger further stress. It must not be overlooked that few ethnicities or religious groups may have norms that encourage behaviour high on the above specified dimensions and may be very functional within them. In these circumstances, measuring 'family satisfaction' in each family member would be a better index of affiliation.

The above model highly correlates with other family models such as Beavers' System Model (Beavers & Hampson, 1990) and McMaster's Family Model (Epstein, Bishop, & Levin, 1993) and thus, may be understood as a comprehensive model. The Beavers' System Model is a cross sectional perspective on competence - structure, available information and adaptive flexibility of the system; and family style - a curvilinear relationship to healthy functioning ranging from centripetal (family satisfaction from internal indices) to centrifugal (external indices of satisfaction is prioritised over family). The McMaster's Model of family functioning (Refer to Fig. 13.6 below), is derived from the systems theory that identifies a clinical picture of six dimensions essential in family functioning, i.e.,

- problem-solving— finding solutions to problems that threaten the functionality and integrity of the family,
- communication—the exchange of verbal information is observed in two aspects, affective and instrumental
- roles—the distribution of tasks that are necessary for function and tasks that are not integral to functioning
- affective responsiveness—the full range of emotional response suitable to stimulus and context
- affective involvement—the interest and value given to the activities of an individual family member by the whole family
- behaviour control—behavioural patterns adopted by each family member in situations that demand physically dangerous situations (health issue, accident), psychobiological needs (eating, sleeping, aggression), and ones involving interpersonal interactions within and outside the family.

Self Assessment Questions 2

1. Which of the techniques of applied positive psychology for flourishing relationships is based on Gottman's research studies on married couples?
2. What are the main characteristics of a balanced family?
3. What is "Familism"?

13.6 APPLYING POSITIVE PSYCHOLOGY IN THE FAMILY CONTEXT

(1) Child Parent Relationship

Child is an integral part of family and even so in family centred positive psychology (Seligman & Csikszentmihalyi, 2000). This derivation is best taken up from a framework of ecological systems, i.e. the environment and contexts within which individuals function.

Think about your first point of contact for socializing. It is usually your home and your school. This is the microsystem. The interactions between your parents, teachers, and your peer group comprise of the bidirectional influences of the mesosystem. These interconnections affect relationships, communication patterns of the child. Now think of the larger picture, have you ever had to cancel a vacation plan because of your mom's/dad's work duties? You are not directly related to your parent's work environment, yet you were affected by it. This is the influence of the exosystem. Now think of a time when the government made corporal punishments in school a crime. This policy provided relief to millions of students being cruelly punished. The influence of the government or customs around us makes up the macrosystem. Therefore, now you understand that things that do not involve you directly in your daily life can still be pervasive (Bronfenbrenner, 1977). It is imperative to introduce early interventions for children and adolescents to set up a positive life trajectory (Magyar-Moe et al., 2015; Peterson & Park, 2003).

Positive education interventions like mindfulness, multicomponent positive psychological interventions, well-being, resilience, strengths, positive writing, body image, acts of kindness, etc. will teach children ways to increase their positive cognition, emotions, and behaviours in ways that enhance well-being whilst also helping students to cope with emotional concerns, relationship difficulties, and adversity (Owens & Waters, 2020).

While developing any interventions for children and adolescents' one must be mindful of their developmental needs and maturity, i.e. positive characteristics like gratitude and empathy might not be comprehensible for 6 to 8 years of age (Froh et al, 2007). Also, their brains are very plastic in nature (adaptive) and the intensity or frequency of intervention is not comparable with the interventions meant for adults. Moreover, any intervention provided to children should be through a designated medium and not self guided in nature.

(2) Capitalization on a Positive Event

Just like how you would receive dividends in a share whose value has increased, celebrating a positive event is expected to increase the inter and intra personal dividends yielded (Langston, 1994). The broaden and build theory explains this phenomenon as maximising on positive affect, increasing the value and strengthening the bond with the person. It has been noted that the person sharing genuine positive news feels an abundance of positive emotions as a result of the process (Vasquez, Lee, & Conoley, 2012), even if the person is a stranger (Ilies, Keeney, & Scott, 2011). This also helps in reshaping communication styles in families where automatic response to any kind of event may be passive, neutral, or sometimes negative (Gable, Reis, Impett, & Asher, 2004). Capitalization helps to focus on interpreting the positive event in a unique and a meaningful manner giving a sense of privilege to the family member.

Example of positive capitalization:

Son: I got a first prize for my school debate competition, and I have been chosen to represent my school at a national level with 50 participating schools. I am nervous, I am good here, doesn't mean I'll be good there.

Father: It doesn't matter how you perform, I'll be proud of you (unintentionally ignoring the positive event, while showing unconditional love)

Or

Father: I am so happy you came first! I am so proud of you. Let's celebrate this tonight at your favourite pizzeria (*capitalization on a positive event*). We can also talk about things that can make you less nervous.

(3) Interjections

This method may also be called triangulation, or in other words, a therapist, or sometimes another family member too could interject and rephrase certain situations.

Mom: These teenagers nowadays hardly have time for their parents. Look at Rishi, he's busy in college classes, comes home and is off for his tuitions. And the rest of the time, he is on the phone always. I don't remember the last time we sat and ate together...

Dad: It sounds like he doesn't get much time at home...and that you miss spending time with him, isn't it?

Here, the father acts as a neutral interjector who demonstrates the situation with attentiveness and minimal biasness, yet addressing the need of the mother. It can be called a diplomatic way of dealing with a situation that is lengthy in its problem focus. This interruption of a probably damaging train of thought is preventive of a pent up conflict.

(4) Visualization

Visualizing is a guided technique which has been used successfully in family therapy to enhance approach motivation towards family goals. This has been proven to be helpful in orienting positive behaviour by increasing each individual's confidence in the probability of success of an event, increasing the chances of it actually occurring (Hansen & Wänke, 2010). It requires enumerating steps leading up to the goal. For example, in order to enhance self care among family members, it would be a good exercise to imagine all types of self care rituals that could boost their mood. As a family they could encapsulate them on a board that would act as a visual representation of their aspirations to implement self care (eg. baking a cake together every weekend).

(5) Family Rituals

This is like a Pandora's box of memories that help members of the family recall and celebrate their values and strengths. Family rituals comprise of resilience, pride, and stability (Fiese et al., 2002). It could be a ceremony, a spiritual gathering, weddings, reunions, etc. These are usually unique to the family or sometimes to the culture. These events are distinct from daily life routines as they are capable of communicating values. For example, celebrating milestone marriage anniversaries could help galvanise the positive emotions of gratitude and appreciation of relationships.

(6) Catching a Virtue

This approach commands awareness and recognition of positive qualities by the family members especially useful in enhancing prosocial behaviour as well as the relationship between a child and parent (Johnson, McDonnell, Holzwarth, & Hunter, 2004; Seligman, Steen, Park, & Peterson, 2005). Ideally if this exercise is repeated twice or thrice a day, it reinforces the virtue and the child is likely to repeat the behaviour with more frequency. Using positive techniques with elementary-aged children, it was found that the intervention is both effective for the participants and enthusiastically received by the children's families (Spaventa-Vancil & Conoley, 2012).

(7) Harnessing Happiness and Positive Emotions

Positive Family Therapy developed by Conoley and Conoley (2009) is aimed to increase positive emotions and well-being in the family context. This requires all family members to recognize and accept responsibility for themselves and for the collective success of the family. Additionally, they are required to recognize their contribution in making a difference in the development of the family and common family goals such as conducive environment, preservation of values and virtues, and helping each one attain personal success. Positive statements are encouraged and while negative feelings are not ignored, they are discouraged. Each person is bestowed towards a goal and is responsible for the benefits and progress and feeling of happiness of every member of the family.

A similar positive prevention program was developed by Balancho and Marujo (2006) which focused on enhancing family wellbeing and happiness in Portuguese families. This program involved children and scheduled activities based on happiness, optimism, hope, creativity, pleasurable family climate and communication patterns within the family. The preliminary results of this positive intervention were found to increase wellbeing, positive emotions, and happiness in the family context.

Activity 2: Apply Positive Psychology in Family

Family rituals can be as simple and fun. As a family, pick up any event that all family members are able to do. Based on each one's ability, assign a task to each member no matter how old or young. Set a certain date every month to follow this ritual. You can reschedule to fit the ritual on a holiday or weekend, but do not cancel it.

Example: Going for a family dinner to a favourite restaurant which has a calm ambience and everybody could talk with each other. This should be done on a set date once a month.

13.7 CONCEPT OF AGING

Last scene of all,

That ends this strange eventful history,

Is second childishness and mere oblivion;

Sans teeth, sans eyes, sans taste, sans everything.

- William Shakespeare (*All the World's a Stage*)

Shakespeare in his very famous monologue described old age as a drab picture of unknowingness and silliness with almost nothing exciting to enjoy. Even the *Philosopher's stone* in Harry Potter was sought to make an elixir that made one youthful forever, not "old" forever. Do you also associate old age with an age or a phase of dependency, morbidity, and cognitive infirmity—everything unwanted, right?

You must have observed people around you, there are a few people above 60 who are fit, active, and about like a 40 year old, while there are a few who tend to feel like 60 while being 40. Clearly, age is not limited to chronology. Age, too, can be understood as a biopsychosocial process.

Meaning and Types of Aging

From a **biological perspective**, aging is deterioration at the cellular and molecular level in the body. Scientific research in this framework has been able to discover ways that alleviate physical pain or increase longevity. The **sociocultural factors** also determine our mindset about aging. Have you noticed the undying efforts of the beauty commercials of soaps, hair dyes, body lotion, etc. that propagate that wrinkles, grey hair, loose skin are signs of being old? On the other hand, we also celebrate people like Fauja Singh, a British Sikh 101 year old man who finished a marathon. Both the examples are unrealistic portrayals of what aging looks like among the common people. A common social benchmark of aging is through policies of retirement and entitlements that people receive after a certain age (usually 60 or 65). In few cultures like Japan and India, people of older age are treated with respect and seen as a symbol of wisdom, while in individualistic societies aging is undesirable and sometimes viewed as a liability.

Aging is viewed in terms of **psychological changes** when we refer to people as ‘being in a mood’, being slow, or being forgetful, or being emotionally needy. The psychological adage of “you are only as old as you feel” in fact has many positive implications of better health and wellbeing. Gana, Alaphilippe, and Bailly (2004) assessed 857 elderly retirees for youthful illusion (bias of feeling younger than one’s real age). It was reported that retirees who acknowledged of an perceived age deflation experienced better leisure time, higher self esteem, better perceived health, and less vulnerability to boredom than those who did not harbour this perceived youthful bias.

Gerontological studies have classified age types that are dependent on factors others than biological aging. **Primary aging** is understood mostly as biological aging whereas **secondary aging** is a byproduct of ‘disuse, abuse, and disease’—factors that are under personal control of an individual.

Another meaningful classification is by means of **functionality**, i.e. a comparative standard of activity and health in social and physical environments with those of the same chronological age. Based on this, another reference can deduced: *young old* (people aged between 65 to 74 who are active in their daily life), *old old* (people aged between 75 to 84 and have a moderate level of activity but are limited by frailty and infirmity), and *oldest old* (age 85 and above who find it extremely difficult to cope with daily tasks).

Erikson’s psychosocial theory provides a framework to understand conflicts faced during old age that focuses on self reflection of the life lived and the sense of fulfilment or regret felt. Those who feel accomplishment will feel a sense of integrity. Those who do not find success feel regretful and despaired (Malone, Liu, Vaillant, Rentz, & Waldinger, 2016).

13.7.1 Successful Aging

You must have come across interviews of celebrities who are sought to let out their secret of fine aging. We usually connote them as ‘aging gracefully’, ‘aging as wine’, etc.

So how do we understand ‘success in aging’?

The term ‘successful aging’ was made popular by Rowe and Kahn (1998) who defined

it based on three factors: a) no disability or disease, b) high cognitive and physical abilities, c) meaningful socioemotional interaction with others. Importantly, they did not reduce aging to simply being a by-product of genetic factors but rather extended it as a combination of biology and lifestyle. Fig 13.6 provides a summary of various definitions rendered to the meaning of successful aging. These definitions at the same time point out to several features that help identify successful aging.

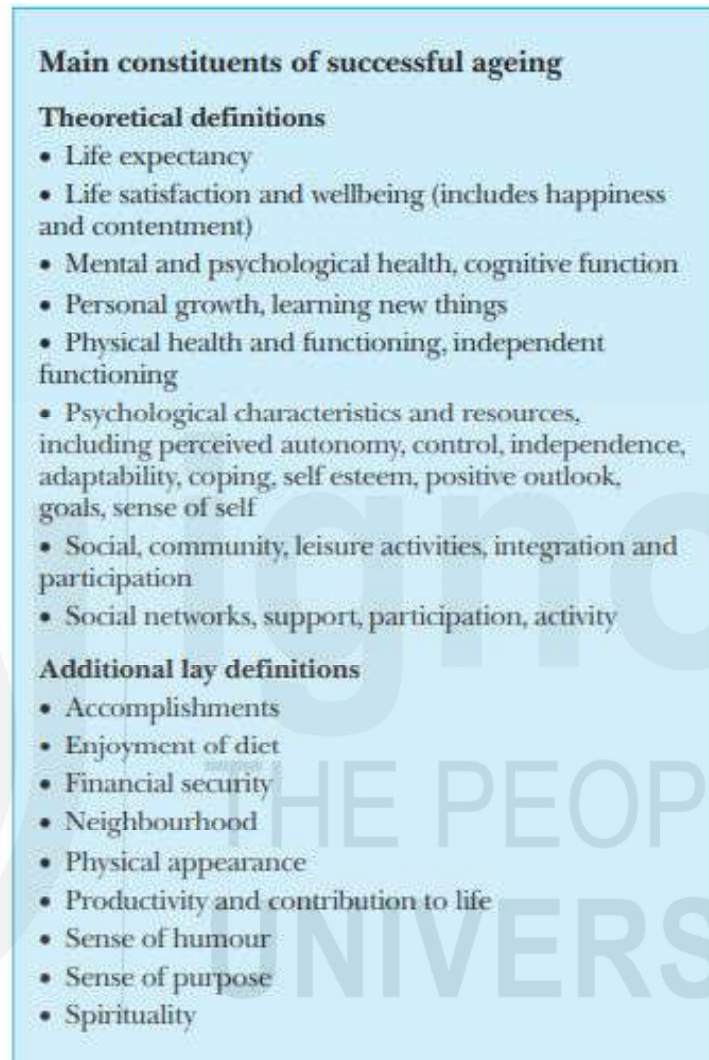


Fig. 13.6: Definitions or indices of successful aging (Bowling & Dieppe, 2005)

13.7.2 Theories of Successful Aging

Most theories, either with a biological or psychological approach, are inclined to explain how things worsen or change during old age. Below are a few theories that help predict the strategic management of resource and time by older people.

- ***Selective Optimization with Compensation***

This theory was proposed by Marsiske, Lang, Baltes, and Baltes (1995) which stated that older people prioritize desired activities and goals by reasonably optimizing their resources and their ability to compensate for any shortcomings that are a result of aging. For example, an old person who loved playing football in their younger days but is unable to do so now because of knee and joint pains may seek another medium to be active and optimize energy and time accordingly, such as spend it in walking, birdwatching, etc.

- ***Socioemotional Selectivity Theory***

When we are young we usually seek new information, make new contacts, adapt to survive, sometimes at the cost of spending time with family. This motivational orientation changes as one grows older. Carstensen, Fung, and Charles (2003) explained this aspect of emotional aging in older people who become person focused rather than future focused, i.e. they begin to cherish time with family and loved ones, or even in professional contexts want to mentor, guide, or try to make changes to the world and leave something for the next generation. This systematic change is owed to the perception of time left to live.

This theory is derived from the *disengagement theory of aging* by Cumming and Henry (1961) who explained that aging comprised of gradual mutual disconnection of an old person from their various social circles, eg. retiring from office. A healthy disconnection was socially viewed as well adjusted as opposed to being perceived as ‘social impingers’.

- ***Activity Theory of Aging***

Havighurst and Albrecht (1953) postulated that post experiencing various life events such as retirement, health deterioration, etc. older individuals give up the normative routines and engagement that they followed during middle adulthood. Instead of completely giving up on the activities they enjoyed and pursued they could find alternate engagements that are less taxing to them such as volunteering for social work, finding a new hobby, etc. Being active is usually revered by society and automatically helps to boost self worth and life satisfaction (Lemon et al. 1972).

- ***Continuity Theory of Aging***

Atchley (1989) explained a socially sanctioned adaptive mechanism of aging in which older adults persevere to maintain link to their past by continuing their activities, beliefs, and social relationships as they age. An example is reuniting with friends from school, work; or continuing to walk briskly instead of running.

13.8 APPLYING POSITIVE PSYCHOLOGY FOR SUCCESSFUL AGING

Positive aging is defined by Havighurst (1963) as incremental longevity and satisfaction from life. Ryff (1982) similarly defined successful aging as positive optimal functioning in developmental progress across the life span. A few strategies to implement for positive aging are provided below.

- **Reducing Ageism**

The negative stereotypes about age are socially constructed such as young people cannot be leaders, old people cannot be active, etc. This eventually translates to devaluation in the society, prejudiced behaviour, unfair treatment and discrimination based on age. This not only has its own negative implications in mental and physical health of the individual (Stephan, Sutin, & Terraciano, 2015) but also reflects in perceived change in ‘subjective age’ because of the age related cues and information. Levy (2018) has proposed a PEACE model expected to reduce ageism through positive education about ageing and contact experiences (Refer Fig. 13.7). Education about aging with positive older role models would help one appreciate getting older and dispel myths related to it. Positive contact experiences will help integrate the relations between generations through mutual cooperation, like working together on a social project.

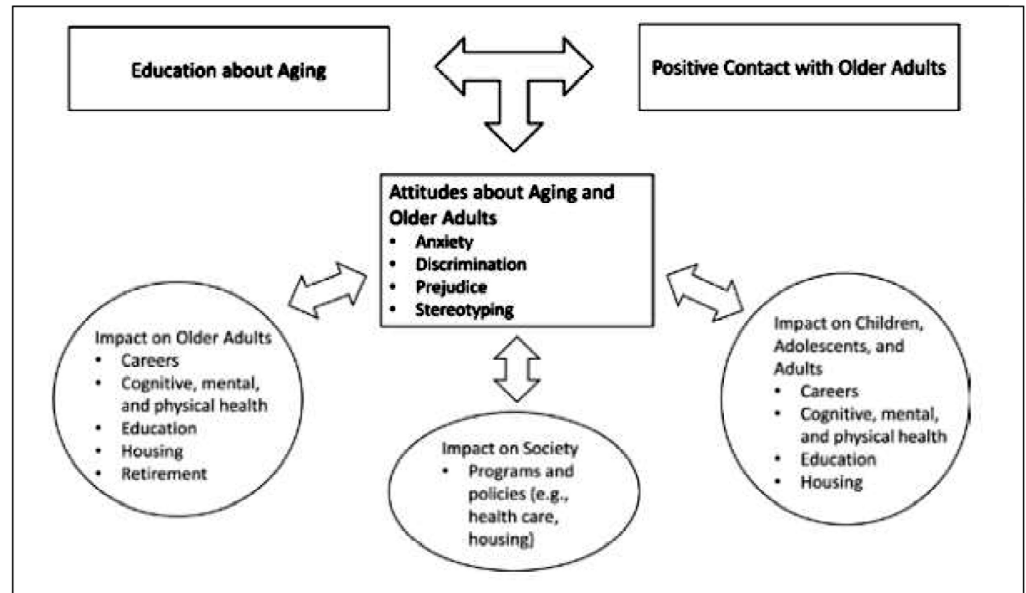


Fig. 13.7 : PEACE Model to Reduce Ageism (Levi, 2016)

• Productive aging

Productive aging is referred to when older people work to enhance their own welfare or that of the communities and society at large (Bass, Caro & Chen, 1993; Ranzijn, 2002). Productivity includes goods or services that otherwise would have been charged for. However, it extends to unpaid work, such as intangible contributions like passing on wisdom, guidance, knowledge, and expertise. The idea is to disable the notion of utility confined to capitalistic services and goods.

• Accepting Death Anxiety

Just talking about death is scary. Inevitably there is a lot of associated taboo with the concept of death, and causes apprehension or dread. Occasionally it is normal to feel this, but it feels more close to reality as we get older. Especially during old age the apprehension may develop into an emotional difficulty. Wong and Tomer (2011) has suggested that accepting death anxiety as a paradoxical reality is valuable as it enhances resilience, meaning of life, and flourishing. Positive attitude and meaning centered acceptance about death can contribute to well-being (Neimeyer, 2005). Figure 13.8 enlists the different types of death acceptance that can help one optimally adapt to the idea of death.

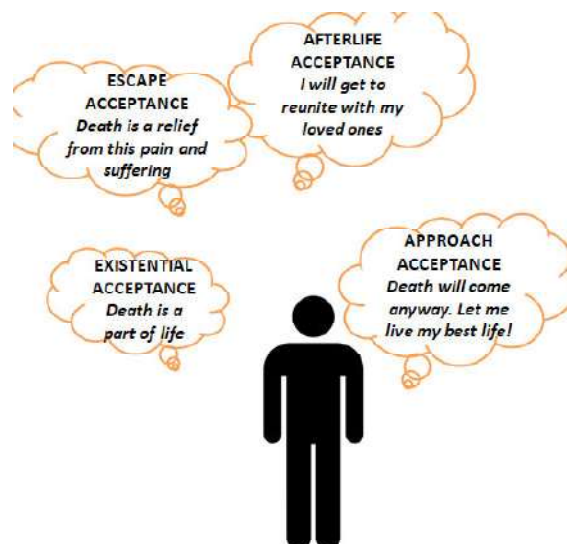


Figure 8. Types of death acceptance (Wong & Tomer, 2011)

- **Positive health**

Subjective aging can have various psychological and affective implications of cognition resulting in loneliness, anxiety, fear, depression, disability, and pain. This could increase the stress burden, challenge sleep patterns, cause amotivation, disability, and increase chronic pain. Positive intervention help to minimise outcomes like decreasing coping ability, increased risk of injury, lack of self care, dependence on pain killers, opioid usage, etc.

In the framework of positive psychology, several studies have confirmed that positive psychology can create a fruitful liaison with health management. One such use is the practice of optimism (Smith & Bryant, 2019). Similarly mindfulness meditation has been efficacious in managing lower back pain, insomnia, poor sleep quality by helping to foster strategies for stress reduction and slowing biological aging process in the elderly (Hazlett-Stevens et al, 2019; Black & Slavich, 2016). Other positive mechanisms such as creativity (Fox, 2013), hope (Wippold & Roncoroni, 2020), humor (Morse et al, 2018), self compassion (Kim & Ko, 2018), spirituality and religion have been found effective in buffering dementia (Agli, Bailly, & Ferrand, 2015) and positively cope with aging effects.

- **Positive emotions**

Learning from the socioemotional selectivity theory, positivity bias in the form of maximisation of feelings of contentment, serenity and happiness helps to regulate emotions while overlooking criticism. So surrounding oneself with enjoyment, jovial people, and cherishing ordinary everyday experiences (going to a movie, dinner with family and friends) would invariably enhance wellbeing and life satisfaction. In a study of happiness and longevity in Catholic nuns, it was found that even at 80 years of age the most cheerful nuns (based on diary entries at a younger age) had survival rate of 75% compared to 40 % for the least cheerful group of nuns (Danner, Snowdon, & Friesen, 2001). Conversely, it has been seen that lower level of happiness has been associated with dementia, lesser social support, dependence, and loneliness (Baltes, & Smith, 2003).

- **Active lifestyle**

Staying active doesn't quite mean to remain physically engaged. Active lifestyle requires adequate and regular challenge and stimulation that results in a sense of fulfilment such as playing card games or regular and enjoyable interaction with people. No one activity is found to be superior to the other to ward off cognitive impairment (Carlson et al, 2011). A study of 397 elderly Koreans aged 65 and over found that only active leisure activities help the elderly to enjoy their old age by increasing their physical health compared to passive leisure activities that are enjoyed alone which may impede a socially-healthy aging process (Chul-Ho, Johnson, & Chulhwan, 2020). This study maintained that there was no difference in the forms of leisure activities.

- **Religious or spiritual engagement**

Spirituality or religious activity guides the elderly to tap into an active inner resource and increases coping strategies. A quasi experimental study of 60 elderly residents in Indonesia experienced a higher quality of life after being subject to a purposefully designed religious intervention (Prammesona & Taneepanichskul, 2018).

- **Music therapy**

A very common activity like listening to music could have manifold benefits and is known to boost positive emotions in elderly. Lauka (2007) reported that few listening strategies were associated with psychological wellbeing in elders. Hays and Minichiello (2005) in their qualitative study also revealed that music provides people of connecting in their self identity, maintaining wellbeing, enhancing and expressing spirituality. It also helps to maintain positive self esteem, competence, independence, and avoid loneliness.

Activity 2: Apply Positive Psychology in Ageing

Have a conversation with your grandparent. The alternative could be visiting an old neighbour or visiting an old age home. Note down their daily activities. What are the things that they still continue to do that they had done during their youth? Identify which theory of successful aging they are using to cope with the changes in lifestyle.

Example: Your grandfather may have loved to spend one day a week with his friends going for a football match, or going for a dinner. You observed that he still meets his friends on alternate days of his evening walk. This is the application of the Continuity Theory of Aging in context.

Self Assessment Questions 3

1. What is capitalization on positive event?
2. How do family rituals help family centred positive therapy?
3. Differentiate between primary and secondary aging.
4. What are the different perspectives of aging?
5. Describe the PEACE model to reduce aging.
6. Identify two strategies that may help boost successful aging.

13.10 LET US SUM UP

This unit focused on three major areas where positive psychology can be applied to enhance wellbeing and life satisfaction. The dynamics of the close relationships, family, and aging were analysed. Further, several practical approaches of positive psychology were enlisted with examples for enhancing our close relationships and family relationships. The concept of aging and successful aging were elaborated. Various techniques for aging successfully were described. Positive psychology is an evolving and expanding field of research which has great potential for achieving a flourishing state in our relationships and in growing older gracefully and successfully.

13.11 KEYWORDS

- Close Relationships** : A relationship of mutual trust and respect, rapport, bond, affinity
- Familism** : Ideology that prioritizes family over self

Subjective Age	: Perceived age of oneself
Positive Aging	: Adopting a positive outlook to enhance quality of life and satisfaction during life span
Ageism	: Discrimination against individuals or groups on the basis of their age
Positive Health	: An approach to manage health using techniques of positive psychology

13.12 ANSWERS TO SELF ASSESSMENT QUESTIONS

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 1

1. Positive psychotherapy aims at “building what’s strong” as opposed to “fixing what’s wrong”.
2. PERMA stands for Positive emotion, Engagement, Relationships, Meaning, and Accomplishments.
3. Close relationships are distinct from casual relationships as they are marked by trust, knowledge, intimacy, care, and interdependence.
4. The three major components are intimacy, passion, and decision/commitment.
5. There are three primary styles: Eros (passionate, romantic love), Ludus (playful love), Storge (friendship love).
6. Concurrent with attachment styles found in infants, adults have secure, avoidant, and fearful avoidant attachment styles.

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 2

1. The Sound Relationship House, the Emotional Bank Account, Three Good things are a few positive techniques based on Gottman’s research.
2. A balanced family is characterized by an average level of family cohesion (a balance of self and family togetherness), an average level of flexibility in rules and leadership, and high communication.
3. Familism refers to a strong identification with nuclear and extended kin enmeshed with high cooperation and affiliation.

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 3

1. Capitalization on positive event focuses on interpreting the positive event in a unique and a meaningful manner giving a sense of privilege to the concerned individual.
2. Family rituals comprise of resilience, pride, and stability; and are usually unique to the family or sometimes to the culture. These events are distinct from daily life routines as they are capable of communicating values and often help galvanise the positive emotions of gratitude and appreciation of relationships.

3. Primary aging is understood mostly as biological aging whereas secondary aging is a byproduct of ‘disuse, abuse, and disease’—factors that are under personal control of an individual.
4. Age can be understood from a biopsychosocial perspective as well as based on functionality. Biological refers to deterioration at cellular level, psychological perspective is the subjective age we confer to, and social perspective is the age standard expectations set by social norms.
5. The PEACE model focuses on reducing ageism through positive education about ageing and positive contact experiences.
6. Having an active lifestyle and focusing on positive emotions may immensely boost positive aging.

13.13 UNIT END QUESTIONS

1. Describe the theories of love and friendship that help understand what close relationships are.
2. What are the different positive techniques to help relationships flourish?
3. Define the characteristics of a balanced family.
4. How can you apply positive psychology in the context of family?
5. Is aging only a biological process? Elaborate.
6. How is positive psychology useful for successful aging?

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UNIT 14 POSITIVE PSYCHOLOGY IN WORKPLACE, HEALTH AND WELL-BEING*

Structure

- 14.1 Learning Objectives
- 14.2 Introduction
- 14.3 Psychological Capital
- 14.4 Flow
- 14.5 Meaningful Work
- 14.6 Employee Engagement
- 14.7 Well-being
- 14.8 Positive Psychology Interventions at work
- 14.9 Let Us Sum Up
- 14.10 Key Words
- 14.11 Answers to Self Assessment Questions
- 14.12 Unit End Questions
- 14.13 References
- 14.14 Suggested Readings

14.1 LEARNING OBJECTIVES

After studying this Unit, you would be able to:

- *explain the meaning and scope of positive psychology in workplace;*
- *discuss the key constructs of positive psychology applied in workplace;*
- *explain Psychological Capital (PsyCap) and describe its four components and measurement;*
- *discuss the concept of flow and meaningful work and their impact on employee satisfaction and well-being;*
- *describe employee engagement and well-being in the context of work; and*
- *describe positive psychology interventions at work.*

14.2 INTRODUCTION

Effective management is the ultimate goal of any organization. This requires adoption of new paradigms where excellence as well as sustainability need to be the core values. This requires the leaders and managers at all levels and types of organizations to take

a balanced approach to human behavior by focusing not only on infirmity/diseases but also on strengths and human capacities. This realization has resulted in the development of a new field named Positive Psychology in the Workplace or Positive Psychology at Work (PPW). PPW is an umbrella term which covers application of knowledge, concepts and principles of positive psychology at work. Despite the importance of PPW, positive psychology at work did not get its due recognition until recently. For example, an article in the famous 'The Wall Street Journal' (Wang et al. 2011) recognized the importance of the business world's increasing attention to positivity in the workplace, which has even extended to the United States Army, as it adopted a technique for increasing soldiers' resilience (Cornum, Mathews, & Seligman, 2011).

PPW studies psychological states like self-efficacy, optimism, hope, resilience, flow, and other personal resources in coping with organizational demands which can affect organizational performance. Moreover, PPW focuses on positive emotions and what makes work meaningful for us. PPW also deals with the idea of positive leadership which would result in positive human capabilities and positive emotions. At another level, it is also interested in organizational outcomes such as employees' engagement, and the factors which affect employees' engagement.

According to Ulrich (1997), employee contribution has become a critical business issue as companies need to engage not only the body but also the mind and soul of every employee. The employees need to feel respected and valued for their contribution. This will motivate them, increase their work commitment, and lead to employee satisfaction. All these are included under the term 'gainful employment' (Snyder, Lopez, & Pedrotti, 2011). It focuses on employee well-being with a comprehensive approach, taking care of the physical, personal, psychological, economic, social, and organizational aspects. As indicated by Snyder et al. (2011), gainful employment is characterized by nine features which can also be described as the benefits accruing from it (refer Fig. 14.1).



Fig. 14.1: Aspects of Gainful Employment

Let us now learn about certain key constructs involved in positive psychology at work. These are PsyCap, Flow, Positive emotions, Meaning of work, Employees engagement, and Well-being.

14.3 PSYCHOLOGICAL CAPITAL (PSYCAP)

Case study 1: Sheila's story

Sheila was supposed to join one of the premier hospitality chains after the completion of her Hotel Management course. She was one of the top rankers and was offered the highest pay package from the batch. She was very excited to join the workforce and to show her skills/talent to the world. However, Covid-19 struck the world and affected all aspects of our life/various industrial sectors and the hospitality sector was badly affected.

The organization withheld the job for her as the market was closed due to lockdown. She got frustrated, depressed, and lost hope in life. However, Sheila slowly recognized that there are millions of people around the world having the same fate as her. She decided to use the pandemic to develop new skills by joining online courses, learning dance, and the French language. It was difficult initially but slowly she started believing in her abilities, could see the pandemic as a chance to learn new skills which were not possible earlier due to the hectic academic schedule of her course, and finally, she bounced back, and got a new job with good salary and perks.

- *How did Sheila feel when her job was withheld by the company?*
- *Identify some of her strengths that helped her to survive the pandemic and move ahead in life.*

The case of Sheila above highlights the importance of Psychological Capital (PsyCap) in people's lives. PsyCap is one of the very important developments in PPW, and it comprises of self-efficacy/confidence (Bandura, 1997), optimism (Seligman, 2002), hope (Snyder, 2002a), and resiliency (Masten, 2001). PsyCap has been formally defined as:

“...an individual's positive psychological state of development and is characterized by: (1) having confidence (self-efficacy) to take on and put in the necessary effort to succeed at challenging tasks; (2) making a positive attribution (optimism) about succeeding now and in the future; (3) persevering towards goals and, when necessary, redirecting paths to goals (hope) in order to succeed; and (4) when beset by problems and adversity, sustaining and bouncing back and even beyond (resiliency) to attain success (Luthans, Youssef, & Avolio, 2007,p.3).”

Moreover, PsyCap has been presented as a higher-order core construct that integrates these four individual-level attributes not only additively but also perhaps, synergistically (Luthans et al. 2007). There is evidence that investment in PsyCap would result in a sustainable competitive advantage for the organizations. According to Luthans et al. (2007), the return on investment on the development of PsyCap through micro intervention is 270%. Moreover, there is a substantial body of knowledge to suggest that PsyCap is positively related to performance, wellbeing, and other desirable outcomes (Avey et al., 2011; Newman et al., 2014; Luthans & Youssef-Morgan, 2017; Nolzen, 2018). At the same time, PsyCap is negatively related to undesirable outcomes such as stress, burnout, and counterproductive work behavior (Avey et al., 2011; Newman et al., 2014).

Let us now learn about the four components of PsyCap, also acronymed as ‘HERO’ (you have already learned about these positive constructs in detail in earlier Units).

- a) **Hope:** Hope is defined as a positive motivational state comprising of agency (goal-directed energy), and pathways (planning to meet goals). These two cognitively interact to achieve the desired goals in the organizational context (Snyder, Irving, & Anderson, 1991). People who are high on hope are likely to have self-directed determination, energy, and high control over the situation, which would result in the generation of alternate pathways to reach the desired goal. Hope is related to work performance, physical and mental health, survival and coping beliefs and skills, and other desirable positive life and well-being outcomes (e.g., Onwuegbuzie & Snyder, 2000).
- b) **Self-efficacy:** Self-efficacy is one’s conviction about their ability to mobilize the motivation, cognitive resources, and courses of action needed to successfully perform a specific task within a given context (Stajkovic & Luthans, 1998). Self-efficacy leads to enhanced confidence and performance. There are meta-analytic reviews to suggest a positive correlation of 0.38 between efficacy and work-related performance (e.g., Stajkovic & Luthans, 1998). This relationship is much higher than what has been found for performance and other constructs such as goal setting, job satisfaction, the big five personality traits including conscientiousness, transformational leadership, etc. Pati & Kumar (2010) found that occupational self-efficacy is the significant predictor of employee engagement in 150 software programmer working in large software Indian organizations.
- c) **Resilience:** Resilience refers to positive adaptation in the context of significant adversity or risk. Resilience is defined as the capacity to rebound or bounce back from adversity, conflict, failure, or even positive events, progress, and increased responsibility (Luthans, 2007). Thus resilience is not only about bouncing back from the adversity but also adapting to positive, and challenging events in life (e.g., getting a new assignment or getting promotion). In the present day context, when restructuring/downsizing/laying off is the order of the day, resilience could be an important resource for employees who can adapt effectively to constantly changing work environment.

Resilient people have a greater sense of reality as they are open to new experiences, are flexible to changing demands, and show more emotional stability when faced with adversity (Tugade & Fredrickson, 2004). Resilient individuals may use adversities/ failures as a “springboard” to reach higher ground. Moreover, adversities and failures may help an individual to refine one’s philosophy of life, goals, and priorities, leading to ‘resilient reintegration’. This implies that the disruption in one’s life routines allows for the exploration and refinement of resilient qualities. According to Ryff & Singer (2003), resilient people experience enhanced self-reliance, self-efficacy, self-awareness, self-disclosure, relationships, emotional expressiveness, and empathy. Resilience is also related to performance and bottom-line gains (Luthans, Avey, et al., 2006; Suryaningtyas et al., 2019). Employee resilience has also been linked with fewer interpersonal counterproductive work behaviors and lower emotional exhaustion (Shoss, Jiang, & Probst, 2018).

- d) **Optimism:** Optimism is concerned with the interpretation of events/things in our lives, and therefore, optimism is defined as an attributional style and is associated with positive outcomes. However, optimism has to be balanced, realistic, and flexible. An over optimistic explanatory will have undesirable side effects or even dangerous implications because it may lead to higher risks and underestimation of potential dangers. Thus, optimism is not only about the attribution of positive events in life, but it also involves taking into account the past events, the present context, contingency planning, functioning in a disciplined manner and preventive care. People with high optimism use both cognitive and emotional resources.

Optimism is positively correlated with many desirable outcomes such as authentic happiness, life satisfaction and workplace performance. Performance in various other life domains such as education, sports, and politics are also found to be positively related to optimism.

Measurement of PsyCap:

PCQ-24 (Luthans, Yousseff, & Avolio, 2007) is one of the most widely used scales to measure PsyCap. It comprises 24 items, 6 each for the four constructs of self-efficacy, hope, resilience, and optimism. The items have to be scored on a 6-point Likert scale, ranging from 1 (strongly disagree) to 6 (strongly agree). Scoring can be done dimension-wise as well as overall. A higher score indicates more PsyCap as compared to a low score. PCQ-24 is a valid measure used in many countries including India (Cid *et al.*, 2020; Imran and Shahnawaz, 2020; Sahoo and Sia, 2015). However, there is some evidence that the core of Indian 'Self' is different from the individualistic orientation of PsyCap constructs (Roseman, Dhawan, Rettek, & Thapa, 1995).

PCQ-24 is a copyrighted scale and needs to be used as per the test manual (you can refer to Psychological Capital Questionnaire (PCQ) - Assessments, Tests | Mind Garden - Mind Garden for reference).

PCQ- 24 (Sample items)

1. *I feel confident analyzing a long-term problem to find a solution.*
2. *I feel confident in representing my work area in meetings with management*
3. *If I should find myself in a jam at work, I could think of many ways to get out of it*
4. *At the present time, I am energetically pursuing my work goals*
5. *When things are uncertain for me at work, I usually expect the best*
6. *If something can go wrong for me work-wise, it will*
7. *When I have a setback at work, I have trouble recovering from it, moving on*
8. *I usually manage difficulties one way or another at work*

14.4 FLOW

Case study 2: Romeo-The Storyteller

Romeo is a student of literature. He likes to read real-life stories and enjoys the characters' progression in the story's development. Somewhere in his heart, he knew that he liked storytelling and would want to pursue his career in scriptwriting. Initially, he didn't know the technicalities and skills of writing. He did an online certificate course in writing. In his college fest, he eagerly took part in a writing competition. This competition was important for him. He experienced a kind of excitement and new zeal while attempting to start building his story. He was fully involved with the task and found a great sense of pleasure and curiosity in it. He was completely cut off from the outside world and fully immersed in the life of the characters he was building. He created the range and character arc of his protagonist and found himself as one with his character. He was not aware of the time passing by while writing the story. Words were flowing easily and quickly for him like a smooth stream. At that time, he didn't focus on whether he was going to win or lose the competition; he was enjoying the process of writing, and that mattered to him the most. However, somewhere in his deep heart he was sure he would win and was ready to try out something in this field even if he loses this one.

After reading the section on flow,

- *Identify the mental state of Romeo.*
- *Can you identify the factors which would have paved the way for flow experience?*

Flow is a state of consciousness where people become immersed in an activity and enjoy it intensely (Csikszentmihalyi, 1997). There are three essential components of flow: *absorption, enjoyment, and intrinsic motivation*. Absorption means that when people are in a flow state their sense of time disappears as they are fully concentrated on what they are doing. This absorption experience in itself is so enjoyable that people are intrinsically motivated to continue with what they are doing. The activity/task itself becomes the reward. Flow is a peak experience that may fluctuate from one performance to another performance. It implies that flow is not a permanent phenomenon, it varies task-wise and also may vary across time.

In the context of work, flow can be considered as a short-term peak experience that has integrated components of absorption, work enjoyment, and intrinsic work motivation (Bakker 2005). Employees in a flow state are fascinated by the tasks they perform, and the intrinsic aspects of the tasks in themselves are enough to motivate them. Flow also refers to one's intense involvement with the task which would result in high levels of focus, confidence, and performance (Harris et al. 2017). Performance usually becomes automatic, as no deliberate effort is required when one is in a flow state. For example, when a batsman plays well in front of a big crowd, he is in total control of the situation and plays effortlessly. He is immersed in the game and enjoys every ball he plays.

Flow has been generally conceptualized as a situational construct (e.g., Bakker, 2005; Fullagar and Kelloway, 2009), however, individuals can also proactively create their own flow experiences at work (Bakker & Woerkmom, 2017). Flow is positively related

to various indicators of job performance such as self-rated as well as other rated performance.

Moreover, Bakker (2008) found that the three dimensions of flow were differently related to performance. For example, work enjoyment predicted task performance, while intrinsic work motivation predicted contextual performance. Some other researchers also found the role of personality factors in the flow and organizational performance relationships. Demerouti (2006) reported the role of conscientiousness in this relationship. Moreover, employees who are high on knowledge sharing experienced more flow which in turn predicted creativity (Yan et al. 2013).

Bakker (2005) found that job resources including autonomy, social support, supervisory coaching, and performance feedback were important antecedents of flow experiences among music teachers and their students. Salanova, Bakker, and Llorens (2006), in their longitudinal study of Spanish secondary school teachers, showed that organizational resources including social support climate and clear goals facilitated work-related flow over time. Moreover, self-determination strategies (self-leadership, job crafting, strength use), personal resources (such as self-efficacy, optimism, resilience), and some of the organizational context (e.g., HR practices, leadership, etc.) would result in flow experience for the employees (Bakker & Woerkom, 2017).

Measurement of Flow:

Bakker's (2008) Work-Related Flow Scale (WOLF) is one measure that has been widely used. WOLF has been successfully translated/adapted in many countries such as Italy, Australia, China, South Africa, etc. Recently Bakker et al. (2017) validated a modified version of WOLF in the academic setting and called it as 'Study Related Flow Inventory' (WOLF-S). There are thirteen items measuring absorption (4 items), work enjoyment (4 items), and intrinsic work motivation (5 items). All items are rated on a seven-point scale ranging from 1 (never) to 7 (always). A high score on this scale indicates high study-related flow as compared to a low score. The scoring can be done dimension-wise as well as overall to give a single score of 'Study-related flow'.

Study-Related Flow Inventory (WOLF-S)

The following statements refer to the way in which you experienced your academic work during the last two weeks. Please indicate how often you experienced each of the statements. (1=never, 2=almost never, 3=sometimes, 4=regularly, 5=often, 6=very often, 7=always).

1. When I am learning, I think about nothing else
2. I get carried away when I am learning
3. When I am learning, I forget everything else around me
4. I am totally immersed in my studying
5. My studying gives me a good feeling
6. I do my study obligations with a lot of enjoyment
7. I feel happy during my learning
8. I feel cheerful when I am learning

9. I would still learn even if I did not have to
10. I find that I also want to learn in my free time
11. I study because I enjoy it
12. I am learning for my own sake
13. I get my motivation from the learning itself, and not from the grades

Source: Bakker et al. (2017)

Self Assessment Questions 1

1. What is gainful employment?
2. Name the components of PsyCap.
3. Hope consists of _____ and _____.
4. _____ is one of the most widely used scales to measure PsyCap.
5. Flow is not a permanent phenomenon. True/ False
6. Mention the three components of flow.

14.5 MEANINGFUL WORK

Case study 3: Amit's Story: Does a job need to mean something?

Amit, 32 years old, working in a reputed banking firm in India is going through a crisis at work. He cannot understand his reduced sense of motivation and focus at work even though he is earning seven figures. His manager and colleagues create a healthy and positive work environment. But he feels that his work is not making him feel empowered. It's difficult for him to explain that his salary is not a motivating factor.

Why is Amit unhappy with his work? Amit's reduced enthusiasm and focus at work are due to the need for a higher purpose in life. He is going through a crisis of meaning.

But why does work need to provide a higher purpose and meaning? How can this increase motivation and productivity at work?

Many employees are going through a crisis of meaning at work. They need their work to serve a higher purpose in life, desire more control over work, and need growth opportunities to proclaim the joys of the role they are serving at work. Thus, employees are looking for work that provides meaning to them (Tommasi et al., 2020).

Experiencing one's life as meaningful has been recognized as significant for human well-being and satisfaction, as most of our activities revolve around finding a sense of purpose in life (Martel and Pessi, 2018). Life is primarily a chase for meaning, and humans find meaning through different sources, such as through love and work (Mayseless & Keren, 2014). Work plays an important role in human life, with most

individuals spending a large portion of their time in organizational settings. It provides a sense of financial security, psychological and social benefits, but in addition to that, it provides an individual with a sense of purpose, autonomy, meaning, and identity (Rosso et al., 2010). Meaningfulness with work predicts positive workplace outcomes including organizational commitment, organizational citizenship behaviors, employee engagement, and job satisfaction (Rosso et al., 2010). But with the globalization and the accelerating speed of the digital era, there is increasing competition and challenges at work which have caused stress, emotional exhaustion and burnout among employees. The diversity of employees in the workplace as well as a modern working culture have consequences for attaining meaning in work. Thus, in recent years the topic of meaningful work is gaining importance among scholars and practitioners (Tommasi et al., 2020). The heightened interest in this topic is also due to the influence of positive psychology in organizations to study work outcomes (Bailey et al., 2019).

Meaningful work is defined as workplace characteristics that facilitate the attainment or maintenance of one or more dimensions of meaning (Fairlie, 2011). It is considered as a psychological need that helps to strengthen an individual's self-esteem and personal agency (Bailey et al., 2019). Moreover, meaningful work is considered as an individual's judgment regarding their work and the value they derive from work (Steger et al., 2012). Aligned with this view, meaningful work helps achieve a sense of calling and enjoying benefits such as enhanced motivation, productivity, and well-being. Employees who feel their work is meaningful report greater well-being and view their work as more central and important to their self (Martel and Pessi, 2018). In contrast, a lack of meaningful work has long been recognized as a primary source of alienation, anxiety, emotional exhaustion, burnout, and boredom in the organization (Shantz et al., 2014). Thus, the absence of meaningful work can potentially undermine the person-work-organization relationship (Bendassolli, 2018).

Understanding what makes work meaningful?

Reena, 28 years old, is teaching in a government college. She gives a lot of intrinsic value towards her work. Even though she doesn't get enough time for herself but she feels very motivated when her students graduate. The graduation ceremony is a tangible result of her hard work as her students successfully completed their courses and ready to step into the outside world. She is driven and focused towards her work because her classes can be a source of learning as well as an uplifting experience for her students. Moments of profound meaningfulness arises when her students, colleagues and alumna's visit her, and appreciate her teaching skills and provide her with a sense of job well done.

Can you explain how meaningful work is manifested based on Reena's story?

In Reena's case, meaningfulness was associated with fulfilment of her potential and sense of pride. Receiving praise, acknowledgement and the impact her work had for other individuals, groups, or the wider environment mattered a lot. *But are these the only factors that lead to meaningful work?*

Scholars in the field of meaningful work have acknowledged that the 'self' helps to comprehend work as meaningful (Lips-Wiersma and Wright, 2012). Lips-Wiersma and Wright(2012) proposed a **multidimensional framework of meaningful work** which includes both the *content dimensions* (i.e developing & becoming self, serving others, unity with others and expressing full potential), and *process dimensions* (that is

the conflict between being-doing, self-others, and inspiration-reality) of meaningful work. This meaning making process is not independent but influenced by social relations and interactions with others, within or outside the organisation.

As Bailey (2019) mentioned that individuals cannot recognize meaningfulness entirely within themselves. But it is created when their work provides benefits to them as well as when their work is appreciated by others. Hence, the source of meaningful work, i.e., '*unity with others*' is understood by employees by their contribution to society in the context of the organizations to which they belong. This source of meaningful work is concerned with the social dimension of work and the individual's membership therein, concerned with the question '*where do I belong?*'. Moreover, meaningful work requires employee to perform work that contributes or is subjectively experienced to fulfil a higher purpose beyond the self (Rosso et al., 2010). This source of meaningful work i.e '*serving others*' is associated with a higher calling (Steger et al., 2012). Lastly, the job design, role of employees in the organisation, and the fit between personal values, and tasks are relevant in achieving meaningful work. So meaningful work is the significance and meaning that one attaches to the work activities and tasks performed.

Moreover, Tims, Derks, and Bakker (2016) found that the higher the ability of an individual to craft one's job, the higher the experienced meaningfulness. So the source of meaningful work i.e '*expressing self*', relates to individuals being able to influence their jobs. Research has mentioned that to achieve meaningful work there should be a balance among the above-mentioned sources of meaningful work (Rosso et al., 2010). Lips-Wiersma and Morris (2009) mentioned that lack of balance between the self and others can produce meaninglessness. Moreover, a balance between inspiration (i.e. the human need for long-term dreams and hopes) and reality is required. They also mentioned that these dimensions answer the question of "*why am I here*" which is central for understanding the concept of meaningful work. Hence meaningful work is an ongoing search process towards coherence of these dimensions (Lips-Wiersma and Morris, 2009).

Research on self-determination theory has argued that the psychological needs for autonomy, competence, and relatedness are key predictors of meaningful work (Martela & Riekk, 2018). This theory explains that these **three psychological needs** should be fulfilled as they are critical in motivating and enabling a sense of purpose for employees. When employees are autonomously able to choose their activities and work tasks, they experience their work as more meaningful. Research has mentioned that *autonomy* and *self-determination* is closely linked to empowerment at work (Martela and Riekk, 2018). Moreover, feeling of incompetence at work and inability to finish task leads to meaninglessness. Finally, the concept of *relatedness*, that is the relationships with managers, colleagues, and friends in organisation are mentioned as a key source of meaningful work. These three needs have positive associations with meaningful work which leads to well-being and healthy functioning. Research also suggest a fourth factor in predicting meaningful work that is *beneficence and prosocial behaviour*, which means that doing something which benefits other people leads to emotional benefits as it increases people's sense of task and work meaningfulness.

Although research on meaningful work is relatively new but there is a growing body of evidence that suggest that it has positive impact on human beings, not only at the individual level, but also at the organizational level. It helps employees to foster their life and work by satisfying intrinsic and basic needs for living. At the organizational level, it contributes to organizational performance, including financial performance. It

also leads to job enjoyment, intrinsic motivation, job security, growth opportunities, positive self-concept, organization identification, and morale (Bailey et al., 2019). Thus, meaningful work has numerous positive outcomes to employees and organizations.

Measurement of Meaningful work:

The Work as Meaning Inventory (WAMI; Steger et al., 2012) is used to measure meaningful work. The WAMI is a 10-item questionnaire measured on a 5-point scale ranging from 1 (absolutely untrue) to 5 (absolutely true). A high score indicates more meaningful work as compared to low score. The WAMI consists of three subscales including positive meaning, meaning-making through work, and greater good motivations, and all the 10 items can be added together to get an overall score of meaningful work.

The Work and Meaning Inventory (WAMI)

Work can mean a lot of different things to different people. The following items ask about how you see the role of work in your own life. Please honestly indicate how true each statement is for you and your work.

Absolutely Untrue (1), Mostly Untrue (2), Neither True nor Untrue (3), Mostly True (4), Absolutely True (5).

**The scoring of Item-3 is reversed; 1 implies Absolute true while 5 means absolutely untrue*

1. I have found a meaningful career.
2. I view my work as contributing to my personal growth.
3. My work really makes no difference to the world. (R)
4. I understand how my work contributes to my life's meaning.
5. I have a good sense of what makes my job meaningful.
6. I know my work makes a positive difference in the world.
7. My work helps me better understand myself.
8. I have discovered work that has a satisfying purpose.
9. My work helps me make sense of the world around me.
10. The work I do serves a greater purpose.

Source: Steger et al., (2012).

14.6 EMPLOYEE ENGAGEMENT

The Great Resignation during the Covid-19 pandemic: Why So?

Millions of employees voluntarily quit their jobs during 2020-21 mainly due to uncertainty associated with Covid-19, and the consequent drastic changes introduced to deal with the pandemic. These drastic changes have resulted in collective burnout or exhaustion arising from prolonged emotional and mental stress. Moreover, many resigned as they look for better job opportunities that offer better pay, new challenges, and more flexibility. Many job seekers are looking

for new challenges due to exhaustion and stagnancy as a result of following a similar working pattern daily, as a result of the work-from-home arrangement, and many others are looking for stable jobs. Interestingly, a survey conducted by Amazon India during September 2021 suggested that over 50 percent of job seekers are looking for opportunities in sectors or industries where they have little or no experience.

However, the problem is much deeper, the toxic culture is mainly to be blamed for such a large-scale resignation. Toxic work culture can be found in any kind of work setting and is not conducive to employee well-being, productivity, and progression. A toxic culture is characterized by conflict, hostile interpersonal relationships, and unethical conduct. A recent study conducted at law firms showed that **half of the legal workers felt that their productivity and wellbeing have been impacted by 'toxic workplace culture'** ('Toxic work culture' impacting productivity, say half of legal workers - Legal Cheek). The study further shows almost two-fifths (38%) of participants be less engaged with their roles as a result of their workplace culture, while a little over a fifth (21%) had taken time off due to an incident that occurred at work. Seventeen percent reported calling in sick as a result of an incident. 29% also reported that they would quit their current role as soon as they could find a new job.

The above description clearly shows that in these kinds of organizations, employees could not feel cognitively and emotionally attached to the organization because organizations failed to win the heart and soul of their employees.

Source: The Great Resignation: Why are so many people quitting jobs across the globe? - Business News (indiatoday.in)

Employee engagement refers to an employee's psychological investment in the organization. However, Harter et al. (2003) felt that employee engagement is not merely psychological but it is a combination of cognitive, emotional, and behavioral attachment with the organization. According to Gallup (2017), employees' engagement is the involvement and enthusiasm of employees in their work and workplace. Based on the Gallup Employee Engagement Survey Analysis Tool (ESAT, Corporate Leadership Council, 2009), engagement can be divided into two components i.e., emotional and rational engagement. **Emotional engagement** is defined as "the extent to which employees value, enjoy, and believe in their jobs, managers, teams or organizations", while **rational engagement** has been defined as "the extent to which employees believe that managers, teams, or organizations have their self-interest in mind (financial, developmental, or professional)" (p. 4). For Schaufeli et al. (2002), employee engagement is a positive, fulfilling, work-related state of mind that is characterized by vigor, dedication, and absorption. Moreover, it is a persistent and pervasive affective-cognitive state that is not focused on any specific object, event, individual, or behavior.

Kahn (1990) proposed the first serious conceptualization of employee engagement and referred to it as the harnessing of organization members' selves to their work roles. Kahn (1990) believed that employee engagement is related to the fulfilment of three psychological needs. These needs are meaningfulness (sense of return on investments of self in role performance), safety (sense of being able to show and employ self without fear of negative consequences), availability (sense of having the necessary resources for investing self in role performances). Employee engagement will be badly affected when the organization fails to provide these resources, and individuals are more likely

to withdraw physically as well as psychologically from their roles (See the case, The Great Resignation during the Covid-19 pandemic).

Employee engagement helps in assessing and governing employees' perspectives on important facets of organizational culture. It helps in finding out whether employees are sincerely involved with their work or merely investing their time, whether human resource practices and team building activities lead to positive outcomes or there is scope for improvement. According to more than 50 years of research in the area of employee engagement, Gallup (2019) reported that irrespective of the economic times-good or bad, company size, nationalities, and industry type, engaged employees are more likely to bring out better organizational outcomes than those who are not.

Several factors may lead to employee engagement in organizations. According to Towers Perrin (2003) and Saks (2006), job characteristics such as challenging work, career advancement opportunities, and autonomy in decision-making are important predictors of employee engagement. Adequate resources to carry out one's task efficiently can also lead to employee engagement (Bakker and Demerouti, 2008). Moreover, infrastructural facilities such as cafeteria, gym, and daycare center will assist employees to stabilize their lives more productively, which in turn would lead to engagement. Personal resources such as self-efficacy, self-esteem, optimism (Xanthopoulou et al. 2009), and overall PsyCap (Thompson et al., 2015) were also found to be important factors leading to engagement. Simbula et al. (2011) found that self-efficacy has a short-term (4 months) and long-term (8 months) lag impact on engagement. Managers/supervisors play a crucial role in inducing employee engagement as they would help employees to know what tasks need to be done, encourage and voice up for them when required, and elucidate how the employee's work leads to organizational success. Singh and Sanjeev (2013) found five factors as predictors of employees' engagement in India; they are encouragement and meaningful task, recognition and support, motivation and cooperation, feedback and corporate annual reports.

Engaged employees are like to bring their mind, heart, and soul to the organization. A positive correlation is generally found between employee engagement and organizational performance. Harter et al. (2002) reported a positive correlation of employee engagement with customer satisfaction ($r=0.33$), as well as with employee profit ($r=0.17$). Xanthopoulou et al. (2009) also found that employee engagement has a positive effect on the financial performance of the organization.

Measurement of Employee engagement:

The Employee Engagement Scale of (Shuck, Adelson, Reio. Jr, 2016), which consists of 12 items, 4 items each for the three dimensions such as cognitive engagement (CE), emotional engagement (EE), and behavioral engagement (BE), is a reliable and valid tool to measure employee engagement. All items have to be rated on a 5-point Likert scale, ranging from 1 (strongly disagree) to 5 (strongly agree). Scoring and interpretation can be done dimension-wise and also as total. A high score indicates more employee engagement as compared to a low score.

Employee Engagement Scale

Please give your frank responses to the following questions on a 5-point scale ranging from 1 (strongly disagree) to 5 (strongly agree).

CE 1. I am really focused when I am working.

CE 2.	I concentrate on my job when I am at work.
CE 3.	I give my job responsibility a lot of attention.
CE 4.	At work, I am focused on my job.
EE 1.	Working at <my current organization> has a great deal of personal meaning to me.
EE 2.	I feel a strong sense of belonging to my job.
EE 3.	I believe in the mission and purpose of <my company>.
EE 4.	I care about the future of <my company>.
BE 1.	I really push myself to work beyond what is expected of me.
BE 2.	I am willing to put in extra effort without being asked.
BE 3.	I often go above what is expected of me to help my team be successful.
BE 4.	I work harder than expected to help <my company> be successful.
<i>CE: Cognitive Engagement, EE: Emotional engagement, & BE: Behavioural Engagement</i>	
Source: Shuck et al. (2016)	

Self Assessment Questions 2

1. A sense of calling at work can help achieve meaningful work. True/ False
2. Multidimensional framework of meaningful work includes _____ and _____ dimensions.
3. What are the three psychological needs associated with meaningful work?
4. Name the two components of employee engagement.

14.7 WELL-BEING

Case Study 5: Rita and Shwetha: Two perspective on Happiness/Well-being

Rita, a college student got a notification tune from her smartphone and couldn't resist checking it. To her surprise, it was an amazon lottery ticket which she applied for a few days back by playing a simple quiz game. A few moments later, she got a call from Amazon and was told that she was the winner of the 20,000 cash prize, which would get transferred to her bank account in 24hours. She got super excited to know this and informed her friends. She thought that she could spend this money as she wanted and even do lots of shopping for her upcoming farewell party. Moreover, she invited all her friends to a party to celebrate her lottery win. She was feeling elated and on top of the world.

Rita's friend Shwetha also got excited to join Rita's party. It was indeed a lavish party and all of them had fun. However, Shwetha also felt that the party could have been slightly low-key. She thought how much happiness the party would give and for long can one remain happy with the pizza party. She also felt that some of the money could have been given to Rita's maid (who lost her husband because of the COVID-19 pandemic) so that she could pay the school fee for her daughter. It also made her sad and dejected. Shwetha decided to help them. First of all, she started home tutoring the girl and some other poor kids from her neighborhood. She also managed to get help from one of the NGOs to buy smartphones for the kids to attend online classes and lectures. It was difficult initially but Shwetha did it. The process of helping the poor kids and managing to get them smartphones made her happy.

Can you compare the idea of happiness of Rita with that of Shwetha? Happiness is frequently used interchangeably with well-being. For example, happiness is usually equated with hedonia (experiencing pleasure and avoiding pain), and well-being is considered a broader phenomenon involving affective, cognitive, and behavioural components (Kun and Gadencz, 2022). In the present context, both concepts are used interchangeably for a simpler understanding.

There are at least **three conceptualizations of well-being**: hedonic, eudaimonic, and social framework. The hedonic framework is based on positive affect/negative affect and life-satisfaction constructs. According to the hedonic framework, happiness is cognitive (how satisfied one is from life?) and affective (positive affect versus negative affect) evaluation of one's life. The eudaimonic framework emphasizes optimal functioning and is measured in terms of self-acceptance, purpose in life, environmental mastery, positive relationships, personal growth, and autonomy.

Many researchers/psychologists have recommended using both the hedonic and eudaimonic approaches (Kashdan, Biswas-Diener, and King, 2008). Henderson and Knight (2012) also found that a life rich in both pursuits was associated with a greater degree of well-being. Waterman (2008) insists that both types of well-being are important and should be measured. The sociocultural context also needs to be considered while conceptualizing happiness (Srivastava and Misra, 2011).

Social well-being is the third kind of well-being (Keyes, 1998) that includes social coherence, social acceptance, social actualization, social contribution, and social integration. It reflects how we are functioning with others and how well we are contributing to the social realm of society.

There is no denying the fact that generic well-being (hedonic, eudaimonic, and social well-being) is an important concept, however, Dagenais-Desmarais & Savoie (2011) felt that generic well-being measures may not tap the complexities of the contemporary organizations and would create difficulties in explaining organizational outcomes such as performance, absenteeism and turnover. Organizational context is characterized by management processes, organizational cultures, and organizational systems which are unique to the organizations and different from other life domains such as friends and family. The work context constitutes an important life domain wherein one adapts to a complex set of relationships, responsibilities, and expectations, and is evaluated and rewarded (or sanctioned) by others.

A large part of an individual's life is spent earning a living from the organizations and finding meaning and purpose for life. There is evidence that well-being and performance are interconnected for a long time. Hersey (1930) conducted many studies to explore the employee well-being and productivity relationship. Similarly, Fisher and Hanna (1931) concluded that 90 percent of employee turnovers could be attributed to employees' well-being in their classic work 'The Dissatisfied Worker'. However, these researches could not be followed due to the great depression of the 1930s. A renewed interest has surfaced in recent years in employee's wellbeing as well-being has been presumed to be related to performance and turnover (Wright, 2010). This strand of research concurs with the increasing number of ill-health reported by employees and the cost of it. There is also evidence that work-specific measures of well-being had incremental validity over generic measures in predicting work-related outcomes (Hunthausen, Truxillo, Bauer, & Hammer, 2003). Therefore, there is a need to explore well-being at work.

One of the first **comprehensive models on employees well-being** in the occupational setting was developed by Warr (1990) and called it '*affective well-being*'. Affective well-being is a multi-dimensional construct and it is measured with the frequency with which individuals experience various positive and negative affects. Affective work-related well-being is a three-dimensional model and these are enthusiasm–depression; anxiety–comfort, and pleasure–displeasure. Although there is some support for this model, however, clubbing positive and negative affect together is problematic as these two constructs are related but distinct from each other (Karademas, 2007). Moreover, the existing generic measures of distress/wellbeing were used to tap affective well-being by Warr and other researchers.

Pryce-Jones (2010) presented another *model of happiness at work* based on her five-year extensive study. In this model, happiness at work is defined as a mindset that allows an individual to maximize performance and achieve potential while encompassing job satisfaction and engagement. This model has put the employee at the center (in terms of his/her achievement potential) thus emphasizing the power an individual has over his/her level of happiness. There are 5 C's placed around this center and these are – Contribution (constructive and productive effort), Conviction (motivation, efficiency, and resilience along with a positive perception of job importance), Culture (norms, values, and behavior of an organization), Commitment (an interacting set of feelings and beliefs) and Confidence (self-control; high levels of self-belief; a clear understanding of role). The outer circle is conceptualized with pride, trust, and recognition. While pride and trust are the individual's contributions to the organization, recognition is an organizational level construct that is a kind of exchange for a job well-done by the employee. Pryce-Jones (2010) has provided comprehensive and research-based evidence for the utility of workplace happiness.

Dagenais-Desmarais and Savoie (2011) developed a comprehensive *model for psychological well-being at work* (PWBW). They adopted a qualitative bottom-up approach starting from the experience of individuals, as exploring what actually is psychological well-being for people. A series of 20 critical incident interviews were conducted with French-speaking workers and they were asked to report critical incidents of psychological well-being at work that they had

experienced. The interview transcripts were content analyzed which resulted in 80 PWBW manifestations (80 statements). To develop the PWBW model inductively, these 80 statements were administered on a sample of 1,080 participants. Data were analyzed with exploratory factor analysis, confirmatory factor analysis, convergent and divergent validity. The exhaustive analysis revealed that PWBW can be conceptualized through five dimensions (Dagenais-Desmarais and Savoie (2011):

- (a) Interpersonal fit at work - perception of experiencing positive relationships with individuals interacting with oneself within the work context.
- (b) Thriving at work - perception of accomplishing a significant and interesting job that allows one to fulfill oneself as an individual.
- (c) Feeling of competency at work - perception of possessing the necessary aptitudes to do one's job efficiently and have mastery of the asks to perform.
- (d) Perceived recognition at work - perception of being appreciated within the organization for one's work and one's personhood.
- (e) Desire for involvement at work - will to involve oneself in the organization and to contribute to its good functioning and success (p. 670). It would be interesting to report that these five dimensions of PWBW are not completely independent constructs rather they belong to an all-encompassing construct of PWBW. The results revealed a reliable and valid measure for PWBW with 25 items on a six-point Likert scale, from 0 (disagree) to 5 (completely agree). The scoring can be done dimension-wise as well as a whole, and a higher score indicates more psychological well-being at work than a low score. PWBW is reliable and valid in many countries including India (Sandilya & Shahnawaz, 2018).

Employee well-being is a crucial factor in an organization's performance and success and it has implications for health, work behavior, job satisfaction, and burnout (Crede et al. 2007; Fisher 2010). Moreover, Individuals with higher levels of well-being are more cooperative, have more satisfying relationships, stronger immune systems, fewer sleep problems, greater self-control, better self-regulation and coping abilities (Diener & Seligman 2002; Chida & Steptoe, 2008). There are many individual, group, managerial and organizational levels factors that are strongly related to employee well-being (Nielsen et al. 2017). Therefore, the organization needs to leverage employees' well-being by devising organizational policies and practices which would lead to well-being at work.

Measurement of Psychological well-being at work:

Dagenais-Desmarais and Savoie (2011) scale of employees well-being at work as discussed above is a reliable and valid tool. There are 25 items, 5 each for five dimensions as given below. Interpersonal Fit at Work Items: 1, 6, 11, 16, 21; Thriving at Work Items: 2, 7, 12, 17, 22; Feeling of Competency at Work Items: 3, 8, 13, 18, 23; Perceived Recognition at Work Items: 4, 9, 14, 19, 24; Desire for Involvement at Work Items: 5, 10, 15, 20, 25.

INDEX OF PSYCHOLOGICAL WELL-BEING AT WORK

This questionnaire presents a list of statements describing how people may feel at work. Considering your job over the past 4 weeks, please indicate to what extent you agree with each statement on a 6-point scale given below:

Completely Agree (5), Agree (4), Moderately Agree (3), Agree (2), Slightly Agree (1) Disagree (0)

1. I value the people I work with
2. I find my job exciting
3. I know I am capable of doing my job
4. I feel that my work is recognized
5. I want to take initiative in my work
6. I enjoy working with the people at my job
7. I like my job
8. I feel confident at work
9. I feel that my work efforts are appreciated
10. I care about the good functioning of my organization
11. I get along well with the people at my job
12. I am proud of the job I have
13. I feel effective and competent in my work
14. I know that people believe in the projects I work on
15. I like to take on challenges in my work
16. I have a relationship of trust with the people at my job
17. I find meaning in my work
18. I feel that I know what to do in my job
19. I feel that people I work with recognize my abilities
20. I want to contribute to achieving the goals of the organization
21. I feel that I am accepted as I am by the people I work with
22. I have a great sense of fulfilment at work
23. I know my value as a worker
24. I feel that I am a full member of my organization
25. I want to be involved in my organization beyond my work duties

Source: Dagenais-Desmarais, & Savoie (2012)

14.8 POSITIVE PSYCHOLOGY INTERVENTIONS AT WORK

Positive Psychology Interventions at work (PPIs at work) are interventions that explicitly apply the theory and scholarship of positive work and organization psychologies to guide, plan, design, and/or implement the interventions to improve personal as well as organizational level outcomes. Donaldson, Lee, and Donaldson (2019) in a meta-analytic review of 22 research articles found that that PPIs at work had a small to moderate effect on desirable (e.g., job well-being) and undesirable work outcomes (e.g., job stress). They also found that “PPIs at work significantly improved well-being, engagement, and other important work outcomes (i.e., leader member exchange, organization based self-esteem, workplace trust, forgiveness, prosocial behavior, leadership, and calling)”. (p-128).

Thus the PPIs focus on the strengths that employees have, increasing the sense of engagement, and employee satisfaction. It underlies a ***strengths-based approach to work*** where the focus is on building on the assets of the employees rather than trying to change their weaknesses (Snyder, Lopez, & Pedrotti, 2011, p. 435). The strengths-based approach involves *three aspects* (Clifton & Harter, 2003): (a) identifying the talents of employees and increasing their awareness about these; (b) integrating these talents into the self-image of the employee; and (c) implementing behavioural change where the employees use their talents to achieve success.

Various positive psychology interventions using the strengths of employees can be described in the following categories (Donaldson, Lee, & Donaldson, 2019):

- 1) Psychological Capital Interventions: As discussed in the earlier section, PsyCap is the synergistic combination of hope, self-efficacy, resilience, and optimism (indicated by the acronym HERO). PsyCap resources are malleable, open to development, and integral to human resource practices (Luthans and Youssef-Morgan 2017). PsyCap interventions are associated with a variety of work outcomes, including improved job performance, engagement, and organizational citizenship behaviors (e.g., Avey et al. 2010). Not only physical intervention, but even web-based interventions can also develop four PsyCap resources (Luthans et al. 2008).
- 2) Job Crafting Interventions: Job crafting is a proactive process at work in which employees can redesign their jobs so that they have some control over their work. Job crafting will help employees to have an optimal fit between job demands and personal resources such as personal needs, abilities, and strengths (Wrzesniewski and Dutton 2001). Job crafting interventions have been found to improve performance, well-being, and work engagement (Van den Heuvel et al. 2015; Wingerden et al. 2016).
- 3) Employee Strengths Interventions: Character strengths are natural strengths of human being can be defined as trait-like, measurable qualities that manifest in ways of thinking, feeling, and behaving. Employees’ strengths interventions apply the theory of character strengths to the identification, development, and use of strengths for employees. Values in Action (VIA) inventory was created by Peterson and Seligman (2004) that can be used to identify and describe the optimal human character strengths. MacKie’s (2014) research has shown

that strengths interventions can be useful for improving the well-being, and leadership of employees. Overall, strengths interventions for desirable work outcomes were shown to have stronger effects than other interventions ((Donaldson, Lee, and Donaldson, 2019).

- 4) **Employee Gratitude Interventions:** Gratitude in the workplace is “noticing and appreciating the positive ‘in one’s work life’ specifically and not in the generic world (Wood et al. 2010). Therefore, employee gratitude interventions are activities that aim to increase the practice of gratitude in the workplace. Researchers have used both paper-pencil and web-based gratitude interventions at work (Komase et al., 2021). Wood et al. (2010) felt that gratitude interventions are a robust strategy for improving employee job well-being. The effect of gratitude interventions for desirable work outcomes was found to be strongest as compared to other interventions such as psychological capital interventions or job crafting or well being interventions (Donaldson, Lee, and Donaldson, 2019).
- 5) **Employee Well-Being Interventions:** Employee well-being involves both generic well-being and work-specific well-being as discussed. In the context of work, Seligman’s wellbeing theory known as PERMA (i.e., positive emotions, engagement, relationships, meaning, and accomplishment) has been used widely. Employee well-being interventions have been shown to reduce employee absenteeism and turnover intentions, as well as improve job satisfaction (Boehm and Lyubomirsky 2008; Layous et al. 2013).

Self Assessment Questions 3

1. What does social well-being include?
2. What is affective well-being?
3. Name the five C’s related to the employee in Pryce-Jones model of happiness at work.
4. Define Positive psychology interventions at work?
5. What is job crafting?

14.9 LET US SUM UP

In this unit, you have learned some of the key concepts of positive psychology in the workplace. You also learned about Positive Psychology Interventions at work which focus on training and intervention. Let us just briefly recall the main points.

- **PsyCap:** PsyCap is the synergistic combination of self-efficacy, hope, optimism, and resilience. PsyCap resources are malleable, open to development, and integral to human resource practices in organizations. PsyCap is positively related to performance, wellbeing, and other desirable outcomes. At the same time, PsyCap is negatively related to undesirable outcomes such as stress, burnout, and counterproductive work behavior. PsyCap is best measured by PCQ-24 which is valid in many parts of the world including India.

- **Flow:** Flow in the context of work is a short-term peak experience comprising absorption, work enjoyment, and intrinsic work motivation. Employees in a flow state are fascinated by the tasks they perform, and the intrinsic aspects of the tasks in themselves are enough to motivate them. Both situational, as well as individual factors, can result in flow at work. Flow is positively related to self-rated performance, other rated performance, and wellbeing. Work-Related Flow Scale (WOLF) is one of the most widely used scales to measure flow. WOLF has been successfully translated/adapted in many countries such as Italy, Australia, China, South Africa, etc. WOLF has recently been modified so that it can be used in the academic domain.
- **Meaningful Work:** Meaningful work is defined as workplace characteristics that facilitate the attainment or maintenance of one or more dimensions of meaning. Meaningful work is considered as an individual's judgment regarding their work and the value they derive from work. Employees who feel their work as 'meaningful' report greater well-being and view their work as more central and important to their actual selves. On the other hand, a lack of meaningful work is a source of alienation, anxiety, emotional exhaustion, burnout, and boredom in the organization. Meaningfulness of work predicts positive workplace outcomes including organizational commitment, organizational citizenship behaviors, employee engagement, and job satisfaction. The Work as Meaning Inventory (WAMI; Steger et al., 2012) is one of the important measures of meaningful work.
- **Employee Engagement:** Employee engagement is a combination of cognitive, emotional, and behavioral attachment with the organization. Employee engagement is related to the fulfillment of three psychological needs of meaningfulness, safety, and availability of the resources needed to perform in the organization. Job characteristics such as challenging work, career advancement opportunities, autonomy in decision-making, adequate physical/infrastructural resources, and personal resources such as self-efficacy, self-esteem, and optimism are some of the factors which will result in employee engagement. The Employee Engagement Scale of (Shuck, Adelson, Reio, Jr, 2016) is one of the valid measures of employee engagement and it measures engagement in the three core dimensions of cognitive, emotional, and behavioral engagement.
- **Well-being at work:** Happiness and wellbeing are interchangeable despite the fine difference between the two. Happiness is usually equated with experiencing pleasure and avoiding pain, however, wellbeing is considered a broader phenomenon involving affective, cognitive, and behavioral components. Wellbeing can be generic as well as work-related. Generic wellbeing measures may not tap the complexities of the contemporary organizations and would create difficulties in explaining organizational outcomes such as performance, absenteeism, and turnover. Though the relationship between wellbeing and performance has been explored since the 1930s, there has been a renewed interest in the past few years in the area of employee wellbeing due to many factors such as the increasing importance of employees in realizing organizational outcomes as well as increasing cost of ill-health. Although there are many scales to measure employees' well-being at work, Dagenais-Desmarais and Savoie's Psychological well-being at work (PWBW)

scale seems to be more valid because it adopts a bottom-up approach. The scale is valid in many parts of the world including India.

- **Positive psychology Interventions at work:** Positive Psychology Interventions at work (PPIs at work) are interventions that explicitly apply the theory and scholarship of positive work and organization psychologies to guide, plan, design, and/or implement the interventions to improve personal as well as organizational level outcomes. PPIs at work had a small to moderate effect on desirable (e.g., job well-being) and undesirable work outcomes (e.g., job stress). Broadly PPIs at work can be grouped into five categories: PsyCap interventions, Job crafting interventions, Employees strength interventions, Employees gratitude interventions, and finally employees wellbeing interventions.

14.10 KEY WORDS

PsyCap: Refers to psychological capital which is a synergistic combination of self-efficacy, hope, optimism, and resilience.

Flow: A short-term peak experience in the context of work comprising of absorption, work enjoyment, and intrinsic work motivation.

Meaningful Work: It is defined as workplace characteristics that facilitate the attainment or maintenance of one or more dimensions of meaning. It is also considered as an individual's judgment regarding their work and the value they derive from work.

Employee Engagement: Employee engagement is a combination of cognitive, emotional, and behavioral attachment with the organization.

Well-being: Well-being is considered a broader phenomenon involving affective, cognitive, and behavioural components related to employee well-being which has important implications for organizational outcomes.

Positive Psychology Interventions at Work: Interventions that explicitly apply the theory and scholarship of positive work and organization psychologies to guide, plan, design, and/or implement the interventions to improve personal as well as organizational level outcomes.

14.11 ANSWERS TO SELF ASSESSMENT QUESTIONS

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 1

1. Gainful employment focuses on employee well-being with a comprehensive approach, taking care of the physical, personal, psychological, economic, social, and organizational aspects.
2. Hope, optimism, self-efficacy, and resilience
3. agency (goal-directed energy), and pathways (planning to meet goals).
4. PCQ-24
5. True
6. absorption, work enjoyment, and intrinsic work motivation

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 2

1. True
2. Content and process dimensions
3. Autonomy, self-determination and relatedness
4. Emotional engagement and rational engagement

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 3

1. Social well-being includes social coherence, social acceptance, social actualization, social contribution, and social integration.
2. Affective well-being is a multi-dimensional construct and it is measured with the frequency with which individuals experience various positive and negative affects.
3. Contribution, Conviction, Culture, Commitment, and Confidence
4. Positive Psychology Interventions at work (PPIs at work) are interventions that explicitly apply the theory and scholarship of positive work and organization psychologies to guide, plan, design, and/or implement the interventions to improve personal as well as organizational level outcomes.
5. Job crafting is a proactive process at work in which employees can redesign their jobs so that they have some control over their work.

14.12 UNIT END QUESTIONS

1. Explain the importance of the study of Positive Psychology at work.
2. Explain the meaning and implications of the four components of PsyCap on personal and organizational outcomes.
3. Define flow at work. Discuss factors which would result in flow at work.
4. Discuss the meaning and consequences of employee engagement.
5. Discuss Great Resignation story and suggest ways so that culture does not become toxic.
6. Define meaningful work. Discuss the factors affecting meaningful work and their consequences.
7. Which form of wellbeing (Hedonic or Eudaimonic or Social) is more relevant in the present day world and why?
8. Given a chance to choose, which wellbeing interventions you will choose (between generic and work specific) to motivate and reduce distress level of employees?
9. The 'Gratitude at work intervention' has been found to have strongest impact on desirable work outcomes as compared to other positive psychology at work intervention. Explain why it would have happened.

REFLECTIVE EXERCISES

Reflective Exercise 1: (PsyCap/ Resilience)

As you have noticed that many people had to do work from home (WFH) during the

COVID-19 pandemic and it continued for long. WFH required many adjustments (space, infrastructure, staying at home throughout, not-so-fixed working hours, etc.), which some individuals could do well whereas others faced problems.

If you know someone (family/friends) who did WFH during the pandemic, talk to that person and find out how resilience helped them to navigate the difficult territory of WFH during the pandemic. Try to identify the facilitators and inhibitors for WFH, which would have helped/hindered resilience during COVID-19.

Reflective Exercise 2: (Flow)

People experience flow when they are immersed in the task/assignment which they are doing, and enjoy the task immensely so much that they lose track of time. Performing the task itself becomes more important than success and failure on the task. Have you ever seen someone doing something who you felt were in a flow state? How did you know they were in a flow state? What difference do you find between persons who do something with or without a flow state?

Reflective Exercise 3: (Flow)

WOLF-S (Study Related Flow Inventory) has been given in Unit-14.4. Administer this inventory to 5 of your friends, and see how they have scored. If some of them have scored more as compared to others on WOLF-S, what does this imply? Can you write the similarity and differences of high scorers versus low scorers on WOLF-S, when they work on some work-related assignments?

Reflective Exercise 4: (Employee Engagement)

Engaged employees bring their mind, heart, and soul to the organization and the work which they do. It also means that there is no separation between their self (who they are) and what they do. Therefore, employee engagement is a positive, fulfilling, work-related state of mind that is characterized by vigor, dedication, and absorption. Find out someone in your known circle who you think is engaged with their organizations. Make a list of their thought processes, emotional state, and behavior that reflect that they are engaged with the organization.

Reflective Exercise 5: (Wellbeing)

You are aware that wellbeing is of three kinds: hedonic, eudaemonic, and social. Each has its benefits and limitations. If you win a lottery of One Lakh rupees, which kinds of wellbeing you would like to attain and why?

Reflective Exercise 6: (Generic Wellbeing versus Wellbeing at work)

In Unit 14.7, it is presented that work-specific wellbeing is more relevant at work than the generic kinds of wellbeing (hedonic, eudaimonic, and social). Do you know someone whom you think is having a high/low level of work-related wellbeing? Reflect on that individual and write down whether wellbeing at work (high/low) is independent of generic wellbeing.

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Weblinks:

[Psychological Capital - YouTube](#)

[Luthans on Psychological Capital - YouTube](#)

[Psychological Capital – It Takes More Than Money To Trade Well - Bing video](#)

[Mihaly Csikszentmihaly - Flow: Psychology, Creativity, & Optimal Experience - Bing video](#)

[Flow at Work - Bing video](#)

[Meaningful Work with Dr. Christopher Michaelson - Bing video](#)

[Frientorship: The Solution To The Employee Engagement Problem | Claudia Williams | TEDxPSU - Bing video](#)

[What Is The Definition of Employee Engagement? - Bing video](#)

[The Secrets to Happiness at Work | Zack Friedman | TEDxRochester - Bing video](#)

[Well-Being at Work: What Employers Can Do Today - Bing video](#)

[Workplace Positive Psychology Exercises: An Evidence-Based Guide to Implementation - Highlights - Bing video](#)



The logo of Uignou University is a large, light gray watermark on the left side of the page. It features a stylized 'U' that encircles a circular emblem containing a dollar sign and a person icon. To the right of the emblem, the word 'Uignou' is written in a large, sans-serif font, and below it, 'THE PEOPLE'S UNIVERSITY' is written in a smaller, all-caps, sans-serif font.

Block V

Positive Psychology Interventions

UNIT 15 STRESS MANAGEMENT AND POST TRAUMATIC GROWTH*

Structure

- 15.1 Learning Objectives
- 15.2 Introduction
- 15.3 Concept of Stress
- 15.4 Strategies/Techniques for Management of Stress
 - 15.4.1 Strategies Focusing on Physical Aspect and Breathing
 - 15.4.2 Strategies Focusing on Cognitive Processes
 - 15.4.3 Strategies Focusing on Affective Processes
 - 15.4.4 Strategies Focusing on Behaviour
 - 15.4.5 Stress Management Strategies at the Organizational Level
- 15.5 Post-traumatic Growth
- 15.6 Let Us Sum Up
- 15.7 Key Words
- 15.8 Answers to Self Assessment Questions
- 15.9 Unit End Questions
- 15.10 References
- 15.11 Suggested Readings

15.1 LEARNING OBJECTIVES

After studying this Unit, you would be able to:

- *Explain the nature and types of stress;*
- *Describe the various strategies/techniques of managing stress; and*
- *Explain post-traumatic growth.*

15.2 INTRODUCTION

You may be a young adult pursuing this course. You might be thinking of which career to pursue after completion of the graduation degree. Or which further programme to pursue? You might be feeling stressed about your higher education and career; at the same time you might be forming relationship with opposite sex and exploring romantic relationship. You might also be an adult already in job and/or with family; or you might be an older person who has taken up this programme out of interest or to add to your knowledge. Whatever age and stage of life you may be in, you must be facing stress due to various reasons related to that particular stage. Adolescents experience stress related to the physical and psychological changes; adults face stress related to their job, family responsibilities, raising children, taking care of the older family members;

whereas the older people are stressed about their health, finance, and family and social support. Further, stress is also experienced by typical groups of population such as children, women, people with disabilities, transgenders, people with HIV/AIDS, chronic illness and so on. The underlying point here is that no stage of life and no group of people are without stress. Stress is an integral part of life even though each one of us invariably wants that their needs and desires get fulfilled and they achieve happiness in life.

Think of it, if there were no stress, life will be simple, but may feel boring and lack creativity also. Stress in fact pushes us to perform to the best of our ability and stimulates our problem solving and critical thinking. An optimum amount of stress motivates us and enhances our performance. However, when stress goes beyond this optimum level, which may vary from person to person, it results in stressful experience. Various personal and environmental factors may act as barriers to reach our goals and place adjustive demands on us leading to the experience of stress. The term 'stress' has typically been used to refer both to the adjustive demand placed on an organism and to the organism's internal biological responses to such demands. All situations, whether positive or negative, require adjustment, and may lead to stress.

Stress is often termed as a Twentieth Century Syndrome, born out of man's race towards modern progress and its ensuing complexities.

- Benjamin Franklin

15.3 CONCEPT OF STRESS

The concept of 'stress' was first introduced by Hans Selye in 1936. It is derived from the Latin word "*stringere*" which means '*to tighten*', denoting force, strain, or strong efforts and pressure with reference to an object or person. According to Beck (1967), stress refers to any force which physically or psychologically strains the coping mechanism of an organism. Stress is defined as "nonspecific response of the body to any demand (Selye, 1956). Hans Selye, who is known as the 'father of stress research', states that when we do not get any specific response to the stimulus that creates tension in our body and mind, it is called as stress.

Stress can be of two types – positive stress and negative stress. Positive stress is good stress or *eustress* (Truxillo et al. (2015), e.g., stress arising out of job promotion, getting married or moving to a new city; whereas negative stress is known as *distress* (Schafer (1998, p. 8), e.g., stress resulting from a cyclone which damaged your house or suffering from a severe illness. Besides there are also other type of stresses, known as neustress (neither harmful nor helpful stresses, Schafer, 1998); hyper stress (excessive stresses) and hypo stress (insufficient stresses).

Stresses can also be categorized as acute, chronic and episodic acute stress. *Acute stress* can occur after a very stressful life event, e.g., death or accident of a loved one, disaster, failure/setback to reach a cherished goal, trauma, job loss etc. Here the stressor is sudden; and the symptoms are acute, but do not last long. It is also called as short-term stress. Acute stress generally results in diabetes, headache, rapid heart palpitation, acidity, muscle tension, body pain etc. *Chronic stress*, on the other hand, involves long-lasting symptoms, for instance, stress due to bad marriages, chronic illness, successive failures in life, and extremely taxing job/negative work environment. Such stress is long-term and is very harmful for health. *Episodic acute*

stress involves acute stress that occurs frequently or in various episodes from time to time. For instance, taking up too much workload than one can handle from time to time can result in a feeling of frequent stress. This is called as repeated stress and becomes a way of life.

The **sources of stress** are considered as causes of stress that can include frustration, conflict of motives, pressures, life events, fear, resistance, resentment, daily hassles, interpersonal relationships, arising out of biological, psychological, and socio-cultural factors. Generally the factors that cause stress are known as **stressors**. These are the factors that challenge the adaptive capacity of the individual. Thus stressors threaten to disrupt the organism's optimal functioning and the stress response is the cascade of biological processes necessary to return the system to homeostasis (Sapolsky, 1992).

The factors influencing the severity of stresses are the nature of the stressor, the individual's stress tolerant behavior (relating to both physical and mental capacity), environmental factors and social support. Whatever may be the reason, the reactions and responses to those stresses are important that can lead to maladjustment and maladaptive coping behavior causing stresses to the individual.

The impact of a stressor depends on its importance, duration, cumulative effects, multiplicity, and imminence. Stressors that involve important aspects of an individual's life can be highly stressful. Further, prolonged exhaustion imposes a more intense stress than does temporary fatigue. For instance, even if there are frequent arguments between the couple, they carry on with the relationship until one day when it breaks in the face of the "last straw", that is, the precipitating stressor. A number of stressor at the same time also has a greater impact, e.g., if the person gets fired from his job, faces a divorce case, has a heart attack, – all at the same time – the resulting stress will be more severe as compared to facing a single stressor. Finally in most difficult situations including those involving conflict, the severity of stress increases as the need to deal with the demand increases.

Stressors are broadly categorized into *four types* such as, physical or physiological, psychological, environmental, and socio - cultural.

- **Physical stressors** include such stimuli as injury, infection, immobilization, malnutrition, inadequate living space etc.
- **Psychological stressors** include such stimuli as threats to self esteem, failure in an intellectual task, interaction with a hostile person, frustration, conflicts, poor health, poor financial conditions, life crisis and so on.
- **Environmental stressors** include such stimuli as crowding, loud noise, extreme temperature, air pollution, sensory deprivation, environmental overload or under load, etc.
- **Socio-cultural stressors** include such stimuli as social isolation, cultural deprivation, social disadvantages, poor socio-economic status, disturbed family, undesired socio-cultural activities, low social status, and so on.

General Adaptation Syndrome Model of Stress

Hans Selye, the recognized father of stress research talks about General Adaptation Syndrome (GAS) to explain the process of stress reaction.

The GAS has three stages: *Alarm*, *Resistance*, and *Exhaustion*. In the *alarm* stage, the external stimulus/ stressor activates the internal stress system of the body. There are a number of physiological and chemical reactions, such as increased pituitary and adrenaline secretions; noticeable increases in respiration, heart rate, and blood pressure; and a heightening of the senses. If the stressor continues, then the GAS moves into the *resistance* stage, during which the body calls upon the needed organ or system to deal with the stresses. However, while there may be a great deal of resistance to one stressor during the second stage, there may be little, if any, resistance to, unrelated stressors. This helps explain why a person going through an emotional string may be particularly vulnerable to other illness or disease. Finally, if the stressors persist over a longer period of time, the reserves of the adaptive mechanisms during the second stage may become drained and *exhaustion* sets in.

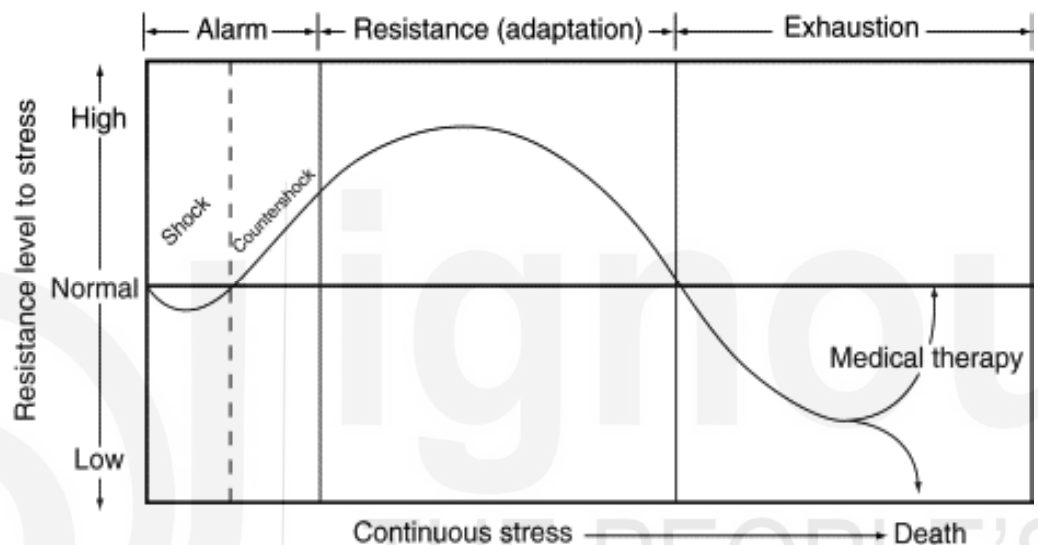


Fig. 15.1: Three Stages of General Adaptation Syndrome

Source: <https://www.sciencedirect.com › medicine-and-dentistry>

Besides the physiologically oriented approach to stress represented by the classic GAS model which remains a vital dimension of modern stress research and stress management, attention is also being given to the psychological (e.g., mood changes, negative emotions, and feeling of helplessness), and the behavioral (e.g., directly confronting the stressor or attempting to obtain information about the stressor) dimensions of stress. All three dimensions (physiological, psychological and behavioral) are important in the understanding of stress and coping strategies to manage stress.

Diathesis-Stress Model

This model of stress (Rubinstein, 1986) explains the occurrence of stress as the outcome of a dynamic interaction between the hereditary factors and the environmental factors. Thus there is a biological predisposition, for instance for getting high blood pressure or blood sugar, which makes the person vulnerable. However, the manifestation of this will depend on the environmental factors or the stressors in the life of the person. Similarly, the person may be prone to getting irritable/anxious, but this will interact with the environmental stressors for the person, that will act as the precipitating factors, to actually get anxious. Hence this is also known as the vulnerability-stress model.

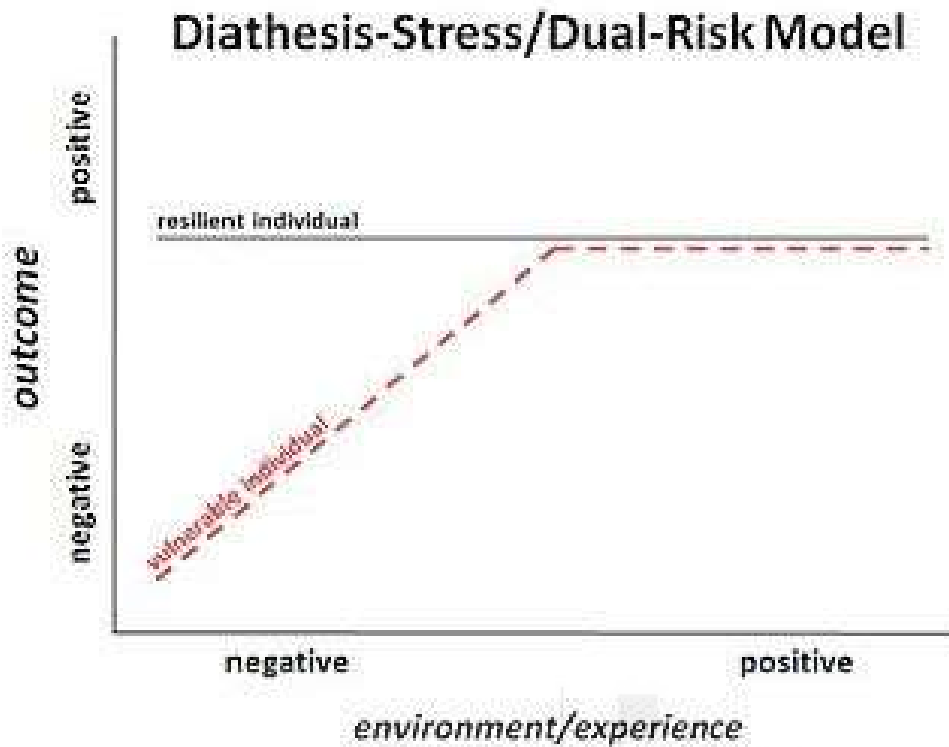


Fig. 15.2: Diathesis-Stress Model

Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:B_%D7%9E%D7%95%D7%93%D7%9C.jpg

Let's Apply

Are you Vulnerable or Resilient?

- Find out your vulnerability. What are the factors that may make you susceptible to stress?
- Identify your strengths or protective factors that can help you manage stress.
- Make two columns on a sheet of paper and write down the above two.
- Analyze if you have more vulnerability or more resiliency.
- Reflect on how can you increase your resiliency.

15.4 STRATEGIES/TECHNIQUES FOR MANAGEMENT OF STRESS

Management of stress requires identifying the stress and the stressors, i.e., the factors causing stress; and also assessing the level of stress. Identification of stress requires one to identify the various signs and symptoms of stress, which can be physical/physiological, emotional, and behavioural.

Identification of Stress

- **Physical signs:** changes in heart beat, blood pressure, body weight, diabetes, sleep problem, stomach upset, aches, headache, frequent cold or infections, muscle tension, changes in menstrual cycle and libido.

- **Psychological signs:** *difficulty in concentration, and troubles in remembering and recalling, worries.*
- **Emotional signs:** *being angry, moody, irritable, sad, anxious or frustrated.*
- **Behavioral signs:** *poor self-care, not having time for the things you enjoy or taking to drugs and alcohol to cope, smoking, overeating, gambling, excessive internet use.*

We can identify the stressors based on situations, activities, and relationships that cause 'trauma' to one's physical, emotional, or psychological self. It can be from school, work situation, family relationship, legal matters, finances, health, illness, environment and other living situation.

Assessment of Stress

The most widely used psychological tool for measuring the perception of stress by the individual is the 'Perceived Stress Scale' (PSS). It assesses the extent to which individuals perceive their life situations/events as stressful. Other tools to measure stress are LEDS (Life Events and Difficulty Schedule by Brown and Harris (1986), Stress and Anxiety Inventory (STRAIN) by Slavich et. al. (2019), and Trier Social Stress Test (TSST) by Kirschbaum, et.al., (1993). Along with the various psychological tools for measuring stress level, stress assessment also involves questionnaires, check lists and interview with the person and significant others to understand the stress and take appropriate measures to manage the stress.

Stress can be a short-term issue or a long-term issue. However, regular management of stress is the key to lead a happy life. The most important point is how one perceives the stress events and facts. This is best explained by Hans Seyle (1979) - "Stress is a 'perception'. It is the demand that is imposed upon us because there are too many alternatives". The concept and principles of positive psychology can be applied to manage our stress effectively and to promote a healthy life and a positive response to family and society.

15.4.1 Strategies Focusing on Physical Aspect and Breathing

- **Physical exercise**

Regular physical exercise is beneficial for physical health as well as mental health. Aerobics, walking, juggling, swimming, riding bicycles, playing soft balls, and tennis etc. can help in dealing with excessive stress levels. These forms of physical exercise increase heart capacities, lower act-rest heart rate, provide a mental diversion from work pressures and offer a means to "Let off steam" (Kiely & Hadgson, 1990).

- **Relaxation Technique**

Jacobson Progressive Muscle Relaxation (JPMR) is a very comprehensive relaxation technique which is based on the principle that stress and relaxation cannot occur together as these are manifestations of sympathetic and

parasympathetic nervous system respectively which reciprocally inhibit each other.

The technique mainly starts with breathing in, holding the breath and letting go while contracting and relaxing 16 muscle groups such as arms, hands, shoulders, neck, forehead-eyes-scalp, jaws - mouth, chest - trunk, stomach, lower back, buttocks, thigh, foot-calf (Ghosh 2015).

The contracting and relaxing of muscle is to be done as follows:

- *Bend the arms up to the elbow, hold for a few seconds and relax.*
- *Clench the hands in a fist, hold for some time and open.*
- *Pull the shoulders in upward direction, hold in this position for a while and then release.*
- *For relaxing the neck, push back the head for a few seconds and then bring to the original position. Similarly, bring the chin down towards the chest, for a few seconds and then bring to the original position.*
- *For chest, take deep breaths, hold for a few seconds and then relax.*
- *Pull in the stomach for a few seconds and then relax.*
- *For thighs, pull the knees together for a while and then relax by drifting them apart.*
- *Squeeze the buttocks together and relax.*
- *For feet, pull your toes up in the direction of your knees, hold this position briefly and then relax by letting go. Heels can be pressed against the ground for a few seconds and then relaxed by letting go.*

Now, rub your palms together, place them on your eyes for sometime, and then slowly open your eyes.

• **Yoga and Meditation**

Yoga:

The main aim of Yoga is self-realization (Balaji, 2012). It is a way of life which enables one to gain inner awareness and develop a higher consciousness to attain 'Mokshya'. Yoga as a practice originated in India and the term yoga is derived from Sanskrit word 'yuj', meaning 'to unite', which indicates a union of consciousness and body. At the practice level, yoga includes *Asana* (bodily postures), *Pranayam* (breathing exercises) and *Dhyana* (meditation).

There are various types of yoga such as Karma yoga, Jnana yoga and Bhakti yoga – mentioned in the Bhagvad Gita, which refer to the path of action, path of knowledge, and the path of devotion respectively. Ashtanga yoga of Maharshi Patanjali talks about the eight limbs or steps in the path to self-realization (you will learn more about it in the next unit 16). Other forms of yoga include Raja yoga, Sahaja yoga, Kriya yoga, Hatha yoga, and Kundalini yoga propounded by various spiritual *Gurus*.

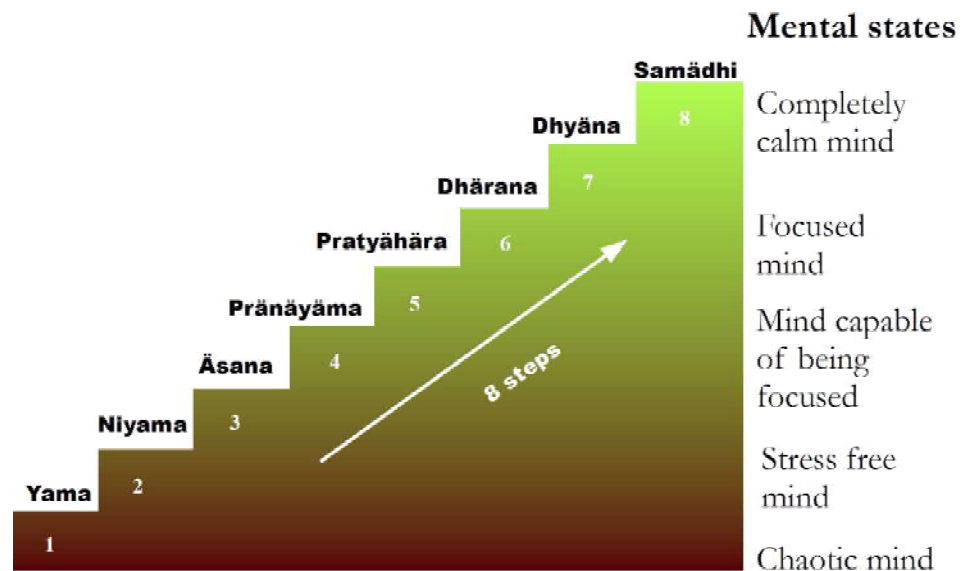


Fig. 15.3 : Eight Steps of Ashtanga Yoga

Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Eight_steps_of_yoga.jpg

Meditation:

Meditation (‘*Dhyana*’ in Sanskrit language) aims at quietening our mind to gain inner awareness and spiritual enlightenment. It also helps manage stress and enhances one’s health and well-being. There are various types of meditation (Villines, 2017, Welch, 2019) such as,

Mindfulness meditation refers to developing awareness about one’s thoughts and emotions in the present moment, without any judgment. It involves shifting from our default auto pilot mode to moment-to-moment awareness mode. Mindfulness meditation originates from Buddhist teachings. The main characteristics of mindfulness according to Kabat-Zinn (1990) are being non-judgmental, cultivating patience, being open minded, having trust, non-striving, acceptance and letting go.

Mindful breathing

- *Sit comfortably with erect and relaxed posture and eyes closed.*
- *Focus on your breath as you inhale and exhale without trying to change it.*
- *If any other thought comes to your mind, just notice it without any judgement, and then gently bring back your focus on your breath.*
- *Mindfulness can help reduce stress and promote positive mental health.*

Mantra meditation uses a repetitive sound, usually “Om” for chanting. It can also be any other word/phrase or 1-2 lines prayer, which can be spoken loudly or quietly. It is prevalent in Hindu and Buddhist traditions and aims at achieving a deeper consciousness.

Transcendental meditation also involves chanting of a ‘mantra’/ or a word which is specific to each practitioner, and gradually intends to transcend or move beyond this specific chanting.

Guided meditation mainly involves sitting with eyes closed and visualisation of certain images that you may find relaxing.

Loving-kindness meditation, also known as ‘Metta meditation’, focuses on generating and spreading love and kindness to all around us. It involves feelings of acceptance and compassion for all.

Vipasana meditation aims at self transformation by focusing and realizing the mind-body connection.

Chakra (wheel) meditation focuses on balancing the seven chakras – the energy centres in our body, to reduce stress, create awareness and bring harmony in our life. The seven chakras are Root chakra (Mooladhara), Sacral chakra (Swadhisthana), Solar plexus chakra (Nabhi chakra), Heart chakra (Anahata), Throat chakra (Vishuddhi), Third eye chakra (Aghnya), and Crown chakra (Sahasrara).

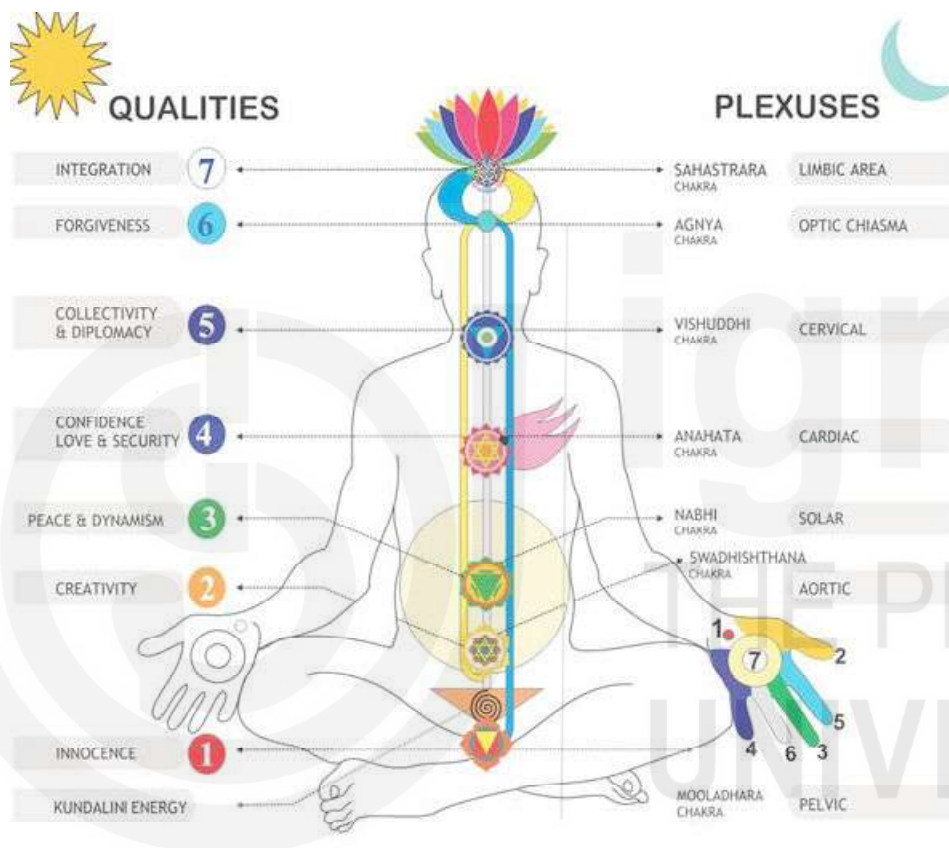


Fig.15.4: Seven Chakras in Human Body

Source: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Chakras_en_en_el_cuerpo_humano.jpeg

Focused meditation involves focusing or concentrating on something by using any of the sense organs, e.g., focusing on your breath, or listening to music, counting ‘mala beads’ or looking at a candle flame, flower etc. If the focus shifts, you can gently bring back it to the object of your meditation.

Movement meditation as the name suggests, involves movement such as walking, gardening, digging, or any other gentle forms of motion or activity.

Biofeedback:

Biofeedback provides feedback about the physiological changes that occur in stressful situations. According to Ghosh (2015, p. 179), biofeedback is “a technique of making unconscious or involuntary bodily processes (as heartbeat or brainwaves) perceptible to the senses (as by the use of an oscilloscope) in order to manipulate them by conscious mental control”. Awareness of such physiological changes as heart rate, breathing, blood

pressure etc. will enable the individual to consciously regulate them (by engaging in deep breathing, relaxation exercises, changing our thoughts etc.), and reduce stressful experience.

Biocybernaut Institute established by Dr. James V. Hardt makes use of neurofeedback (feedback about brain activity on real-time), which enables one to regulate one's cognitive and affective processes(<https://www.biocybernaut.com>), thereby helping one to manage stress.

15.4.2 Strategies Focusing on Cognitive Processes

Cognitive Restructuring:

The way we think about a particular situation/event influences the way we react to it. Our beliefs affect the interpretation of the event, e.g., failure in an exam may lead one student to put in more effort for the next exam, whereas the same event may lead one to feel dejected. The underlying belief here makes the difference! In the earlier case, the student may feel sad about the result, but looks forward to perform better next time; whereas in the latter case, the student thinks this is the end and thinks himself as inadequate and incompetent. Thus the antecedent event results in a particular consequence depending on the individual's beliefs or thought process. This is explained in the ABC triangle given below.

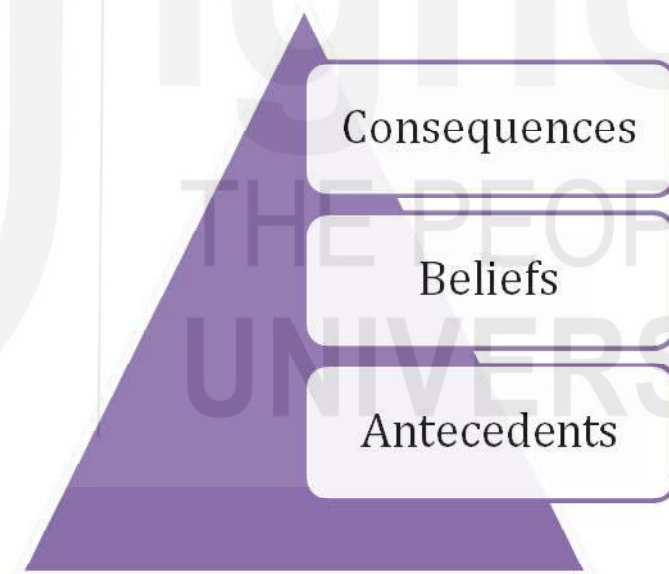


Fig. 15.5 : ABC Triangle

Thus cognitive restructuring requires one to restructure or modify one's thinking patterns. Based on this, Aaron Beck (1967) has developed the Cognitive behavior therapy (CBT), which focuses on modifying the irrational thinking patterns of the individual, resulting in adaptive behavior and stress reduction.

Activity1

Think of any situation/incident in your life and apply the ABC triangle. Write down the activating stimulus, the consequences, and the your belief system. Check whether your beliefs help or hinder the outcome.

Positive Attitude:

Positive attitude refers to having an attitude that good things will happen, that one would be able to deal with a challenge or an adverse situation. Thus it involves thinking in a positive way, and having positive emotions towards the stressful situation. As the proverbial question goes, “if the glass is half full or half empty”?, positive attitude involves looking at things/situations/events/people and focusing on what positive or good is present rather than looking at the negative or absence side. Thus it involves characteristics of optimism, hope, divergent thinking, and resilience. Positive attitude makes one confident, results in problem solving, reduces stress, and increases the inner strength of the individual.

You must be thinking why don't we have a positive attitude then? Mostly we are attuned to negative thinking because of the ‘negativity bias’ of our brain. Our brain easily picks up the negatives as it concerns survival from an evolutionary point of view. However, we can easily develop a positive attitude by developing awareness about it. Practicing positive attitude is a constructive process where you do not negate the negative thoughts. Rather you adopt a critical approach to the situation and think about the best possible alternatives in the situation while maintaining an attitude of positivity. Positive thinking makes your thinking flexible and opens up possibilities. The focus of thinking is contextual, not global, e.g., if you failed the job interview, you think in the context of one interview which did not go well, and you do not think that you will never do well in a job interview.

Positive attitude involves cognitive restructuring where we deliberately engage in thinking in positive terms. We need to practice positive affirmations and focus on the positive side of any challenge. Engage in positive self-talk and use visualization strategies. Create a mental picture of what you want to achieve and how you want to see the things. This will then help you to engage in constructive and divergent thinking regarding ways to achieve this goal. Remember that we first create a mental picture; the physical or actual creation follows this mental creation, for instance, when you are doing a project, or planning a trip etc. Since we are hard-wired for negative thinking, it will require real effort and practice to change our default mode of thinking and engage in positive thinking. This will help to manage our stress and be effective in a situation.

Expressing Gratitude:

Gratitude refers to ‘The quality of being thankful or grateful’. It involves showing appreciation for something. Expressing gratitude also fosters positive attitude in the individual as it reduces our attention on the negative things in our life. If you think about our traditions and culture, our festivals and rituals offer occasions for showing our gratitude towards nature, other people, and our ancestors. We need to recognize and consciously focus on cultivating an attitude of gratitude.

Gratitude not only makes you feel good by generating positive emotions, but also boosts our physical health and psychological well-being. It releases dopamine and serotonin which make us feel happy. Gratitude widens our thinking and perspective, and enhances resilience. One needs to practice gratitude, e.g., by writing gratitude letters, that is, letters that express your thankfulness to someone; gratitude visits where you visit people to express how grateful you are for their support; counting your blessings, i.e., focusing on the good things in your life; keeping a gratitude journal where you write down your positive experiences during the day etc.

Gratitude for yourself: Be aware about yourself. Find out your strengths, focus on what is good in you and express gratitude.

Gratitude for others : Be aware of contribution of others in your life; your parents have given you birth, raised you, provided for your optimum development, education and so on. Other significant people in your life have also contributed to your life in various ways. Your friends, colleagues, neighbours have extended help and support to you on many occasions. Think, identify, and express gratitude for those instances.

Gratitude for everything : Be aware of this precious life, the wonders of the nature, this vast universe, the elements of the universe; and express gratitude.

Coping Strategies :

Coping can be described as deliberate efforts directed towards decreasing the negative effects of stressful situations. An adaptive coping style helps reduce stress whereas, maladaptive coping has negative impacts on physical and psychological health of the individual. *Problem-focused coping* tries to address the problem itself, that is, removing the cause of the stress. For instance, you switch on the fan if you are feeling too hot. However, *emotion-focused coping* deals with the emotions arising out of the stressful experience, e.g., you felt hurt by your friend's behaviour and you tried to manage your hurt feeling by distracting yourself in some other activity. On the other hand, *acceptance-oriented coping* focuses on developing a sense of acceptance for the stressful situation where the things are not under control of the individual, e.g., accepting the loss and damage of house and other properties due to the cyclone.

Individual differences exist in the way individuals cope with stressful situations. This could be due to various factors such as personality of individuals, gender, tolerance level for stimulation, psychological hardiness, style of attribution, and learned helplessness (Beck et al., 1983; Chesney et al., 2006; Shenel et al., 2015, & Tang et al., 2015).

15.4.3 Strategies Focusing on Affective Processes

Emotional Intelligence:

Awareness of emotions in oneself and in others plays a crucial role in managing our stress. In addition to the thinking component of stress, we need to pay attention to the affective component of stress. Knowing about the emotions will help us in changing our thinking and behavior so that it results in adaptive behavior. Thus thinking and emotions need to be integrated which is called as Emotional intelligence (Goleman, 1995). The five components of EI, according to Goleman, consist of self-awareness, empathy, self-regulation, motivation, and social skills. Emotional intelligence basically involves developing awareness about emotions in oneself and in others, and managing emotions.

Positive Visualization:

Positive visualization involves the use of imagination to visualize about a future outcome which we desire, but may not be able to achieve at the present moment. It can be called as mental exercise that helps one to reach the desired goal.

It mostly has been used in the context of sports to enhance the performance and skill of the players. However, it can be used to enhance your performance in any aspect and field. We can utilize our brain's ability to think about future and create a mental pathway to enhance our potential. As we have mentioned under positive attitude in the earlier section, everything is created twice – first you create a mental picture of your desired object, and then it is carried out in the reality, e.g., you plan out the project or your itinerary, and then you carry out it. Thus thoughts precede our actual behaviour. Hence if we can make it stronger at the thought level to begin with, it may transfer to the action level. There are two types of visualization such as (a) Outcome visualization, where you focus on the end goal; and (b) Process visualization, which focuses on the entire process that leads us to our desired goal. When we engage in both outcome and process visualization, it leads to effective results.

Visualization is not just thinking and planning about a certain thing, but it requires vivid imagination involving all the senses. It includes the cognitive as well as affective processes related to the desired object/thing. When we repeatedly visualize something, paying attention to the minute details, and attaching all our senses with it, our brain gets the signal and gets motivated to engage in selective attention, goal-directed thinking and divergent thinking. Further, effective visualization requires us to be self-aware, knowing our strengths, beliefs, and values so that we know what we really want to achieve.



Fig. 15.6 : Steps in the Visualization Process

15.4.4 Strategies Focusing on Behaviour

Engaging in Leisure Activities:

Activity 2: What's your Leisure Ratio?

Examine your day's schedule and find out how much time you are devoting to your job-related work, family responsibilities, self-care, leisure-related, and community support activities. Is there a proper balance between your work and leisure? Observe and maintain a diary over a period of 1-2 weeks. At the end of it, answer the following:

- How much time did you devote to each type of the above mentioned activities?
- Which type of activities added to your stress and which ones helped reduce your stress?
- What are the reasons you engaged less or more in activities that reduced your stress?

Leisure activities are those that we engage in to relax, reduce our stress, and feel good about ourselves. These are pleasurable activities done voluntarily such as playing games, drawing, pursuing one's hobbies, socializing, being with nature, and so on. Research focuses on leisure as a coping resource which has ample benefits for our physical as well as mental health (Chun, Lee, Kim, & Heo, 2012; Pressman, Matthews, Cohen, Martire, Scheier, Baum, & Schulz, 2009; Qian, Yarnal, & Almeida, 2014). Usually leisure time is thought of as a wastage of time and/or given less time for it. However, leisure time has manifold benefits and can help us engage in work and other activities with new vigour.

As there are various stressors, we also have a variety of stress-busters or coping resources. Various leisure activities depending on the individual's preferences and interests can help reduce stress in the individual. It is more informative to study each leisure activity and how it helps to cope with various stressors rather than studying the many ways of coping with certain stressors (Costa, Somerfield, & McCrae, 1996).

Connecting with People:

Connecting with people is an important tool to reduce stress. When we connect and interact with others, it releases the stress and anxiety within. It results in catharsis which reduces the stress in the individual. Feeling connected with others helps one to get the necessary social support, increases their confidence, and generates a feeling of trust.

Connection with our family and relatives, friends, neighbours, and the community is a great asset in managing our stress. It provides us the support and has a positive impact on our physical and mental health. Even if the person is not present physically, still the perceived social connection has lots of benefits. It provides a feeling of confidence, comfort, and assurance that someone is there to provide you with help and support.

15.4.5 Stress Management Strategies at the Organizational Level

- **Communicating Effectively:**

Communication is an important interpersonal skill at the organizational level. It helps in conveying things clearly and avoids conflicts and misunderstanding. It can thus reduce stress and improve relationship. Main aspects of effective communication are : active listening, being open to feedback, paying attention to nonverbal behavior, removing barriers to effective communication, providing personal space, and being assertive.

- **Resolving Conflicts:**

Conflict resolution denotes ways in which conflict can be dealt with or resolved. One of the conflict resolution strategies include *avoiding*. This denotes withdrawal from conflict. Though, in this case the actual conflict may not resolve. But individuals

may use this when they feel that confrontation or engaging in conflict is not worthwhile and the discomfort that they may experience while in conflict is much more than when they avoid it. Another strategy can be *competing*. This is used by individuals who engage in conflict necessarily to win. This is a win-lose situation. Individuals using this may display assertiveness but not cooperation. Next can be *accommodating*. In this case, the individual is cooperative and not assertive. Though, this again may not be healthy as one of the parties may just give in and as such the conflict remains unresolved. This is a lose-win strategy. Similarly *collaborating* also can be one strategy where individuals are assertive as well as cooperative and the parties may come up with an agreed solution to resolve the conflict. This can also be termed as win-win strategy. Compromising also helps in conflict resolution, where each of the party will compromise in some way. Thus, there is partial cooperation and assertiveness. And though, the parties may not be completely satisfied, they are not dissatisfied as well. Individuals who are able to resolve conflicts are often excellent mediators, rational, and able to manage difficult personalities from a place of empathy.

Let's Apply

Next time when you have an argument or conflict, think of which conflict resolution strategy you are using?

Note the context, is it with friends, at workplace, or family. Does the conflict resolution strategy change depending on the situation?

- **Problem Solving:**

Problem solving involves finding solution to a problem at hand. It can be explained as a mental process that includes analysis of the problem in order to find a solution for it. Problems can be categorized into routine and non-routine problems and well-defined and ill-defined or poorly defined problems. The steps in problem solving include identification of problem, brainstorming for ideas and solutions, selecting a solution and implementing the plan of action and reflecting on the effectiveness of the solution. Strategies of problem solving include trial and error, heuristics, algorithm and insight-oriented methods.

15.5 POST TRAUMATIC GROWTH

Post Traumatic Growth (PTG) refers to the psychological growth that occurs following an adversity. The recent COVID 19 pandemic offers the best example of this. The stressful experiences and the challenges faced by people throughout the world have been overwhelming and shocking. However, we are still persisting in our livelihood, adapting to the situation, and trying to find meaning and happiness while undergoing a personal process of change.

The term post-traumatic growth refers to the adaptation and accommodation of the individual to any crisis or traumatic situation and coming out of this by coping to the situation in a positive manner. Post-Traumatic Growth (PTG) and Post-Traumatic Depression (PTD) can be defined, respectively, as positive and negative changes in the after effects of trauma. These changes can be in the following domains such as personal strength, relating to others, new possibilities, appreciation of life, spiritual and

existential change (Zieba, et.al., 2019). In other words post-traumatic growth indicates transformation after an intense traumatic and struggling situation that occurs mostly automatically and naturally, without psychotherapy or any other formal intervention.

The concept of post-traumatic growth has been in existence in the teachings of our religions, spiritual and philosophical deliberations, which talk about the elements of potentially transformative power of suffering. In the scientific research, the term 'Post Traumatic Growth' was first postulated by Richard Tedeschi and Lawrence Calhoun 1995. They define PTG as positive psychological changes in the aftermath of highly stressful and challenging unavoidable occurrences in life (Tedeschi & Calhoun, 2004). PTG brings about a positive shift in our mindset; instead of focusing on the negatives, the person searches out and emphasizes the positives in the adverse situation. The cognitive restructuring in the process helps us grow as better human beings (Fredrickson, 2004). Tedeschi and Calhoun (1996) talk about five indicators of PTG in their Post-Traumatic Growth Inventory (PTGI): Appreciation, Relationships, New possibilities and opportunities, Personal strength, and Spiritual enhancement.

The process of PTG may differ based on the types of trauma, personality characteristics of the person, nature of social support received and experiences afterwards. Further, positive attitude, gender, cultural factors, and socio-economic status may also affect the PTG (Arpawong, 2013; Cordova, 2001; Jaehee, et.al., 2015; Wang, 2014; Yi & Kim, 2014, & Zebrack, 2012).

Post-traumatic growth is an important positive psychology construct that needs to be differentiated from resilience that is much talked about in the field of positive psychology.

Differences between PTG and Resilience

Post-traumatic Growth (PTG)	Resilience
Occurs only after exposure to trauma available as part of one's personality	Can be present before trauma also,
An outcome of highly stressful situation/ trauma	May not occur after exposure to trauma. But if a person shows PTG, s/he develops resilience in the process
PTG always involves resilience	Resilience may or may not lead to PTG
Involves transformation in the personality – changes in one's thinking, beliefs, attitude and behaviour	May not involve any change unless the person is required to show resilient behaviour in any situation

Post-traumatic growth can be a significant phenomenon creating growth, balance, and continuing our life with renewed vigour and positivity. PTG includes aspects/ constructs related to positive psychology such as positive attitude, resilience, emotional strength, emotional competence, heightened gratitude towards life, spirituality, and finding meaning in life. However, one needs to take note of the *post-traumatic growth syndrome*, which refers to the perceived happiness reported by the individual after the trauma rather than real joy and actual well-being. So it can be called as a positive illusion (Lommen, Engelhard, van de Schoot, & van den Hout, 2014), which is for a short duration only rather than the PTG which is more stable in nature.

PTG can be assessed through the Post-traumatic Growth Inventory (PTGI) developed by Tedeschi and Calhoun (1996). It consists of 21 items in five areas such as appreciation, new possibilities in life, relationship with others, personal strength, and spiritual enhancement, which measure positive growth after adversity. A short form of this with 10 items was later developed by Cann et al. (2010); and modified version by Kaur et. al. (2017). PTG can also be measured with questionnaires, checklist and interview methods.

15.6 LET US SUM UP

Stress is like the salt and pepper of our life, presence of which makes our life lively, energetic, varied and dynamic. However, one needs to ensure that the stress does not go overboard and is within the stress tolerance level of the individual. Optimum level of stress will motivate the individual and enhance their performance. In the present unit, you learned about the meaning of stress and the various types of stressors in our life. It is important to identify the stress so that proper steps can be taken to manage it. Various techniques of stress management were described focusing on physical, cognitive, affective, and behavioural aspects. You also learned about post-traumatic growth, an important concept in positive psychology. Post-traumatic growth helps one to go beyond the stress and turn the adversity into opportunity or positive learning experience.

15.7 KEY WORDS

Stress	: refers to any force, which physically or psychologically strains the coping mechanism of an organism.
Diathesis-Stress Model	: explains the occurrence of stress as the outcome of a dynamic interaction between the hereditary factors and the environmental factors.
Biofeedback	: provides feedback about the physiological changes that occur in stressful situations so as to regulate them consciously.
Gratitude	: refers to the quality of being thankful or grateful by showing appreciation for something.
Positive visualization	: involves the use of imagination to visualize about a future outcome which we desire, but may not be able to achieve at the present moment.
Post-traumatic growth	: refers to the adaptation and accommodation of the individual to any crisis or traumatic situation and coming out of this by coping to the situation in a positive manner.

15.8 ANSWERS TO SELF ASSESSMENT QUESTIONS

Self Assessment Questions 1

1. 'stringere'
2. Acute stress is short-term stress which occurs suddenly, and the symptoms are acute, and do not last long.

3. Stressors are the factors that cause stress.
4. physical or physiological, psychological, environmental, and socio - cultural.
5. Alarm, Resistance, and Exhaustion

Self Assessment Questions 2

1. Mindfulness meditation refers to developing awareness about one's thoughts and emotions in the present moment, without any judgment.
2. Cognitive restructuring requires one to restructure or modify one's thinking patterns.
3. Some of the components involved in positive attitude are optimism, hope, divergent thinking, and resilience.
4. 'Negativity bias' refers to the fact that our brain easily picks up the negatives as it concerns survival from an evolutionary point of view.
5. Problem-focused coping tries to address the problem itself, that is, removing the cause of the stress whereas emotion-focused coping deals with the emotions arising out of the stressful experience.
6. Gratitude letters, counting your blessings, gratitude visit, and gratitude journal

Self Assessment Questions 3

1. Daniel Goleman
2. Outcome visualization, which focuses on the end goal; and Process visualization, which focuses on the entire process that leads us to our desired goal.
3. Avoiding, competing, accommodating, collaborating, and compromising
4. Appreciation, Relationships, New possibilities and opportunities, Personal strength, and Spiritual enhancement.

15.9 UNIT END QUESTIONS

1. Explain the concept of stress and describe the types of stressors.
2. Discuss the General Adaptation Syndrome model of stress.
3. Describe yoga and meditation as strategies for dealing with stress.
4. Explain the stress management strategies focusing on the affective processes.
5. Define post-traumatic growth (PTG). Differentiate between PTG and resilience.

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UNIT 16 YOGA AND MEDITATION*

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16.1 LEARNING OBJECTIVES

After studying this Unit, you would be able to:

- *Know the various meanings of Yoga;*
- *Learn about Patanjali's yoga;*
- *Explain the main ideas in Patanjali Yogasutra;*
- *Know the meaning of meditation;*
- *Describe the meditative states in Patanjali Yogasutra; and*
- *Recognize the role of yoga and meditation in positive mental health.*

16.2 INTRODUCTION

The Positive Psychology movement has been a recent development in the short history of psychology, a journey of fewer than 200 years. It emerged out of too much focus on

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the disorders and adversities in life to the neglect of the positives and strengths in life. Hence it focused overly on the good things in life. However, there has been criticism of this first wave of positive psychology, leading to second wave positive psychology (Lomas 2016). For example, it may seem too optimistic and wishful; or be equated with only happiness and seem to ignore the value of some negative emotions. The second wave has also been criticized that the field of positive psychology ignores a multi-cultural perspective. Studies have shown that positive psychology interventions work better in individualistic cultures, where the cultural norms support the pursuit of individual happiness (Suh, 2008 & Sin, 2009).

The values and assumptions based on which people find answers to 'why' and 'how' questions, i.e., meaning in life and the right way to live, is influenced by culture. These ideas are deep-rooted and are not choices but work below the surface of awareness. Since positive psychology has developed in western culture, it has an underlying lens of individualism (Christopher 2008). The third wave of positive psychology which emphasises cultural components, has emerged in response to this criticism (Lomas, et. al, 2020).

Indian culture has a rich philosophical-psychological heritage and a different perspective on human life and its ultimate goal. Therefore, it would be apt to explore indigenous ideas of positive mental health, which seems to be closely related to yoga and meditation. A number of studies has already been accumulated, indicating various benefits of yoga and meditation for both mind and body. Hence it is relevant to understand yoga and meditation in their totality, which you will learn in this Unit.

16.3 IMPORTANCE OF YOGA AND MEDITATION TRADITIONS

Studies indicate that mental disorders are one of the primary causes of years lost due to disability (YLD) or suicide (Reddy, 2010). Currently, more than 350 million people worldwide suffer from depression and as per the World Health Organization (WHO), by 2020 depression would be the second leading cause of disease (WHO, Global Health Estimates: Life expectancy and leading causes of death and disability, 2010). Even in India, depressive disorders have a prevalence rate of 5.1% (SURVEY, 2015-16).

However, routine mental health services are still limited, and people continue to suffer even when various empirically validated therapeutic interventions are present. Many such people do not seek treatment (due to stigma, lack of finances, etc.). For others, the conventional treatment is not optimal due to mismatches related to personality, goals, values, resources and lifestyles. Further, approaches for the acute phase treatment may not work to prevent relapse, and there is a need to limit or remove the residual symptoms. Additionally, beyond symptom recovery, psychological recovery needs to be given attention (Bockting, 2015; Hofmann, 2010; Huhn, 2014; Layous, 2011).

Although the definition of mental health includes positive mental health and well-being (WHO, 2001), its promotion requires a different approach. Here the role of positive psychology is significant, and it can provide various insights for positive mental health interventions. Various studies have shown that positive psychology based interventions buffer against stress, improve health and productivity, and enhance social connectedness (Vázquez, 2009). Here, yoga and meditation can be used as effective positive psychology interventions to enhance positive mental health and well-being.

16.4 WHAT IS YOGA

Living with a deep and permanent sense of well-being, along with finding freedom from suffering, can seem like an unachievable goal. However, this is the promise of yoga if we are willing to sincerely walk on the path of yoga in its complete form. In recent times yoga is often perceived as synonymous with a combination of *asanas* (bodily postures) and *pranayama* (breathing exercises), along with the inclusion of meditation (Goyal, et al., 2014). Nevertheless, that has not been the meaning of yoga as explained over the centuries in the Indian civilisation, where it is a set of practices to access higher consciousness and states of being. Yoga literally means to yoke, from the Sanskrit root ‘yuj’, which means to join and refers to experiencing oneness with the supreme consciousness. The Encyclopedia of Indian Philosophies Volume XII, Yoga: India’s Philosophy of Meditation (Larson and Bhattacharya, 2016), defines yoga in two ways. First, yoga means all those techniques people practice to find release from their existential suffering and achieve consciousness. Second, yoga refers to a specific school of Indian philosophy given by Patanjali in his text *Yogasutra*.

Thus, to fully appreciate its role in positive mental health, we need to explore yoga deeply, its aims and related assumptions. One of the core assumptions is related to how the world is made of not just matter but has underlying consciousness. Based on this idea, yogic practices aim towards experiencing pure consciousness or some similar higher state considered as liberation in a specific yogic system. A variety of terms have been used for such liberated states, such as *Kaivalya*, *Mukti* etc. This liberation is not a transitory state experienced only during deep meditation but a complete transformation of one’s ordinary living, working and relating to others (Agrawal & Cornelissen, 2021).

The three major Yogic paths or the *trimarga* of *bhakti*, *jnana*, and *karma* yoga, is a standard method to categorise these multiple styles and systems. These three pathways are discussed next (Agrawal & Cornelissen, 2021).

- ***Bhakti yoga***: The yogic path of ‘bhakti’ focuses on the cultivation of emotions around the Divine and supposedly results in bliss when one achieves oneness with one’s preferred form of God. In the process, one lets go of ego and desire-based lifestyle. This path may seem to be familiar and probably most accessible. Thus, one may note a large number of bhakti saints revered in different parts of the country.
- ***Jnana yoga***: The Jnanayoga path is that of cognitive realisation of the oneness of consciousness, which may later be experienced first-hand and experientially. Here again, one may drop one’s biases and note the reality as it is, thus removing many sources of pain and suffering.
- ***Karma yoga***: This path, most famously described in the *Bhagavad Gita*, is associated with the proper use of one’s volition or willpower. This path’s core is working without desires (*nishkama karma*) and not being attached to specific outcomes, thereby finding inner freedom. One does work with one’s utmost capacities, skillfully, and with an attitude of fulfilling one’s duties for the larger good of the world. Even when one engages in one’s regular affairs, this path too can lead to ultimate freedom, as discussed in other yogic paths.

It is relevant to note that most people do not practice these yogic paths in an isolated manner. Instead, they may mix components, with some or other aspect being dominant,

indicating their own personal synthesis. Even yogis and mystics combine these paths in their discourses. Yogi-philosopher Sri Aurobindo has given Integral Yoga, with a synthesis of these paths not just in application but also in their philosophy in his book Synthesis of Yoga.

Self Assessment Questions 1

1. Positive Psychology has an underlying individualism. True / False.
2. Which wave of positive psychology emphasizes culture?
3. Name the trimarga yoga.
4. Cultivation of emotions around the Divine is known as Karma yoga. True / False.
5. The cognitive realisation of the oneness of consciousness is Jnana yoga. True/ False.
6. Karma yoga has been extensively described in _____ text.

16.5 PATANJALI'S YOGA

As mentioned, one way to understand yoga is to follow Patanjali's Yogasutra. The text Yogasutra as codified by Patanjali is a millennia old text from India, and evidence from archaeology, various other texts, and oral tradition indicate that this yogic system is probably more than 5000 years old. It describes yoga philosophy, steps and outcomes, and has many ancient and modern commentaries written on it. There are 195 Sanskrit verses (known as Sutras) in Patanjali Yogasutra, categorised in 4 chapters (Pada) to explain profound ideas in the philosophy of mind and its applications. While yoga means union, sutra denotes thread and formula both; thus, Yogasutra may mean a thread of formulas codifying methods to achieve union with the highest Consciousness. These Sutras are short and crisp, meant to be learnt by-heart, chanted and contemplated upon easily, since these were written when printing was either unavailable, or expensive and time-consuming. This system is also termed Raja-yoga, roughly translated as the king of yoga (Taimini, 1961).

16.5.1 The Four Chapters of Patanjali Yogasutra

While first (Samadhi Pada) and last (Kaivalya Pada) chapters are focused upon advanced states of meditation (Samadhi) and ultimate liberation (Kaivalya). The second (Sadhana Pada) and third (Vibhuti Pada) chapters provide insights into the process of yoga practice. The chapters are elaborated below.

Samadhi Pada (Chapter 1, 51 sutras):

This chapter discusses the definition of yoga as stilling of the five types of activities of mind and identifying with deeper awareness. This process occurs through a disciplined effort and detachment. It further discusses various types and levels of samadhi, which is a deep absorptive state. Some essential aids on this path are faith, courage and memory (of past states). The intensity of motivation also counts, and for an intensely focused student, the realisation happens quickly. While Iswara/ Divine is consciousness without any afflictions, others have five types of afflictions (klesha) which lead to suffering. Chanting of 'OM' can connect us to the Supreme Consciousness (Iswara).

Additionally, nine obstacles on this spiritual journey and four signs of the same are also mentioned. Various techniques one can use to overcome these obstacles and thereby silence the mind has also been suggested. The chapter describes a few higher types of samadhi and how the stilling of the mind will reflect true knowledge in pure awareness.

Sadhana Pada (Chapter 2, 55 sutras):

This chapter starts with discussing Kriya yoga, a combination of self-study (svadhyaya), disciplined endurance (tapa) and surrender to Supreme Consciousness (Ishvara-pranidhana). This process of kriya yoga is a means to remove five afflictions (klesha) and gradually get freedom from laws of action-reaction (Karma). The Ashtanga yoga, an eight-limbed path of yoga, is subsequently introduced with limbs of Yama, Niyama, Asana, Pranayama, Pratyahara, Dharana, Dhyana and Samadhi. These limbs are further categorised as external and internal. Together they are meant to overcome present misery and avoid future suffering.

Vibhuti Pada (Chapter 3, 56 sutras):

This chapter discusses the last three steps of Ashtanga yoga, i.e., Dharana, dhyana and samadhi. When these are practised together, it is called Samyama. As per Patanjali, extraordinary knowledge and powers may be gained through samyama. The usefulness of vairagya and the need for purification of the mind is also emphasised in this chapter.

Kaivalya Pada (Chapter 4, 34 sutras):

This is the final chapter of the Patanjali yoga sutra, where the state of liberation (kaivalya) is discussed in detail, along with various extraordinary capacities. Additionally, the law of karma, rebirth, gunas, ordinary perception versus higher discrimination is discussed. The chapter ends with an introduction of the highest samadhi state known as Dharma-megha samadhi.

Self Assessment Questions 2

1. Patanjali's Yogasutra has 195 sutras divided in _____ number of chapters.
2. Chanting of OM as a technique is given in Samadhi pada. True / False.
3. Kriya yoga has been discussed in Kaivalya pada. True / False.
4. Dharma-megha samadhi, the highest kind of meditative state has been described in Kaivalya Pada. True / False.
5. Kriya yoga has three components of _____, _____ and Ishvara pranidhana.

16.6 MAIN IDEAS IN PATANJALI YOGASUTRA

- **Definition of yoga:** Patanjali Yogasutra begins by providing a definition of yoga as the process of silencing the mind, by stopping the waves of mental activities known as Chitta-vrittis. The five kinds of mental activities / chitta-vrittis which needs silencing are: (a) Reality-based thinking, (b) Misconceptions, (c) Imaginations of future, (d) Memory of past, and (e) Sleepy or dull states.

Let's Apply

Sit quietly for the next 5 minutes and try to notice whatever comes up in your mind. Then check how often these thoughts were related to any of the chitta-vrittis: (a) Reality-based thinking, (b) Misconceptions, (c) Imaginations of future, (d) Memory of past, or (e) Sleepy or dull states. You can try doing it daily to notice and bring awareness to where your mind wanders.

- **Process of yoga:** The mind of a yogi, which is a calm and silent mind may seem unrealistic, but it can be achieved through: (a) Constant practice (Abhyasa), (b) Detachment (Vairagya). Certain other helpful psychological aids are also mentioned: (i) Faith (Shraddha), (ii) Courage and strength (Virya), (iii) Memory and learning (Smriti), and (iv) Wisdom associated with higher states (Samadhi Prajna).

The role of motivation and effort has further been emphasised. It interacts with different types of seekers (dull, average or competent), resulting in varying speeds of accomplishments.

- **Barriers in the yoga practice:** On our yogic journey to liberation, nine hurdles and barriers have been enumerated by Patanjali. These are: (a) illness, (b) dullness, (c) doubt, (d) distraction, (e) laziness, (f) desire and craving, (g) imagination and fantasy, (h) lack of progress, (i) lost accomplishments.

These nine barriers can overtly express themselves in terms of four signs: (i) suffering, (ii) despair, (iii) bodily instability, and (iv) irregular breathing. Under the unhealthy influence of greed, anger and/ or delusions, one may engage in negative behaviour, either directly by doing something negative or indirectly by making others do something negative or approve a negative behaviour.

Let's Apply

When you decide to change something within you and grow personally (for example, you want to reduce your anger or minimize the use of social media), how often do you remember this decision and stick to it? How much faith do you have in yourself that you will do what you originally planned? How do you handle difficulties on the way, leave it quickly or face it with courage?

- **Overcoming the barriers in the yoga practice:** To purify and stabilise our mind and overcome negative tendencies which can act like obstacles against further progress on the yogic path, one can utilise various methods: (a) develop single-minded practice; (b) developing the qualities of unconditional friendliness and loving-kindness (Maitri), compassion (Karuna), sympathetic and appreciative joy (Mudita), and non-reactivity and equanimity (Upeksha); (c) practice focusing of attention (on breath/ on one's sensory experiences/ on internal light); (d) cultivating detachment; (e) learning from dream analysis; and (f) meditations.

Apart from these, one can also practice the development of opposite thoughts and feelings to bring balance, known as Pratipaksha Bhavana. For example, when one has criticality towards another person, one can try to develop an appreciation for the same person.

Let's Apply

Developing the qualities of 'Maitri', 'Karuna', 'Mudita', and 'Upeksha' are meant to overcome suffering, despair, bodily instability, and irregular breathing. Try meditating upon 'Sarvebhawantusukhina' (May Everyone be Happy) and visualise people around you, including yourself being happy. Then extend this happiness to every living being without any limits to it. You can also do this exercise with others in a joint and creative manner, where each participant shares a good wish, which they would like to send (e.g., May there be good health in the world, May there be more harmony in our relationships etc.).

- **Role of Ishwara / Divine in Yoga practice:** The term Ishwara/ Divine, denotes 'That Special Soul' (Vishesh Purusha), which is beyond afflictions (Kleshas) and laws of action-reaction (Karma) and is the timeless source of wisdom which can guide us as our eternal teacher. Pranava refers to Prana or breath and is the sound of AUM or Om. It is the sound of Supreme Consciousness (Iswara), where the sound of A represents creation, U denotes maintenance, and M represents dissolution aspects. It has healing properties, and its recitation (Japa) can also remove barriers from the yogic path.

Let's Apply

Since Pranava (AUM or Om sound) is considered to be the sound of Supreme Consciousness (Iswara), try chanting A, U, M for 5-10 minutes and write down your experience of this Japa meditation.

- **Klesha model of suffering :** One of the important models on psychological causes of suffering as presented by Patanjali is the following five core afflictions (Klesha):
 - a) Avidya - which is the primary ignorance of our true Self, and it is described to be an error where one believes the non-eternal to be everlasting, the impure as pure, misunderstands suffering as happiness, and non-self to be the Self.
 - b) Asmita - it is developed next when one misunderstands the mind to be our true Self.
 - c) Raga - it is the attachment to pleasure.
 - d) Dwesha - it is the aversion to pain.
 - e) Abhinivesha - the desire for living and fear of death is the fifth affliction.

At any point in time, these five afflictions can be either dormant, attenuated, manifest or powerful, and when active, they can keep us in the cycle of action-reaction (Karma).

- **Overcoming Klesha :** To overcome these afflictions and to avoid future suffering, one needs to realise the true Self as separate from the material world, made up of Triguna, i.e., the principles of Sattva/ light, Rajas/ movement and Tamas/ inertia.

One can overcome afflictions by the practice of Kriyayoga, i.e., practicing self-study (svadhyaya), disciplined endurance (tapa) and surrender to Supreme Consciousness (Ishvara-pranidhana). These steps are also part of Niyama, one of the eight limbs of Ashtanga yoga, which are described in next section.

Self Assessment Questions 3

1. The five kinds of chitta-vrittis are: (a) reality-based thinking, (b) misconceptions, (c) imaginations of future, (d) memory of past and, (e) super active states.
True or False.
2. We need constant practice (abhyasa) and _____ for yoga.
3. The nine barriers in yoga practice can express themselves as four signs such as: suffering, _____, bodily instability, and _____.
4. Development of opposite thoughts and feelings to bring mental balance is known as _____.
5. In OM sound, A represents _____, U denotes _____, and M represents _____.
6. The five Klesha are avidya, _____, _____, _____ and abhinivesha.
7. Abhinivesha means the desire for living and fear of death. **True or False.**
8. The klesha can remain as dormant, _____, _____ or become powerful.

16.7 THE ASHTANGA YOGA OF PATANJALI

The most famous contribution of Patanjali is his comprehensive system of Ashtanga yoga (the eight-limb). It not only purifies the mind, but also helps in experiencing the state of deepest absorption or samadhi. These eight limbs are further categorised into external (Bahiranga yoga) and internal (Antaranga yoga), depending on the focus of these practices. (a) Bahiranga yoga: Yama, Niyama, Asana, Pranayama. The fifth limb Pratyahara although grouped with bahiranga, is a bridge with the antaranga components of ashtanga yoga. (b) Antaranga yoga: Dharana, Dhyana and Samadhi.

- 1) **Yamas:** The five yamas emphasise ethics in one's relations to the outer world, not only in actions but also in speech and thoughts. These yamas are:
 - i. Non-harming (Ahimsa)
 - ii. Truthfulness (Satya)
 - iii. Non-stealing (Asteya)
 - iv. Following the highest truth (Brahmacharya), and
 - v. Non-possessiveness (Aparigraha)
- 2) **Niyamas:** The five Niyamas are focused on our relationship to ourselves. These are:
 - i. Purity of body and mind (Saucha)
 - ii. Contentment (Santosha)
 - iii. Highest discipline (Tapa)
 - iv. Study and analysis of oneself (Svadyaya), and
 - v. Surrender to the Divine (Ishwara Pranidhana)

The first two limbs of Yama-Niyama are the foundations of the practice, and when they are consistently practised beyond consideration for individual and contextual variations, such as that of place, time, context or family lineage etc., these can become the great vows (Mahavrata). Special powers and capacities may develop when any of these Yamas and Niyamas are established within a person as a great vow through unwavering practice. The last three Niyama of Tapa, Svadhyaya and Ishwara-pranidhana is also known as Kriya-yoga and can remove five afflictions. As per Patanjali, even merely the practice of last Niyama (Ishwara-pranidhana) can lead to the highest Samadhis.

- 3) **Asana:** Asana is described as that which leads to comfortable stability (sthira sukham asanam – PYS 2.46). When asana is practised meditatively without efforts, one can experience equanimity and non-duality.
- 4) **Pranayama:** Pranayama is described as the stopping of inhalation and exhalation, which can improve attention and prepare the mind for advanced yoga. A few types of Pranayama are discussed, accompanying with how the process can be influenced by factors like location, season etc. Although the components of Asana-Pranayama are most emphasised in the modern world, one may notice Patanjali has not emphasised these so much.
- 5) **Pratyahara:** Pratyahara is disengaging and withdrawing one's mind from the external, sensory objects of attention.
- 6) **Dharana:** Dharana is the act of holding attention to a single object or point.
- 7) **Dhyana:** When this one-pointed attention becomes steady and unbroken, it is called Dhyana.
- 8) **Samadhi:** When the state of deep absorption is reached, where only the object of attention is left and not the mind, it is known as samadhi.

When the limbs of Dharana, Dhyana and Samadhi are practised together, it is known as Samyama. The practice of Samyama on various objects or ideas can bring in a variety of knowledge and powers, as described in the Yogasutras.

Self Assessment Questions 4

1. The eight limbs of Ashtanga yoga are divided into two parts, bahiranga and _____.
2. Antaranga yoga are Dharana, _____ and Samadhi.
3. The five yamas are: ahimsa, satya, _____, brahmacharya, and _____.
4. The five niyamas are Saucha, _____, _____, svadhyaya and Ishwara pranidhana.
5. Asana is an uncomfortable stable pose. **True or False.**
6. Pranayama is described as the ongoing of inhalation and exhalation. **True or False.**
7. Disengaging one's mind from the external, sensory objects of attention is _____.
8. When dharana, dhyana and samadhi are practised together, it is known as _____.

16.8 WHAT IS MEDITATION

Meditation is an English term with Latin roots (*meditari*; to think, reflect or contemplate) and indicate ‘deep exploration of mind’ (Goleman & Davidson, 2017). It is considered a ‘technique to control the mind’ (Rao & Paranjpe, 2016) by controlling our attention and awareness (Walsh & Shapiro, 2006). The process of meditation goes from attending to an object (Dharana), sustaining this attention in an unbroken manner (Dhyana) to complete absorption into it (Samadhi). Another term Bhavana is also used in Patanjali Yogasutra for cultivating maitri, mudita, karuna and upeksha. Meditation aims towards a higher state of consciousness. As by-products of this process, healing and developing special powers are noted. The various definitions of meditation may not fully capture its essence due to the limitations of language. The US Department of Health and Human Services reached a similar conclusion regarding challenges in developing a taxonomy of meditation. Using expert consensus, (Cardoso, deSouza, Camano, & Leite, 2004) tried to capture the meaning of meditation through five core criteria based upon its process and outcomes, to overcome some of these limitations. These were - it is done by oneself, using a technique, by relaxing the body, and the analytic mind, while focusing on oneself. Other relevant aspects of meditation were found to be - a spiritual-philosophical context, mental silence and possibility of an altered consciousness.

Many of the currently popular meditation techniques originated in the Indian civilization thousands of years back. It was introduced to the West in 1920 when Indian monk Paramahansa Yogananda travelled to USA. Around the 1970s, meditation got scientific attention when another Indian monk from the Himalayan tradition Swami Rama demonstrated voluntary control over multiple bodily organs in USA. Within a lab setting, he changed brain waves, heart functioning and skin temperature, which were known to be entirely automatic processes. Subsequently, American Psychological Association (1977) issued a statement noting that “meditation may facilitate the psychotherapeutic process” and also encouraging further research “to evaluate its possible usefulness” (as cited by Kutz, Borysenko and Benson, 1985).

16.9 BROAD CATEGORIES OF MEDITATION

For ease of research and understanding, a broad categorization that is often used lately has been mindfulness and concentration meditation, based on the differences in the attention process (Thomas & Cohen, 2014; Lippelt, Hommel, & Colzato, 2014).

- a) **Focused Attention/ Concentrative Meditation:** In this category of meditation, we focus all attention on a single point / object / idea/ image / sound. This meditation process is described in Dharana-Dhyana stages of Patanjali’s ashtanga yoga, where we develop an unbroken flow of attention towards a single point. The process also includes removing attention from other distractions, as done in pratyahara stage. It also includes noticing when one has got distracted internally, by one’s own thoughts and bringing attention back to the focus of attention. This process of meditation is also known as Samatha meditation in Buddhism. This type of meditation further travelled in Asia and developed regional variations and names in interaction with local culture and spirituality.

- b) **Mindfulness / Open Awareness / Open Monitoring Meditation:** This ancient meditation from India was rediscovered and popularised through his teachings by Buddha. It is called Vipashyana, a unique way of seeing, and gaining insight and Sakshi bhava, which means the cultivation of being a witness. In this category of meditation, we try to keep an open and curious attitude towards whatever is happening in the body or mind. We remain aware of our thoughts, feelings and sensations in the present moment. When we notice these without any judgment or need for control, we can then let them go. In recent times the most popular way of learning the traditional form of Vipashyana around the world is through the lineage of Shri S.N. Goenka. Apart from upto 11 hours of daily meditation these retreats have video lectures on Buddhist philosophy related to suffering and release from the same. The aim is to develop an experiential insight into the non-permanent nature of our self and identity.
- c) **Transcendental Meditation:** It is sometimes considered the third category of meditation. Maharshi Mahesh Yogi is acknowledged to be the founder of this meditation technique, who developed it in 1958. Here we may start with silently reciting a mantra, which is usually a short, monosyllabic sound. Often though not always, these sounds are sacred beej-mantra. However, in the process of meditating, we are supposed to transcend it or go beyond it. Here the mantra recitation process is connected with the state of mind, with increase in mantra recitation, when we encounter more distracting thoughts.
- d) **Interpersonally Oriented Meditations:** These were a recently added category, and find their roots in Maitri or Metta meditation which is present in multiple traditions from ancient India (Agrawal & Sahota, 2021). Here we try to cultivate loving-kindness, friendliness, goodwill and compassion for others. These qualities are supposed to be cultivated in a limitless manner, without personal preferences or aversion and thus are called the four Immeasurable. The process includes focusing on an idea, and seems to be a combination of concentration and mindfulness meditation practices.

16.9.1 Other Forms of Meditations

- a) **Japa/ Mantra Meditation:** here we repeat a sacred word or phrase (mantra), either silently or with sound, for a pre-decided number of rounds or for a specific duration of time. This has components of Dhyana or concentrative meditation. The focus of attention is on the meaning of the mantra and its sound, and ignoring both external and internal distractions. As mentioned earlier, Transcendental meditation also uses a mantra, but instead of focusing on the mantra itself, the aim is to transcend it (Lynch, et al., 2018).
- b) **Yoga Nidra, Shavasana:** In these types of meditations, we sequentially relax our bodies. Additionally, there may be specific visualization included. In Yoga Nidra, one also attempts to develop a witnessing quality.
- c) **Other Common Meditation Practices:** A few other commonly practiced meditations are related to body or breath, such as scanning the body for various sensations or focusing attention on one's breathing. Another type of meditation is related to Kundalini, where one tries to awaken and uplift the psycho-spiritual energy in one's body. Yogasana when done mindfully with rhythmic breaths is a type of movement meditation, and other such types are the Chinese

practices of Tai Chi and Qi Gong. It may be noted that this is not an exhaustive list, and many other meditation techniques may also be practised by people worldwide. However, most meditations may have some or other processes given above, or even a combination of them (Hussain & Bhushan, 2010).

Different meditation techniques may have different benefits, suit different people or suit the same person in a different growth stage. Often, a combination of techniques is also present in diverse spiritual traditions. Many people practice a combination of these techniques. These techniques do not exist in isolation, especially in the context of their origin. They are related to various assumptions about the nature of reality, the place of an individual in the larger scheme of things, and an ethical way of living.

Self Assessment Questions 5

1. Various techniques to control the mind are known as meditation. **True or False.**
2. This famous Swami _____ had demonstrated voluntary control over multiple bodily organs in a lab in USA.
3. Concentrative Meditation is also known Samatha meditation. **True or False.**
4. Mindfulness meditation is also understood as process of cultivating Sakshi bhava. **True or False.**
5. In modern times, Maharshi _____ started the **Transcendental meditation movement.**
6. Focusing on a single point is known as _____.
7. Meditation where we remain aware of our thoughts, feelings and sensations in the present moment is known as _____.
8. **The interpersonally oriented meditations attempt to cultivate maitri, mudita, _____ and upeksha.**
9. Yogasana, Tai Chi and Qi Gong are also considered body-based meditation. True or False.

16.10 MEDITATIVE STATES IN PATANJALI YOGASUTRA

Meditation, as described in Patanjali Yogasutras is mainly of the concentrative type, with narrowing and stabilizing of attention during the Dharana-Dhyana stages. After developing an unbroken flow of attention, one may be ready for the next stage of Samadhi, where the individual experiences an absorption in the object of attention. He has further described various kinds and levels of Samadhi:

- a) **Samprajnata samadhi:** These are lower levels of samadhi, obtained through thoughts, such as absorption on gross thought, subtle thoughts, bliss, or the essential individuality or I-ness.
- b) **Asamprajnata Samadhi:** This is higher level of samadhi, which occurs when one can go beyond thoughts.

He has further differentiated between five types of Samadhi based on the quality of mind during those stages:

- **Savitarka Samadhi:** in this stage, there is still a mixing of words, meaning and knowledge of an object.
- **Nirvitarka Samadhi:** here, only the object is illuminated, without any gross thoughts.
- **Savichara Samadhi:** in this samadhi, there is the presence of subtle thoughts.
- **Nirvichara Samadhi:** in this state, there is an absence of even subtle thoughts.
- **Nirbija Samadhi:** this samadhi occurs when even the seeds of thoughts are restrained.

As one achieves the higher stages, one develops discriminative wisdom and the highest samadhi.

- c) **Dharma-Megha Samadhi:** with further spiritual progress, Dharma-Megha Samadhi dawns, leading to oneness with the highest universal consciousness or Kaivalya, the soul's liberation.

16.11 BENEFITS OF MEDITATION

There has been an explosion of research on meditation since 1970, using both psychological and physiological measures. These studies have been done in advanced meditations with many years of practice and novice, beginner meditators. Similarly, it has been explored both in healthy populations and those suffering from mental or physical illnesses.

In a review of the research (Hussain & Bhushan, 2010), meditation leads to multiple effects on the autonomic nervous system, slowing heart rate, decreased oxygen use, and lowered blood pressure. Other common findings related to meditation are increased alpha waves in the brain correlated with deep relaxation and theta waves associated with peace and blissful feeling, along with reduced activity in the brain's emotional centres. Improved attention, perceptual abilities, learning, memory, emotional maturity, and resilience also seem to be present.

Other reviews (Goyal, et al., 2014) focusing on meditation studies in the clinical population have reported a decrease in stress and anxiety, rumination, trauma symptoms, depression, de-addiction, and improvement in sleep, quality of life, well-being, self-compassion, and psychological flexibility. Studies on meditation's effect on physical health have commonly found improvement in hypertension, cardiovascular disorders, respiratory disorders, musculoskeletal diseases, better management of pain, headache, skin issues and improved immune response (Hussain & Bhushan, 2010).

Need for caution: It is also essential to take a cautious approach (Fjorback & Walach, 2012). Some studies have indicated specific adverse effects, often related to distress due to the resurfacing of old traumatic memories or unpleasant thoughts. Further, with those diagnosed with psychotic disorders, one needs a clinician's judgement before introducing meditation. A thoughtful choice needs to be made. There may also be individual responses to meditation, and personal guidance from a trained mentor is desirable.

16.12 MODERN PSYCHOLOGICAL INTERVENTIONS INTEGRATING MEDITATION

Due to various benefits, meditation has increasingly been integrated with counselling and psychotherapy over the last few decades. It began with Benson's relaxation response and became popular with Jon Kabat-Zinn's Mindfulness-Based Stress Reduction Program. Subsequently, an entire trend of integrating meditation with modern psychology started, with examples like Mindfulness-Based Cognitive Therapy, Mindfulness-Based Relapse Prevention etc. (Fjorback & Walach, 2012). The classic Mindfulness-Based Stress Reduction Program is conducted in a group format across eight weeks. One needs to engage in daily individual meditation and other homework for at least 30 minutes and a weekly group meeting of 2.5 hours.

In India too there has been a lot of research and application of yoga and meditation in the health setting (Kumar, Bhide, Arasappa, Varambally, & Gangadhar, 2021). Given the variety of meditation-contemplation and philosophical systems available in the country with both experts in these systems as well as a population open to these systems, one may find rich literature in this area. Sattva Enhancement Therapy and Sattva Cultivation Program is one such module developed at National Institute of Mental Health and NeuroSciences, Bengaluru which integrated yoga psychology and meditation for improving mental health (Agrawal, 2021).

It is also important to remember that at the core of these traditions lies the belief that one can live a life with inner freedom, and it needs to be experienced first-hand and personally. Therefore, a global movement is happening now where psychologists themselves are engaging in yoga and meditation to experience its benefits before teaching it to others.

Self Assessment Questions 6

1. Samprajnata samadhi are obtained by going beyond thoughts. **True or False.**
2. An absence of even subtle thoughts are known as _____ Samadhi.
3. Meditation leads to higher emotional maturity. **True or False.**
4. Meditation is not helpful in cardiovascular disorders and respiratory disorders. **True or False.**
5. One needs to use caution in applying meditation in _____ disorders.
6. Jon Kabat-Zinn had developed Mindfulness-Based _____ program.

16.13 LET US SUM UP

In current times, there is a need to focus on positive mental health, and explore various indigenous models for comprehensive mental health care. In this context there is a need to study yoga and meditation traditions, which has been an important Indian contribution to the world. Yoga has been defined as a combination of spiritual techniques for finding existential freedom, or as the specific school of philosophy described in

Patanjali Yogasutra. As per the former definition, one can study the three major Yogic paths of Bhakti yoga, Jnana yoga and Karma yoga. While one may find a description of causes of suffering, ways to release from suffering, and description of Kriya-yoga in the Ashtanga yoga of Patanjali.

Meditation is a group of techniques for training the mind. Although it goes back in history, the modern research has expanded over the last few decades. The broad categories of meditation are focused attention or concentrative meditation, mindfulness or open awareness meditation, transcendental meditation and interpersonally oriented meditations. Other common forms of meditations are Japa, Mantra meditation, Yoga Nidra, Shavasana etc. Patanjali has also described various meditative states in his Yogasutra. Various benefits of meditation have been found along with a few cautionary notes in recent research. Currently meditation is increasingly integrated with counseling and psychotherapy, and this is the way forward for developing positive mental health amongst people in modern times.

16.14 KEY WORDS

Yoga	: is a set of practices to access higher consciousness and states of being.
Karma Yoga	: involves working without desires (nishkama karma) and not being attached to specific outcomes, thereby finding inner freedom.
Samadhi Pada	: defines yoga as stilling of the five types of activities of mind and identifying with deeper awareness.
Kaivalya Pada	: discusses the state of liberation (kaivalya) in detail, along with various extraordinary capacities.
Antaranga yoga	: consists of Dharana, Dhyana and Samadhi.
Pratyahara	: is disengaging and withdrawing one's mind from the external, sensory objects of attention.
Meditation	: aims towards a higher state of consciousness by controlling our mind.

16.15 ANSWERS TO SELF-ASSESSMENT QUESTIONS

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 1

1. True
2. Third
3. Bhakti, Jnana, Karma
4. False
5. True
6. Bhagavad Gita

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 2

1. Four
2. True
3. False
4. True
5. Svadhyaya, Tapa

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 3

1. False
2. detachment (vairagya)
3. despair, irregular breathing
4. Pratipaksha Bhavana
5. creation, maintenance, dissolution
6. Asmita, Raga, Dwesha
7. True
8. attenuated, manifest

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 4

1. antaranga
2. Dhyana
3. Asteya, Aparigraha
4. Santosha, Tapa
5. False
6. False
7. Pratyahara
8. Samyama

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 5

1. True
2. Swami Rama
3. True
4. True
5. Maharshi Mahesh Yogi
6. Focused Attention or Concentrative meditation
7. Mindfulness or Open awareness (open monitoring)
8. Karuna
9. True

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Answers to Self Assessment Questions 6

1. False
2. Nirvichara Samadhi
3. True
4. False
5. Psychotic
6. Stress Reduction

16.16 UNIT END QUESTIONS

1. What is the role of yoga and meditation for positive mental health?
2. Write an essay on Patanjali's Ashtanga Yoga.
3. Write a short note on Klesha model of suffering as given in Patanjali yogasutra.
4. Describe types of meditation, and explain what are the benefits of regular meditation.

REFLECTIVE EXERCISES

1. What is your personal framework about life? (Give answers to such questions as, who am I / why am I born / what is my place in the universe / what is the best way to live, etc.). Write it down and reflect on these – how they influence your behavior and interactions with others. Remember these frameworks can keep changing and evolving as you grow, mature and gain experience in life.
2. In whatever you do, what are the topmost sources of motivation for you? Are there things which you do without focusing on the outcomes, without having too strong expectations? What are those? Why do you do so? Reflect and write down.
3. Would you consider something beyond yourself, which might be considered as transcendental, such as a Higher power, Divine/ Universe/Nature/Deepest Self, as personally relevant? If yes, how would you describe this relationship?

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UNIT 17 CURRENT TRENDS AND FUTURE DIRECTIONS IN POSITIVE PSYCHOLOGY*

Structure

- 17.1 Learning Objectives
- 17.2 Introduction
- 17.3 Positive Psychology: Goals and Scope
- 17.4 Trends in Research in Positive Psychology
- 17.5 Future Directions in Positive Psychology
- 17.8 Let Us Sum Up
- 17.9 Key Words
- 17.10 Answers to Self Assessment Questions
- 17.11 Unit End Questions
- 17.12 References and Suggested Readings

17.1 LEARNING OBJECTIVES

After studying this Unit, you would be able to:

- *Gain an understanding of the goals and scope of positive psychology;*
- *Describe the research trends in the field of positive psychology; and*
- *Discuss the future directions in positive psychology.*

17.2 INTRODUCTION

You have reached now the last Unit of this course on Applied Positive Psychology. You started in Unit 1 with exploring and understanding the meaning of positive psychology, the key constructs involved, their meaning, and importance in contributing to our psychological well-being. You learned about various character strengths, their manifestations, development and enhancement. You further learned about various areas in which the principles and techniques derived from positive psychology can be applied. After studying all these things, now you are at a stage where you can appreciate the field of positive psychology, its myriad benefits and contribution to human well-being and flourishing. Hence, this is the right time where you can further focus on and learn about the trends of research in the field of positive psychology and also discuss about the potential direction in which the field of positive psychology can expand itself. In the present unit we will recapitulate briefly the origin and the goals of the field of positive psychology, the progress it has made, and discuss the trends of ongoing research and future directions in positive psychology.

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17.3 POSITIVE PSYCHOLOGY: GOALS AND SCOPE

Positive psychology is a scientific field of study, which emerged by highlighting an excessive focus in psychology on the negative side of human functioning to the exclusion of the positive side of human development and functioning. It brought to the limelight a much neglected aspect of human functioning in psychology research, that is, studying the good things, the strengths, the talents, the resilience of human beings. It is reflected in the speech of R. F. Kennedy, when he addressed the students at the University of Kansas in 1968 that “the gross national product measures everything, except that which makes life worthwhile.” Positive psychology focuses on that aspect of human beings – the character strength and virtues, that make our life meaningful and fulfilling.

Thus it came as an *antithesis* to the illness-oriented focus of the field of psychology around two decades back. It was in 1998 that the impetus to positive psychology started when Martin Seligman highlighted on it in his presidential address in American Psychological Association (APA) as its president. He had said, “Psychology is not just the study of weakness and damage, it is also the study of strength and virtue.”

However, psychology research and applications during the 20th century have focused more on understanding and treating mental illness. The Diagnostic and Statistical Manual (DSM), a widely used classification system of mental disorders had started in 1952. It has gone through various revisions and the 5th edition of DSM is prevalent now that had come in 2013. It has greatly added to our understanding of the diagnostic features of mental disorders and their assessment dimensions. Research has also come up with various evidence-based treatments and interventions for these disorders. This is definitely commendable research and progress in psychology to explain and develop substantial understanding of various disorders.

However, we need to pause here and ask, is this the only goal and scope of psychology? As you may recall, prior to the Second World War, **psychology had three fundamental missions**: (a) to cure mental illness, (b) to make the lives of all people better, more fulfilling, and (c) to identify and nurture high talent or genius (Seligman, 1998). However, the field of psychology till the end of the 20th century was dominated by a passive focus on human beings, analyzing the weakness, and repairing or fixing the damage. In short, the emphasis was on “What is wrong in people?” Advent of Positive psychology changed this perspective and asked instead, “What is right in people?”. As Seligman (1998) had said, “treatment is not just fixing what is broken, it is nurturing what is best within ourselves.” In place of pathologizing the individual, positive psychology research focused on finding out what good the person already has, identifying their competence, building their strengths, and nurturing talents. Thus it marked a movement from the deficit model of human functioning to a strength model of human functioning. Research focus shifted from a disease model to a health model of functioning. Various studies have started to focus on aspects related to positive psychology, thereby increasing the reach, impact and breadth of positive psychology (Rusk & Waters, 2013).

Positive psychology emphasized looking beyond mental illness and focusing on mental wellness. Here one needs to note that health and well-being does not refer to the mere

absence of diseases and disorders. As indicated by Keyes, mental health and well-being can be depicted on a continuum ranging from presence of mental illness on the one end of the continuum through absence of mental illness to presence of well-being on the other end of the continuum. The goal of psychology research and prevention has for too long focused on the illness end of the continuum. Positive psychology highlighted the need to centre around achieving a flourishing state of well-being in human beings.

Scope of Positive Psychology

Positive psychology is the scientific study of optimal functioning in human beings – what is good about life, what strengths do we have, how do we form positive relationships and interactions with others around us, how can we contribute positively, how do we build good institutions and positive, resilient, and thriving individuals and societies.

Thus positive psychology has a three-point focus:

- **Individual level:** building positive traits and character strengths
- **Communities/Society level:** building positive institutions/workplaces and caring communities
- **Nation level:** creating positive nations with a positive culture climate, reflected in the governance, functioning and policies of the overall country

Thesis-antithesis-synthesis model

Positive psychology has received both the applauds as well as the criticisms for generating focus on the positive side of life. It has been appreciated much and has garnered more interest in its identification and enhancement of positive psychology constructs. Human beings generally want to be happy in life, gain success, thrive and contribute, and derive meaning and satisfaction in their life. Hence the focus of positive psychology on positive strengths and values took the field of research by storm and pervaded the entire field. At the same time, positive psychology was criticized as developing a Pollyana view, that is, portraying everything as rosy, seeing things through a rose-tinted glass so that you do not see the negative sides.

Human life is not one-sided having only the positives. In order to function effectively, one needs to take into account the reality of the other side of life also. Then only we can ensure a balanced and comprehensive perspective of life that will enable us to thrive and flourish in a true sense. As indicated in Keyes' mental health continuum depicted earlier, positive psychology needs to study the entire gamut of the continuum, focusing both on illness as well as well-being. Studying the entire spectrum will help conceptualize human beings in their entirety and develop a whole approach to study psychological well-being. This can be clarified in Keyes dual continuum model which gives rise to four quadrants. It highlights that it is not mental illness alone, nor mental well-being alone; rather considering both together will enhance our conceptualization of well-being, and lead to appropriate strategies for promotion of mental health and well-being.

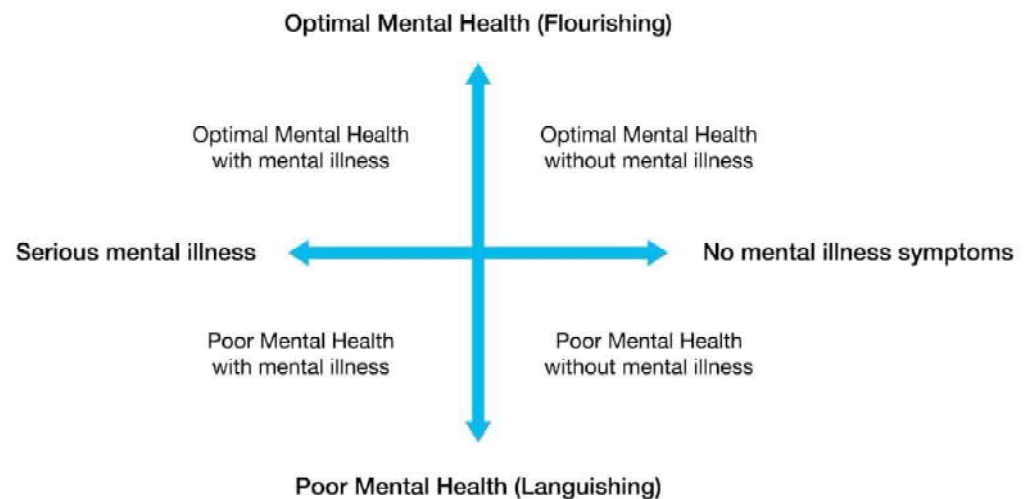


Fig. 17.1 Corey Keyes Dual Continuum Model

Source: <https://opentextbc.ca/mhwframework/back-matter/appendix-b/>

According to Hegel's *Thesis-antithesis-synthesis model*, we can describe psychology's earlier exclusive focus on mental illness as the *thesis*. Positive psychology reacted to this and advanced the *antithesis* of focusing on positive emotions, traits and strengths. However, in the process, the negative side of life, the suffering of human beings and the negative emotions got neglected although the field of positive psychology has never expressed it explicitly. The field of positive psychology was criticized for negating or excluding the equally important negative side of life, the human suffering and pain as these also contribute to the meaning of life and helps the individual to realize well-being in the specific socio-cultural context. The second wave of positive psychology focuses specifically on the dark side of human lives and considers the role of negative emotions and distress as contributing to resilience, meaning in life, and the psychological well-being of individuals. Thus the field of positive psychology is now characterized by a *synthesis* of the earlier negative and the current positive focus of psychology research. It marks the final synthesis stage in the thesis-antithesis-synthesis model of Hegel.

Self Assessment Questions 1

1. Who said, "Psychology is not just the study of weakness and damage, it is also the study of strength and virtue"?
2. _____ came as an *antithesis* to the illness-oriented focus of the field of psychology around two decades back
3. Mention the fundamental missions of psychology prior to World War II.
4. Positive psychology is characterized by a _____ model of human functioning.

17.4 TRENDS IN RESEARCH IN POSITIVE PSYCHOLOGY

• Positive Psychology 2: Focusing on the Negative side also

Positive psychology as a field of research has covered a little more than two decades now, although the concepts related to positive psychology has been there and studied

since long (e.g., May, 1961; Maslow, 1943, 1962, 1970b). In fact, Maslow is credited with introducing the term positive psychology. But research focusing on the goodness in human beings was sporadic and did not gain prominence at that time.

The pathology view of human functioning had gained ground especially after World War II and dominated the field of research in psychology. Towards the end of 20th century, positive psychology perspective started to emerge and influence research in psychology by providing an overarching conceptual space. In contrast to the weakness focus of the pathological model, it emphasized on the human strengths and assets in self-realization and self-actualization of individuals.

However, it led to a debate between the superiority and inferiority of one approach over the other. By using the term ‘positive’ and focusing on ‘positive attributes and experiences’, it implied the desirability of the positive side and the undesirability of the negative side of individual experiences and functioning. For instance, to say that optimism is always good and pessimism is always bad, does not give a correct picture of human functioning and reality. Over-positivity is not good, similarly considering negative emotions as undesirable and unhealthy does not give a true picture of human experience and well-being. Hence, one needs to be clear here that this debate does not hold any ground and is not relevant.

The earlier pathological approach or deficit model of human functioning was relevant in that particular time. It has contributed a lot and advanced extensively our knowledge and understanding of the field of mental disorders. However, it covered only a part of human beings total existence. Similarly, positive psychology perspective focusing only on the positive emotions and character strengths, covers the other part of human beings total existence. Hence, there is no point in arguing that the earlier deficit approach was inadequate or the present strengths approach is effective to understand human beings and promote their well-being. Rather, there should be an inclusive approach where we take into account both the positive as well as the negative side of human existence.

Responding to the emerging views and studies in this field, the second wave of positive psychology (PP 2) has highlighted this point that we cannot ignore the negative, the deficit and the suffering aspect of human existence as those also have an implication for our comprehensive well-being. As stated by Wong (2019), PP2 is characterized by the following (a) accepting the reality that life is full of evil and suffering, and confronting it with courage, (b) overcoming these suffering and the dark side of life will lead to sustainable well-being, (c) recognizing that everything in life comes in polarities and there is a need to achieve an adaptive balance through dialectics, and (d) deriving the insights from indigenous psychology to enrich the field of positive psychology.

Hence the second wave of positive psychology considers well-being as a dynamic interaction between the positive and negative aspects in the life of an individual. It advocates four underlying principles (Lomas, 2016):

- a) Appraisal: It states that appraisal of an emotion as positive or negative will depend on the contextual factors, e.g., even though anger is considered a negative emotion, it can have useful function in cases where there is injustice.
- b) Co-valence: It refers to the presence of both positive and negative aspect in the same experience or phenomenon. For instance, many of our highly valued positive emotions (love, optimism etc.) have a dark side or a negative element also.

- c) Complementarity: Both the positive and negative elements inherent in the emotion complement each other to make it a whole experience. It is like there are two sides of the same coin, which make it a whole coin.
- d) Evolution: It focuses on the contextual factors in the study of the positive or the negative aspects of human experience. It states that finally, it is the synthesis of the various aspects related to the phenomenon that is important for its holistic understanding rather than focusing on the different elements of it separately.

- **Creating a Positive Environment and Culture Across Settings**

Human beings always live, develop and function in a socio-cultural environment. They are never in isolation. Hence it is crucial that the surrounding environment reflect positivity and a thriving culture marked by openness, creativity, motivation, resilience, empathy, meaningfulness, and spirituality. Research is focusing on creating or nurturing positive environment and culture in various settings such as family, school, health and organizations. It needs to pervade all aspects of life and arena of human functioning.

Concept and principles of positive psychology is being applied in different contexts such as *school, family, workplace* etc. For example, the Government of Delhi has introduced Happiness curriculum from Nursery class upto class 8th in July 2018 to promote well-being of school children. In a study on 300 students from class 6th to 8th, Devi & Patra (2020) reported positive feedback regarding the Happiness curriculum from the students as well as teachers and parents. The Collaborative for Academic, Social and Emotional Learning (CASEL) (www.casel.org) also focuses on promoting various socio-emotional skills among children from kindergarten to high school. Fostering socio-emotional competencies will help create a positive emotional climate in the whole school in which children can thrive.

Socio cultural context influencing the individual well-being has also been studied. For example, studies have been conducted relating religious and spiritual practices to well-being in Indian sample (Singh, Jain & Singh, 2014; Singh et al 2019). Similarly, Arya, Singh and Malik (2017) have studied the impact of 'Sahaj marg' on well-being related parameters. Agarwala, Mishra, and Singh (2018) have presented a review study on religiosity and consumer behavior. Diener et al. (2017) have highlighted the need for cross-cultural studies and experimental interventions to develop long-term subjective well-being in individuals. Research studies thus recognize the importance of culture specific understanding on human happiness and well-being.

- **Positive Psychology Interventions**

Research in positive psychology has given rise to many positive psychology interventions (PPI) that help to enhance mental health and well-being. Besides these evidence-based PPIs, there are also various strategies used by the common people or the age-old practices in our families and societies that are used to improve general well-being. Further, there are also religious and spiritual practices that contribute to enhance our happiness and well-being. Various studies are being conducted on the efficacy and application of these interventions in different settings, for example, Khanna and Singh (2019) have found out the efficacy of Seligman's positive interventions on adolescents in India. Although PPIs use the positive constructs having universal value such as resilience, mindfulness, gratitude etc., research also needs to focus on their expression and effectiveness across diverse backgrounds and demographic variables.

A major development in the application of PPIs is the use of technology in delivering these interventions (e.g., Singh & Bandyopadhyay, 2018). With the advancement in the field of technology and changing times due to digitalization and the current pandemic situation that has impacted the whole world during 2020-2021, online positive psychology interventions are being increasingly studied (e.g., Rippstein-Leuenberger, Mauthner, Bryan, & Schwendimann, 2017). The credibility, procedure, effectiveness and ethical issues in online PPIs need to be investigated more.

- **Research on Neurobiological Correlates of Positive Psychology Constructs**

Studies have focused on finding out the neurobiological correlates of various constructs related to positive psychology. For instance, research has indicated the neural correlates of emotion regulation, especially to up-regulate positive emotions (Rueschkamp, Brose, Villringer, & Gaebler, 2019). This upcoming field known as Positive Neuroscience, focuses on finding out how our brain and nervous system mechanisms influence flourishing, thriving and well-being in individuals.

17.5 FUTURE DIRECTIONS IN POSITIVE PSYCHOLOGY

1) Positive Psychology 3: Moving towards a systemic approach

The first wave of positive psychology focused on positive aspect only. Realizing the limitations of an exclusively positive view, the second wave has brought about focus on the dynamic interplay between the positive and negative aspects in any kind of human functioning. As the field of positive psychology is progressing through its third decade, there is the possible emergence of a third wave of positive psychology (Lomas et al., 2021). This visualization of a third wave in positive psychology advocates shifting their focus from the individual 'person' to studying individuals in their 'sociocultural context'. Thus it highlights a systemic focus and adopts an interdisciplinary and multicultural approach to study individuals.

PP 2 marked the synthesis stage in positive psychology which highlighted going for a unified experience of the phenomena by combining the positive and the negative elements. However, as per Hegel's dialectical analysis model of thesis-antithesis-synthesis, the last stage of synthesis again becomes the thesis for another dialectical movement. Thus the third wave of positive psychology can be the antithesis for the thesis of PP2 focusing only on the field of psychology to interpret human experience. PP3 moves beyond the boundaries of psychology to various other disciplines, and cultures to situate individuals in their particular context that can affect their well-being. The systemic and socio-cultural dynamics become the central focus of research during the possible third wave of positive psychology in the current decade. Thus there can be a systems informed positive psychology (Kern et. al., 2020). PP1 can be said to have focused on 'positivity', while PP2 focuses on 'polarity', and PP3 on 'complexity'.

2) Inclusive perspective focusing on both positive and negative aspects

Abnormal and Clinical psychology are well established fields now, lots of research and theoretical frameworks are available to explain disorders in terms of their diagnostic classification, etiology and treatment aspects. Similarly research is building up in the area of positive psychology and we can have evidence based full-fledged comprehensive field of study for human strengths. But one note of caution here (as it was also explained

in earlier section in this unit) is that although clinical psychology had made so much progress, still it gave rise to the dissatisfaction of focusing on only one side of human existence. So let us not repeat the history and let positive psychology meet the same fate, that is, end up with one-sided focus only.

Positive psychology needs to focus on a comprehensive as well as inclusive view of human existence taking both positive and negative aspects. It needs to recognize the deficits or weakness but also highlight the assets in the individual, both internal and external assets.

Towards this end, the field of positive psychology has much to gain by including the eastern perspectives on human existence and functioning into its ambit. The eastern perspectives such as Confucianism, Taoism, Buddhism, Hinduism, Jainism etc. majorly focus on a balanced perspective on the development and functioning of individuals. For instance, the Yin and yang concept in Chinese philosophy represents the opposite yet interdependent forces of yin and yang that govern our life and the universe. Yin represents the feminine energies, dark and negative aspect whereas yang represents the masculine energies, bright, and positive aspects. It highlights that these two forces are interdependent and need to be balanced for harmony and peace in the universe. Hinduism also talks about “*Ardhnariswar*” symbolizing the unity of female and male contributing to balance and harmony.

3) Indian perspective on human well-being

In contrast to the positive psychology having a western orientation, the Indian perspective emphasizes the role of both positive and negative thoughts and emotions in developing a sense of lasting well-being (you have already read about this in Unit 2 and 3). The Indian view talks about *Sthitapragya*, which refers to maintaining a balance between the positive and negative, and achieving a state of equanimity in both happiness and misery, success and failure. This promotes sustainable happiness.

Indian psychological thought has always focused on the relational nature of human beings and the interconnectedness of different entities in this universe. It highlights the socio-cultural context in individual's happiness and well-being. On the other hand, positive psychology is characterized more by individualism (Christopher & Hickinbottom, 2008). Indian psychology advocates the idea of *Sarvodaya* or the well-being of everybody. It talks about happiness derived from practicing “*Vasudaiva Kutumbakam*” (the whole world is like family). Thus, going beyond the individualistic happiness, it emphasizes on aiming at collective happiness, that is, true happiness is interdependent. When everybody will stay happy and maintain harmonious relationship, there will be positive growth and progress in the society resulting in a happy nation and a happy planet. As Snyder, Lopez, & Pedrotti (2011, p. 492) have put it, positive psychology needs to focus on “what is good for the many rather than rather than just for the one”.

This integrated view of the individual with their ecology is absent in positive psychology. The individual considered as ‘*Jiva*’ in Indian psychology, is not an isolated entity (Rao, 2011). Indian psychology is broad-based that includes all dimensions of human existence reflecting the individual's relation and interdependence with the surrounding eco-cultural system. Further, it is not limited to western materialistic view of happiness, rather it focuses on physical-socio-cultural-moral-spiritual aspects to have an integrated view of well-being. The goal is *Sarvebhavantu sukhinah* (May all be happy!). This notion of sustainable happiness implies a broader perspective of well-being aiming at peaceful

and harmonious co-existence of all life on this earth. Various character strengths and virtues such as courage, gratitude, kindness, forgiveness, empathy and love become significant in making this world a happy place. This has important implication for future research in the field of positive psychology. Studies have attempted to develop and validate scales on positive constructs in Indian socio-cultural context (*Sat-Chit-Ananda* scale by Singh et. al., 2016; *Sukha-Dukha* scale by Singh, Raina & Sahni, 2016; Ashtanga Yoga scale by Raina & Singh, 2018; Vedic Personality Test by Wolf, 1999).

Thus Indian psychology has a great possibility to contribute and enrich the goals and scope of positive psychology leading towards an inclusive perspective on human well-being.

4) Research on happiness and well-being needs to inform our policies

There is a growing body of literature in the field of positive psychology. The academia is taking interest in the positive side of human functioning and enhancing their strengths to help people thrive in their life. However, research ultimately needs to impact the formulation of policies and guidelines toward the betterment of individuals. Towards this end, there needs to be greater interaction and collaboration between the academia and the government functionaries. This will help the policy makers and decision makers to formulate policies and action plans to move beyond the Gross Domestic Product (GDP) and integrate overall well-being into these as exemplified by the Gross national Happiness (GNH) measures of Bhutan. According to Adler and Seligman (2016), GDP combined with measures that capture changes in well-being will lead to a more comprehensive, multi-dimensional, accurate portrayal of social progress. They conclude that the science of well-being is theoretically, metrically, and empirically ripe enough to complement economic measures of prosperity for public policy.

5) Building positive communities and societies

The individual is embedded in their societies. They live, function and conduct themselves in their communities. As indicated by the Indian perspective on well-being, the ecological context of the individual has significant influence on the growth and development of individuals, their satisfaction, actualization, and well-being. Bronfenbrenner's ecological theory also highlights the role of different layers of eco-system around us in the development and functioning of the individual. The dynamic interaction among these systems affect the mental health and well-being of individuals.

Although the role of socio cultural context is being increasingly recognized, there needs to be more research in this direction. It will help us understand the dynamics of the human ecology and human well-being and flourishing.

6) Moving beyond the third wave of positive psychology: Focus on post disciplinary well-being research

As indicated earlier, the third wave of positive psychology can become the thesis according to the Hegelian dialectics model and mark the beginning of an entirely new approach to the study of well-being. Called as the post-disciplinary well-being research, this new approach will focus on an inter-disciplinary, multi-disciplinary and trans-disciplinary approach to the study of well-being (Wissing, 2022). Thus well-being studies in future will move beyond the discipline of psychology to include the knowledge and research gained from other disciplines as well. This will enhance the comprehensive understanding of well-being. Further, it highlights an inclusive view of well-being, covering the bio-psycho-social-spiritual-ecological well-being. Individual is not a separate entity.

There is interdependence of all the elements on each other in this planet earth. Hence, we need to focus not only on the individual well-being, but also the collective happiness and well-being of people and also this planet earth.

Thus as stated by Wissing (2022), future research implies the need to have metatheories that will cover the diverse kinds of research related to the concept of well-being across disciplines.

Self Assessment Questions 2

1. Who is credited with introducing the term positive psychology?
2. The second wave of positive psychology considers well-being as a dynamic interaction between _____ and _____ aspects in the life of an individual.
3. The third wave in positive psychology advocates a focus on _____.
4. What is the yin and yang concept?
5. According to Indian psychology, the individual or 'Jiva' is considered an isolated entity. True/ False
6. Bronfenbrenner's theory is known as _____.

17.8 LET US SUM UP

The present Unit highlighted the background of origin of the sub-field of positive psychology and drew our attention to the fundamental missions of the field of Psychology. Hegel's thesis-antithesis-synthesis model was used to explain the progression of positive psychology in different waves. The current trends in positive psychology research has focused on integrating both positive and negative aspects of human functioning, and developing more evidence-based positive psychology interventions. There is a need to study Indian psychological constructs having an implication for positive psychology. Future of positive psychology needs to move beyond the western individualistic perspective of well-being and adopt an inclusive Indian psychology viewpoint which talks about collective happiness, interdependence of all forms of life on this planet earth and sustainable well-being. Further, future research trend will focus on a systemic approach and benefit from post-disciplinary perspective on well-being.

17.9 KEY WORDS

Positive psychology	: focuses on that aspect of human beings – the character strength and virtues, that make our life meaningful and fulfilling.
Strength model of human functioning	: focuses on 'what is right in people' instead of 'what is wrong in people'.
Co-valence	: refers to the presence of both positive and negative aspect in the same experience or phenomenon.

: refers to maintaining a balance between the positive and negative, and achieving a state of equanimity in both happiness and misery, success and failure.

: the concept derived from Indian psychology refers to the well-being of everybody.

17.10 ANSWERS TO SELF ASSESSMENT QUESTIONS

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 1

1. Martin Seligman
2. Positive psychology
3. Psychology had three fundamental missions prior to World war II: (a) to cure mental illness, (b) to make the lives of all people better, more fulfilling, and (c) to identify and nurture high talent or genius
4. Strength

Answers to Self Assessment Questions 2

1. Maslow
2. positive and negative
3. systemic
4. The Yin and yang concept in Chinese philosophy represents the opposite yet interdependent forces of yin and yang that govern our life and the universe.
5. False
6. Ecological theory

17.11 UNIT END QUESTIONS

1. Provide an account of the origin of positive psychology.
2. Describe in detail the scope of positive psychology.
3. Explain the waves of positive psychology in terms of Hagel's thesis-antithesis-synthesis model.
4. Describe the research trends in the field of positive psychology.
5. Discuss the role of Indian psychology in the future of positive psychology.

17.12 REFERENCES AND SUGGESTED READINGS

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